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MYSTICAL LEGENDS



1: Rune of the Spellcaster



The Mystical Universe

Mystical Legends

Legendae Mystica

#1: The Rune of the Spellcaster

Author / Illustrator - Kenneth Calhoun
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Author's Notes

Mystical Legends was developed well before I thought about writing a solid story. Many iconic characters were known before being given roles in the storyline. The original concept consisted of superheroes fighting evil, but it slowly developed into an intricate world with a unique magic system, a broad history, and the impact of fantasy in a modern setting.

When I was around ten or so, I created the characters that "Avery," "Ted," "River," and "Pyrus Bourn," of Mystical Legends were based off of (more on those characters later in the actual story). They were like different personalities of myself, making them unique and each special in a different sort of way. I doodled the characters, created illustrated books without words, and imagined the type of stories through drawings and fake books. Eventually, I wanted them to be more than just fantasies or inspirations that would never live to breathe a word. And so, I began developing a real map of the type of story in the genre that I was entertained the most.

As a freshman in high school, I wrote the original (roughly) five-thousand-word short story, "Zenith Luces and the Journey of the Mystical Beings," which set the basis of all the subsequent Mystical Legends stories to this day. This is located as an extra chapter at the end of this book. The story's writing level remains unchanged, reflecting my development since then. This short story takes place in the twentieth century when the separated Mystical Beings were finally gathered together by an unexpected young individual who wasn't even a Mystical Being. This short story was a starting, yet permanent, draft to what would become the Mystical Legends Universe (MLU for short). It was also pretty fun writing a story by walking away from the main characters and creating an entirely different cast.

The Mystical Legends series takes place in the modern age and showcases many characters who develop the unique locations and factions that divide the world. The story's premise is: if Mystical Beings existed, what would the ordinary human world think of it, and how would they react? It also explores the world's intricate system through magic beyond just fighting. With these starting criteria set, the series would actually finally begin… like, actually now.

This first book introduces you to the main character, the setting, and the magic system itself (on the base level, as it can get a bit complex). Because it was such a difficult task to write a good beginning story, I had to scrap and redo the first book several times. In fact, I even finished an entirely different first book (almost as long as this one) that I regrettably had to dismiss due to its overarching premise being a bit weird and nonsensical. Feel free to contact me if you'd like to grab a hold of that copy and read the cringe. Anyway, with the final version of the first book (what you are about to read now, I hope) done, I could focus on the series as a whole through the future books.

I'm not as adept as a typical non-standard writer or author, when it comes to writing in general. I simply wanted to lay down the type of story I wanted to tell. And so, this first book is the sort of result you'd expect from a "science" guy like me. No excuses for me though. Regardless of that, I don't discredit my skills as I still constantly try to hone it everyday. So by reading the series, you can see the continuous development of my writing style as an author too.

With that in mind, this is it. The first book of the Mystical Legends series, flesh and all, right in your hands… finally (it literally took me a year to finish…? Ugh). So, as of this book's completion, I will have started the second and third books simultaneously and the story would really have progressed.

The future of Mystical Legends is envisioned for much more than simply the books, so stay tuned for future releases of other means of entertainment in the Mystical Legends Universe (I mean, the MLU).

Your author,

Kenneth Calhoun

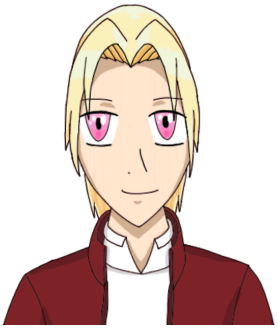
Abstract

What if mythical beings in fantasies were not myths but Mystical, beings who either dwelled alongside humans in secret or inhabited their own domains? What if their fate would eventually be sealed as the presence of magic became known to the wider world? This is the story of the Mystical Legends, individuals who rose to defend against the threats seeking to realize this goal.

The journey begins when a boy finds his purpose and how his unknown past may shake up the course of future events. One thing is, his past is linked to a mysterious power sought out by an infamous flame master desiring to use the power to level societies. With the discovery comes the unfounding surface truth of the Mystical Beings' origins. How will this boy, Avery, shake off his past life to adhere to the calling of the new Mystical life and whatever threats that may arise.

Meet the Characters

Meet the Mystical Legends and the fellow supporting characters!



Avery Obtainia



Kaden Icelander

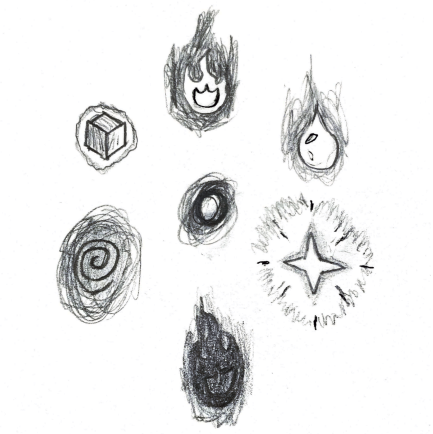


Teddric Tech



River Grant

Prologue: Magic's Origin



For as long as the world existed, there was magic.

Well, not necessarily the stringent definition as described now. In its simplest forms, it was the essence of all things, illuminating the darkness of time.

Just as the earth was formed by a supernatural power, so was the magic which flowed through life.

It spread like wildfire and was the basis for bending and altering the natural laws. It was an energy flowing alongside the natural energies of time and space.

Magic soon took the form of the fundamental aspects of nature: fire, water, wind, and earth, which have both a dark and a light attribute to influence its creation and destruction. These supernatural variations of magic defined the natural laws that determined the world and its course.

Such an energy wouldn't be called the standard conservation of life as the physical energy changes states and enacts movements through a fundamental law. This energy, known as the basic energy or qi, allows all of life to exist which is one's mastery over awareness and control. Magic is different as it's an energy that constantly changes with flux, time, and space.

The world thrived on magic; however, it would not last.

Skies were symbols of freedom, yet the ground yearned to be free. The flames swayed freely like a wild dance, yet it was vanquished by the ever-surging seas.

Where there was light, shadows loomed. Where darkness enveloped the light, a single beacon of hope stood firm. When it would not last, none felt satisfied with their limits.

As the magic brought the existence of the very nature-bending powers, it too harbored a realm of both light and shadow where light cannot encompass everything nor could darkness exist without perception by light.

As in a world once perfect but conformed into imperfection by the ones who took pride in themselves, there were always those who wanted more than what the world offered and those who did not seek what the world could offer.

An imbalance became evident as no one side could operate without eliminating the other. This was the unnatural curve which ripped between the balance through the struggles and conversation of powers—those who were blessed and those who weren't.

Power became a division, class became a test of power, and rule was created to bend the minds of the weaker under a single superior.

Several thousand years ago, a talented man brought order and peace to the world using a power known as Sage.

Through the chaos of the two sides fighting for balance, he sought to end the quarreling and bring about an age where discontentment was abolished.

He was what others called "the Greatest Magni of all." A person deemed as the pinnacle of magical talent.

Magic was abundant, and wonders never ceased to grow; the same was true of this newfound power of Sage. This power, however, granted him ascension to a state beyond tangible and natural beings entirely.

It was not long before he wanted more power and influence that reigned eternally. The limit of his powers was tied to his mortality, a fate every person was doomed to face since the imbalance of the realms.

He saw himself as the only one capable of upholding supreme rule, thus, his quest for longevity conflicted with his former justifiable ideals.

Although he was first recognized as a hero, his greed overshadowed his just heart; he became corrupt and dove into dark magic, hoping to gain powers beyond sage and the earth's natural phenomena.

He, among others like him, thought it was for a greater good.

He gained values that violated the concepts of freedom and justice because he desired to create an equal and just world with his own two hands, using whatever means necessary, the same as those he sought to abolish—a utopia that would be wiped of pain and suffering.

Unlike the one true One who created the world in its entirety and its orderly complexities through the ever growing energy of magic, he thought that he might just become the successor… or surpass the known limits of the world itself.

His belief that with power comes control motivated him to push beyond the boundaries of morality.

A human lives on three factors: their soul, which is their existence or state of rational thought; their spirit, which is their magical power to influence the laws of nature; and their body, which is their physical manifestation controlled and anchored to their soul.

Each of these were simultaneously anchored together like a trinity but also separate aspects of one's self through different realms, or dimensional planes.

This man sought to gain power by stealing the spiritual essence, known as the catalyst of magic, of every individual and existence on earth.

He thought that, by removing magic capabilities, war would not rage on, and peace would be eminent for every being forever.

Being the scapegoat, he would be the last who harbors true violence in order to end the present and future brutalities of disunity.

Civilizations disliked the man's newest ideals.

Even though they were far from him in terms of power, they were prideful and liked their simple lives with magic and a self certified sense of control through power they equally wielded.

They believed in their rights, but ideals without sufficient power were meaningless despite all this.

They had no chance of stripping his strength or his dominance.

And so, his rampage from nation to nation started shortly after attaining Sage to gain followers and spread his fame.

Now pronounced as the **Demon Lord**, a global catastrophe-level threat feared by the masses of the world, the man successfully began to wipe away all magic while none had the courage to challenge him.

He had researched for years with his limited longevity and discovered a new power called Mage, which aided in completing his pre-existing powers of Sage.

Standing at the pinnacle of knowledge, no one could get further in discoveries than the pronounced **Demon Lord** himself.

When hope seemed lost, a group of twelve individuals finally banded together and fought against him. They were known as the most potent magic wielders at that time, second to the genius that was the **Demon Lord**.

Their individual strength could not bend him, but their combined power became a threat to his plans and final exhortations.

But they were too late to stop the spell from activating.

Instead, they managed to direct all the magic drained from the earth into three orbs, preventing the **Demon Lord** from obtaining his own power.

The war raged on for numerous years, with neither side giving up or gaining the upper hand.

At this point, most humans could not aid the twelve in defeating the **Demon Lord**.

With a sense of what would result, the twelve prepared as much as possible, even to sacrifice themselves for the greater good, something the **Demon Lord** forgot its understanding and greater impact.

Some of them created a temporary barrier that prevented the draining spell from impacting a central magical region. But the rest of the world's living species were permanently doomed to lose its magic.

When the tri-combination of the soul, body, and spirit was imbalanced, the spirit becomes nothing more than an empty shell that serves as an individual's life force and identity.

The body and soul became weaker than at the beginning of the earth, thus limiting the infinite capabilities that humans once grasped.

The twelve's physical bodies vaporized in the concentration of potent magic.

But their souls remained intact to their spiritual essence.

Thus, becoming the first spiritual beings.

Overwhelming spiritual energy would corrupt any mortal body, so their interventions throughout history remained limited.

They only had the power to observe and produce minor changes.

They were worshiped early and became known as the twelve **deities**.

The **Demon Lord** was defeated by the Twelve, ending his reign of tyranny and initiating an age where no one single being held supreme.

Stories of old were soon created to elaborate on the morals of heroes vanquishing villains for the sake of the citizens and for good.

As much as the **Demon Lord** wanted to end wars, other greedy individuals sought more power, feeding their egos instead of uplifting their ideals for a more significant purpose.

Wars later broke out between nations to claim the three orbs, and their whereabouts became history.

Others would rise to defend the weak from the strong. They sought to form a society free from tyranny but upholding their ideals by watching their every action.

Eons later, those who aided and strengthened civilizations were known as the **Mystical Legends**.

Their virtues were passed on as an inspiration to future generations to advocate positive change in society.

And so came the age of Mystical Beings, magically enhanced humans, and non-Mystical Beings, humans whose spiritual authority was stripped from them.

The tales of old would soon fade, revealing the dominance of non-Mystical human authority.

The Mystical Beings would be disregarded and diminished in size; however, their influence would only be strengthened now.

When one would begin to seize powers just the same as the first **Demon Lord**, others would rise to stand against them. But their fate would not be strained as the burden of the Twelve.

Some would be threats significant enough to shake the course of history for the worse.

These fated battles, locked between good and evil, brought the revolution and the evolution of the Mystical Beings into hiding.

Three main events changed the course of Mystical Beings' livelihood:

The protection of Mystical Beings from non-Mystical humans.

The re-gathering of the Mystical Beings who were later scattered.

Finally, the impact of the Mystical Beings on societies worldwide.

This story begins at the start of the third event when the **Mystical Legends** ceased to exist, and their stories became legendary.

But legends never fade as their fate will only be upheld by those who choose to continue their legacy.

The story starts anew with a new generation who will learn about the secrets of the past.

They would then paste together the future shrouded in mystery.

What will be the future of magic if it originated as a power wielded equally by all?

What will be the ultimate choice when good pitted against evil does not prevail when that evil is just as good as good is just as evil?

That… is the meaning to be uncovered by the new and not by the prior generations.

***

A young golden-haired boy, asleep, experienced a vision that he could not fathom whether it was reality or a dream.

He lay on the ground, conscious but unable to move.

Darkness loomed from every angle.

The pitch blackness seemed close yet distant.

He could perceive sight, which proved the void's presence.

Then, a door opened from a distance, revealing a grand white light. It was far away, and it only seemed to consume a pinch of the darkness surrounding the void.

It was a spec floating in space.

The boy recollected this moment to be a perception of a place unknown, yet it was something much grander, something forcing his essence into another place too comprehensive to understand.

Not just a place but a whole new realm entirely.

A figure from the distance came out of the door and into the void, guiding the light into darkness.

She steadfastly approached the boy, drawing near in quick succession, almost too fast for the boy to formulate the distance.

She was a tall woman with long dark brown hair and illuminating tan skin.

The void was no longer the center of attention. Suddenly, the light-flooded around the boy as the woman stood before him.

The woman was beautiful, ageless, and dominating.

She wore a simple but flowing white dress trimmed with glistering gold. Her jewelry around her neck glistened red-sapphire as she approached.

A laurel of gold-platinum pulled her hair behind her head, but an invisible wind swayed it back and forth.

Her display depicted an elegant woman, perfect as a supreme and elegant goddess.

Her pink sapphire eyes narrowed and focused on the boy whose eyes were of the same color.

“I have come to make you my vessel. And in trade, you will gain new powers,” the woman stated, kneeling down and touching the boy’s left cheek.

Then, a glowing white curved arrow mark imprinted around the boy’s left eye and disappeared.

“Now it is complete.”

Golden cuffs appeared and fastened onto her wrists. The same cuffs onto the boy’s own wrists.

“The time has come for magic to reign again.”

Then she fell and faded into the boy, thus ending the dream.

And just like that, this vision would be soon forgotten just as the endless darkness would envelope a void in the absence of light.

Chapter 1: A Beggar's Life

Change happened daily in the city that never slept, the iconic Big Apple. Life in New York was characterized by bustling crowds moving to and fro, cars honking as they navigated about, and shadowy street corners where thieves and immoralists lurked.

However, is this change significant in such a vast city?

With every passing individual, New York revealed itself to be different from one's initial expectations.

Change was unavoidable, but it could not be easily grasped by anyone. So, change certainly was anything but extraordinary to those dwelling within the district.

And so, a particular change was about to occur; yet, the city would not realize it.

At a quiet, forgotten street corner near the Trade Center, a humble baker boy waited earnestly for those who would purchase his well-baked bread.

A stand full of the exact pastries was positioned beside him.

Unfortunately, New York was busy at other street corners, and other vendors had rights to many more popular streets, so he needed help to afford such luxury.

The baker boy was quite stout for a youngster like him and seemed quite intelligent at first glance, yet his lazy habit of leaning against the counter, slouching his shoulders, and occasionally picking his nose led most spectators to have a disagreeable opinion about him.

He wore a dirty smock with a faded bread logo as if it endured many harsh conditions. His deep, dark brown eyes intimidated every individual who glanced at him.

Even if his job was to sell, he was doing a terrible job being approachable.

Through his laziness and hard-pressed glares, his one gift was that he could spot any thief, even before they could act.

This was the only reason he was hired in the first place as the city was filled with a variety of the bad and nasty sorts.

The job was only secondary to his desire to have fun chasing people for a justifiable reason and catching them in victory.

Suddenly, rising out of his lazy posture, he hid behind the bread counter, his senses tingling.

Then, emerging from the west side of the lonely street, a shadow appeared and seemed to approach the bread counter.

The shadow darted almost like lightning towards the bread.

The baker boy glanced towards the counter to catch the thief, but to his dismay, three of the freshest loaves went missing almost in rapid succession.

Imagining that he might've hallucinated, the baker boy would never intentionally let anyone successfully slip bread from under his nose, so this ordeal frustrated him the most, despite his usual lazy behavior.

Without a moment's delay, the shadow was gone again.

However, the baker boy had caught a glimpse of the culprit dashing away, holding three large loaves around his arms and grinning sneakily.

In that slight moment, time seemed to stop just for a moment to play a prank back.

The baker boy became enraged, his face beet red and almost crimson.

He was not going to let some small fry steal from him and make a mockery of his status.

"Oy, you there! Stop, thief!" the baker boy shouted.

He began sprinting after the thief in a frenzy, unaware he'd be leaving his stand unattended and much more open for an even worse ambush than just a single little crook.

The thief only looked back to stick out his tongue. To effortlessly make such a gesture meant this thief was no ordinary individual.

The baker boy considered this a crude joke, perhaps to make him look bad… or worse, to get him fired.

He didn't care if the bread was stolen, but he would not let his dignity be shattered by a mere pipsqueak.

The thief was a strange figure, much smaller and younger than the baker boy himself.

One may question why such a young person reduced himself to this level of living. But rest assured, this thief was actually no ordinary thief at all.

Born into an orphanage, later escaping to find a better life only to sink into poverty, then reverting to thievery for survival, our thieving hero, Avery Obtainia, came to be.

Though his identity was barely known to the police of New York, the thief was sure that stealing was the most profitable way to survive.

New York was a heartless place nonetheless for those who had nothing to wager. The boy, Avery, only knew of stealing to pass the day.

His history was unknown; he didn't know his parents and had no home. Though he desired the life of others, he was weary of their trust and lacked the presentation to obtain higher social status.

He grew up discomforted and dismissed. However, he learned the true essence of reality that most others his age failed to understand: the harsh reality that humans lived in, the wealthy lifestyles many swam in, and the few individuals who understood those in poverty.

These hard truths were much more apparent in the big city.

Having no life of an agenda, Avery spent his time sneaking about, stealing food, and entertaining himself in productive and meaningless ways.

Through the orphanage, he learned basic reading and arithmetic and taught himself the rest to stick up to society's schemes. He was especially aware of his standings enough to wish for the lifestyle he didn't have and see the flaws which prevented his successes.

As so happenly, food was a primary source of his learning and anticipation each day.

He often floated about the same street corner where the baker boy was stationed because it offered him chances to snatch food without anyone having a care to stop him.

As a young, mischievous boy like himself, it was hard not to squeeze a bit of fun into the mix, even if it was a bit risky.

The reward was all the more satisfying upon competition of a hard task and learning along the way.

Gaining wisdom and intellect from experiences was what the boy lived for each day, regardless of standards. This young boy had gotten used to this life of thievery for several years now.

Bustling and scurrying through the city both day and night, the boy was observant on the most effective methods of obtaining resources, especially from low grade vendors in forgotten street corners.

A few poor vendors would pile around to sell their goods, as it was an optimal location away from the beating sun, the noisy street cars, and the roaming police officers.

It was also typical for these vendors to be subordinates of the main company, so when they were tasked with selling merchandise, they would often find easy loopholes to do the bare minimum.

In the case of the baker boy, he settled in a dark secluded area as it was the optimal place to be lazy and only serve a few sketchy customers.

The thief happened to stumble upon such vendors and realized the amount of *free* stuff he could gain. And so, his thievery of food sprouted from there onwards.

Today, it was Avery's usual bread-snatching time and a moment where fine hot savory bread was on display.

Occasionally, he loafed around the pastry stoles from various vendors who would momentarily be distracted.

There was, however, one particular vendor who baked particularly delicious bread with an unusual nose-catching sweet scent.

Each loaf could easily be the size and width of an average person's arm slightly larger than an arm, elbow, and shoulder for the young boy Avery himself.

This happened to be the stand operated by the baker boy himself.

The time to pounce was when the baker boy became quite drowsy in the later afternoon right before the large flux of crowds returning home for the day.

Now, the thief, the boy Avery, was quite sure that he snatched the bread without an eye's notice, but today was different.

Usually, the baker boy would not notice bread go missing or remember the number of loaves at the start of the day; however, rare circumstances occur.

Today, the baker boy caught sight of the culprit despite his physical state.

While in pursuit, Avery had to think fast to evade the baker boy and a potential arrest.

Speeding across crossroads and alleyways, Avery sprinted faster and faster to either exhaust his pursuer or outrun him.

This scurrying of cat and mouse continued for several minutes until Avery, stopping to catch his breath, found, to his delight, that the boy was no longer in pursuit. It was

later revealed that the baker boy was lazier than motivated to bother chasing for long. His physique was far from being on par with the thief.

Avery quickly hid behind a nearby alleyway to ensure that the baker boy could not catch sight of him again.

He had begun to regret snatching the bread in the first place because his presence had been discovered.

If the baker boy was up for it, he could've convinced a decent policeman to come after Avery.

Now turning to examine his treasure, Avery took a huge bite out of the buttery, soft bread.

Smelling like warm buttermilk honey, it was the best the city had to offer, well… to the boy's opinion at least since his access to quality food was limited.

He changed his mind and admitted it was worth his life after all.

"Mmmm… So good!" he exclaimed, mouth-watering up with warmth.

The soft bun melted against his usually dry mouth, bursting additional flavors of sweet sugared butter.

It had been forever since Avery had something as tasty as a bakery pastry.

After a few moments of delightful munching and chewing, being unaware of the passing time, Avery was saddened at the sudden disappearance of the first large bread loaf in his hand.

He became mesmerized by the taste that his body instinctively gobbled down the loaf to maintain the flavor in his mouth. A good thirty minutes passed of him slowly munching through the bread which was unusually way too large for his stomach. To him, the time blinked by in a flash and he was dissatisfied that his satiation had ended too soon.

Eying about, Avery glanced down and noticed a thrown-away mirror. He picked it up and examined himself.

His features were a sooty layer of mud and dust, for he had not visited the local baths in a while after his recent ventures.

His golden hair, which looked primarily ragged, could've been mistaken for an angel's, if properly combed.

His eyes were like bright pink sapphires, the only attributes that made him look more admirable and also persuasive in any escapes against pursuers more vulnerable to young child-ish cuteness.

And was a face that shone like the sun was right now a face of sweat and some dirt and grime from the muddy atmosphere.

He was a short boy for not having access to all the food he could ever eat; however, his body focused on strength and stamina for running, parkour, and climbing due to his throbbing fatigue at the end of each day from such activities.

His clothes were not of anything extraordinary either, consisting of a tattered, now gray (used to be white) polo and a gray jacket in poor condition. He wore worn-down gray pants with a hole at the knee from all the scraping.

This appeal was the best he could manage due to his unfavorable tribulations. He had managed to clean these clothes occasionally at the lake in Central Park during the night.

"Whew, I guess I'd better take a shower," Avery thought as he examined himself closely.

He was able to wash himself a few times when opportunities arose.

The local gyms usually had rare days with free admission.

When such occasions occurred, Avery took advantage of them.

On some other rare occasions, Avery found a secluded lake or pond where he could bathe without distractions.

However, it would be during the night, resulting in him freezing in the frigid water.

This thought of action was mainly initiated to prevent others from discovering Avery's presence.

After a few moments of glancing outside the alleyway and sensing no traces of the baker boy, Avery felt assured that he could continue his everyday routine.

Avery then decided to store one of his loaves of bread at his little base.

Gathering enough food to supply him for that day or a few days was part of his daily routine.

Holding the two remaining loaves tightly in his hand, he set out for his forgotten dwelling place.

This "base" was not something a typical person would imagine. I

The base consisted of a giant cardboard refrigerator box underneath a cringy-looking building that protected it from semi-harsh conditions.

As the case of "forgotten," no one bothered to maintain the district as litter was scattered around and the structures themselves were run-down.

Cautiously crossing a chain of traffic intersections and hiding his profile in the shadows, Avery soon approached his base.

He opened a thin door to his humble home and scrambled in and fell down upon an old, tattered yellow bean bag which used to resemble an inflated emoji.

Scattered inside were items stolen or discovered at various points, some risky desired possessions while others lucky finds in the local trash bins and other public uncared for remains.

The interior was about the size of a typical home bathroom; on the smaller side, that is.

On one corner was a chest, while on another was the bean bag where Avery slept and read.

In the center was a tiny table where he ate.

In another corner was his kitchen, mainly consisting of a little refrigerator (which did not work) and a few cardboard nailed shelves to store random trinklets.

At the ceiling of the room was a single naked bulb with wiring taped to the ceiling and walls. The wires hooked up to a small cord that led outside to a small solar panel.

This solar panel was nothing particular; it was just one found on outdoor garden display lights: small, lightweight, and mostly useless.

Avery threw the bread on one of his shelves and flipped open his flip phone which he happened to come across while dumpster diving.

There was no use worrying about the battery either as he took advantage of a couple of phone charging stations scattered at public restaurants.

His flip phone lasted about a week without charging, so he bothered charging only while he remained in a particular area for theft.

He began munching down on the second loaf and began scrolling the web.

Avery noticed a new community highlight on his web browser, "ATLAS CTN: Charity for Those in Need."

"Hmm… Well, I really need it. I am sure they have some good stuff and food there," Avery mused, reading the announcement over and finding no ulterior motives implied.

He decided that it was a perfect opportunity to hone his begging skills.

And if he needed to use his thievery skills, he would use it.

Using his hands as guides, he ruffled his hair the best he could to make it more presentable.

Without a moment's delay, Avery set forth once again towards ATLAS, the Advanced Technology Life Academy.

He always wondered what the S at the end stood for. He thought that the place should've been called ATLA instead.

ATLAS was known to be "second" to the best private school in New York City.

The only school that ever rivaled and was number one was OSNYC.

Both schools were known as rich, prestigious schools with not much known except for the prestige and high graduation rate or prodigies and influencers. The barrier of entry was too high for average folks, no less a homeless boy.

It was understandable that a bunch of people from there wanted to throw away their old clothes to lower-class citizens. They probably gave the (barely worn) clothes for free (even though they could still sell them for profit) to raise morale for being charitable in the public's eyes.

Being a loner and freelancer, Avery needed more money and resources to even consider registering and attending an official school or similar institution, so he sought to educate himself using free public resources such as the library.

He knew that in order to evade those who may come in contact with him, he had to be knowledgeable in various subject areas and modern trends.

Having all the time on his hands, he was pretty intelligent, spending the remaining time insulting in meaningful pleasures and using his wits in scenarios even talented folks would suffer if thrown right into the spot.

Avery realized at a young age the value of observing and how much he could gain from paying more attention to his surroundings.

At some instances shortly after leaving the orphanage, he made rash decisions that almost cost his freedom because of his ignorance.

And from the lessons learned of the consequences, he vowed to never make mistakes like that again.

He didn't want to remember them either. Past was the past, focusing on what he needed next helped him survive.

Avery decided another thievery heist would supply him for the next few weeks and clear himself from the radar, especially after nearly being caught by a street vendor.

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Upon reaching the school ATLAS, Avery was surprised to see so many people, including what he considered "rich snobs" and businessmen.

Flocks of people gathered at the school's front pavilion.

Food, clothes, and other booths lined the side, trying earnestly to attract attention.

The usual beautiful marble entrance was dulled by the charity booths, making the gathering look like a flocking flea market.

He spotted the first businessman, aged and regal, responsible for handing the needy clothes. With a white suit and gray hair, a short-cut beard, and a stiff build, the man might've been a marine admiral.

Bending on both his knees, Avery got to work.

With his small petite appearance and young complexion, he usually managed to snob all kinds of goodies, but the situation really depended on the generosity of people.

Most people wouldn't even hand food to cute kids these days, so he had to be aware of who to approach.

"Please, sir, could you spare a check, money, or some clothes?" Avery whimpered, his big eyes and fake tears aimed at the man.

The rich noble snob glared at him as if he were the last thing the earth needed.

Avery thought perhaps he overdid it on the begging for the man didn't seem the least sympathetic despite living an aged life.

Perhaps the particular man he chose was more heartless than others, either living through it or growing up spoiled.

“Go away, you little beggar. You don’t deserve to come to this sacred event,” the man hissed, almost laughing with trembles.

He was flocking his hands as if the boy was a disease.

“But this was a charity, right?” Avery protested earnestly, stepping closer. “You will give me clothes, right? I really need some. Can’t you tell?”

“Why was I ever going to give my riches to you?” The man sniffed and strode off, “Disgusting little humans.”

Now, Avery realized that this event really was a scam, merely a method for gathering fans and supporters.

Only a few honorable civilians were going to get money.

The term “charity” was a loose term for this event.

He noticed one rich guy handing another rich guy an entire suit.

The event was clearly set up for only the rich people to come and the poor to be ridiculed.

No other individual there was as poor as he. Likewise, their appearance was more diplomatic than causal.

Now focusing on the particular clothing being exchanged at the booths, Avery realized that even the cheapest attire was too expensive for him to afford.

Avery was jipped big time.

But he still found this opportunity to profit from thievery instead.

Gold and silver watches, earrings, purses, and treasure were within Avery’s slick fingers.

Mobs of people covered every inch of the property so he could easily blend in and get away with a juicy prize.

Though it was risky, the mobs proved beneficial for covering his sneaky behavior.

Looking around for his first victim, Avery spotted a man hunched over a suitcase, obviously trying to find something.

The man had opened the briefcase to inspect something shiny. One arm of his held several crumpled but organized pieces of paper.

Avery slipped through the crowd and scrambled to the suitcase as soon as the man left it unattended for a short moment.

Turning his back onto the majority of the crowd that paid no mind, he opened the suitcase and hovered his body over it as a shadow.

Inside lay a beautiful, costly-looking item.

Avery picked it up and dashed away as fast as he could. He hurried through another gathered mob and snuck out of the site.

Rushing down the streets with adrenaline still pumping, Avery stopped to examine whatever treasure he had stolen.

Looking carefully at it, he couldn't decide if it was a snow globe or a giant clam with a pearl in the middle.

Whatever it was, it looked valuable and worth selling for probably several hundred dollars at best. Its weight proved its material was definitely nothing cheap.

He only needed enough to supply necessary things for the day, so he thought the extra cash might be fun to use for pleasures.

Entering a nearby pawn shop, Avery asked the shopkeeper to appraise the item. Looking at the item suspiciously, the shopkeeper took it, turned it around at every corner and crevice.

All New Yorkers knew the rule: never interfere with anyone's business regardless of obvious suspicions as often such reported claims returned as false accusations. Thus, as young as he was, the shopkeeper did not question Avery, despite his deprived state and poor appearance.

"Well, son. I don't know if this is real, but if it is, it's made of pure twenty-four-carat gold and contains the largest pearl this world has ever seen, at least from my analysis."

"What!" Avery exclaimed, his mouth dropping wide open. "How's that possible? How much can I sell it for?"

"I honestly can't put a price on it. It is too priceless."

"But I've no need for it. It's some old family heirloom that I have no need of you see."

The shopkeeper scratched his head and thought for a moment. "Well, I don't know what to tell you. If I were to put a price on it, it would be far too low and too much to afford. I don't have enough money in this shop to pay for it. I don't even know if there is anyone here in this city who would buy it from me for me to make a profit either."

"Can't you at least buy it for a few dollars?" Avery suggested, hoping the man would be greedy and find every opportunity to profit.

"Sorry lad, but as an honest shopkeeper here, I cannot buy it for what it's worth. It would not look too good if someone bought it from me if I manage to even sell it. I do not want to see myself get into a legal situation here either if someone else aroused suspicions," the shopkeeper declined.

Avery left the store dejected, having stolen an item too valuable to even buy him a good lunch.

Throwing the object in some nearby bushes, he walked home. He found no sense in keeping items that were of no use to him. Holding onto such an item would also catch unwanted eyes in addition, which, he desired to avoid.

***

Sunset was steadily approaching New York as Avery arrived home from his recent expedition. He felt something was off as soon as he arrived at his familiar alleyway. Analyzing his entire base thoroughly, Avery noticed, to his shock, that the door of his base was open.

When he entered his domain, he was disturbed to see that it was in rambles. It was as if someone had come in looking for something and torn up the entire place in the process.

Quickly turning around, Avery was then faced by two large shadowy figures. Without a moment's delay, he scrambled out of a hole in the side of the refrigerator box and ran as far away from them as he could.

He crossed over a dozen blocks without proper tending to his breathing but managed to stay distanced.

Finally panting and out of breath after what was a run of a marathon, Avery stopped to rest.

Looking up, he saw the two figures slowly walking towards him in the distance with the rising moon behind them.

"What … do you … w-want?" Avery asked, trembling and at a loss for words. He had no chances to consider the origins of the two followers and how he ended up in the situation.

The two figures said nothing and still continued steadily towards him.

Avery ran aimlessly in the direction furthest away from the two intimidating figures. But the two were still quick to pursue him, every path he turned and passed.

They hadn't lost sight of him, even though Avery was considerably faster, despite his fatigue to count.

Now, Avery was shaking all over and could not think properly about his actions. Unlike stalkers who would only make him feel creeped out, the irregular presence of the figures freaked him with chills through his spine.

He ran quickly and then came across a dead end, with the two figures close behind.

Avery desperately tried climbing the wall, but it was no use with his timid and shaking body. The approaching shadows of the figures brought back a flood of memories of Avery's previous life at the orphanage and his reasons for leaving.

The first figure extended his hands towards Avery while he braced himself for a fistfight. Something emitted from the figure caused Avery to feel confused. His senses started to dullen, and his eyes started to droop.

His body began to slump forward, and his head was raised towards the two figures now right over him.

Avery's consciousness began fading, and his senses began to dull rapidly. Whatever the reasons, the two men were swift in capturing him.

One figure bent down, whispering…

"Nighty night."

***

Avery awoke to the sight of jail cell bars. The air around him was musty and damp with the smell of beer. A guard sleeping in one corner seemed to completely ignore the ongoing commotion of the other prisoners. At one end of the room was a single door, possibly the only escape route from the jail.

Seeing a familiar sign, "ATLAS," Avery knew it was not a typical jail, if the term was even suitable to describe the environment.

Then the doors opened, shedding a brilliant bright light. That light was extinguished by the form of a tall, intimidating figure.

This figure wore an expensive dark blue uniform that resembled a raging sea. He had a short silver beard that made him seem ageless and immortal. What was genuinely intimidating were his two pairs of lighting blue eyes that seemed to radiate even when facing away from the light behind him.

The man walked slowly but steadily towards Avery. Avery could make out his bloodthirsty dark blue eyes staring down at him. The figure stood a few inches from Avery's cell, looking intently down upon him.

Speaking slowly and steadily, more whispering, the man said, "Listen, boy, stealing is not how you should live. Quit it before it becomes a habit."

Avery, too startled to reply immediately, only gazed back at the terrifying figure with fear. He recognized this man as the same one who owned the suitcase where he stole the round gold object.

For someone to have caught him so quickly, it meant these rich individuals didn't make light work of their pradicements.

The man narrowed his eyes as if scanning Avery's appearance, then his stare lifted slightly.

"Hmm… I thought so…," he mumbled before shouting, "A fool's answer. You're coming with me."

The man snapped his fingers, and the cell door locks clicked open. He indicated Avery would follow.

Somehow, Avery knew that there was no escape, so there was no point in attempting to run away as the man seemed capable enough to single handedly knock him out if needed.

Avery followed meekly behind as both exited the jailhouse.

A limousine awaited the man as he sighed and breathed in the fresh air. The man asked Avery to get in.

The boy, with no choice, complied.

The limousine drove off from the jailhouse when the man entered and seated himself properly.

The man pulled out a solid gold watch, examined the time, and pointed to the driver, "Steven, could you drive a bit faster?"

The chauffeur nodded and sped up.

Avery leaned hesitantly over to the window to analyze his surroundings. He was no longer in the familiar locations he had freely roamed.

Turning around to see the man sitting beside him, Avery looked up and saw his serious complexion. Being in an uncomfortable situation, Avery lacked the courage to pipe up and ask about his situation.

"It is upsetting to see someone like you in such a low state in society. I will be sure to change that, but precautions must still be taken," the man said.

"W-What d-do you mean?" Avery asked, sitting tensely.

"Tell me, boy, what do you know of your past?" the man questioned, ignoring the former question.

"I don't know much about my past. It's just my life at an orphanage and then running away."

"Hmmm... I see," the man contemplated. "For someone like you, it's best to change how you live."

"H-How?" Avery stated, thinking back on his lack of ordinary desirable skills.

As if intently reading Avery's mind, the man added, "What you possess is well above any other average human. You should use those skills to help society instead of ruining it."

The man's eyes perked up as if he saw something intriguing about the boy's physical features.

"But I don't have money or the reputation to go to school or get a job," Avery protested, remembering sleeping in the slums, constant theft, and the use of public resources to go by each day.

"You don't need any of that. Your life is how you make it. The resources you use shape your life. The limit is how much you search and how much you strive."

Avery bowed his head in resentment, "But I've utilized everything I've grasped. What do you know of my situation?"

Raising his eyebrows, the man chuckled, "Apparently, you've yet to see the full library of resources that you could potentially get. Not everything is physical; think deeper, use your theft for cleverness, and strive for something much greater than a meal for the next day. I know enough to understand the harsh reality of New York City as you know it."

The man leaned back against the limousine seat and removed some money from his pockets.

"Use this to apply to OSNYC in three years." He recognized the boy's age and then added, "When you turn fifteen, think of going to high school as a way of starting from zero."

Receiving the money, Avery looked into the man's eyes. They were not the same cold, dark eyes but bright, stern eyes of an endless ocean.

"Why? Why help me?" he continued to ask suspiciously.

"Your life will become much more interesting. Think of it as a new starting point for your new life. This is all I can do for you at the moment. Everything else will be in your hands. Strive to the top, work hard, and strengthen your skills. Then, you will pass the exam with flying colors. All of which I've said is… legit."

"But still… Why me? And how can I even believe this is real money?"

"I see potential in you, and I want you to find that. Though my mean demeanor and approaches earlier were a bit excessive, I do see that you may succeed. Just trust that the money's real, what reason would I hand fake ones if not at all?"

Avery took the logic as sound. The man certainly was no scammer as he openly displayed his wealth as a final verdict.

Being captured by hired thieves in the night was a bit excessive, yet it did seem odd the man went that far for a small theft.

"What about the thing I stole? I-I.. lost it…"

"Don't worry about that. It was retrieved easily. The subsequent steps were simply necessary to catch the culprit. Somehow, a marine artifact of that caliber was actually consumed of some of its power—never mind, the item is safe."

Thinking of the two figures again, Avery thought those extra steps were very unnecessary. If given a normal meeting, he could've easily admitted how he stole the object and where he left it.

"At first, I imagined you to be just like the rest of them of New York society, but from judging your character, I'd say you would try to make wiser decisions when in the right conditions," the man casually explained.

“I see… uh, thanks for thinking of me so highly, I suppose.” Avery’s tension began to subside as the continuation of the conversation morphed into something far more critical.

“So, where do you plan to take me?”

“I’ve sorted an agreement with a foster family so you can continue your life in desperation for shelter.”

“Foster family? Isn’t that a bit excessive?” Avery questioned.

“You very well cannot keep living in the streets. Best you start breaking your habits, starting now.”

Avery was surprised this man would go so far for a pathetic street boy like himself, but seeing this man as the first person who understood his status, Avery vowed to do as the man had instructed.

The tide continued in silence as Avery began formulating strategies. If there was one skill that he was proficient in, Avery would say it was his careful decision-making.

“What should I even strive for then if I no longer use my skills for surviving?” Avery asked finally, breaking the silence.

“That’s an interesting question indeed. What would you strive to do with your life if you did gain what you always wanted?” the man responded.

“I don’t know… maybe self discovery? Find a way to live so others wouldn't fall where I am?”

“Hmm, I’m sure you’re aware of a lot of things from observation. Perhaps you’ve not fully realized the value of life.”

“Value of life? Like surviving?”

“Part of life is discovering its value, rather, allowing others to display it towards you. As you begin this next step, you should take in consideration of the people around you more.”

“Is that really… it?”

“Don’t undermine the extent of it. No one can possibly define the meaning of life or the reason for living on their own, after all, everyone in nature has self centered interests. But what is found outside of that, that is just the beginning.”

Avery was shocked at this realization but also intrigued. “If you say so, mister, then I will strive to follow your advice, after all, you have given me this chance to restart.”

“Well, I suppose this will be the end of our meeting for now. May you strive for what’s right and find that life you seek,” the man shook Avery’s hand.

Shortly later, the limousine dropped Avery off at the foster home where he would live. Not much was given about the foster family, as it was Avery’s opportunity to make a great impression.

Without another word from the man, the limousine left, thus leaving the boy alone at the entrance of the family’s home.

Standing before the door to a private apartment, Avery knocked. The door opened to reveal the greeter who recognized the boy as the foster child.

Stepping inside, Avery pushed forward, releasing the old, scrawny street boy version of himself. Thus, the protagonist follows this path to become stronger in hopes of chasing this new desire: to set a better life for himself.





Chapter 2: Enter the School

Taking the exam was his only way of escaping the life he had experienced for as long as he had known. This test would change everything about his life, and he would accept an offer for a full-ride scholarship to New York's most prestigious high school. He learned about the opportunity at twelve and set his eyes on the goal.

Now fifteen-year-old Avery Obtainia had a chance at a private high school with a hybrid option for learning and living on-site. A much-needed change from the miserable life he had endured for a while now.

Avery spent the last three years training his mind and physique for the potential chance of entering the school to gain a better future.

He had worked part-time to get enough money to look presentable and get the necessary materials to succeed.

He obtained enough earnings to support himself when he started his first official entry-level job, but of course, a paper was the only way to prove his efforts.

Work was easy, education was the only thing he could spend time on, and a future of pleasures could only be achieved by getting a proper education at an institute and scoring a higher-paying long-term job.

Avery lived with a foster family known as the Alexanders, who cared nothing about him except for giving him a place to stay in the trade of manual labor. It was a double benefit for both parties. However, the one rule set in place was that Avery could not meddle in their family affairs, thus making education, food, and entertainment entirely up to Avery to figure out.

The Alexanders were used to having a chore boy, but Avery differed from their opinions. He sought a future of his own and admired the one who gave him the chance.

In the past few years, he tolerated the immense struggles of being a second rate individual in a household of semi-wealthy people.

The family lived in a small apartment complex several stories above the busy and sketchy street corners. The interior of the house was a pig's pen and the family was constantly acting like slobs.

Avery was required to clean after them occasionally to keep his right to stay. Of course, with the legal issues of child protection laws, the family only threatened to strip him of his rights.

Today, a beautiful Sunday, was the testing day, and the school's entrance was impossibly packed with parents and potential students. Avery had just arrived to witness this disturbing scene.

Not only was it busy, but media broadcasting companies were present to showcase the second most anticipated event after the famous Thanksgiving parade hosted in New York every year.

The Official School of New York City (OSNYC) was one of the prettiest and prestigious institutes in New York, so earning a way into it was such a big deal. Most of the students who entered were big shots who were financially stable enough to study and train for the school exam to get in.

Being competitive also meant the school hid most of its secrets quite well. Being located near Times Square also didn't make the popularity and recognition any less.

Having just arrived from a short walk, Avery approached cautiously, wanting to avoid being pushed and shoved by most other people.

Some policemen patrolled the perimeter to regulate crowd control and potential hazards.

Being relatively short for his age, Avery had above-average features, such as shoulder-length golden hair, an athletic physique, and a gentle, composed expression.

He also wore a unique but ordinary clothing style that retained its similar features to his former clothes, such as simple gray khakis, a white polo, and a maroon member's only jacket.

He carried a backpack with essential supplies and all of his personal belongings. This simple image was how he viewed his style; it was something no one would suspect, as he lived an untypical lifestyle.

Nonetheless, his specific features caught attention from time to time.

Shoving through the crowds, Avery managed to squeeze himself into a group of kids on the front lines who were expected to enter the school building first.

Being nimble and one of the crowd, it was a typical behavior and none took too much interest.

Not a moment later, the doors opened, and the crowds could pour inside the school. The mood changed a bit from excitement to anticipation.

Everyone entered a large lobby, showcasing the school's elegance and the grandeur of the interior. A large red carpet covered the center of the floor from the entrance to the main help desk.

Several entryways scattered around the room led to various rooms that had yet to be toured. The room was several stories high, with balconies looming around the area's interior. A chandelier loomed from the ceiling of the grand lobby, another feat to display the school's wealth.

Once everyone settled into the lobby, many began congregating and greeting one another patiently until an announcement came.

Not knowing anyone, Avery thought it would be splendid to look about the room and gauge the type of applicants he would compete with.

The room was sizable for the crowds to split a sizable distance from each other.

"Wow, this place is something else," Avery mumbled, gazing at the ceiling and strolling about.

If it were the past, he'd look for an opportunity to snatch something worth some bucks. But now, despite his other forms of struggles, he continued to seek to realize his goals as set by the man. At least starting out, getting a respectable lifestyle.

Another applicant, who overheard Avery, remarked, "Yeah, well, I've seen better."

Avery turned to the sound of the voice to be hailed by a tall, hip-hop-looking guy. "You must be one of the newcomers hoping to get in."

Striding over, the guy greeted Avery with a handshake. "Name's Teddric Tech, but you can call me Ted."

The African American guy named Ted performed his signature pose of a fist in the air. He removed his high-tech headphones and brushed himself off.

"Uh, hi. I'm Avery Obtainia. It's nice to meet you." Avery adjusted his collar in response, though uncomfortably as his interactions with others was scarce for the sake of pleasing them.



“I’ve not seen you before. Probably because you went to a different school or you’re not from this area.”

“No, this is my first time, but… you know others here?”

“Well…” Ted meditated, “You could say that many people here are students from a local middle school. But I don’t affiliate myself with any of them.”

“Well, I heard about OSNYC about three years ago, so I’ve trained myself up to this point. I never went to public school.”

“As far as I know, the test changes every year, but no one knows what it would contain, even for my folks who work directly under the school,” Ted recollected, shrugging his shoulders.

“You say… Well, I guess we’re all in the same boat,” Avery said, now thinking how he might have an upper hand.

"It's not so simple. In this room alone, there are more competitors with higher IQs than anywhere else. Plus, the division between social classes of wealth really pinpoints the distinct skillsets of the applicants."

Ted then pointed at a group of guys and girls wearing full suits and dresses of ridiculous luxury. "I'd say those guys over there have a higher acceptance rate just because they're richies with private tutors."

"Yeah, I guess you're right. I suppose even these types of schools favor the individuals with the wealth to back them up. It scales the school's morale in the public's eyes."

"If so, we're not going to lose since we've got more motivation and passion than those big shots will ever have," Ted assured.

"You're right! Let's do this."

Now wasn't the time to let go of hope, Avery, of all people, knew this to the highest degree.

Avery and Ted seemed to hit it off, so they fist-bumped and declared their newfound friendship.

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"Greetings, applicants!" an announcer called out from a balcony above the help desk, "All of you are well aware of what you are getting into, so without delay, let me briefly explain what you are expected to do."

The room went dark, and a spotlight shone on the balcony where the announcer stood. He then ushered in the start of the next phase of the event.

Attendants casually strolled around and managed the crowds to ensure the entire experience was professional.

Video projectors above the chandelier projected blank white canvas displays around the room. The crowds gasped as the animation began to showcase and bring the logo of OSNYC into view.

"Today marks another year for the incoming freshmen of OSNYC, and like all years, we'd like to showcase the trials that the applicants will face to the general public. Because of the prestige and secrecy of this school, the examination will be thoroughly proctored, and the challenges will be unlike anything imagined. Of course, it's not impossible, but it

will take intelligence, a sixth sense, and a strong will to fully push past your mortal limits and go into a realm beyond human comprehension," the announcer stated. "The doors will open soon, and the applicants may proceed."

Avery cheered along with the crowds at the introduction. However, he became uncertain about the challenge since it was devolving from a typical pen-and-paper examination.

He thought this way because anything other than pen and paper could cover a myriad of subjects that he had zero experience in.

Thinking of his past physical training, Avery was confident enough not to be deferred.

"Now, the challenge will be simple: find the room with the admission letters and hand it over to one of the faculty signed with your name. Faculty will be spread around the floors. Cameras will be monitoring the building, so the public will be watching. Only standard methods are allowed. Aside from that, any method is okay to find the right room with the admission letters. Rooms that are unlocked may be accessed, but don't worry, the letters will not be in a locked room," the announcer continued.

To think that the objectives were so simple, but Avery knew that there would be some sort of exception.

"There is a time limit of thirty minutes. Those who do not succeed during that time fail, but everybody else fails if all the letters are taken and submitted."

"I guess we can team up and do this together," Avery suggested.

"Yeah, for sure!" Ted nodded. "Phew, I'm glad I don't have to go against someone in a one-vs-one setting."

"One-vs-one? Are you saying they've done stuff like that?"

"Oh I don't know, just guessing, you know. This test does give vibs of proctors who would've administered something like it in the past."

"Whatever fate did bring, le'ts just seize it to our advantage."

"Uh, sure. You do say oddly passionate stuff."

"Oh really? Not intentionally, just trying to be assertive at times like this," Avery explained.

Then, the doors opened, starting the challenge.

"Disperse!" the announcer shouted as the crowds cheered for the event to begin.

Avery and Ted picked the door closest to them and tailed a group of students who seemed confident of their actions.

Of course, the building's layout was well documented, but only a little was known. OSNYC had hundreds of rooms stuffed in forty stories, making navigation and communication much more complex, so this challenge would fall into a speed run.

Following the other applicants down the main hall towards the stairs, Avery and Ted encountered several closed entrances to rooms. Opening each door and peeping around was an assured way of searching potentially every room; however, it was very inefficient.

The winning mood in the applicants made verbal information sharing nonexistent due to each one's desperation and clouded judgment. Some individuals would check the same rooms that others before them contained because no one indicated that the room was a dud.

Avery, noticing this, stopped in his tracks and nudged Ted, who had been following nonchalantly. "We should change our methods. Following a group of students and searching every room is pointless."

"What do you suggest? I think if we just do the pursuing and looking around, we should be fine," Ted said in his usual optimistic tone. "I mean, we are lucky."

"Working together is a big part of this, but checking every room is a big task for one person alone. The best strategy here is to split up and cover more ground."

"That's true, but there's no cellphone coverage or free Wi-Fi here, so communicating is definitely off the list. We could wait a bit and find someone who did find the letter and talk with them, though the chances of them spoiling the location is low since this is a competition."

Avery paced about, deep in thought. He knew every second was valued, so his mind was racing with options.

"One suggestion is we report in at, let's say, floor twenty's lobby at increments of five minutes; of course, we would have to be fast. But this method ensures that we spread out the task and communicate interesting aspects," he offered with nothing else ideally conceptualized.

Ted noted this and agreed without any complaints. Avery and Ted separated and decided to report back in precisely five minutes. Avery chose the upper twenty floors while Ted searched the lower twenty.

Though they were busy initially, the stairs were the quickest way of traveling from floor to floor. There were two stairs, one on each side of the OSNYC building. The stairs wrapped along a box-like interior up to the top, so one could quickly glance upwards or downwards as desired. One may have chosen to go over the railing and fall to the ground floor because the center is void.

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Three minutes passed, and analyzing applicants from floors twenty-one through twenty-three showed no sign of obtaining the coveted letters.

Avery was almost getting exhausted, keeping up with his pace from floor to floor and scanning all around the rooms. He thought it may have become hopeless as the letters could've been shoved in a tiny janitor's closet.

With forty total floors, all the applicants had been thinned out, so rivalry for stair and elevator usage was minimal. However, the problem that arose from this was the lack of subjects to investigate.

Using the remaining time, Avery continued grinding floors until he completed floor twenty-six. Most of the floors had typical classrooms and large gyms; however, the layout was the same, so the more floors Avery passed through, the better he could maneuver and speed up his pace. Seeing the time running out, he quickly returned to floor twenty.

***

At the first minute, Ted brilliantly thought about searching for a building map to help him eliminate locked rooms or floors during maintenance. Without much effort, he managed to spot a detailed map in one of the halls on floor twenty.

Taking a photograph of the map, Ted began marking the rooms that would most likely be off-limits to the applicants, such as offices, storerooms, and living spaces.

Deducing all this, the room count only decreased by twenty-five percent, which was good in the long run but not very practical for a thirty-minute challenge.

Ted, being a decent multitasker, decided to slowly head down each floor and spy for suspicious behavior among the other applicants while he marked off rooms on his phone. This plan was somewhat effective but counterintuitive. Every second he glanced from his phone to survey the room was a second wasted.

Using the remaining four minutes to finish marking all the first twenty floors, Ted chose to head back to the meeting spot.

He had cleared three floors then but knew his pace would increase since he had fully marked the remaining maps. Having decent memory, Ted also got the basic layout of the floors.

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"I managed six floors, which is okay, I guess," Avery spoke, half confidently, to Ted, who was waiting at the stairs on floor twenty.

"Better than what I did. But hey, I have the layouts down for my remaining floors, so mine should be a breeze," Ted bragged.

"Okay, sure. The strategy seems to work, but I feel that something is off."

"How come?"

"Oh well, the other applicants seem to be doing the normal floor checking, you know. But I did not see anyone who might have found the letters."

"Strange. You would think it would be pretty obvious."

"How many people are actually admitted every year?"

"About a hundred, I believe," Ted guessed unconfidently.

"Well, back to the grind," Avery concluded.

"Yeah, you say it. Grind is the word for this."

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The duo continued through their respective floors. While Avery kept the same pace as before, Ted's pace accelerated due to his increased awareness.

At the second meeting, both discussed their progress; however, neither found the letters nor rumors of where they would be.

With only ten minutes left in the challenge, some students who found the acceptance letter turned it into the faculty and reported back to the main first-floor lobby. Their smug attitude walking slowly to the main lobby proved their unwillingness to disclose the location.

What Ted had mentioned was accurate. Most students didn't care to waste time breathing to show or support another applicant; it was the game of king of the hill where only the best stayed, but the weak toppled.

With time as their most prominent opponent, Avery and Ted sped up and used their total energy to traverse from floor to floor in the swiftest manner possible. Both covered over eight floors each; it was up to their own personal speed to do the remaining.

At their subsequent last meeting, it was agreed upon that their current strategy needed to be fixed. So, they decided on a new approach altogether. Both blamed themselves for not thinking sooner.

Because the letters were only at one spot, it was optimal for the ultimate strategy possible: operation – sabotage the stairs.

Well, sort of.

Most of the students had been spread among all forty floors, so the cycle of students using the stairs was only about ten percent of the total number.

The elevator was inconvenient to use, so it was not worth monitoring.

Operation "sabotaging the stairs" required both Ted and Avery to go to the highest point and lowest point, respectively, and glace up or down the stairs right at the edge of the railing to see any applicant running from a room to a faculty member.

Meeting at the center floor was convenient, as the duo each only had to pass twenty levels to reach their destinations. Because the OSNYC had duo stairs, both Avery and Ted had to run back and forth between the stairs in intervals of thirty seconds to secure the most possible travel methods.

Ted spotted a girl with a letter from floor nine traveling to floor six. He rushed to the level from whence the girl came and began searching desperately for the room with the letters.

Finding a room at the far end of the U-shaped layout on that floor, Ted peeked inside and saw a table with a very short stack of acceptance letters.

The room was a typical classroom; however, it was a bit obscure and at the furthest point from the stairs and elevator.

He had the strange thought of snatching one for himself and winning on his own, but deep down, he knew it was stupid to envision it.

Another thing that occurred to him was that no one sabotaged the other letters in any way, probably, most likely, due to the apparent camera aimed intently at the stack.

He snatched two of them and headed back to floor twenty, where he would meet Avery for the final meeting. Realizing it was a team effort, he knew that he'd feel more accomplished having a friend along.

"Phew, we got it!" Ted exclaimed, waving the letters as Avery approached him.

"You could've been secretive when you came here," Avery suggested.

"Nah, I'm not that kind of guy. We were in it together."

"That's what makes you unique, I suppose."

"What do you mean, you suppose? Never mind, forget it. Let's sign this and be done."

"Alright," Avery agreed. "So, where did you get it anyway? Was it really so hard to find all this time?"

"If you were lucky, you'd stumble upon it. But it was in an obscure place—a room at the top of the U-shaped layout of floor nine. Luckily, no one was unsensible enough to sabotage and hog more for themselves. I just managed to snatch two of the last few remaining."

"Is snatching more than one allowed?"

"I dunno. No one stopped me."

Both grabbed pens from a nearby classroom and signed their names on the bottom of the acceptance letters.

Finding a nearby faculty member on one of the lower levels, they turned their letters in and headed back to the lobby, relieved.

Ted hurried ahead to watch the remainder of the competition from the lobby digital displays. Avery, on the other hand, decided to casually walk back. He needed to rest his weary legs.

Eyes closed and walking blindly, Avery bumped into a girl who was in a rush. Upon colliding, both crumpled onto the ground, dazed for a moment.

When he opened his eyes and saw the girl, Avery fumbled to his feet and offered to help her out.

"I'm so sorry. I was not paying attention," he apologized frantically.

The girl wore a brown hood, which concealed her caramel-colored hair and green sparkling eyes. She also wore a white long-sleeved sweater shirt and a long green skirt.

"I-It's my f-fault," the girl confessed shyly.

"No, no, no. I was not paying attention."

"B-but s-still… I was… running," the girl nervously stated.

"It looks like you haven't signed a letter yet. I'm probably only making you lose more time. Sorry about that," Avery sincerely apologized.

"No, it's… okay."

"How about this? Please trust me on this one. The acceptance letters are on floor nine. You just need to find a room on the far end of the building."

"T-Thank you," she said, before rushing off.

Avery smiled at the sight of the girl. There were only three minutes left of the challenge, which should have been enough for the girl to finish. If this type of challenge was merely luck based, he was okay with sharing its location.

***

When the timer expired, alarms blared thunderously throughout the school, and an announcement was broadcasted throughout, stating that all applicants were to report back into the main lobby.

When all had gathered, the announcer from the booth proceeded with his remarks.

"Good job to those who were able to submit their acceptance letters! And those who didn't, try better next time? In all honesty, the competition was a luck-based and, mostly, a strategy-based game. Of course, all the rooms would eventually have to be checked, but who would inspect them is a different story altogether.

"We saw many strategies today, and it was surprising how many different approaches worked out. This was a test not of social rankings but of intelligence and calm collectiveness. Those who were levelheaded were able to see through the confusion of all the applicants rushing floor by floor. Some formed large groups to tackle each floor by sending individuals and reporting back. Others sabotaged moments where others clearly had the letter and pursued the location from where they came from.

"In life, there are those who lead and those who are led. The people who did the grunt work may sometimes be luckily rewarded when they stumble upon the right room, but those who analyze will instantly recognize the optimal time and location to dive in—no luck involved, only sheer confidence. This challenge allowed each individual to

gauge their senses and decide what was best suited to their skill sets. As they say, it is not guessing if one is confident with their choice.

"Time is one's most challenging opponent and often prevents an individual from doing something. This challenge hopefully helped you all to think more efficiently.

"Again, it was a pleasure to see this challenge unfold. Thank you to all of those who applied and attempted the exam."

In the end, there was more to the test than met the eye. Though it was a simple objective, the approach was in the thousands. Avery sighed in relief as he and Ted managed to use a strategy that saved them minutes before time ran out.

There was no way I could've done this myself; luckily, I had met Ted. It's too bad that all that I had prepared for up to this moment didn't really apply. It goes to show that life is unpredictable, Avery thought.

Ted, unbothered by the results, shouted and cheered along with the rest of the crowd. He was very chill and level-headed for the amount of stress that one would usually have while in an exam for a prestigious school.

"Anyway, dude, it was really fun doing this now that I think of it. I'm glad I met someone like you," Ted thanked, handing out his hand for a fist bump.

"You, the same," Avery returned, bumping fists.

***

After the event unfolded, most of the applicants had left the school. Only the accepted students remained. The lobby seemed even more lustrous now that the mob of people had disappeared.

"Man, am I beat," Ted announced, stretching his arms.

"You could say that again," Avery agreed, sighing. He had exhausted so much energy during that thirty-minute challenge that he hadn't realized until now that he was running on fumes of desperation. At least one of his routines paid off for this challenge.

Avery glanced around and counted about fifty other students who had passed. It was interesting to note that out of the over two hundred applicants, only these few had succeeded.

The man who was the announcer stepped up and greeted the students. “Let me formally introduce myself to you all. I am the principal of this school. You can call me Principal Hatami Sugo.”

Avery rubbed his head in confusion.

Usually, the head of the school only makes announcements if the school is short on staff or no one is qualified to take the role. However, the principal was so outgoing that it made sense for someone like him to greet the students and represent his ideals for the school.

“Now, financial information can be discussed later on,” the principal continued, “but in the meantime, those intending to stay on-site may choose to follow some of our senior students to the designated dorms. Orientation and introductions will start this evening at eight o’clock in the main hall on floor two. Be sure to be there on time.”

The exam was held a day before the official first day of school, which explained why upperclassmen students were not present.

Most of the dorms were located on the lower floors; however, the luxury rooms for Prefects and honor students were separated and located higher up near their respective classes that they managed.

Avery and Ted followed several students, guided by some seniors, to the dorms, which started on the third floor. Dorms were optional for students since both staying on-site and off-site had their pros and cons.

The two main pros for both sides are being closer to the classes on-site and better living overall for off-site.

Freshman dorms were duos and were distributed along the edges of the U-shaped halls of floor three. Avery and Ted decided to share a room for convenience. It was a bit early and too awkward to intervene with other students.

The dorm room was straightforward: two beds, two desks with chairs, two closet dressers, and a single shared bathroom equipped with a tub and sink. It brought serious college vibes, which Avery knew immediately after watching a few anime shows in his spare time over the past few years.

The beds were distanced on opposite sides, with desks beside them and a window in between. The room smelled of fresh cleaner, thus indicating the thorough effort contributed to its prestigious atmosphere.

Unpacking was a linear path for Avery since everything he owned was in his simple backpack: two changes of clothes, toiletries, some personal mementos, an all-purpose tool knife, phone charging cords and accessories, waterproof bagged private legal documents, and a small water bottle.

Setting his backpack onto his bed, Avery quickly hopped on and lay down. It was relieving to rest his body and mind from the traumatic experience.

"Bruh, is that all you've got?" Ted inquired skeptically. He had never seen someone with so little personal luggage before.

"Well, have you met anyone worse?" Avery responded, shifting his upper body up to face Ted. "It's basically been living solo for me for as long as I can remember. So, of course, I didn't have the luxury to splurge and overstock on waste."

"Don't worry, man, I was just kidding… or not."

"I have a few spare changes of clothes stuffed in here anyway, if you were concerned on that regard," Avery noted.

"Okay, hadn't thought that though."

Moments later, Ted left the school to return with two large luggage suitcases.

By the end of the setup, his side of the room was transformed into a small living space with a gaming desk, a dresser packed to the brim with unfolded clothes, and a few accessories plugged into the wall outlet. Several strange gadgets were scattered across his gray quilted bed.

"Wow, some setup you've got there," Avery commented, having difficulty keeping his remarks back. "Are you sure you got into this school?"

"Haha, yeah, right. Don't worry about me. I've got the brains and the brawn to do this and study. This is my passion: to create the best personal gaming computer. And these are not a waste to me!"

Ted opened one of the desk dowers to showcase his extensive collection of mechanical tools, computer parts, and weird gizmos.

"What is the use of those *weird* contraptions?" Avery inquired, pointing particularly to a large black box with buttons.

"These are my work-in-progress hardware," Ted exclaimed. Then, indicating to the black box, "This baby here is my circuit box where I test the amount of voltage a particular invention of mind can handle."

“Uh huh, how cool, I guess,” said Avery in shock. He had yet to step into the world of engineering and electronics.

“And don’t call these things weird. That is an improper word for it.”

“So what should I use?”

“I dunno, anything but that… like cool.”

“That seems like a stretch for ordinary looking things.”

“Nah, what are you talking about?”

“Anyway, we should get going soon,” Avery suggested when the time drew near for the orientation.

“Yeah, might as well,” Ted agreed, though he felt reluctant to leave his new setup. “Please stay where you are, I’ll be right back soon,” he pleaded to his equipment before following Avery out.

***

When it was drawing near eight o’clock, Avery and Ted hurried to the second-floor lobby to attend the required orientation and introduction to the school.

A large group of higher-level students had gathered to cheer for the incoming freshmen, who were slowly entering the center of the room one by one.

“All of you are here because of the unique magic within you. Of course, normal humans weren’t going into the school since our faculty easily evaded those who lacked this magic,” the principal said from the stage at the far end of the lobby.

Avery was stunned at this strange introduction and was not aware of the straight change in the room. He was soon to witness the sight that would change his life forever.

It was a celebration, with vibrant colors bursting into the air like none other. And the principal was the one to declare the next phase.

“That’s right!” the principal continued, addressing the crowd below him. “Welcome to the Official School of New York City, the first and prime institute in the U.S. for Mystical Beings!”

Chapter 3: The Rankings

Magic—the vibrant glowing kind that would emit from thin air—burst from all the students and glittered the air. There were chants of "huwahs" and "yeahs" as soon as the principal said the interesting words, "Mystical Beings."

Avery thought at first that everyone else received some sort of fan merchandise, but upon further inspecting the raised hands in the room, he saw no such indications.

Being the closest, Ted's hands glowed with a faint silver light as he released his magic into the air as confetti along with the crowd.

A large cheer went into the air so the principal decided to wait a moment for the students to settle down.

It was a sight as all the students had stayed conserved and then all let out a deep sigh altogether through the use of magic for the first time of the school year.

During the commotion, Avery tapped Ted and spoke in a raised voice, "What's going on? And also, what are Mystical Beings?"

As someone hard-programmed for self-reliance for solving problems, even now, the boy had no way to even comprehend what he experienced.

Ted shrugged as if unfazed by such a mean joke, but after a second of comtemplating the fact and receiving no remark of "just kidding," he shuddered and almost jumped in shock.

"You're not serious, are you?" he said sternly in disbelief.

"What do you mean?" Avery replied back blankly. "I really don't know what's going on."

"—You don't know about magic… or even Mystical Beings? H—uh—How–?!!" Ted rambled, now in disbelief.

Mesmorized by the scene himself but still wanting an answer, Avery simply gestured his hand in a quesitonative tone, "No?"

"Hhhhhh! This is something else!" Ted shouted in complete awe, jaws dropped – not for a good reason of course.

Almost panicking, he began to wobble about, seemingly shuddered by the thought of a mishap and other dangerous prospects brewing.

His voice got drawned in the cheers so no others understood what he stated except for Avery who was concentrating on his dialogue.

His head circulated in thought almost about to burst from being fried from the inside out.

“How’d I stumble into this then? You make it sound like it’s not normal” Avery pointed out, now wary about Ted’s strange reaction.

Avery thought that a simple explanation would’ve been easy to get, but his luck was not faring even with a friend.

Ted’s attention was steered from the celebration as his source of confusion and confuzzlement pounded against his very nerves.

Then he responded, “It’s not! Typically, only the ones with magic powers would be able to interact with the faculty during the challenge. As stated earlier, the faculty have special devices which can sense if you have mana. If not, then they can hide their presence from those people, making the challenge impossible for them to complete.”

It so happened that Ted was more confused about why Avery was at the school at all more than whether he had magic or not.

“So, you say I have magic…? But I would’ve known it all my life or something. This is a lot to process. In a typical situation, you’d expect me to be freaking out, you know?” Avery said this, indicating his brain was not short-circuited compared to Ted’s.

“Yeah sure, whatever. It is what it is,” Ted admitted, finally registering the cold hard facts. “if you were aware of it, you could develop your mana within you. But it seems without a hint of assurance and understanding, the growth of magic potential is basically zero.”

“Huh? You mean like my lack of belief in the assurance of magic’s existence prevented it from manifesting?”

Avery’s slip up of his slight technical expertise was revealed.

“Yeah, seems like you catch on pretty quickly. It is the only logical solution, after all, no mere human has simply entered this school and survived,” Ted gleamed, almost too proud of his method of bringing sense.

"You make it sound so secret," Avery stressed. "Also, mere humans makes it sound like everyone hear is out of the ordinary."

"Ha! Ordinary? That's just a term ot define those with no hope in their life!"

Avery was hurt, after all, he barely survived with a scrap of food per day a few years back. And he was considered ordinary?

"Now that I'm here. I'll learn and catch up quickly," Avery stated, determined.

"Maybe. Humph, Looks like you'll have to take magic basics before catching up even to the rest of the people here."

"You can give me a short summary. I do understand technical concepts, perhaps its easy to grasp."

"Oh, there's a lot more to be said in a short few minutes… our hours—I mean days. You can't simply learn from what is said either though."

"Oh?"

"People like me are Mystical Beings who like living in the human lands since it is relatively cheap and a simple lifestyle. Usually, magic is not shown in public due to security reasons, but it is still a nice perk to have for making life easier," Ted explained.

"You'll have to start honing your magic at the point where a typical Mystical Being toddler would've already finished," he finished.

Avery's face tinged, disturbed by the analogy, "Toddler? I don't know if I want to be compared to that…"

There was no way he'd let his dignity built by his hard work be shattered by a mere insult, so he felt compelled to protest.

"Heh, don't worry. Before a big explanation, first you should get your magic genetics evaluated. That way, we can better assess what to do from there," Ted said this, hoping to weasel his way out of a long lecture, which would be such a drag.

He knew it would take several hours to explain just the bare-bone basics so the boy could go by without being uncovered for his naiveness.

"I think I understand what you're saying, but shouldn't this all be impossible, according to scientific approaches?" Avery questioned further. "You know, evidence to back all this up?"

"Oh, there's an in-depth explanation of the sciences behind it, but that's a later high school or even college course that isn't important right now… ahem, I mean details that are too complicated and may even halt your potential development."

"You would think what I know would help me to understand better, after all, I do understand the physics of a lot of things," Avery noted, looking into the air.

He thought back on the numerous textbooks he read out of sheer boredom. Some of it, however, was practical for enhancing his alleyway refrigerator box home while others were just to pass time and get geeky.

Looking about, he noticed slight differences between the students, especially the upperclassmen. Some students had pointed ears, unusual hair colors, something resembling more of an animal's ears, and unique eye colors.

He almost felt stupid for lnot recognizing such obvious details prior.

"So alongside magic, there are different species, like those in light novels?"

"Yep," Ted responded. "Though it doesn't really matter that much. Species are more of a designation and representation of the characteristics and magical affinity one would possess."

"I'm supposing there's a way to hide one's such characteristics?"

"In a way, but not entirely. Best use is concealing artifacts, but they're pretty expensive, hehe."

"Artifacts…?"

"Anyhow, the mechanisms of the Mystical world is yours for the taking, if you're up for it," Ted interjected.

"Right, I must now believe this to be so."

Avery, being calm and rational now, was able to sort through the vast knowledge recently handed to him.

He was not the typical person in the past who would freak out or be stunned. Now that he grasped his position, moving forward was key.

It was at this point in the modern age where such thing's didn't surprise anyone. In fact, it would result in a major scientific breakthrough of a plane non-Mystical humans have barely scratched the surface of.

Focusing back on the present, Avery decided to make sense of it all later.

"Let's discuss more later," he stated, concluding the conversation for now to focus on the current celebration.

"Sure thing… though it may not be easy," Ted warned.

"It's not like I can go back now. Worrying about it is pointless anyways," Avery smirked.

"Uh, sure," Ted responded, shrugging.

Ted was glad to not have to answer other questions regarding him to think. In his mind, he preplanned all the times where he would use his brain and the other times where he'd rest and be lazy.

Once the cheers died down, the principal invited some fellow students to take the podium and give a few remarks, thus extending the time the students would stand. And Avery and Ted just thought they'd be wrapped up there.

The remainder of the event was a bit muddled since the duo felt drowsy when each student came up and blabbed about how the school was good, the education was superb, etc…, and all the other stuffy *typical* details.

Once the boring stuff dragged on for far enough, the principal reintroduced himself again.

Bringing everyone's attention back into the moment, he concluded the opening remarks and laid some simple school ground rules that spanned another few minutes.

He had a strange sort of passionate tone that was almost contagious. Speaking about the do's and don'ts of the school really irked the ears of the students as they felt pleasure imagining loopholes in said rules.

This, of course, brought the mood and energy up again.

"Now that we've come to an end, you are all dismissed," the principal finally said, releasing all the students from their misery after what seemed like another hour of idle talk and nothing else.

Only a few of the students stayed and introduced themselves to one another. The rest rumbled out of there hoping to avoid any other sudden events.

Friends, socializing, community—It was a bit difficult for Avery to fit himself in as his verbal interactions with other people was very minimal, even in his foster years. This didn't sway him much as he anticipated there were other dire oppertunities to partake in in the broad future.

He still hadn't had sufficient time to collect his thoughts but he believed allowing the circumstances mold him would be the best push through each day.

The rest of the evening was spent touring the rest of the building, going through lectures of additional mandates, visiting the cafeteria, exploring the gym, and adjusting to the new school life.

***

On the next day, orientation really began. Not that yesterday wasn't, but because the school still had more to educate their students on prior to official classes.

Avery headed alone to the dining hall on the fifth floor to grab a hearty breakfast. To his surprise, it was rather amusing.

A large open area for chairs, tables, and trash cans. On the perimeter of the room, various food stations displayed the delicious options from a distance. Intricate honeycomb crevices scattered the gorund sizable enough that entire tables and chairs were nested comfortably.

The same honeycomb detailing scattered the wall as asthetics for those zoning out while waiting in line.

Avery found an intriguing omelet stand and received a red fiery piping hot omelet which captivated him first by the smell. Finding a table open near a group of intriguing students, he sat down in hopes of making a few new friends.

Seating himself propoerly, he overheard the students discussing their training regimen.

"Perhaps I may learn a few things simply from snooping," Avery mumbled as he nibbled on a slice of the omelet on his fork.

Though he admitted eavesdropping was wrong, this form was okay since he was close enough to overhear and the other students didn't seem to be bothered by his presence—if it had been registered by them, that is.

Glancing over, Avery noticed the sheer muscularity of one of the students in particular. His hands were large enough to stretch the entire size of the breakfast plates the food was served upon. He wore a stretched-out muscle shirt of the famous Acitas clothing brand showing off his eight-pack abs formed underneath.

The other two students sitting opposite were just as built but not quite as menacing looking as the former. One wore a yellow beach shirt while the other had on a simple black t-shirt, both stretched to fit their physique.

They all dug into the large pork slices in front of them, chewing effortlessly, making the meat seem like dough. As far as Avery could tell, they were pure monsters who shouldn't be riled with.

All three of them wore strange bands on their upper right arm with the label, "Intern," which Avery suspected could be misleading given they were actually students his age.

Then again, he didn't want to conclude anything as they could probebly be transfer students from another school helping out or something of the like. Or perhaps they were actually old men lacking proper education.

By their slouchy posture, unfitting attitude, and questionable habits, Avery couldn't imagine all three of them having more than just a few brain cells shared amongst themselves.

"—So anyway. I believe I'll be ranked pretty high since I've been training my muscles in tune with my magic," the most muscular guy in the tank-top stated, clearly dominating the conversation as a leader of the gang would.

"Way to go boss, no one stands a chance. You may even be the top student at Regnum Academy at this rate, hehehehhe," the beach-shirted student assured.

Turning his head, the tank-top guy instantly noticed Avery.

"And who is this dainty looking shrimp?" he asked, obviously getting the impression from Avery's small complexion.

Nearly jumping in his seat, Avery tensed up and gave no response. The big guy's stare and gruff tone discomforted the boy's neutral nature.

The other two also took note of Avery.

"Must be one of the other new students here, boss," the black shirted guy stated, as if to bunch all other students in one category lower than themselves.

"Well, uhh," Avery spoke, scratching his head, "my name is Avery Obtainia."

"Heh, normal name for someone as small as you. Name's Billy Bones Acitas. You'd better remember it," the tank-top guy threatened.

"Uhh sure. I won't do such a thing," Avery spoke quickly. He wasn't scared of the trio but was intimidated by them.

Stuffing a huge pork slice into his mouth with his bare hands, Billy gestured his hand towards the other two guys.

"These are my comrades Frank Bower and Josh Hake."

Josh, in the beach shirt, smirked and Frank, in the black t-shirt, simply nodded. Both of them seemed uninterested with Avery and continued feasting into their massively piled plates of meat.

"So… what's this rank system you're talking about?" Avery asked, changing the subject, hinting for a lighter mood.

"You don't know?" Frank laughed. "Ranking of magic, of course. Stupid people like you should know that!"

"Ah yes, that," Avery replied, pretending to be familiar with it, and hiding his scawl from being called stupid.

"We'll be doing it just to flex our power over the vast majority of the shrimps here!" Frank hallered.

Avery caught on now, just about everyone else was called inferior to the trio as their hulking size were incomparable.

Then Josh added, "No way someone like you can ever reach the level of…"

"All right," Billy interrupted, "let's be nice, boys. Anyway, you'd better not annoy us, otherwise you'd get what you deserve."

Though he seemed to be speaking to his dish as a threat, the last sentence was obviously directed at Avery.

As the one calling the others to behave, the head seemed unaware of his verbal abuse. So much for being nice.

"Heheh… I won't bother you guys," Avery laughed nervously as he quickly ate the remainder of his dish and rushed away.

He sighed and loosed up when he was well distant from the cronies. That was a proper name for students like them.

"Yeah, finally that boy got lost. I hate little pipsqueaks like him," Josh huffed loudly as Avery retreated barely out of ear shot.

"Whatever," Billy said, uninterested.

"Tsk, like who's the judge of character here?" Avery mused. He hadn't expected to meet such jerks even at the established side of humanity.

***

After breakfast, Avery met up with Ted who was making his way to the first orientation item on the list.

Striding up the stairs, Ted looked intently at the schedule flier he held in his hands, checking and rechecking the times to be certain.

"So, what is scheduled for today?" Avery asked, jumping on the bandwagon of his sorted plans.

"Starting later we have normal classes that any typical school would have. But the interesting thing this morning is the magic level tests and obtaining our very own identification cards."

"Oh really? But you've been staring at the flier for a while now. What's up?"

Ted rubbed his neck. "Hehe, I'm just trying to figure out where to squeeze my gaming time."

Avery's jaws dropped, "That's what you're worried about?"

"It's more than just that. I'm testing some new hardware that just came in today," Ted exclaimed, drooling at the thought.

His creepy evil laugh immediately after did not help his argument.

The two then continued climbing the stairs, neither feeling tired even though the challenge made them beat yesterday.

"So, tell me about this Mystical ranking system?" Avery asked, pleading that Ted would be more useful than the bullies.

"Oh right. I forgot about that. Anyway, simply put, the ranking system is just a way of identifying individuals to their specific power level which is a combination of their mana capacity and strength.

"Tier 0 is obviously no magic, Tier 1 and so on just scales the amount of magic you have. Tier 10 is the highest level attainable, but super rare unless you train very hard. And when I say very hard, it takes decades for even geniuses.

"Right, geniuses unlike you," Avery sarcastically replied, after being unable to help himself point out the obvious.

"Bruh, that's too cruel. I'm so going to reach Tier 10 eventually."

"Oh, 'eventually' as in… it can improve?"

"Of course! Now, the rankings here for students vary but are generally low to mid-average as the innate mana capacity is lower at birth and must be developed."

"Oh, I see. It's the same as an RPG system."

"In terms of games, I think describing it that way is concise enough."

"So, the more you train, the more magic you can use and the stronger it is," Avery concluded.

"Hmm… yeah that sums it up. So, in your case, you probably barely have any magic in you since you didn't use it as a child up to this point."

"What do you mean?"

"I'm not much of a neurologist, but basically magic in the form of energy is called mana which develops along with your body. Using and harnessing your magic throughout your body helps your magic flow better and release purer."

"Oh interesting… I never asked but what's your magic?" Avery inquired.

"Mine's metal. I can essentially create metal and such by converting mana into physical matter," Ted boasted.

"Ah, I see. Fancy stuff. Seems kinda OP."

"Yep."

"So magic is a definite energy that can create any matter. I'm guessing it's scaled by the amount you use before being drained," Avery ascertained.

"Our genetics define the type of elements our magic is. There are four main elements: fire, wind, earth, and water. Those elements are defined further by yin and yang, light and darkness," Ted clarified. "Oh yeah, magic follows the law of conservation of energy where it cannot be created or destroyed, only transferred either in the air, other living things, etc…"

"How is magic created? You know, like what materials make magic?"

"That's a complicated topic, but the gist is that magic can be obtained from both non-magical and magical sources. In the simplest terms, most molecular structures are built with magic and energy, thus, breaking it down allows our bodies to transfer the magic to other areas."

"Hmm, I suspect that magic essentially is a supernatural energy used to construct or destroy by altering the elements around it."

"Yeah, I think that's how my middle school lecture went," Ted contemplated.

"Think you could teach me how to start using magic?" Avery proposed.

"You just gotta feel it man. And then it'll just come out like… boom!" Ted waved his arms outwards in an arch to describe his statement.

"I lost you there," Avery said, scratching his head.

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Once arriving at floor ten, the duo went into the largest room on the floor: the gym. It was a typical gym with basketball floor detailing and hoops on either side. Bleachers lined the sides of the field.

A strange transparent ball mounted on a mechanical stand at the center of the basketball quart intrigued Avery. Typically, lots of students were bunched together to be the first to touch the ball.

"All new students, make a single neat line right behind this crystal ball at the center. I'm Prefect Calvin Cloy, so don't hassle or stagger the line," a student shouted from a handheld megaphone mic.

Some of the students contifnued fumbling around to be the closest to the front of a misshaped line.

The Prefect, now nearest to the crystal ball, shoved the students backwards. "Come on, seriously. You don't know what a straight line looks like?"

Avery and Ted stood at a distance perplexed at the sight.

"Were they homeschooled or something?" Avery remarked.

"Nah, it's their egos taking over. Most of the Mystical Beings who live here are rich big shots, as you've probably noticed so far."

"By the way, how come you're not one of those rich snobs?" Avery realized.

"It's complicated. But in summary, my family was basically exiled out of the Mystical Island. We didn't have a lot of money to begin with."

"An island?"

"Most of the Mystical Beings live on separate islands that the normal humans cannot find."

"Ah. There just seems to be more and more that I don't know," Avery shrugged. "Perhaps I should read a friendly introductory book. Don't they have one of those?"

"Good luck finding something like that. Most details are primitive knowledge everyone knows. And if you were interested in the Mystical species, it would be an entiere study of history, geography, and magic."

"Yeah, thanks for that."

When the line finally took shape, Avery and Ted came up to the end and watched on the side as the first student approached the crystal ball. Avery shivered at the sight of Billy and his gang ahead in the line.

"Simply place your hand on the crystal ball and it will measure the amount of magic you have. It will also announce the magic affinity you possess and create a license card showing your rank and stats," the Prefect explained. "Now hop to it. We don't have all day."

"Uhh right," the student up front responded timidly as he placed his hand on top of the crystal ball. The ball glowed with a bright brown hue and then a card popped out of the mechanical stand.

The Prefect picked up the card and read aloud, "You are Kashi Nishi–whatever.

"Your magic affinity is earth, specifically mud magic.

"Your species type is a Terralor.

"It seems your power is a low average which ranks you to, roughly Tier 1: *Commonus*.

"Your strength is okay, making you roughly slightly below average."

The Prefect handed the card to the student and ushered for the next in line to step forwards.

"So, what's a Terralor? And what are the rankings?" Avery asked.

"A human species with tougher skin than average Mystical Beings. Typically, Terralors have earth-based affinities," Ted responded.

"Huh, interesting... but... uhhh, mud magic?"

"Yeah mud magic, I'm sort of lucky to have something denser. As for the rankings, called tiers, there are ten in the following order: *Commonus*, *Bonus*, *Altus*, *Magnus*, *Maximus*, *Bonus Dominus*, *Altier Dominus*, *Magna Domina*, *Maximus Dominus*, and *Ultimus Dominus*. Tier o has no name. Each of these tiers above *Commonus* have distinct levels from one to three which separates even further the power gap between individuals."

"That's so unoriginal. Let me guess: Latin."

"Uh huh. But, technically, it's a pretty old system adopted from ancient times. I think it sounds kindof cool!"

"Ok. How about strength, how's that calculated?"

"The magical crystal has a special device with some sort of electromagnetic wave scanner that can check an individual's dexterity, especially in their muscle fibers. At least that is what I thought..."

Numerous students touched the crystal ball in an orderly fashion which peaked Avery's attention since he learned the various magic affinities and species.

When it was Billy's turn, the Prefect, having recognized him, changed his mood to address his social position.

"Hi there, Mr. Billy Acitas, very respectable intern for this school. Please kindly place your hand on the crystal ball."

The word "intern" was a trigger point as Billy gave a twisted face as he glared around the room.

The Prefect had been passively tearing every student up to this point but hearing a change of tone really surprised everyone else.

"Whatever," Billy said uninterested.

Billy placed his hand firmly on the ball. The ball then glowed a bright crimson red color.

Picking up the newly produced card, the Prefect read aloud, "Ooo, intriguing. Billy Bones Acitas, you're quite the strong one.

"Your magic affinity is strength, specifically strength enhancement magic.

"You're one of the great Magnivirigentis species.

"Your power is way above average which makes you roughly Tier 4: *Magnus*, Level 2.

"Your strength is at the top five percent of Mystical Beings, making you the strongest one here.

After handing him a unique license card, Billy briskly walked off with his compatriots when their rankings finished.

When it was Ted's turn, the Prefect stated the usual. Ted placed his hand on the crystal ball and a card popped out of the stand.

Picking it up, the Prefect read, "Teddric Tech.

"Your magic affinity is metal.

"You are a Metalor.

"Your power is above average which ranks you at Tier 2: *Bonus*, Level 3.

"Your strength is above average, decent I suppose."

After Ted's card was handed to him, he stepped aside and waited for Avery. It was finally Avery's turn. This was the moment where he would learn more about himself.

Avery stepped forwards and placed his hand onto the crystal ball. At first, no light emitted, but then a bright radiating white light shone from the ball.

"Interesting," the Prefect stated intrigued. He picked up the card and examined it. "Avery Obtainia.

"Your magic affinity is light.

"You are an Angelor, a… less common species.

"Your power is barely readable, below average, making you rank 1: *Commonus*.

"Your strength is above average."

The Prefect handed the license card to Avery. An uproar stirred around the room in shock and amazement. Uncomfortable with the spotlight, Avery rushed out of the room.

Avery caught up with Ted and the duo walked towards their next destination. Shadowing the emptiest routes, Avery and Ted passed through a narrow hall unused by typical students.

“Dude! How in the world?” Ted exclaimed, astonished at the reveal. He hustled with excitement.

“I don’t know. I’m as shocked as everyone else,” Avery blurted, taking the situation uncomfortably.

“The magical ball is never wrong, however, word about your power will spread like wildfire, don’t fret over it. Many might deduce that you recently learned about your own magic, hehe.”

“Is that a bad thing?” Avery doubted, taking Ted’s joke seriously.

“Depends.”

Walking along in silence and releasing all the tensions, Avery ‘s usual cheeriness returned.

“So, anyway, what is an Angelor?” he asked.

“A species strong in magic and usually have affinities in light or fire. They have the ability to fly due to their unique characteristic: their wings… which is sort of where the origin of the name comes from.”

“Well obviously I can’t be one since I don’t have wings,” Avery denied.

“Well, you’re still premature. The presence of magic slowly changes the development of the body.”

“If it’s puberty, it’s probably too late,” Avery remarked sarcastically.

“For Mystical Beings, it’s much different,” Ted declared. “Don’t worry. You’ll have plenty of chances of increasing your mana capacity. Physicality grows with magic. Many attributes are very established for powerful Mystical Beings, who then tend to not remain in the mainlands.

“Anyhow, PE is specifically oriented towards magical training. Of course in your past, I guess, not being aware of your magic presence can strongly affect the overall growth of magic, that being your case, you’ve barely honed it at all.”

“Thanks for the insight. It was very encouraging.”

“Happy to oblique.”

“Anyway, what’s the point of the scoring system?” Avery asked.

“Its main purpose is the ranking system, as you know, however, the numbers themselves only indicate the amount of magic or strength you have, but none of that

guarantees intelligence or dexterity… and a bunch of other skills or experiences. It was a newly added system to ensure the authenticality of the individual who partakes in a challenge with a specific requirement."

"I see… so it's more of a status type of thing to regulate your progress."

"That's one way of putting it. But the levels are not merely a flex but a way of displaying one's true capabilities. The rankings take account of all of one's abilities, so the true gap between each level is quite big. Cheap magic artifact runes like that ball would't measure a strong one's magic."

"I appreciate your help, Ted," Avery acknowledged passionately.

"Where'd this come from? It's nothing, you know. Happy to help! It makes me feel good, you know."

Every word of Avery's was genuine. He was glad to enter this new life with a patient friend like Ted, the second person whom he respected shortly after their introduction.

Just as the man had elaborated briefly, finding someone and befriending them made one's own actions quite contrary to their usual ones.

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Several days had passed and Avery got used to this new life that he so eagerly wanted.

Every day, except for the weekends, was the same: breakfast, two classes, lunch, one more class, PE, another class, dinner, and then chill time.

To call it chill time might've been a stretch; the choices were to do class activities and stress about homework later, and vice versa.

Avery didn't care too much about the schedule. He liked his new life and was not complaining one bit, well except for the magic learning part. He had slowly developed his mana levels to a point where he felt the mana coursing through his body, just barely.

The school, once thoroughly analyzed, was basically the same as a college, of sorts. Though the classes and curfew times were mandatory, the time gaps in-between could be filled with almost any imaginable activity or club.

With a vibrant library and stockpiled funds, the students had access to almost any resource for advanced projects.

A few more days had passed, that night at the dorm, Avery was practicing his magic release as usual.

He felt the magic coursing through his body easier, thanks to Ted who explained the methods of feeling it.

Avery still couldn't understand Ted's verbal directions, but he was surprised he could mimic Ted's awkward demonstrations.

Avery had attempted multiple times now this evening to release his magic only to yield muscle aches as results. His body could take one more attempt before becoming numb.

"At the core of one's heart lies the origin of one's mana. Just let it all release and go… bam!" Ted demonstrated an explosion from his chest outwards. "Can you feel it?"

Avery, concentrating intently, replied, "Yes, I'm getting it. Just painful… that's all."

Ted multitasked again, both teaching Avery and playing another video game.

Similar to moving a muscle that has never been moved before, Avery aimed his full attention within his body to release all the magic. He began pushing the magic outwards towards his arms.

"Trying to direct the magic to your fingers like a snake slithering along a river," Ted suggested.

He happened to be killing a large snake in his RPG game, thus, his analogy was shallow and very unoriginal.

"Remember, the releasing of magic is called discharge and is crucial for the application of any magical situation. You do remember that brief explanation in class, right?"

"Of course I do. I think I paid more attention than kyou, but okay." Avery felt the mana surging further down his right arm.

He decided to focus on a small section rather than a large area. Clenching his teeth and flexing his arms, Avery's mana sped up and circulated around the palm of his hands.

"So, you told me that the release of magic should feel weird?"

"Yep," Ted nodded. "Like a geyser about to pop."

With a burst, similar to holding one's breath for a long period and releasing it, Avery's magic ignited in its matter form for the first time.

A small flame-shaped white light hovered slightly above Avery's palm. He sensed the mana leaking out of his hands and memorized the feeling and tension. He grinned at this accomplishment.

Though the magic released had no color, as far as Avery could tell, it felt warm, bright, and gentle. His fingers didn't seem to ache anymore, and as a result, he felt confident on future attempts. Surprisingly, it obviously did not feel like a geyser popping, instead, more like wiggling a sleeping muscle awake.

Glancing over his shoulder, Ted witnessed the sight. "Congratulations! Now you just have to continue honing it till it becomes natural. Also, you'll have to learn to manipulate it to some extent. Right now, you're also oozing a lot of unnecessary unused mana as a form of vapor."

Avery's smile faltered a bit. "Oh, come on. Must you be so unfazed and critical?"

Ted smirked. "Nah bro. Where's the fun in that?"

After practicing a bit longer, Avery slumped into his bed looking up into the ceiling. Ted continued to grind his video game. Avery had turned off the lights which only made the intense flashes of Ted's RPG fights more noticeable.

"Tell me Ted, what is your goal in life?"

"To start my own video game company… and to earn more money so I can fund more invention projects."

"Ah I see. Sounds like a fantastic goal. For me, I still haven't found what I can contribute myself to yet. You see, starting my new life here, I don't know what I really want to do. With the introduction of magic, the possibilities only expanded. But deep down, I want to find the place where I belong… er, not really belong, but where I can gain the bonds and friendships that could help me grow personally."

Avery knew that much now from his experience hanging out with Ted.

"I don't know. Seems like your past is shaping what you seek for the future. Though you are aware of what you might do, you don't have to choose now. My goals were only inspired by what I'm good at!" Ted emphasized.

"I'm only who I am now from this man I met three years ago," Avery said. Then he explained his journey up to this point: his orphanage years, his street beggar life, and finally his three years of fulfilling a prestigious goal.

“I won’t pry about your hardships but it seems like whatever conditions you lived in have shaped your calm personality. Usually, from what I understand, one who rises from poverty tends to lose their knowledge of their past identity.”

“Well, I suppose it's all thanks to that man I met.”

“This man you speak of seems interesting. And you said you were at ATLAS of all places. Perhaps it has ties to magic…”

“Magic? … huh,” Avery stated, intrigued, “Anyway, where can magic thrive the best anyway?”

“The Mystical Island,” Ted stated. “It’s a place of the future and a society where magic is free.”

“Have you been there?”

“No. I’ve lived my entire life here. My parents can’t go back, so I am not motivated to go there.”

Avery turned and looked out the window at the bright skyscrapers towering through the pitch-black skyline.

“The world really is something,” he muttered as he drifted to sleep.

Overhearing, Ted shrugged. “Hopefully he finds what will make him complete, but…”

Ted stopped himself and continued grinding in silence.

Chapter 4: Cabin in the Forest

Ahhh! Why did it turn out this way? Avery thought as he charged down the streets of New York chased by the thugs.

These ruffians were none other than Billy and his cronies Frank Bower and Josh Hake. Being interns and all, it seemed the school didn't mind their abusive behavior.

It was the last day of the weekend now, exactly one week since Avery first entered OSNYC to take the exam.

The situation Avery got himself into escalated quite rapidly when he exited the school to run a few personal errands.

Clearly word had spread at this point of Avery's species type and low magical power since it was rare and all, uncommon, and distasteful to some. Of course, Billy never liked weak shrimps, but he was particularly annoyed with Avery's mere existence.

Billy wanted some sort of valid reason to meddle with Avery, so as Avery exited the school, he accidentally knocked into Avery's path on purpose.

Pretending to take the full force of the collision, Billy's rear contacted the ground.

"Why you little…!" Billy roared.

Seeing the situation revolving quickly, Avery made a dart for it.

He didn't want to get into a major conflict. Making matters worse, Billy's cronies were only extra witnesses in support against him.

Gaining a safe distance, Avery glanced behind him to see Billy getting up and becoming serious by flexing his popping knuckles. He wasn't too weary as he knew he had run away from nearly large dudes like Billy in the past.

And so, Billy's pursuit brought Avery into the current predicament.

On a weekend, the streets were fairly busy so Avery's evasion from pedestrians only slowed him down whereas Billy charged through them like a raging bull.

Just from noticing those large muscles, Avery knew that he stood no chance if he fought against Billy. His magic power was still in its rudimentary phase. No chance would it even make him wince.

Thus, the showdown began. The race of sheer muscle power vs endurance. As soon as Avery stops, the game would be over.

Now hundreds of meters from the school, Avery's former plans were foiled now that he ran opposite from his desired route.

Finding a sharp corner wedged between two buildings, Avery thought he might be able to fool Billy, so he sped up and maneuvered quickly around the corner. To his bad luck, he bumped into a girl from around the corner.

"Ahhh…" cried the girl.

"Oh ow!" Avery tensed as his head took the brunt of the force. He knelt to his knees using his hands on his hands to absorb the pain.

The girl staggered a bit and then fell into the boy's arms, her face within inches from the boy's and her caramel hair flowing and touching his ears. The impact only stung her right arm as it crushed against Avery's skull.

The girl quickly removed her arm from her face and was a bit reluctant to make a sudden move with her feet.

"It's you," Avery said, eying at the girl, but quickly trying to process the situation and fix his mistake.

She had a sensational fragrance about her that would've been pleasing to contemplate on but the situation called hardly any time for it.

It was the same hooded girl Avery knocked into earlier after the exam. She seemed to have taken the obscure route since it conjoined two streets.

Now that Avery really analyzed it, the obscure route was more of a creepy alleyway.

Recognizing who the boy was, the girl spoke, "U-uh… we meet again. Sorry about before."

"Oh, don't worry about it."

He got up and helped her up and ensured that nothing was wrong. Obviously he'd get the major brashing from whatever higher up who hears of his incident of injuring a girl.

Avery then surveyed his surroundings before preparing to sprint again.

“W-What’s the rush?” the girl called after he ran a short distance, still transmissible for conversation.

Finding it rude to not respond, Avery stopped in his tracks.

“Uh, I’m being chased. Got to hurry away.”

Finding explaining would take too long, Avery suspected the girl would only be collateral as Billy rampaged here. He grabbed her arm and continued running with no choice but dragging the girl along.

“What are you doing?” the girl shouted with a mild volume that was clearly straining for her.

“Billy Bones Acitas is chasing me. Got to get away fast!”

The girl’s eyes widened, revealing her emerald sparkling eyes even more. “Y-You could’ve told me that!”

Glancing behind him, Avery replied, “He’s right behind our tail now. Oh, very bad now.”

No amount of beggar’s life could prepare him to face the monster of a human chasing him. He would flee from risky situations, but unlike the games of cat and house, this was essentially a deadly manhunt.

With the target in sight, Billy leaped with tremendous force and landed before Avery and the girl, denting the ground around him in a crater too unpleasant to be fixed.

The cronies arrived at the scene not long after, cornering Avery and the girl.

“Now, who’s running from me,” Billy berated. “But hey, thanks for leading us right to a private scene for business to be exacted.”

As Billy said this, Avery looked around and saw no pedestrians. They were also sandwiched between the bullies and the two buildings on either side.

Looking up, Avery saw a raven perched on an air vent stuck to the side of the building. Judging the situation, no one but the animals would witness this scene.

“L-let’s just talk this out guys,” Avery suggested, extending his hands. “I’m sure there’s just a misunderstanding. Let’s talk this out.”

“Oh yeah and why’s that?” Billy demanded while flexing his arms, untested by any pleading.

“Uh, I’m sorry if, you know, I knocked you over.”

"SORRY! HA! Yeah right. There's nothing to be sorry about," Billy roared.

"Uh, why's that?"

Avery thought the whole reason he was being chased was because he bumped into Billy. He was now more worried than perplexed.

"Peh, because I intended things to come out this way," Billy cleared up.

He also gargled his throat to unclog an insurmountable amount of boogers as he spat on the ground at his side.

Stepping closer, he lifted Avery by the collar into the air in one effortless swipe.

"Your mere existence disgusts me. It was one of your kind that ruined my life. I think all demihumans should just die. You don't even deserve to go to such a luxury school like OSNYC!"

"Uh boss, I don't think he's a demihuman, is he?" Josh analysed with his narrowed eyes with confusion.

"So what! He is one, there's no doubt," Billy hallered. "All Angelors are, even if they don't seem to have disgusting birdy wings!"

"Uh, what are you talking about? I didn't do anything," Avery spoke as he clawed at Billy's thick grubby mitten fingers. "I'm confused. I-I t-think you got the wrong guy."

"Yeah right," Billy squeezed. "Right or not, I'm taking my frustrations out on you."

"Boss never gets his captured subjects wrong! He's always tight," Frank clarified.

"They're not test subjects… more like captive prisoners—that's more like it!" Billy sneered.

River, witnessing the scene unfold, trembled backwards.

"And who are you?" Frank called, quickly restraining the girl, and forcefully removing her hood.

"Ah it's one of those cute fox girl demihumans! Pleh!" Josh grimaced, quickly kicking the girl away from him while also backing up. "How did another ulger thing get in our path?"

Sure enough, uncovering the hood, the girl's caramel brown hair fell around her shoulders. Instead of regular ears, she had fox ears of the same color located on either side of her head.

Avery turned his head to see the cruelty of the cronies.

"Arrghhh! You…"

His throat choked up from his awful posture in the air and he was unable to say anything else with his throbbing threat.

"So, demihumans are conspiring together huh?" Billy observed, "No matter. I'll make sure both of you drop out of the school. Your existence is worth only as high as the normal non-Mystical humans."

"Huh yeah, I didn't know they allowed regular demihumans here. That's just wrong for any Mystical Society?" Frank observed.

Forcefully tossed downwards, Avery fell to the ground, breaking a few backbones in the process.

"Gah…"

Avery coughed and remained paralyzed with pain.

Pain like this shouldn't feel real, right? Avery thought as he looked into the blue but mostly dusty gray sky.

Billy stepped a foot on Avery's chest, declaring, "Even though my revenge won't be exact, I'll still have a hell of a good time plummeting you near death. Don't worry, we'll just say you got into a fight with a wild raccoon or something."

"They're heinous creatures here, so I heard," Josh added.

Grinning madly, Billy twisted his foot, increasing the pain.

"Try reporting me if you get away, that is if you do, but I doubt anybody would believe you."

The other bullies trembled in laughter.

The girl trembled in horror while the cronies watched in delight.

"You got it boss."

"Go boss!"

The cheers of the cronies didn't make the situation any better. Avery winced as Billy pressed his foot harder.

"Don't worry about it. I will make your pain short and sweet," Billy cackled, flashing his white teeth in triumph. "Perhaps you might see your life flashing before your eyes, hehe. Don't worry, I won't kill you or anything. That would just be wrong, wouldn't it."

His threats now were beyond sanity. Standing and watching the scene was even worse, thus, the cronies were simply inhumane.

Then, not a moment later, Billy was instantly thrown back in shock. As he stood up his cheek was bloody, and a dent formed in his pudgy face.

Avery quickly got up and ran a distance to see the girl not far off staring at him. His body writhed in pain, urging him to shut down, but adrenaline pumped him along.

Giving up in a sorry state in front of evil aggressors was the last thing he intended to do.

When the cronies were captivated at the scene, they forgot about their captive for a short moment, thus giving the girl a window to crawl away to throw a rock. Despite her fright, she still instinctively acted.

"WHO THREW THE ROCK!!!!!!!?" Billy roared as he smeared his bloody face with his hand only making his appearance more disgusting.

Avery quickly bolted away as Billy locked his red flaming mad eyes at him.

He passed between the two stunned cronies and continued running alongside the girl who took the charge.

He could feel his heat and blood burning up, keeping him in overdrive mode.

If there was one thing to say about the bullies, their brains were as single minded as their muscular size.

"Aaarrrggghhh! Go get them!" Billy shouted, blinking back into reality.

"Sorry."

"Sorry boss."

The bullies obeyed Billy's command, confused as to where Avery and the girl headed.

"YOU dummies! Just go!!"

Frank and Josh took the street across the alleyway from where the girl originally came from, thus, broadening the distance between Avery and the girl.

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Avery and the girl had been running for some time and it seemed that the bullies had lost them, for the moment anyway.

Although bruised and slightly grzed, River remained fine except for the extended distance on foot.

Avery, however, had put his body into overdrive as he continued to walk, but his pain about his body slowly diminished as time went along.

Finding an entrance into central park, they scrambled through a narrow passageway obscured by trees.

Following the path until the trees grew in size and width, the duo found a sizable tree and rested against it.

As soon as he stopped, Avery collapsed before the trunk of the tree. At this point, he could feel his body becoming numb.

“Awh… argh,” he groaned, “That was close. Thanks for that back there.”

The girl, realizing that Avery was referring to the rock she threw, nodded and then shyly replied, “Uh, take it easy, I-I’m sure your body is in a worse position than the f-fear I felt.”

Though the pain was half the intensity it was initially, River sensed that the damage was taxing his body.

“Yet you managed to… arghh… distract them.”

“Well, I-I just did what I could.”

“What’s your name by the way?”

“My-my name is River Grant,” the girl responded shyer than before.

“I’m Avery Obtainia, glad to meet you again despite our circumstances” Avery introduced, resting himself against the tree. “Anyway, I remember now. You’re a Naiad and you have water magic, according to the crystal ball rankings.”

“Y-yes,” River replied, “I used my waterpower to reinforce the rock.”

“Whoa cool! Water magic is sure something, huh.”

“It’s r-really not anything s-special,” River assured. “I’m just s-surprised you're not fazed.”

“Regardless of how the event transpired, there’s nothing to do at the end but first realize you're alive… at least that is what I’d like to say is the honest truth.”

“W-what?”

“I’m okay now. Was more worried about you though.”

"I-I'm fine. Thank you for your consideration."

After the heavy breathing from the pair could subside, now all that they could hear was nature all around them.

"So, what type of species are Naiads?" Avery inquired, eager to learn yet another type of species.

"They're h-humans with characteristics of sea creatures, particularly water breathing and manipulation of freshwater."

Avery realized that River had already caught on with the news that circulated throughout the school of his lack of magic knowledge.

"How did all these species come to be?" Avery inquired.

"W-well. In the past, DNA was heavily impacted by magic, thus, creating different affinities, attributes, and species."

"I mean if you're a Naiad, how come you have fox ears?"

"I-it's from one of my parents who was a demihuman."

"Oh well it's kind of cute," Avery lied. It was actually really cute. Something completely existent in only anime and manga fiction really was real and he was happy to know the true origins of such features.

"I-it's r-really not anything s-special," River fumbled, blushing, and placing the hood over her head to avoid the attention.

Then there was a moment of silence, except for the natural beauty of the forest.

"So, anyway, what is this forest?" Avery asked, looking about the peaceful scenery. "I've never been here before."

He spotted a few wildlife, particularly some squirrels, birds, and a raven, throughout the trees nearby.

"This place is called Weeping Willows. I just happen to remember from studying a map of the city," River responded, a lot more confident.

"Oh interesting, never knew that a whole section of Central Park was shrouded in such large trees," Avery remarked.

Pressing his hand against his chest where Billy placed pressure, Avery felt magic pulsing from his hands. His hand began glowing with a bright pink light. Near the light, his chest began easing up from its former pain.

"W-what's going on?" River asked, startled.

Avery raised his glowing hand. "I think it's my magic. It seems to have healing properties because… I feel much better now."

"H-how'd you know…?"

Feeling his magic reaching its limit, Avery dispersed the magic and felt his chest.

"I suspected that it might work. I realized something from practicing earlier. Most of the pain around my body seems to just go numb as time went along."

"Healing magic is r-rare to come by."

"Oh really?"

"Usually, it's a mage spell that requires meticulous magic manipulation and concentration," River explained.

"Maybe because I have light magic."

"P-perhaps, but not likely. Light magic itself doesn't change the physical characteristics of someone or s-something."

"Well, I suppose there's still a lot to learn."

After resting for a bit, Avery felt confident in his ability to walk again… for the most part. River, who had only been traumatized, seemed to hold up well physically.

He effortlessly stood tall and stretched his back which surprisingly did not hurt at all despite knowing he disjointed some bones.

Looking about, Avery pursued for some sort of exit from the forest. Unfortunately, earlier they were so desperate for escape that they paid no attention to their surroundings.

"Well anyway, I guess we will go in one direction until we get out. Central Park can't be that big," Avery chuckled.

Avery took the lead and headed in the direction of the sun barely visible above the shady groves.

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Traversing through the thick forest for some time, Avery and River decided to find a place to chill for a bit. Glancing about, Avery heard something very unusual nearby.

Crouching closer, Avery spotted the voices of humans coming from straight ahead of the path that he and River took.

Avery and River, upon approaching close enough, witnessed the scene by peeking behind a bush a couple hundred feet from the source of the voices.

The voices came from three individuals who plowed their way through the forest to the spot they stood.

"We're looking for a thing. Something I dug up from the archives states it's here," a man, clearly represented as the leader of the three, spoke.

The other two individuals nodded.

River gasped, keeping her voice minimized by placing her hands on her mouth.

"What's wrong?" Avery asked, keeping his voice to a whisper.

"T-That's the infamous Pyrus Bourn," River replied, starting to be overwhelmed. "And the other two are his subordinates: Tom Nado and Tony Smith."

The individual, deemed as the leader named Pyrus Bourn, wore a muddy orange-brown sweater with a pair of baggy black pants. His notable features were his wild bright crimson hair and his burning fiery eyes.

Pyrus pointed at the forest ahead. "Continue the work! No more breaks! You've had plenty already. Don't think I didn't see them!"

Tom Nado, a dark red-haired guy wearing a gray t-shirt and athletic pants, scrambled towards a large truck wedged between several tilted trees. A large fire extinguisher-looking logo was painted on the side with text below it reading, "Fire Increaser Co."

Tony Smith, a black-haired guy wearing black pants and a brown shirt with a rock logo, followed in pursuit after finishing his sandwich.

The two subordinates initiated the truck to life. The truck then roared and began slowly grinding through the forest forward.

Pyrus Bourn eyed around him, but identifying nothing, he trotted alongside the truck.

Believing not to be noticed, Avery and River quickly scrambled away, stepping on leaves, and snapping branches in the process.

Proceeding carefully without being heard, they left the heavy tension behind them as the continued through the willows.

Brushing past bushes and trees, Avery noticed something up ahead.

"Look. It's a cabin, or something," he stated, trudging briskly.

"It really is one," River confirmed.

The duo approached the cabin cautiously. It was old and worn down. The windows were covered and what remained as a yard was overgrown with moss, weeds, and trees. Cobwebs scattered the frames of the windows and birds perched on the mossy roof.

Avery approached the door and read the sign beside it. "*Domus Angelorae*."

"It might be dangerous—w-wait," River faltered.

Glancing at the sign, she gasped at its familiar title.

"I-It can't be. I thought this was long gone."

"What is it? Do you know something?" Avery asked.

He slowly opened the door and peeked inside.

"Well, uhh."

With almost no hesitation, the duo stepped inside. An old couch was stationed at the center of the room, an old kitchen was located on the right, stairs that led up to an upper loft were located at the back.

Not as bad as the condition outside, cobwebs and critters made their dwelling on the inside.

"This place sure needs some cleaning. I wonder who used to live here?" Avery inquired, brushing off a table near a fireplace in the left corner of the room.

"In an famed story from past history called Zenith Luces and the Journey of the Mystical Beings, this cabin used to belong to an Angeloress named Caela Obtainia," River explained, taking note of the cabin's layout. "There's no doubt about it."

"Obtainia? Like my last name, that's strange."

"It's no coincidence. Somehow, you're both connected. I just can't figure out how."

"I mean I never knew my mother, but judging from the condition of this place, you'd think she lived here a long time ago… which sounds kind of hard to believe."

"I-I thought the same, but it's a long story and I can't be certain."

"Huh, you sure know a lot about history and features around these parts…"

“I didn’t know about the existence of this… but, I do have my experiences growing up with these historical events, well… living in an established place that is.”

Avery’s raised his head in thought. “Sounds like you’re experience and knowledge is beyond typical Mystical Beings around these parts.”

“Uh huh.”

Avery bustled about when suddenly his foot had a bump from under the carpet. He knelt to the ground and felt the texture to be certain.

“I think there’s something down here. It felt like some sort of handle.”

As River made her way over, Avery rolled up the carpet to reveal a secret double trapdoor to a basement.

The duo ventured deeper into the basement.

Finding the staircase leading somewhere darker, Avery, now more accustomed to his basic magic, lit a small white flame in his hand and guided the exploration.

Stepping down from the last staircase, Avery and River stood before a single large open room with a curved black panel on one end and shelves of books behind the stairs.

Ancient weapons and tools hung from either side of the room. The spectacle of the scene was the single table at the center holding documents and more tools.

“Strange,” Avery examined a paper he lifted up. “It’s all in Latin.”

“It is the official language of the Mystical Beings,” River said. “But for this area to be untempered with is… odd.”

Avery examined the document carefully.

“Luckily, I spent a little time learning Latin, for no reason but boredom. But this paper here says that this cabin is called the Sky House, an ancient relic of the Angelor clan… or at least that’s how I understand it.”

“Finding a relic of the past is rare. Th-this alone could get you admission to the elite Mystical Being school.”

“Oh really. A strange building called the Sky House?”

“Ancient relics, or rather runes, have all kinds of functions undiscovered to the current civilization.”

Avery picked up a golden circular halo and held it close to his face. “This is a strange object.”

“It’s probably also a rune, perhaps one of the Angelors,” River corrected.

“Huh, I can feel my magic drawing towards the rune,” Avery noted. Then the magic rune began glowing with a bright golden color.

“What’d you do?” River questioned. “You know that relics aren’t to be messed with.”

This was the first time Avery saw River relatively upset.

“Uh, sorry. It just sort of happened when I picked it up.”

Avery placed the rune down and the bright color then faded. River picked it up but no glow occurred.

“It seems to only react to your magic,” she admitted.

“If this place was owned by an Angelor, it further proves it I suppose,” Avery remarked.

“I suppose,” River agreed.

“So, what do we do then? Keep this place or report it to… OSNYC I guess?”

“I don’t know but–”

Before River could finish, both she and Avery heard a loud thump from the main floor. It was the sound of someone barging their way through a door.

The duo rushed upstairs to investigate the ordeal. Upon reaching the main floor, they stood face to face with Pyrus Bourn and his subordinate duo.

River froze, “How—”

“So, this is the relic we’ve been looking for,” Pyrus remarked in awe. “But it seems that we have some trespassers. Hmm… unwanted trespassers at that.”

With a sudden instinctive decision and glancing at each other, River and Avery bolted into action decisively and shoved their way between Pyrus and his gang.

Rushing past the startled arrivals, Avery and River darted into the forest. Both believed that Pyrus and his subordinates were long distant, however, the main villain seemed much more manipulative than he first looked.

Now regaining their breath, Avery and River peeked through the trees to see what the trio was up to.

Looking down at his hand, Avery noticed he had grabbed the round halo rune from off the basement table as they hurried out of the cabin.

The Fire Increaser Co. truck had plowed through hundreds of meters of trees and was resting near the cabin. The trio of the truck had been searching and finally captured the ancient Mystical relic.

"How did he find us?" Avery asked, panting heavily.

"I-It doesn't matter. We must get away. There is no chance that we can defeat him. He is known as the greatest swordsman."

"Is that so?" Avery contemplated.

Then he noticed a blurry black creature flying closer from the forest. It suddenly occurred to him that he encountered this exact creature several times before.

"What is that?" Avery pointed at the last location the creature was seen.

"Uh, I don't see anything," River replied, confused.

Then a strange raven flew from the trees and stared straight at Avery.

Upon making eye contact, Avery's consciousness began fading and his body became numb.

Shocked by the sudden situation, River scrambled towards Avery and leaned him against a tree.

"Hey, what's going on?"

Avery could do nothing but barely shake his head. He gripped the halo-shaped rune tightly in his hand to seize consciousness, but a vision quickly began invading his mind.

The forest, the sky, and River disappeared from his sight; Avery's consciousness entered into a dream.

A raspy voice echoed through Avery's head: *I've been observing you and had she conceded, you would not have lived such a meaningless life; but I have found you now and I will show you everything*.

Avery could do nothing about the situation except acknowledge the event and hope that he endured.

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Then the vision really began.

A woman in her young twenties was sitting at a table reading a book which was written in Latin. The room seemed to have been built underground since no windows were seen on the walls.

There was a single staircase leading up to a hatch. The woman faced towards the large familiar black panel. This was the same cabin, but of another time and age, at least a hundred-year prior.

The woman looked worried and tense like someone was after her.

Then the hatch opened and a boy about seventeen came down.

The woman lunged out of her chair with magical spells swirling in her hand ready to cast at the person. Strange runic patterns made up the rings of the pink magic.

Realizing it was a friend, she extinguished her lit hands and sat back down.

"All clear for now," the boy said. "I didn't see any bad guys when I came here. Sorry for barging in."

"Thank you."

The boy went to the table, pulled out an extra chair from beneath it, and sat down.

"Can you explain to me what happened?" the boy asked.

"Well, Luces, there was this ghost-like figure … or more of a shadow … chasing me when I left the garrison. Of all the Mystical Beings that I know of, it was the most unusual. He wanted to kill me."

"Oh. I think you are talking about this strange shadow creature," the boy said.

The woman was puzzled but she kept it to herself.

"How did you find me?" she asked.

"I, uh, just did. Why are you here Caela?" the boy asked desperately.

He seemed to know something that the woman did not know.

"It's about the earth orb … I kept it hidden here hoping that nobody would ever find it but apparently, I was wrong. The strange new creature is good at reading the minds of all species," Caela said.

"So, is this where you live?" Mr. Luces confirmed.

"Yes. Now I must find a way to permanently hide the orb," Caela replied pleadingly.

“It might not be you who would hide it, would it?” Mr. Luces asked in an odd sort of manner. He clearly knew something that Caela didn’t know.

“Now we must find a temporary place for the earth orb then; a place where the spell will not break until the one who is destined to truly hide it comes,” Caela explained. “That is probably the best option by far since we have limited time.”

She went to a shelf and removed an orb that was hidden in a box. The orb was glowing orange with yellow splotches.

“Why can’t you just put a spell that will destroy it or make it go, poof?” Mr. Luces asked.

“First of all, you can’t destroy what is not created by a living species. A strong spell that would be capable of destroying such an artifact could potentially wipe out everything in a near vicinity,” Caela briefly explained.

“You’re probably right,” Mr. Luces said.

Then both heard footsteps not far. It sounded like an army had just arrived.

“Oh no,” Caela said.

“The skeletal army’s here,” Mr. Luces stated. “Sorry for not saying it earlier.”

“Wait what? Skeleton army?”

“I sort of ran into them when I was sailing away from an island to come here,” Mr. Luces confessed.

“Wait! But you said that you didn’t see any enemies when you came here! Oh well, then we are found,” Caela said. “And I did not know that the strange shadow lord had skeletons as minions.”

“Begin your magic spell while I distract them,” Mr. Luces suggested.

Then he ran up the stairs and opened the hatch. He approached the door on the main floor.

Everything about the main floor matched with the current cabin but was younger. The couches had their full color: bright light brown. Lanterns hung from the walls undamaged next to every door.

There was a hard knock on the door that rattled on in subsequent echoes as if an empty metal can was hit by a thin bone. Mr. Luces drew a sword from his belt sheath. The blade was pure silver iron.

"Open up, Lord Doom is here. If you don't then we will have to break in," a clickity bony voice demanded.

Mr. Luces had no choice but to reveal himself and just talk to them.

"Well, I have a question. Why do you need the orb of earth and why seek it here?" Mr. Luces asked.

"The *lord* does not tell us these things," the skeleton rattled. "We know it is here by another great Mystical Being master."

"Well, you should probably ask your master what the purpose of the orb is, the orb's power is too great for anyone to use," Mr. Luces explained.

"The orb's power is to shape our kind into a better future. Can't you see how scattered the Mystical Beings are? We need to make an entrance to the humans with great power. The humans will fear us and then we can live among them in security," the skeleton assured.

"Liar!" Mr. Luces yelled, "You just want it to get power and control all other beings. You seek control of everyone and everything."

"You assume too greatly," the skeletal speaker pointed out. "The orb has more purposes than being hidden; it has the power to shape society to a greater level. It can nourish and keep the world alive! Why else does it exist?"

"The orbs are meant for constructive use, not power," Mr. Luces said.

"Well, you are not using it for that purpose. You, and among many Mystical Beings in the past, underestimate the purpose of the orbs; the orbs exist to be used by all Mystical Beings. Instead, you steal it from the rest of the world and keep it for yourselves," a strange low voice said.

The door flew open without a sound to reveal a cloaked figure.

Mr. Luces backed a few steps; the lanterns' fire dimmed as if the cloaked man had an aura of darkness that could quench the light.

Mr. Luces had no facial expression of fear. He had fought and met this villain before whereas Caela had no clue who he was.

"You shall give us the orb!" the cloaked man requested angrily.

"You will have to pass through me," Mr. Luces said confidently. He had his sword gripped in both hands ready for action.

"Then you shall die trying to protect it," the shadow lord snarled.

A valley of darkness emerged from the ground and took the shape of a sword in the master of ghosts' hands.

Mr. Luces charged, and the swords clashed with a loud metal scraping stone sound.

The cloaked figure seemed relaxed while Mr. Luces was struggling to block the sword from hitting him.

The shadow lord's sword went forwards with a quick whoosh; Mr. Luces had no choice but to roll out of the way which made him unbalanced.

He accidentally moved too fast in which he was knocked down by the wall of the cabin. His sword skittered away to another corner of the room.

The room was way too small for combat. The shadow lord grinned eagerly, at least that was what it looked like from his hooded face.

The cloaked figure didn't want to wait anymore so he unleashed a stream of power from his hands that lunged at Mr. Luces.

The dark shadow that leaped from his hands had morphed into chains that held Mr. Luces to the wall. Then he and his leader, a skeleton soldier, went over to the hatch and opened it. It was too late.

He was within grasp of the orb if Caela had not set the spell yet.

The shadow lord trudged towards the hatch as if he had all the time of the world. He opened the hatch carefully being aware of potential threats that may leap out.

When he opened the hatch, the stairs led down with no sign of anybody. Mr. Luces prayed that Caela would find an escape.

The cloaked figure and his minion walked down casually; Caela Obtainia was waiting for them. She looked fiercer this time with her hands glowing with bright red magic light.

She used to have blue purplish sparkling eyes, but right now they were replaced with a shade of glowing red; there was even an aura of power that she was radiating.

"Ah, the orb bearer," the shadow lord sneered. "Where is it?"

Caela analyzed him suspiciously … and with a little fear. This fear was not of being beaten, but of what he was capable of.

"Who are you? And how did you find me?" Caela Obtainia asked.

“I am Lord Doom and I have eyes like a raven. My consciousness is spread abroad so I may look anywhere!” the cloaked figure answered with a hidden sneer as if she was stupid that she hadn’t heard of him before.

“Now where is the orb?” he demanded with impatience.

“I have hidden it. The orb has a magic spell on it that will keep it hidden for a long time,” Caela replied with some relaxation. “You can’t take it until the right time comes; that won’t happen until a few decades.”

“Then you shall not live and see that day,” Lord Doom said.

He seemed to know very well what the spell was capable of. “A pesky mage spell will only delay the inevitable, but for how long…”

“What kind of threat is that!?” Caela angrily shouted.

“Oh, it will happen, whether you try to affect it or not. It is the best option for him,” Lord Doom stated, assured that the future was within his grasp.

Caela launched some power from her hands that chained Lord Doom against the wall; the power took the shape of chains.

He didn’t seem to be angry; he was just annoyed.

His skeletal minion drew his sword and lunged at Caela. Caela sidestepped his first attack and punched him with a ball of magic. The impact sent the skeleton flying across the room making it dazed when it fell to the ground.

Lord Doom easily pulled his arms out of the magic chains. Unfazed, but annoyed, he summoned his sword and clawed the air with irritation.

“Your bright light might be my natural enemy, but you are no match for the lord of darkness. There is no way to fully destroy darkness as it encompasses all, everywhere where light isn’t and the places that light leaves,” Lord Doom jeered, pumping his words into the sheer delight of his views.

“Where did you learn that? Don’t you know that light always covers darkness with good?” Caela objected.

“What makes you think that you are doing right? You are casting us into the darkness because of who we are, and you are confiscating a power that all deserves to have.

“Don’t you realize that I want the orb to bring balance; I want the Mystical Beings to live freely with the humans and have peace?” Lord Doom stormed. “Just give me the orb and you will be spared from harm, imprisonment, and death!”

His statement punched Caela hard. “You may be right. Some in the light may have ill intentions and don’t deserve power. But still, that doesn’t make your actions any better. If it was really that easy, I would hand the orb over, knowing that you’d fullfill your expectations.”

She seemed hesitant for a moment pondering what he had described. For this shadow lord, power meant little to him as he was already far superior to many of the Mystical Beings.

Lord Doom drew her closer with shadow claws, ready to act no matter the choice she made.

The shadows were swirling around Caela now. Her eyes started to dim, they turned to a shade of gray, but she then burst out of the shadow with a bright light. She was then glowing with a bright white light too intimidating even for Lord Doom to look at.

She was clearly getting weaker by using such a strong power, but he did not have the time to attack her when she got weak.

“General, we must leave,” the skeleton soldier who had just appeared into the room warned.

“Yes,” Lord Doom replied, “we may leave now. Next time, woman. I will take hold of that orb.”

Then shadows consumed them both and then they disappeared.

Mr. Luces' bonds evaporated, so he was able to run down and see what happened. When he arrived downstairs, he saw Caela Obtainia extinguishing the power she was releasing.

“Where’s Lord Doom?” Mr. Luces asked.

“Lord Doom? Wait, you knew him all along?” Caela questioned.

“Well, it’s complicated,” Mr. Luces confessed. Caela seemed to have read his thoughts by his expression.

“You are not from around here, are you?” she concluded.

“I am, but I am not,” Mr. Luces answered. “Anyway, I must be going.”

"Going? But why?" Caela demanded.

"I have unfinished business elsewhere, but don't worry you'll see me again and I trust you will know what to do when that time comes. Trust a satyr who will visit you and help in the journey of the Mystical Beings." Mr. Luces exited without a trace.

The scene disappeared and darkness loomed from all senses. A chill swept throughout the endless nothingness. But the raspy voice still persisted.

You see. The ones proclaiming to be heroes aren't such things. They do not see the possibilities of the future. They view power as a roar of nature, not as a tamed animal. Find and give me the orb and I will give you power.

Somehow Avery felt extremely compelled to respond. Thus, began the telepathic conversation.

"This is a lot to take in. You also sound sketchy. Why should I trust you?"

I never lie, of course you won't believe you unless I show you.

"You don't need to show me. I know your every intention, just from the vision alone. But that doesn't mean I agree with you."

Oh, is that so? If you won't comply then I'll have to seize control before you get stronger.

"I'm not going to falter if you're using these types of inhuman methods."

I'm doing what is best for you. I have no intentions of killing you. If you choose to comply, then I'll spare you and give you power beyond your dreams.

"If you're talking about control then forget it. All you villains have the same goal and it's getting pretty old."

You really don't understand. My goal is to seize control and bring balance and equality to all Mystical Beings and the non-Mystical humans.

"But your motives are unjust."

Heh, war persisted throughout history and will continue to stir the course of human civilization for eons. I do what must be done in the least complicated manner possible.

"Seizing control of me?"

You're the only one who can find the orb. Other methods may be plausible; however, it would result in catastrophic wars or further division.

"Sounds like me that you haven't thought of alternatives."

Alternatives? Power is the only way to unite people together. If you help, then you'll get the recognition you desire.

"Sorry but I'll have to refuse, for the final time."

You leave me no choice...

Before the raspy voice could further seize control, Avery felt a certain warmth entering the void.

Then a door opened from a distance, revealing a bright light on the other side. A female voice, oddly familiar to Avery, called from the light and her echoes shattered the darkness.

The voice then said, "Do not be undermined by the remnants of the past. Come and continue your journey to learn who you are."

Avery no longer held connection with the former raspy voice. Contemplating the female voice's message, Avery was unable to give a response.

Seeing his body again, Avery glanced around the void which seemed less black as before. The chill and the feeling of emptiness no longer existed.

Although he had a choice that seemed worthwhile to consider, Avery knew only one decision: he was going through that door.

Walking forwards, his every step became brighter while drawing nearer to the door. He stood at the frame and stepped into the light.

Then the dream ended.

Chapter 5: The Big Shot Prodigy

Waking up, Avery saw River crouched near him. He scrambled to his feet and noticed the rune he gripped tightly was glowing brightly in the same golden colored aura as earlier.

Looking in the same direction as before, Avery saw the raven burning up and withering away to nothingness.

"Is it done?" Avery blinked, collecting the view of the forest again.

"What happened?" River asked frantically, clearly worried.

"I had a vision… and there was this voice." Avery explained the full details of the dream to River who was easing up from her worry.

"A voice…?"

"Yeah…. Something of the sort after seeing raven in the sky."

"Strange… that should be impossible," River contemplated.

"If that voice was the same as the shadow guy, Lord Doom, then shouldn't he be dead or very old?" Avery inquired.

"These days he's known as Lordius Doomolo. The age difference is a bit of a hard thing to describe, perhaps forbidden magic or something."

"Wait… there's forbidden magic?"

"Magic that is too dangerous or changes the natural laws of normality are considered forbidden magic. Usually, magic deemed forbidden are ones that use inhuman methods to cast."

"Now that I think about it. I bet the ravens I've been seeing were him spying on me. So how come he doesn't come in person if he's that powerful?"

"Long ago, he was defeated. The only explanation is that a fragment of his consciousness lingered from one of his pet ravens and it has been searching for the orb ever since."

"That's a little more assuring, but it seems unusual. So I guess it confirms… that it was only a remnant of the past."

“Yes, it was just a remaining vassal that just hadn’t been destroyed. The true story of Zenith Luces defeating the shadow guy is an epic that is told to this day.”

“I don’t really mean that. It’s just that he was searching for the same orb that the Pyro guy was searching for now. It’s just a thought,” Avery explained. “By the way. You seem more confident.”

“Oh, uh really? I-I guess it’s just from enduring the events that happened recently with you,” River responded, turning red.

Avery glanced at the cabin in the distance again. The villain trio were still present in the forest.

“So, what do we do now?”

“As much as I’d like to do something, we just don’t stand a chance with such a risk,” River explained.

“Let’s make the smart choice,” Avery agreed.

The duo then searched for the exit to the forest. Enough time had passed that Billy and his gang were no longer in pursuit of them.

***

After finding their way into the city again, Avery and River took a breather on the street in front of IT Tower’s property. They stood beside the grand gates that led into the maintained gardens around IT Tower.

The grant tower itself soured over fifty stories high, rather short for a skyscraper in New York, however, the reflective white panels and light blue windows made it glisten brighter than all others in the city.

IT, the private corporation, was known for its brilliant tech and top-notch security. Since its start over five years ago, its innovations have sparked its rise to the highest mantle.

The IT Tower was near OSNYC, so using it as a beacon was only practical for navigation. For those who desired to avoid violence or lawbreakers, standing near IT Tower was always a vital choice.

Seeing no suspicious bullies, Avery and River sighed in relief. It was almost dark meaning the chances for sketchy activity only increased.

“At least I got this, whatever it is,” Avery noted as he held up the golden halo-shaped rune.

He was surprised he had grasped it tightly up to this point. “It seems to be something I can use to strengthen my powers.”

“Angelors are hard to come by, so you may be the only one who can use it,” River agreed.

Avery decided to pin the rune under his jacket so as to not lose it or hold onto it by hand.

The duo waited a bit longer for the coast to be clear, but then they were caught off guard by a young guy who addressed them.

“You lot, what’s going on?” the individual inquired as he exited from IT Tower. He then stood at the opened gate and examined the duo.

“Oh hey, we’re just chilling. Sorry for that, sir.” Avery bowed slightly addressing the young individual who was clearly in a higher social class than the other two.

“Oh no formalities here, I was just heading out from work. You can just call me Kaden Icelander, or just Kaden,” the young individual greeted, quickly shifting his tone.

“Also chilling? That is what I do best.”

Kaden Icelander was a white-haired boy with light skin and sharp blue eyes. He was about the age of sixteen, a year older than the two, but his grand height made him look even more mature. His stature proved his high rankings, and his stunning navy suit also depicted his superiority.

A golden “ITA” badge was pinned on his right chest. One of his hands had a silver ring on the middle finger with small inscriptions.

“Oh, but still, you’re the great Kaden Icelander, the child prodigy of IT,” Avery exclaimed. “How should I now address someone as high as you?”

“Still, no worries about it. I am not the CEO, I just help out with a few things, that’s all.”

“Ok,” Avery and River spoke at the same time.

Kaden Icelander eyed the duo carefully as if they were on interrogation. “Judging from my deduction, I see that you two are Mystical Beings.”

One of his eyes seemed to change colors as he said this but it was too quick to really comprehend.



“How—”

“What?”

“Rest assured. I know a lot of things, but I won’t disclose them obviously. A big thing at IT here is the NDA policy,” Kaden explained.

Avery and River sighed.

“Yeah, but still, how can we trust you?” Avery questioned.

"You just have to," Kaden said. "If I was some evil villain, the word of Mystical Beings existing would've spread already. Perhaps worse, I'd be some tyrant Mayer of the city with cynical plans."

"Uhhh."

"So, you were on the run. Something happened? I'm guessing you ran away from a bigger fish than you could bite."

Avery and River nodded. Though the phrasing made it sound like the young prodigy was scolding the duo.

Kaden Icelander scanned the area around them carefully.

"Hmmm, I thought so," he stated, "Well, anyway. Come with me for a bit. We should talk."

Kaden Icelander's face and tone became serious, giving both Avery and River the chills. This guy was not someone to mess with.

Without a moment's delay, Kaden Icelander gestured his hand and a black limo pulled up. This was only a feat rich snobs could accomplish.

"Now get in," Kaden said in the same expressionless tone.

The doors of the limo automatically lifted themselves into the air to reveal the furbished tan leather interior. Avery and River sat on one side while Kaden the other.

Gesturing again for departure, Kaden relaxed against the leather seat as the limo hummed in action. Then the limo began driving away from the tower towards its new destination.

"So, where are you taking us?" Avery inquired, noticing the limo traveling away from the direction of the school. The tint of the windows made the outside surroundings dimmer and far more distinguishable.

"Somewhere at the edge of the big city. We're going to the harbor," Kaden replied, typing furiously on his mobile phone.

This phone was the standard brand of phones that the general public trusted these days. They were called IT-Phones. Of course, made by his father's company, also IT, the phones were heavily inspired by the brilliance of the young prodigy.

"W-Why take us somewhere like there?" River asked, looking down nervously.

"It's quite simple," Kaden assured with a slightly lighter pitch. "I believe you two were being followed."

“Followed?” Avery exclaimed. He almost stumbled off his seat.

“H-How?”

“If you’re talking about the raven, I saw it crumble into nothingness,” Avery added.

Seeing Kaden’s expressionless face indicated his lack of surprise upon hearing this. Avery suspected this individual knew and experienced a lot more.

“So, you’ve not noticed. The raven was most likely a puppet of the real user who summoned it. When I met you guys, I noticed a shadow lurking about,” Kaden explained, tossing his hand.

Then sighing, he mumbled, “It must be those people acting up again. And they had to wait so long…”

“I-I didn’t sense anything.”

“The shadow figure knew how to mask their presence, however, a skilled individual like me won’t be fooled,” Kaden explained, tapping under his eye which gleamed in confidence.

The rich prodigy’s strange shifts in tones really tipped Avery’s perception of him in all directions.

“Who was this guy?” River asked quietly.

“Hmm, probably one of those shadow worshipers,” Kaden remarked. “Now that I think about it, it was one of those cults that were led by Lord Doom before his demise. Though there are several cultist members, each with their respective strength and power, I cannot tell who the person really is. They’ve been hiding.”

“How do we stop him?” Avery requested, believing this follower to be a Mystical Being with much more caliber than normal New York citizens.

“The shadow worshiper isn’t aware of your knowledge of him at the moment. I believe the best course of action is to capture him.”

“What’s so special about the harbor?” Avery quarried.

“Deciding where to confront this pursuer, it would be wise to do it at a quiet location,” Kaden suggested. “The harbors are near water, a place ideal for me to show my style.”

“Hmmm, ok.”

“W-why help us at this point?” River spoke.

“It’s quite simple. I have my own reasons: to obtain information. Happening to run into you guys was just a stroke of luck, that’s all.”

To say it was a stroke of luck was a bit of a stretch, given the duo’s situation at this moment.

“Information?” Avery blinked. “Is that so? What is your plan anyway to… stop this stalker?”

“Quite simple actually,” Kaden Icelander leaned closer as to reveal a secret. “You two get noticed by the stalker and I will follow suit.”

“T-That s-sounds terrible,” River faltered.

“I’d have to agree,” Avery agreed. “Why just the two of us?”

“We don’t want him to run off because he sees me. The presence of magic is key to determine whether he would retreat. He’s not interested in me at all either.”

“How come? I think it would be safer if we didn’t engage,” Avery assured.

“I can observe and come in later as a surprise attack.”

“I still don’t like the idea.”

“The capture of this guy would help the greater good of the Mystical Beings,” Kaden stated, almost threatening this time.

Avery tensed and only thought of ways to steer this conversation away from an angry prodigy.

“If it means that we won’t be followed anymore, I suppose we have no choice,” Avery resented, regretting his submission but desiring to avoid further conflict.

“W-Will we be safe?” River brought up.

“You’ll both be fine. I’ll assure that,” Kaden stated, now back to his delightful mood. Still, Avery and River felt uneasy at this half-thought-out statement.

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Seeking to cover any suspicions, Kaden dropped Avery and River off at the street nearest to the docks upon arrival.

“You’ll figure it out,” was Kaden’s only response to Avery’s question of drawing the stranger out and stalling for time.

Avery watched as the streetlamps around luminated the hazy fog. His heart felt light and his mind racing with thoughts. River looked at him expectantly.

"So, let's head towards the docks," Avery said, gazing at the end of the street ahead.

A thick fog covered the distant sea beyond the barely visible dock. A small dim light of the Statue of Liberty could be seen through the mist.

"Yeah," River said contently. Though the situation was uncalled for, she seemed satisfied to be with Avery. In fact, she inched close enough to assure herself that she remaineed not alone.

Easing up from the shyness she formerly displayed in front of Avery, River began conversing, "So, how are you feeling?"

"Fine, I guess. Though I was surprised to chat with the great Kaden Icelander, though he was less than what I expected."

"Yeah same."

As they stepped from concrete to wooden planks, Avery noticed a shadowy figure approaching them.

Noticing as well, River grabbed Avery's shoulder tightly, making him blush a bit.

"Wait… be on your guard," she said.

Avery sensed a sinister aura coming from the figure. He nodded and proceeded cautiously. As the shadowy figure passed under a lit lamp, the light within the lamp instantly disappeared, enveloping the street in more darkness.

A glowing purple light emerged from the figure's hand. Before Avery and River could react, the figure emerged into view.

"That cocky Kaden Icelander sure knew his thing," Avery muttered, pretending not to notice the figure.

"So, Angelor. We meet at last," the figure spoke, interrupting the silence. "So, the premonition from the exalted one has come true, and so soon too! How goody!"

"Who are you?" Avery asked, turning around. "How'd you find us?"

"Call me whatever, that doesn't matter," the figure said. "I can find anyone here through the use of my shadows."

"You don't look like the same person from my vision, but you do seem different, like less scary," Avery exclaimed. "I'm guessing you're not that Lord Doom guy."

"I am here to fulfill what my late master wished to fulfill. I am a Hand of Doom."

His evil expression was swayed for fear originally; but his serious expression backfired this expression as he only made himself appear more insane.

"So, like a shadow worshiper, one of those sketchy cult members," Avery noted, recalling what Kaden had mentioned.

"You dare insult me!"

With a flick of his wrist, a burst of dark energy shot an inch from Avery's feet, burning a hole into the concrete sidewalk.

Avery could barely react to the sudden threatening attack. Grabbing onto River, he was able to maneuver both of them from the sudden attack.

Kaden didn't mention his threat level, Avery thought as he masked his timidity. He instantly fell into serious guard mode. "That wasn't cool, man."

Avery made up his mind. The figure was not like Lord Doom at all.

The proclaimed shadow worshiper stepped forward maniacally.

"You will come with me. If you don't, I won't miss next time; the next shot will hit the girl."

"Alright, if you want to take me, leave River out of this," Avery countered.

"I can't allow that. No witnesses."

"I guess you leave us only one choice," Avery stated, realizing that the figure was not someone to be messed with.

But having enough time to fight than fight, Avery knew that his best course of action was just the same.

With an exchange of a nod, Avery and River made a run from the enemy. Without careful decision making, the duo ran towards the docks, making their broad escape route slimmer.

Somehow the situation Avery was in was far more dangerous than Kaden had stated it would. If Kaden were to make a move, it would've been right about now.

The shadow worshiper was not as shocked as the Pyrus Bourn trio, so gaining an upper hand was not plausible.

Dark Magic: Shadow Spikes.

A valley of shadow spikes emerged from the ground around the figure and launched towards Avery and River. They were fast, but at the increasing distance between them and the duo, it was far easier to dodge most of them.

Running behind River, Avery blocked the incoming spikes from targeting her. Grazing his shoulders and piercing his back, Avery staggered along without reducing pace. His adrenalin rose again for the second time that day.

"If you really wanted me, I guess you won't kill me," Avery shouted, feeling his body becoming numb, but still very much alive.

Small trails of blood flowed down from the spots where he was injured. This was all ending way too much a hassle for being a week-old baby of the magical world.

"It was not my intention anyway; however, I won't hesitate to give you pain!" the figure spoke, now delusional.

The shadow worshiper, riding on a swirling shadow cloud, pursued and approached at tremendous pace.

Narrowing the gap, the shadow spikes continued to emerge from the ground as the shadow worshiper passed; and so, the speed of their flight increased.

Avery had not tried focusing magic while focused on something else, so his usual magic output he could muster decreased by a significant amount. Holding his hands with small orbs of light energy, he turned and repelled the incoming spikes with his magic.

Glancing behind and seeing Avery had stopped to fight back, River turned and chose to aid. Her courage was higher than before, due to Avery's attempts to protect her yet again.

Stepping forwards to stand beside Avery, River lifted her hands and raised the water surrounding the docks.

Water Magic: Water Sphere.

Two large spheres of water formed from the amount of water she could muster.

"River?" Glancing around, Avery witnessed the sight of River's magic powers unleashed.

The winds picked up around the water balls, lifting the hood from River's head, revealing her fox ears and stern green eyes.

"You won't stop us!" River shouted in a new demeanor unlike her.

Stopping his former attack, the shadow worshiper slowed his speed as he approached the duo.

"Ah, you're another one of those demihumans. You of all people understand what we are aiming towards. A world where Mystical Beings live equality and are known among the world," he said, descending from his cloud and striding casually. "My master cared for the likes of you, but you simply want to throw it away; what a shame!"

Being near the edge of the docks, the duo had no other means of escape except swimming. Aware of this, the shadow worshiper was confident of his final gestures to end this fight.

Hearing the shadow worshiper's pep talk didn't make the situation any better. Staggering with intense pressure, River shot a water ball towards the shadow worshiper.

The water suddenly dispersed onto the wooden planks around the shadow worshiper as he continued his same pace being unharmed.

"What–" Avery gasped.

"Petty magic like that won't stop me."

A shadow veil vaporized from around the shadow worshiper.

"As you can see, most magic will not phase through me. You don't stand a chance against me!"

River attempted another attack with the other water ball; but it simply dispersed the same as the former.

Gained time through the diversion, Avery circulated light magic throughout his right fist and lunged towards the shadow worshiper.

Light Magic: Lighted Fist.

Unfazed, the shadow worshiper remained in place to take the hit, but the shadow dispersing barrier around him shattered on contact with Avery's fist of light.

Staggering backwards from the force, Avery wiggled his right hand from the force.

"I'm surprised your light magic is already potent enough to destroy the reflection barrier, however, your efforts will only delay the inevitable, hehehe," the shadow worshiper chuckled.

"Yeah, for sure. I'll keep punching you until you are done for," Avery assured, going into stance for another attack.

He felt more alive than ever, even his magic flowed faster through his body. At this point now, his injuries from the bullies had pretty much faded.

Increasing the output of the magic, Avery's fist of light from his right hand became brighter than the night street lamps around the docks. Even the most seemed to part from the white light rays.

Avery sidestepped and launched a rapid fist attack from the side, hoping to cut the shadow worshiper's guard. The original attack was sufficient enough to delay the reconstruction of the reflection barrier, thus, a perfect opening was created.

Avery's fist connected with the figure's chest, pushing both apart.

With a slight groan, the shadow worshiper was only lightly grazed. His durability surpassed the sheer amount of strength that Avery gained the past few years.

"Well, it was a perfect blow, however, it seemed futile," he said, his full attention on Avery. "It would've been something far more dangerous if you were a full-fledged Angelor. But this power is much greater than the likes of you!"

"Lucky for you, that was just a distraction," Avery pointed out.

River swiftly made her attack during Avery's full counter.

Water Magic: Water Fist.

With a fist submerged in a thick layer of water, she landed a hit on the shadow worshiper's blind side.

Turning too late, the shadow worshiper took the full blow. Without the use of the barrier, the water fist made its mark. Pushed near the edge of the dock, unfortunately he easily recovered.

River continued pouring blows on him, however, he pushed her aside as if she were an insignificant fly.

River tumbled a short distance from the figure, taking an attack much harsher than her body could handle.

Thinking the subsequent blows would have at least made the figure dazed, Avery gasped as the shadow worshiper stood tall as if nothing grazed him at all. Nevertheless, he could not tolerate that he'd injure someone before his eyes.

Laughing, he stated, "Is that all you can muster?"

Several more shadow spikes emerged from the ground which Avery blocked with his slowly draining light magic. But more spikes impaled his body as his accuracy decreased.

Panting, wounded, and magically drained, Avery felt his body begin to fail him. He had nothing else to throw at the enemy.

Finding the situation dire, Avery spoke quickly, before it would be too late, "I'll go with—"

But before he could consider surrender, a strange figure appeared behind them from the air.

"Looks like I underestimated the enemy's capabilities. Sorry for being late," a familiar voice spoke. "The great Kaden Icelander is here to finish this."

Ice Magic: King's Domain.

Then the entire battlefield, the dock and everything around it, instantly covered with ice.

"Who might you be?" the shadow worshiper asked, fanning the ice around him with flames, eying Kaden Icelander who appeared suddenly onto the scene.

Looking up, Avery saw the confident figure several meters above him. "Kaden… you finally came."

Stepping from the heavy fog surrounding the new battlefield, Kaden Icelander gleamed expectantly. He stood on a pillar of ice a short distance from the shadow figure and the dock, converting the water in his proximity into sharp ice glaciers.

"Of course I'd come. You did better than I expected. I was even able to see some of his circus tricks at work," Kaden responded.

Avery wasn't sure if Kaden's joke was for real. Seeing that the enemy would be focused on Kaden, he rushed to River's aid and strained the remaining magic within him to heal her wounds.

"I see your cult has been far more active lately, so what is it that you are looking for?" Kaden inquired, gesturing for an answer.

An ice bridge then conjoined itself from the piller to the dock deck.

With a graceful dash and leap, Kaden landed onto the dock a few feet from the shadow worshiper. Several more ice spikes emerged from the waters surrounding the dock.

The shadow worshiper only cocked his head in delight. "Now you're an interesting fellow, heh," he said gleefully.

“Just answer the question,” Kaden demanded, raising his hand and forming a sharp long spear composed of dense ice.

Ice Magic: Ice Javelin.

With a gentle arc, he aimed and threw the javelin towards the opponent. Flying inches from his face, the shadow figure only seemed amused.

“You’ll have to defeat me, I suppose, haha,” he laughed cockly.

But his tense posture after the attack gave clear indications of his rising worry.

Seeing the flinch of the shadow worshiper, Kaden replied, “Well, if that’s the only way then I’ll defeat you and take you to the higher ups.”

“Fat chance,” the shadow worshiper assured.

Dark Magic: Flame of Darkness.

Then purple flames began spreading around the dock, melting all materials around it. He lept onto a shadow cloud and soured several feet above Kaden Icelander.

“Hahaha, I suppose since you intruded on such a special moment for me, I will have to kill you, boy!” the worshiper taunted.

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Avery hoisted River’s body over his shoulder and sprinted around the fire towards the empty streets. The fight was escalating and his mere presence would just be in the way of Kaden’s fight.

The former dock was now a battleground. Wood chips, slashes, and ice stained the planks as the duo fought.

Arriving on the streets, Avery rushed towards a dark corner alleyway and rested River’s body down. Glancing back, he saw the small spec of the prolonged battle.

“W-what’s going on?” River coughed as she struggled to bring her words out.

“You shouldn’t talk,” Avery warned, “just rest your body until you’re feeling better.”

“But, the shadow cult…?” River spoke weakly, suddenly clutching onto Avery’s shoulders.

“Don’t worry, Kaden’s got it handled,” Avery assured.

"Kaden…?"

"Yeah, he finally arrived, though late, finally entered the fry."

He then began applying magic into his hands and rested it on River's chest.

Light Magic: Healing Magic.

"What are you…?"

"Just a bit of healing to help you. Please rest."

"O-ok."

***

Now in the midst of the battle, Kaden Icelander and the shadow worshiper had exchanged blows but neither were at the verge of giving up yet. The shadow figure continued his superior stance on his shadow cloud.

"Now now, I don't like when people look down on me," Kaden affirmed.

Then a pillar of ice formed below his feet as he ascended above the shadow worshiper. Daggers of ice jabbed out of the pillar to break the opponent's stability.

"And I certainly don't like people who openly say they want to kill me."

Dark Magic: Dustification.

Black mist poured around the proximity of the shadow figure, disintegrating the ice threatening him.

"No witnesses, I can't afford to let you get away, otherwise my boss would be mad at me."

"Ah, your boss, huh. That shadow guy is long dead you know."

"Ugh, don't you dare refer to my boss in that cocky tone of yours! He is never dead. He lives within each and everyone of us, waiting for a moment to revive!" the cultist roared.

"You must be mistaken, people don't revive from the dead as easily as you claim," Kaden tossed his hands in uninterest.

"With that, you most certainly will die by my hands, no, a slow death will be nice for you!" the shadow worshiper launched forward on his hovering cloud.

“Let’s end this,” Kaden affirmed as he dove towards the shadow worshiper.

Ice Magic: Twin Ice Blades.

With twin ice blades summoned to his hands, he sliced the shadow cloud into bits.

While midfall, the shadow figure lacked the concentration to utilize magic, so, he took the full damage from his fall.

Curving his body to make a gentle descent onto the dock, Kaden approached the shadow worshiper expectantly.

“Looks like you’re just a mere minion of the cult, don’t spout big words that you can’t handle. A real Hand of Doom is much more powerful!” he mocked.

“Gaugh, you,” the shadow worshiper protested, but was cut short by coughing. Looking down at his body, he noticed sword slash wounds. “How—”

Kaden stood high and brushed his hair. “I suppose you’re ready to be taken in if you lose that quickly. Don’t worry, I made sure to lightly graze you. We do need you in one piece after all.”

“I won’t let you—”

Kaden’s eyes sharped. His normal blue irises were now completely black. A chill went over the shadow worshiper, causing his body to become numb.

“Sorry, but that’ll have to do. I can’t keep the fight going,” Kaden said.

Ice Magic: Frozen Restraining.

Ice chains cuffed and strangled the shadow worshiper.

Then, raising his hand, Kaden generated a strange magic circle of ancient insignia that engulfed the shadow worshiper’s body. Dissipating the circle, the figure was no longer there.

Kaden sighed and stretched his arms. “Man, must I do overtime work also? It’s too bad Lucy and Amos are on a mission right now.”

Looking about, Kaden saw the mess the battle made. “Well, I should clean up after myself. After all, I don't want those normie New Yorkers to find out.”

With a flick of his fingers, the ice rink and spikes around the area dissipated and water splattered across the docks.

“Well, I should get going. Gotta see if the others are alright.”

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Avery waited in desperation for Kaden's return. The flashworks of the battle dissolved soon after he had gone to safety so he was unsure if Kaden was the victor. Of course, leaving River behind to check it out would've put him in risk if the shadow worshiper had been the victor.

Looking into the night sky, he still couldn't grasp the reason why he was being targeted. Sure, it shouldn't surprise him considering the new world he has entered, but still he considered himself to be nothing special to get special treatment on the enemies' bingo book.

After escaping the tensions of the battle, River fell unconscious. Avery promised himself that he'd protect her at all costs.

Avery continued pouring healing light magic onto River's body. This was the first time he'd pushed his magic to this limit, thus, he gritted his teeth hard to prevent himself from losing consciousness.

Rhythmic footsteps suddenly approached Avery and River. Jumping up and looking about, Avery caught sight of Kaden Icelander approaching.

"So, uh, did you win?" Avery pleaded.

"Like I'd lose," was Kaden's response. "I'm here in one piece."

"Thanks for the help at the end, I guess."

"Remember, if you're ever in need, I've always got your back," was his response, even if it didn't sound so uplifting at that moment, it would become something Avery continued to remember.

"So… what happened to the shadow worshiper?"

"I sent him to ATLAS. There the higher ups should take care of him for the time being. I'll also interrogate him later. Too lazy to do it now."

Relieved to hear the danger was over, Avery's body only seems to weigh more. His drowsiness began kicking in, but he remained awake to finish what he started. He also planned to get River to safety.

"What now?"

"I'll take you two back to the school. You're much safer there for the time being."

"O-ok."

Picking up River's body and muttering about the further strain on his body, Avery followed Kaden to a newly arrived limo. It was different from the one that dropped them off before.

Passing the harbor, Avery couldn't help but wonder what the normal citizens would think when they saw the docks. With the state it was in, it was almost as if some wild weather came blowing in.

"I made sure to call in advance, so hop on in," Kaden stated, completely ignoring Avery's shock of the docks.

Opening the limo door and placing River's body at a seat, Avery and Kaden sat at opposite ends of the leather chairs facing each other.

Without a warning, the limo booted to life and started driving towards inner New York City. The dark tinted window separated the back compartment from the driver of the limo.

Adjusting himself on the overly expensive leather seats, Avery tensed up as he gazed upon the majestic figure of Kaden Icelander. After the brunt of the battle, Avery suspected Kaden to have tatters or stains, but none were present.

"Tell me Kaden, what happened during your battle?" Avery asked intently.

"Just the usual defeating the enemy and capturing him. I did have to wipe all the ice away though," Kaden spoke calmly.

"I'd wager that shadow worshiper was not much of an obstacle for you."

"Hmm… It was intriguing, pitting my powers against shadow magic. He was, in the end, a regular run-of-the-mill crony of the former glory of Lordius Doomolo."

Then there was silence. Kaden had a slight smirk as he thought of his victory. Avery, however, only began questioning this new life he sought out for.

"Thinking back on it, I first thought of this new magic side as some fantasy or reality that I could find a passion for, but now I've realized there are threats more dangerous than I could ever imagine. How come I've become the middle of this mess? I've had weird encounters, a vision from some raven that I'm still trying to process, this sudden attack from a cultist, and now I can't imagine there isn't more."

Avery couldn't imagine becoming more open with someone, but somehow Kaden's mere presence (most of the time) gave off friendly vibes.

"How long have you been here?" Kaden asked.

"Well, as long as I can remember. I used to be a street boy until three years back when someone helped me to set my eyes on OSNYC. I've only learned about magic and Mystical Beings about a week ago now."

"And do you know anything about your parents?"

"Nothing."

"I'd figured as much. Typically, a Mystical Being like you wouldn't usually have trouble like this, even in the mainlands. But it might be something of your past that has brought all of this up. You're an Angelor, a species essentially extinct and rare. It could tie into the vision you've told me, but I don't have proof to clarify this."

"Ah I see. So, are there more of the cult that may be chasing me?"

"I'd assume now since the one I captured seemed to be suspicious of you and wanted to capture you alive. There might be other members, but I'd say that they don't know about you yet nor the impending situations… it seems that hiding is still their main objective as cult members stayed in numbers in times past."

"So the raspy voice from the raven really is after me for the orb, huh."

"Based on my calculations, I'd say so, but you mustn't worry."

"Hmmm… I don't know. There were those three guys at the cabin."

Avery explained his journey to Kaden from the school exam up to the point of meeting up with him for the first time.

Kaden's intrigue peaked higher than usual. Most facts weren't surprising at the very least, given the amount of experience Kaden went through but…

Something was amiss when Kaden began piecing information together.

"Is something wrong?" Avery asked, noticing Kaden's puzzled complexion.

"Oh nothing much. Just sorting through what you just told me."

"Is that it? I think you know something I don't, right?"

"It's not that," Kaden said rather rashly. "You don't need to worry about it. It doesn't concern you. I was just thinking of some other issue."

"Oh ok," said Avery as fatigue continued to creep over his body.

"What of our interactions from now on?"

Kaden then indulged in thought methodically. “I am a busy person so you may not see me around a whole lot.”

“Oh I see.”

Avery was just warming up to another friend. But circumstances differed as the young prodigy mainly saw the fated interaction as a means to his goals.

“This wouldn’t be the last time you will see me, hopefully,” Kaden responded with an air of assurance.

“That’s… nice…” Avery’s vision blurred as sleep finally seized over.

Silence was now the only sound during the remainder of the ride back into the heart of the city.

Staring at the duo who were both unconscious, Kaden sighed. “Man, now I have to deal with this? But, these people might turn out to be just what I needed for my goa..”

Chapter 6: Sleuths on the Grind

Avery awoke to the alarm next to his bed. Looking frantically, he saw he was back in his dorm room in OSNYC. Glancing at the window, bright yellow rays of light entered the room, indicating the night has passed.

Ted, who was gaming at his desk, turned around and stood up. "Alright man, you're awake!"

Avery sat in his bed contemplating. Looking at the alarm clock, Avery realized he missed the morning and afternoon classes.

"There's no need for that. You came back yesterday night all unconscious and stuff. Looks like you were with some girl. Did you–"

"No, of course not! Well, I'm glad that I was able to get a good night's sleep. There were just some complications."

"You mean the shadow cult that attacked you and then Kaden Iccelander came in to save the day?"

"Huh?"

"News spread all around the school. You're practically famous now since you survived the attack of a shadow cult."

"It was just one guy. Kaden admitted it was just a small fry. Also, why does the entire school know this?"

"Some official from ATLAS came in and reported it to the principal and then the school. They wanted everyone to be aware of this predicament and to be cautious. There was some meeting earlier about the situation too."

"Oh I see. I guess if it is for others' safety to know this then that is okay."

"Yeah well the best part was that you got to meet Kaden Icelander. How cool is that!" Ted exclaimed.

"Well, I was surprised. But I accidentally stumbled upon him near the IT Tower. Then he said that I was followed and then things sort of kicked off from there," Avery assured. "See, nothing special. Just… don't make a big deal out of this, okay?"

"Aww man. You are very humble to put yourself that way, but remember that you did something that no one else did. Think of it as some prestigious class or honor that you received. Of course you'd want to announce the world of that feat."

"Please, I beg you. I don't think you get the idea."

"Of course I do. Just chillax man."

"Uh ok."

"Kaden Icelander is a prodigy known to have already gone through all of high school at a young age, and most of college too. Most Mystical Beings know the magical projects that he works on. He also travels back and forth from the island quite often."

"Oh I see. It would've been nice to see him once more just to say thanks and stuff," Avery said.

"Who knows. He's as busy as one could get."

Changing subjects, Avery then asked Ted, "So, how come you skipped classes today?"

Ted tensed up. "H-how did you figure it out?"

"Hmmm… Well usually class is happening now. Also, all your school work seems to be in the same disarray as the last weekday you left it."

"You're sure observant. I just wanted to make sure you were alright so I bailed on my classes. The real reason was cus I wanted an excuse to play video games."

"You sly you," Avery teased.

Ted smirked. "I guess you're feeling better."

"Yeah for sure," Avery gleamed. "I'm glad to be back here, safe not having to worry." Crawling under his covers, Avery snuggled with his pillow.

As Avery laid in his bed, he began determining his next steps. Roughly sleeping for a good fifteen hours restarted his mind for fresh thoughts.

After taking a shower and changing clothes, Avery set out to explore the various activities the school hosted in the late afternoon. He and Ted were both eager to do something fun for a change, so getting involved in some school club was the most efficient method.

Passing through his dorm floor lobby, Avery heard some students exchanging gossip when they caught sight of him.

"What's their problem?" Avery asked Ted who was walking beside him.

Ted stretched his arms and yawned. "I dunno, man. Whatever they like to talk about these days. Maybe it's about you, cuz you're famous, you know?"

"I don't get why they're still so interested in the recent event. I would've thought that news would come and go very rapidly," Avery indicated, trying to assure himself of his own statement.

"Things like what you went through typically don't happen in New York, you know? Plus, it's only been a portion of a day."

"I get your point, but I'm just trying to live a good life and yesterday's ordeal was just almost life threatening. I just hope that nothing more happens and perhaps I may live a normal life."

"A normal life? Huh, come on, man. Almost every person here wants a different one. You see, the reason that Mystical Beings started moving to these non-Mystical places was they either wanted an easy life or they wanted to become famous. But in reality, their children don't feel the same way. Most of the students here are eager for some excitement," Ted explained. "You know me, I'd like some thrill myself."

"I understand that. But I guess I'm just saying that I've not lived this life that you all hate so much and I just want to experience it for myself. I've worked three years just to get here."

"Three years?" Ted laughed, "Man, that's sure some dedication."

Right at the stairs, Avery and Ted were shoved to the side as a group of gruff students charged their way through the room.

"Everyone wants their freedom," Ted shrugged.

"Maybe they don't realize the pure underwhelmingness of having obtained pure freedom."

As the two descended to the main floor lobby, Avery caught sight of River hurrying through a crowd of students. She had a hood over her lowly bent head. Desiring to know her condition, Avery rushed towards her.

"Hey, River! Everything alright?" Avery greeted as he came to a halt before her.

Lifting her head and locking eyes with Avery, River sighed with relief. “I-I’m doing fine. It’s nice to see you again.” She seemed glad to see a familiar face.

“That’s good. I-I just wanted to make sure you were alright, you know, since yesterday’s situation,” Avery spoke nervously. Somehow he was getting quite heated from standing in front of the girl.

“Who’s this, Avery?” Ted asked curiously.

“Oh yeah, Ted. This is River Grant. She was the girl I was with yesterday,” Avery gestured. “And River, uh, this is Teddric Tech. He’s… a friend of mine.”

“Uh, n-nice to meet you,” River said timidly. Not being in a dire situation, River was still quite shy of most other people. Afterall, her secret of her demihuman features still discriminated against her unlike other students.

“You can just call me Ted. I’m a pro-gamer and an excellent mechanical designer and such. Any questions concerning technology, I’ve got your back,” Ted greeted, flexing his balled fist.

“I’m sorry that the news came out about the recent incident. I didn’t start or anything,” Avery admitted.

“N-no, i-it’s fine. I heard about it anyway. Don’t worry about me, no one suspects I was there or anything so y-you have no worry,” River assured quietly.

“That’s a relief,” Avery sighed. “So, where were you hurrying off to in a rush? It’s okay if you don’t want to answer.”

“No, it’s fine. I-I just was heading to my dorm room after getting a quick drink of water.”

“Did you want to hang out with us? We were just thinking of checking out some school clubs,” Avery offered.

“S-sure. If-if you want me.”

“Of course, we’d be happy to have you with us,” Ted gleamed.

River’s eyes sparkled in delight. It was the first time she had a real friend. Her timidity often seized the ropes of her desire to have friends, but after the recent event, she felt more confident to meet others, especially if they were a friend of Avery’s.

“Th-Thank you, th-this really means a lot to me,” she confessed.

“Glad to hear that!” Avery said, giving a thumbs up.

Ted couldn't help but laough under his mouth for some reason.

Behind the main lobby was a large illustrious conference room that could've been mistaken for a medieval ballroom. Upon entry, the trio gasped at the sight of various club booths scattered around the perimeter of the room. Glazed with gold and rich wood, the conference room looked goofy with the full spectrum of colors scattered around the room.

Due to the large number of clubs, each booth was only spaced apart by two feet, not nearly enough for the popular booths to properly prioritize the people in line to praise and speak with them.

"This is… interesting," Avery stated, catching sight of some intriguing club names displayed above the booths.

"Heh, the names are a bit cringe," Ted pointed to a booth with bright yellow letters on black stating, "Reading Bookworm Bros."

River eyed the booths from under her hood, but she ensured her face was concealed.

Starting from the left side, the trio toured around until they came to some fancy booths with unique designs. Passing by numerous designs, Avery began to doubt he could determine a singular club out of the dozens.

"Hey, you three! Wanna join the Spy Academy Club?" a voice called, catching the attention of the trio as they passed a strange box booth. The trio were rounding a corner where especially intriguing booth designs were located.

Walking suspiciously towards a black and blue booth, a hatch opened to reveal a squeaky voiced kid who seemed too underaged to be an official student of the school.

"Uh, who are you?" Avery spoke.

"My name is Albert. I'm starting a Spy Academy for agents who want to snatch intel about the shadow cult."

"Ohhhkay," Ted responded, perplexed. "Sorry kid, but we're not here to play around."

"Oh come on! We can do real investigations, real sneaking around," the kid named Albert begged.

"It sounds intriguing, but Ted here is right. I am looking for, you know, something else," Avery dismissed kindly.

“But I heard yesterday about a shadow cult attack! I want to do some sleuthing. Don’t you want to join the fun? I scrambled some scraps together to create this box so that others can join.”

Jumping through the hole to greet the trio, the kid pulled some stickers out of his pocket and waved them in front of the trio. “Members get special stickers to mark their allegiance.”

“How old are you?” Ted asked, passing on the sticker sheet that was given to him.

Receiving the sticker sheet, River passed it to Avery and hid behind him to avoid any more unnecessary attention.

“Oh I’m only ten, but I got into this school because I completed middle school.”

Albert, who was about two-thirds the height of Avery, was a young boy with black hair, brown eyes, cheeky face complexion, and a devilish grin. He wore a t-shirt with a wild design and slicky Acitas shorts.

“Only ten, that’s quite impressive,” Avery complimented, but seeing the sticker sheet in his hands, he then said, “Why am I holding this?”

“Looks like you want to join,” Albert squealed eagerly.

Avery thought of the shadow worshiper’s attack and assured himself how not fun it was, but hearing Ted’s earlier comment about others’ seeking daring adventures such as the one he exploited, he couldn’t dismiss the pros and cons of both perspectives. Regardless, Avery still imagined the danger and harsh reality of this so-called adventure that the students envied. Even pretending to sleuth around, he still didn’t think it was good to take something so serious and reduce it to a mere game.

“Now, Albert,” Avery began, “I know you want to investigate the shadow cult and all, but don’t you think you’re a bit young to get into stuff like that?”

“If you’re thinking I’m not smart, don’t worry. I know all there is about the great villains of the Mystical Beings—Lordius Doomolo, Pyrus Bourn, Ion Mustard, Benny, I mean Bennett Lock-Burr, uhh… you name it,” Albert continued excitedly.

Perking his ears up, Avery was just sold on joining the club when Ted stepped forwards, snatched the sticker sheet from Avery, and shoved it at the young boy.

“Wait Ted—”

“Come on boy, we’ve got no time for this,” Ted sternly stated. Then he marched off not realizing Avery and River remained where they stood.

Remembering his childhood life in the slums of New York, Avery couldn't tolerate thinking of anyone else suffering the same fate. This same feeling rushed through his body after Ted stormed off. He also didn't want to say no since it didn't hurt to say yes.

Ted, however, seemed indifferent when it came to kids.

Seeing the boy sniffing a bit and on the verge of waterworks, Avery knelt down and padded the boy's shoulder. "Don't worry Albert, I was just about to say that I wanted to join."

"You really mean it?" Albert sniffed as he spoke softly.

"Y-Yeah," River agreed, supporting Avery's statement.

"Alright!" Albert hollered in delight, now shifting back to his former mood.

Avery stood up and scratched his head. "I am curious about all these bad guys of the Mystical Beings, so be sure to tell me everything," he said with a grin.

"I will!"

Glancing about, Avery then pointed out, "I don't think anyone else is interested in your club, so I guess you could explain what our role is in this… Spy Academy."

"First off, since you two want to be official members, you'll have to put on the sticker first," Albert stated, flexing his golden star sticker on the right chest of his t-shirt.

"Uhh, ok," Avery said, blinking hesitantly.

Peeling a golden heart sticker from the sheet, Avery slapped it onto the right chest of his "Members Only" jacket. River peeled a golden circle sticker and did likewise.

"Now that you're both official members, let's do greetings and then decide on codenames for each other," Albert announced.

"G-greetings?" River spoke shyly.

"Codenames," Avery followed.

"Uh huh, codenames. A good agent always has a codename to ensure the enemy does not know their true identity. It's also easy for quick reference."

Avery was unsure where the conversation was going but he willingly followed along. Albert knew info about some of the enemies that he faced, so he was curious to learn more about them and their motives. Determining if Albert actually was telling the truth was a whole other matter altogether.

“My name is Avery Obtainia. And this is River Grant,” Avery presented while also gesturing at River’s presence.

“H-hello.”

“Now that I have members, it’s time to start my first mission. Come back here,” Albert spoke, leaping into the box booth.

Finding the back half of the booth sliced open, Avery and River took the casual route to enter the claustrophobic space.

“You didn’t nearly make this big enough,” Avery spoke, eyeing the ceiling just barely touching his head as he stood normally.

“Ah hehe, it was just made yesterday. I’ll have a proper headquarters later.”

Instead of entering the right, River remained outside — a short distance so she could still participate the best she could.

Keeping the front hatch open, Albert continued to scan the area for potential members to scout out. “So,” he began, “My first mission is quite easy but it’s just too hard for me to do alone.”

“What is your mission?”

“That big fat guy over there stole my sonar goggles.” Pointing to a beefy figure too familiar to Avery, Albert continued, “You see, my dad gave it to me and that guy stole it because he was a jerk.”

He probably had some ulterior motive, Avery thought, smirking at the idea that anyone would still just be called a jerk. But this was just the case since Albert pointed to none other than one of Billy Bones’ cronies.

“So… you want me to like…. take the goggles he’s wearing back?” Avery confirmed skeptically.

“Yep.”

“I-is it special?” River asked.

“Oh yeah, It’s quite expensive, afterall, it is an IT technology.”

River shook in her stance. “T-that is quite important.”

“See here,” Avery explained, “That’s a friend of Billy’s and he and I don’t get along. I'm trying to avoid him at all costs.”

“Easy,” Albert spoke while standing up and pointing towards the mass of students gathered throughout the room. “You just have to quickly grab it from him and get away before he catches you. An agent never reveals their identity so it’s all part of the mission.”

Avery began to question whether Albert’s proclamation of the mission being easy was true. He made up his mind to go along with the plan, so long as he avoids Billy Bones at all costs.

“Don’t worry, you guys. I’ll be the commando.”

“H-how is that going to work?” River asked. Looking down at the ground, it was already clear she wanted no part in this.

Avery patted her shoulder, “Don’t worry River, let’s just finish this quickly and be done. I’ll do the snatching, I suppose.” Eyeing Albert’s calm expression, Avery suspected that he wasn’t at this school at his age for nothing.

“I’ll tell you if that big boss of that guy notices you with my special instantaneous wind magic,” Albert added.

Instantaneous — intriguing for such a big work like that coming from a ten year old’s mouth.

“Wait, you have a way of doing that?” Avery questioned.

“I use my wind magic to transport sound to and from specific targets.”

“I-I’ve never h-heard wind magic used that way,” River said.

“It’s pretty cool, eh?” Albert gleamed. Unlike typical wind magic users, Albert was skilled with manipulating the currents in the air, however, the amount was limited. He explained this in short detail and then proceeded with the plan.

Seeing the crowds in the conference room hadn’t decreased, a good thing, Avery proceeded with the initialization of the plan by crouching close to where Billy’s gang was located. The bully trio were interrogating the tabletop game booth about “issues.” Finding the goggles being worn by Frank Bower, Avery pretended to be unaware of the environment and stepped closer.

Realizing he would not even barely reach for the goggles, Avery began to worry this plan would backfire. Approaching within a few feet, Avery was only two-thirds the height of Frank.

"So, any brilliant ideas?" Avery asked in. low volume, knowing full well that Albert could hear.

Then Albert's voice rang into Avery's ear even though his presence was not close, "Well, you could jump on him and grab it," which was not a soundproof plan at all.

"You're kidding! I'm the one who's at risk here," Avery protested.

"You agreed to this."

"I'm already regretting this."

Sucking it up, Avery examined for any possible escape routes for cover if he succeeded in the seizure of the item. Of course he could dark straight through the crowds at the center of the room, but that was too risky as Billy's gang would easily spot him dashing away.

There was just one escape route remaining, and it was an extremely dangerous one – potentially one for the history books.

River hovered among the crowds near the middle as to support Avery if something arouses the plan in some way. She desired to help out as much as she could but her confidence level only dropped among the masses of students.

Glancing at River and indicating a gesture for a distraction, Avery leaped onto Frank's back. A disgusting odor soured into Avery's nose, only making this whole operation stupid.

Feeling a sudden jolt and weight, Frank shuffled his body around and then his head. "Hey, what are you–" he began, only to be splashed by a few gallons of water.

Seizing the chance, Avery snatched the goggles from around his head and jumped off Frank's back.

Frank, smearing the water from his eyes, glanced in time to see the culprit on the run among the crowds.

Avery was relieved the plan worked so far. Frank had only caught a glimpse of his back, so there would be no suspicion as to who it was. Of course, Avery knew it was not over till he was in the clear.

Stirring his senses to overdrive, Frank rammed through a group of students, making a beeline towards Avery's direction.

Not wanting to give his face away, Avery only suspected that the shrills and groans as students fell behind him was the result of the bully.

“Hey Frank, what are you doing?” Billy Bones’ familiar voice called across the ballroom, which echoed and silenced all other conversations. “Can’t you tell we’re trying to force the students into an orderly fashion?”

“Ok, boss,” Frank instinctively responded to Billy.

Shuffling around, everyone’s attention was gazed upon Avery, the runner, and Frank, the pursuer. With simple deduction, it was clear the two figures to look at were the ones who were running in the room. Not everyone could clearly see, but they gazed in the general direction everyone else was fixed upon.

“Great,” Avery huffed. “Why did it have to end up like this?”

Smelling a foul odor and feeling the rumbling of the ground behind him, Avery concluded Frank was gaining speed towards him rapidly.

It was time for the dangerous escape route.

Sprinting in the general direction of the exit door on the opposite side of the room, Avery weaved around the individual groups of students to cause some confusion on Frank’s part. It was proven that the bullies combined were slow to think.

Reaching the side with the expense sports booths made of wood, plastic, and metal, Avery approached the nearest one and began to climb.

Avery successfully climbed onto the roof without the booth collapsing under him. Being a good altitude from Frank’s grasp, he could camp out and wait for the bully to leave, but Avery knew it was not a wise strategy, since, typically, Frank would resort to knocking the booths down with his massive strength.

Postured into a running stance, Avery charged forward and leapt from booth to booth until he came within range of the exit door.

With large lines gathered at each of the sports booths, Frank could neither resort to violence nor shove his way through the crowd.

Avery was homefree. With a final leap and a midair roll, he landed and burst through the exit.

Holding up the IT goggles that he found was not worth the endeavor, Avery sighed, releasing his stress.

Walking into the lobby on the other side of the door, Avery attempted to reduce his profile to begin scouting for River and Albert.

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When Avery met up with River and Albert eventually, they all agreed to talk logistics at a quiet lounge on the upper level.

Resting his real down on the couch, Avery released a loud sigh and relaxed his limbs. River sat beside him as Albert bounced around with ceaseless energy. When Avery handed Albert his goggles, Albert's happiness level skyrocketed, thus, causing his energy level to be unmeasurable.

"Your codename is Whiteout," Albert pointed to Avery.

"Whiteout? How come?" Avery asked.

"You've got some quick speed and agility, like a whiteout," Albert explained. "You were so cool. I can't wait for my magic to reach that level!"

"Uh yeah," Avery replied, twitching his smirk. None of the skills he displayed were magic oriented in the slightest.

"Usually martial arts or parkour are taught way later in high school."

"Is that so…" Avery reminisced about the three years worth of physical training which improved his movement skills after his time as a thief. "I guess you could say it comes from some prior experience."

Avery held back the remark of his escape from the bully as nothing special.

"And your's is Water Girl," Albert pointed to River.

"W-water girl?" River exclaimed flustered.

"While your water was cool and all, it was… eh, disappointing," Albert noted. "A worthy codename is for cool magic!"

"You should be a bit kinder to River," Avery reprimanded the boy.

River blushed at Avery's sudden defense for her. "It's ok, Avery. My magic isn't that interesting. I think the name suits me."

"If you're fine with that, alright," Avery said, turning and looking into her deep green eyes.

Turning and dropping her head down, River's face did not cease its blushing.

"You love her!" the kid said in a sassy tone.

Both Avery and River became redder but neither admitted or denied the statement.

“Okay, enough of this,” Avery finaly stated. “Also, no more missions or whatever that has to do with Billy Bones or his cronies,” Avery warned.

Avery straightened up and looked intently at Albert. “Now, tell me. What do you know of the motives of Pyrus Bourn or the shadow cult?”

“Oh you want to talk about bad guys, great! I’ve got lots to say of their plans and our countermeasures!” Albert exclaimed.

Avery nodded. He hoped to learn everything he could and avoid these threats as much as possible, for the sake of the life he desired.

“Well, according to extensive research I’ve done on our opponents, Pyrus Bourn was some non-Mystical Being who came to the Mystical Island to claim as his own, however, his plans were stopped by the Mystical Beings and the early shadow cult leader Lordius Doomolo,” Albert said.

“So a non-Mystical Being found the Mystical Beings?” Avery questioned, “Isn’t that against the whole… hiding the Mystical Beings?”

“It was about a hundred years ago when this happened, so rules were not as strict,” Albert explained.

“A hundred years ago, how was he able to live that long?”

“Strange things happened and he and his minions disappeared for over ninety years before reappearing to seize their original volcanic district,” Albert elaborated.

River’s head perked as she listened. It was an indication of her first time hearing this. “H-how do you know all this?” she asked, hoping to verify the source of the fact.

“Mmmm… My dad had some books from the Mystical Island so I was able to do extensive research.”

“Oh,” River replied contently. Though she lived in New York aware of the Mystical Beings, she herself seemed to be uneducated in most of the history.

“I guess how old they may be isn’t a big concern,” Avery said.

“Pyrus Bourn’s motives are a bit unclear, though in the past, he desired nothing more than seizing full control of the island. So it may be true to this day since his district is actively manufacturing Fire Increasers.”

Avery saw several ads from Fire Increaser Co., so he suspected that Pyrus was financially stable to do wild things.

"The shadow cult leader Lordius Doomolo was defeated around the same time that Pyrus disappeared a hundred years ago. I've become more interested in them now that I heard that two students at this school encountered one of the cult members," Albert continued.

Avery gave an uneasy laugh. Apparently Albert, and perhaps most of the students, did not know the identity of the two students.

"Yeah, uh huh. Though… I wonder what the cult's been up to," Avery stammered.

"Their original goals long ago were to free the Mystical Beings of the need to hide and proceed with one world government."

"Huh, so they were activists who wanted liberation, to some extent," Avery said.

"Something like that… but it is unclear whether their plans have been started since there has been no activity since their boss's defeat."

I wonder why they wanted me, Avery thought. He knew the answer was not going to be discovered from Albert afterall.

"Still, I bet they're not much of a threat, but we can do some sleuthing to find more of their plans," Albert suggested.

Avery wasn't quite assured by that last statement, but he decided to hold off on the negative thoughts.

"I believe I've got enough info for now. I'll ask you if I want to learn anything else," Avery said, appreciating Albert's presence.

"It was a great first mission. I can't wait to send you on even more," Albert responded with a wider grin than ever.

"I-I suppose," River said.

And so, the first mission of the Spy Academy agents was a success.

For the next few days, Avery, River, and Albert would continue to strategize new tactics to solve mysteries around the school and investigate info about the shadow cult. It was a fun experience and Avery felt it relieved himself of the former events that negatively shaped his perspectives.

Ontop of his classes, he continued learning the basics and also honing his magical power. He vowed he would remain strong to not end up in a chase situatio against the bullies ever again.

Learning a little more about the foes he encountered helped him conclude that those people were like any other person, such as Billy. It was so futile to ponder on such trivial matters.

Chapter 7: The Hidden Agenda

The next day, Kaden Icelander entered the ATLAS tower in New York quite early for a special meeting concerning the recent incident. Passing through the empty pavilion and standing before the large navy-blue tinted glass doors, he swiped a keycard on the right side of the door.

With a green light flickering a moment later, Kaden pushed through the door and entered the silver lobby. Unlike OSNYC, this school donned its signature by utilizing white marble and silver insignia paved around a large circular domed lobby. Several other glamorous decorations scattered about, especially on the passing faculty and students with their white tuxedos, dresses, and sparkling silver badges.

A head desk was stationed at the center to guide those unfortunate individuals on their first visit to this institute as its halls were almost worse since each floor consisted of its unique configuration. But Kaden, being a delicately prepared individual, didn't bother greeting or stopping to verify his target location. His father's company even foresaw the construction operations and the finish touches of the building (though they had no control over the specific blueprints). In terms of the color scheme itself, the building was a complete nockery of the real IT Tower.

Making a direct route to the elevators, Kaden swiftly swerved around some students and businessmen and managed to squeeze himself into an elevator just about to depart. With an agile body and unmeasurable dexterity, the boy slipped in naturally without a doubt in his mind of failure.

Smelling the stinky potato chips breath of some grizzly students among the group on the elevator ride and also being squashed far more than he could tolerate, Kaden vowed to speak with the principal of the school and change some logistics and procedures. Even though he believed he would never enter this place again, he still found the sight wholly unsatisfactory for any sane person's visit. Befitting a Mystical institution, the situation was even worse for an esteemed royalty who resided governance.

Arriving on the highest floor of the tower at the expense of several minutes—precious time he would never get back, Kaden marched into a large hall lined with doors only

unlockable by authentication. This was the floor of the administration of the Advanced Technology Life Academy (ATLAS). It was an accelerated academy for the top Mystical Beings on the mainland, created solely by the wealth of a graduate student of a distant land.

Though he was there for serious business, Kaden was almost tempted to barge in and complain about the hospitality of the school instead. He briskly strided towards the door at the end labeled, "Meeting Room 19."

Pressing a voice verification button, Kaden announced his name and occupation in a low annoyed tone. Hearing the approval ding, he was surprised it even took his awful voice. Thinking this was a raising concern, he thought that even the security was too laxed.

As soon as the door unlocked, Kaden burst it open and shouted in a loud voice, "I'm here! Finally!"

Several gentlemen sitting around a large round wooden table stared at him, blinking preplexed.

Unlike the rest of the ATLAS building, this meeting room was more pleasing to the eye with its woodsy and brown texture—a nice change of pace from the rest of the institute where the sun lunged its full glory off the white reflective marble.. A large tinted glass lined a third of the room, being the only source of light. The city skylines, with IT Tower brightly looming amidst them, were displayed in full appeal.

Now that the meeting would commence, it was decided on in short notice to be held at ATLAS for various security reasons, the main one being privacy. No one mentioned the other security vulnerabilities, but it really didn't matter at this point now.

It wasn't typical for Kaden Icelander to be late, in fact, very atypical. Some more important matters held his attention. It was standard for him to make an impression; in fact, a bad impression was better than no impression after all. Thus, he (sort of) purposely arrived a bit later on time to prove this point.

"What's a kid doing here? I thought Mr. Icelander was coming in," a gentleman at the far end railed. At least the man did not say, "You're late."

"Sorry, but my father couldn't make it, I mean, he hasn't been present for a while now. I, ahem, am Kaden Icelander, the manager of IT and I will be the one sharing info about the recent *incident*."

"Hmm… I see. I suppose there's nothing to be done about it," the same gentleman grumbled. "Very well. Have a seat and let us get this meeting started."

Kaden Icelander seated himself at an empty chair furthest away from the man speaking earlier and examined the other gentlemen around the room. None of them seemed particularly eye-catching as the boy never met them before and probably never will again.

"So, a small introduction," another man began, "My name is Oceanus Aquia. I am one of the administrators of this estate. My nephew Atlas Aquia first instituted this academy when he just graduated from college in hopes of teaching Mystical Beings on the mainland how to use magic while also concealing their identities so they can live a wealthy life in a paper money economy."

This man, named Oceanus Aquia, had shoulder length silver hair and a mystique silver beard. He had sharp blue eyes that made everyone else in the room feel tense and uneasy. He wore a navy suit and represented himself as the most respectable man in the room. Even Kaden had to admit his busyness didn't compare to this man's serious demeanor.

The gentleman beside him on the right introduced, "I'm Dr. Hatami Sugo, principal of the Official School of New York City, or OSNYC for short. I'm involved in the wellbeing of the students at my institute, but the recent incident has caused me some concern since plights in New York are not typically centered on Mystical Beings. But, with the help of the Mystical Surveillance Corps, I'm sure any threats can be dealt with efficiently." Fine words for someone glancing down on a sheet of notes.

"Yeah right, like that's going to happen," Kaden Icelander grumbled, fully aware of the unpredictable performance of the Mystical Surveillance Corps in New York City.

Principal Sugo, though a bubbly and approachable individual, wore a simple attire of a collared shirt and jeans that oozed of boringness. His messy black hair and dopey tan eyes gave impressions that contradicted his character.

Next to him sat the tallest gentleman in the room. He had brown hair and focused blue eyes. Though not the most fashionable person in the room, he remained silent as to focus only on the meeting at hand.

"Greetings, gentlemen," he announced, "I'm Council Seat Jim Jaedin. I'm a council member of District 7 from the Mystical Island. I've come here due to an urgent call. Though the incident didn't seem significant, the presence of the shadow cult in activity

still gives leeway to other potential threats. It may well also be a conspiracy and I'm suddenly here for nothing..."

Aside from Oceanus' presence bringing everyone to caution, Jim Jaedin was the one who attracted their attention.

The next man to introduce himself was the one who repromanded Kaden previously. Standing up and bowing slightly to become the center of attention, he said, "I'm Marx Lugner Sumaho, officer of the Mystical Surveillance Corps, or MSC, of New York City. I can testify that the incident was dealt with swiftly and there were no casualties."

Marx held his standards pretty high, though far from the scale of Oceanus' attire. Wearing a grey suit coat and a white collared shirt, his posture demonstrated his orthodox gestures. With somewhat light blue puffy hair and a fixed stern glare of his silver eyes, he did give off intimidation vibes—ones that aroused frustration and uncertainty. His clear glasses glowed brightly against his shadowy posture.

He "ahem'd" as if he was a still holding the attention but it only made him stand out like a sore thumb. Sitting back down, He smirked slightly at his accomplishment unaware of the differing opinions scattering the room.

Somehow Marx anticipated Kaden's agitated expression after he spoke. Having hit a nerve, Kaden Icelander was displeased with the man even more, afterall, the man was in charge of the same MSC that Kaden despised.

Unaware of the newfound rivalry between the both, Oceanus stood up and proceeded with the next item on the agenda. "Mr. Icelander, Officer Sumaho, would you both kindly start off the report of the incident?"

Seating himself, Oceanus examined the two addressed gentlemen expecting a proper exchange of etiquette. Instead, both Kaden and Marx stood up quickly at the same time. One would expect a young teen to be full of vigor, but a grown man like Marx himself rising unexpectedly in response caused the others to have concerns on his mentality.

"Alright, then I shall begin," Kaden spoke to the group, gesturing his hands high and snatching the attention first. He obviously didn't want to leave the details off to the mushroom head of the MSC.

"Sorry, but the MSC has the full report. I must give the proper details since it is our department who does these kinds of things," Marx objected, pulling the attention back. He was clearly hinting at Kaden's lack of authority in the issue.

"I was there at the incident so I am fully aware of what occured," Kaden countered.

Marx began prowling around the table as any restless person would do in a circumstantial situation like so..

“You will base everything off of what you remember, but I will carefully explain the event in full detail,” he spoke adamantly.

“Of course you’d have magic sensors that recorded all suspicious activity in the city, but I’m sure you don't know the context of the situation. The magic sensor system only receives visuals, or rather wave signatures, like an aerial device, so sound and specific details aren’t interpolated,” Kaden briefly explained. He was unsure why he was getting worked up, but he felt no ounce of surrender against Marx.

The face off remained neutral as neither increased their volume in response to their built up irritation, but only the tension gew between them.

“I was able to scout the origins of the event long before the incident occurred and I have video footage,” Marx spoke with authority.

Kaden huffed, but being a sensible man, he let the matter go. “Go ahead, I’ll be sure to correct you if you are wrong.” He sat down and folded his arms in discontentment.

Marx gleamed in triumph, but faltered a bit when he realized his cheap win.

“Anyway,” he stated, catching the attention of the room, “Yesterday evening, reports and magic scans pinpointed large amounts of mana used near the harbors at the south of the city. Luckily it was a dull night so possible third-party eye-witnesses were not present.”

Now, pointing at various sections of a detailed topography map and chart displayed on a floating holographic screen, Marx continued his conversation as if it were a lecture and he was a famous lecturer.

The hologram display was an intricate system designed by IT. It utilized magic particles in the air that shelled normal light waves together to form a semi transparent layer that could be manipulated in its formation. Such a futuristic system was only possible via the physics phenomena of magic in the air. Of course, the average Mystical Being became less amused by the spectacle as time went on.

“You can see on these graphs that the type of magic the shadow cult member utilized was shadow magic, the same used by other members of the shadow cult in times past. This graph shows a breakdown of the percentage of total magic used by affinities. Of course, Kaden Icelander came in and froze the entire area with ice.”

Kaden Icelander stiffened at the comment targeted at him. “At least I cleaned up after myself,” he muttered proudly, hurling the words to the speaker to hear.

“And what is that magic affinity number located below the seven percent use of water magic?” Principal Sugo asked, cutting Kaden’s comment just by a hair.

“It-It’s light magic. There’s no mistaking that,” Council Seat Jaedin pointed out.

“Yes, it very much is light magic,” Oceanus affirmed.

“Tell me, how many individuals were present at the incident?” Principal Sugo asked.

“Four, to be exact,” Kaden Icelander stated as he sabotaged control of the hologram display to shift to a new screen. The new slide displayed visuals of the four individuals at the incident: The shadow worshipper, Kaden Icelander, Avery Obtainia, and River Grant.

Marx gritted his teeth but remained unrepolsive under the serious conversation in motion. Sighing, he walked over to the other gentlemen and slapped down some documents. “These are some info of the two students of OSNYC at the incident.”

Picking the paper up, Oceanus’ eyes widened as he read the document containing River Grant’s information. “Interesting… Who would’ve thought.”

Then, glancing at the profile paper of Avery Obtainia, Oceanus gleamed unexpectedly.

“Seems to me that this situation was much different from a simple street attack, we’re dealing with a cult member with motives. I believe Mr. Kaden, who was present that night, may be able to inform us of the situation,” Oceanus stated, passing the papers onto the next gentleman.

“We could interrogate the villain,” Council Seat Jaedin suggested, uncertain what was the best way to approach the situation.

“A possible choice, however, the ability to squeeze information out of a zealous cult member is slim to none,” Principal Sugo spoke with deep certainty while carefully examining the papers passed to him.

“It’s been done. Interrogation didn’t go well since the cult member was quite composed regardless of the threats and other methods,” Marx stated, adjusting his glasses.

“I would like to know what the cult member was after and why the two students were involved?” Council Seat Jaedin asked, still desperate for answers. Though he held a high

seat in the island, he lacked outside info that would elevate his presence to the same level as the others in the room.

Recalling the event and Avery's dialogue, Kaden Icelander spoke informatively. "I believe the cult was after the destruction orb, also known as the Terracustodis. Not just them, but Pyrus and his gang also."

The room became silent when a sudden light gasp echoed through the room.

"One of the three orbs? They're locations are as unknown as the legends say, except the one that cloaks the Mystical Island from the world," Council Seat Jaedin exclaimed.

"Yes, the same orbs that brought the demise of the **Demon Lord**," Principal Sugo added.

"What could the cult stand to gain from that? Though it is powerful, it seems a little unusual," Council Seat Jaedin indicated. "Only indirect magic and high efficiency runes can manifest even a portion of its power."

"In the past, their leader desired to reveal the Mystical Beings to the world and conquer the mainland under one rule where the magic reigns above all," Oceanus ellaborated.

"Preposterous, how can attacking two students be a part of finding a legendary orb?" Marx said disdainly. "How would they, of all people, know the whereabouts of such an artifact? This all must be a bluff by Pyrus Bourn who we know is the only active suspicion."

"It's not highly improbable," Principal Sugo said as he passed the paper profiles along, "that this could all be a ruse. Given what we have at hand, it seems more likely a real goal, afterall, the boy with light magic is an Angelor."

"An Angelor?" a couple murmured. "Isn't that like… rare?"

"Yes," Kaden Icelander affirmed by pointing his pointer finger up. "Based on researching and studying the accounts, it is clear that Avery Obtainia, the Angelor, may be the sole reason this incident occurred and why future ones may arise if precautions are not implemented."

Once the papers were back in Marx's hands, he stood up and admitted, "I'd have to agree with Mr. Icelander. It seems that the cult is after something and the reason no fatal casualties occured means that they want to keep a low profile for now. I can't say how many cult members may remain, but I can say that they are active and thus must be extinguished."

"It is true, Angelors are one of the only ones that possess pure light attributes, however, they're supposed to be almost extinct, so how…?" Council Seat Jaedin questioned while collecting his thoughts.

"It may be linked with his past, which is still covered in mystery. All we know is that he was living in the streets of New York for most of his life before unexpecdily applying and entering OSNYC of all schools," Marx said.

Oceanus gleamed as if hiding something important from the others. "I suppose him finding the school was a good thing in the end."

"Since you all viewed the profile papers, you should have a good understanding of the situation and the backgrounds of the ones at the incident," Kaden Icelander announced.

"There isn't much we can do. Regrettably, we have to do further investigation," Marx stated in a slight temper.

"What about the girl?" Principal Sugo asked.

"She just happened to be with Avery when the event unfolded. They had some complications with some bullies at the school," Kaden briefly explained, unconcerned with the specifics of the other profiles.

"Hmm… I'll have to do something about the bully, but if it's Billy of all people, I don't know," Principal Sugo murmured.

"If the orb is what they're after, won't it be easier to confiscate it ourselves and then vault it?" Council Seat Jaedin asked.

"It may be a wise option, but the means of finding it is still unclear," Oceanus said. "Attempting to even search for it will cause the enemy to be on guard."

"If the boy is involved in this, then we must do some precautions to make sure that he remains away from enemy hands," Principal Sugo suggested. "What may be the best option?"

"Wait!" Marx said abruptly, "Why must we go into this effort for some mere students?"

The other gentlemen gawked at him.

"Think about it. It would be a huge financial burden."

"Nothing that you'll need to worry about," said Oceanus, waving his hand to indicate he would cover the costs.

“The possibility of the cult attacking is very low, since their intent is to hide themselves as much as possible. I believe the main concern arises from why the students were targetted. Further investigation on the island is well worth the small amount of money that may be poured into them,” Principal Sugo explained.

“I believe the academy at the Mystical Island is an ideal location. The prestige and hte number of elite Mystical Beings will guarantee protection,” Kaden stated with overconfidence of the school’s reputation.

The others nodded in agreement since no differing opinions arose. Marx, though skeptical of the unanimous choice, backed down. He didn’t want to be the single person rejecting everything.

“Very well, I can make the arrangements for Regnum Academy,” Oceanus stated.

“Regnum Academy of all schools? Isn’t that a bit high on the radar?” Marx indicated, clearly doubtful of the choice.

“We still have to take account of Pyrus Bourn and his gang. Though a treaty is between his district and the main Mystical one, he does not abide by the same rules, thus, further protection at Regnum Academy is the optimal choice,” Council Seat Jaedin explained confidently, now under his jurisdiction of understanding.

“If it’s all about succeeding and overcoming the prestigious challenges, then I think the boy especially has a chance,” Oceanus assured.

The others around the room wondered if he had some connection with Avery, but being a prominent figure in the room, it was quite rude to bring up opinions.

“How about others directly involved? They could potentially be targets,” Council Seat Jaedin inquired.

“River Grant was the only other person at the incident. It may be wise to take precautions for her as well,” Oceanus added.

“It does seem like a wise idea,” Kaden agreed.

“Also to note, this boy, Teddric Tech, seems to be quite close with Avery Obtainia. I believe he should be considered,” Principal Sugo noted.

“Yeah, I suppose so. That last name… sounds familiar, but no matter,” Council Seat Jaedin concured.

A silence spread through the room as Principal Sugo was hard at work typing some information. Though the talk was easy, the process to transfer student information through the Mystical Being internet was a complex business.

"Paperwork should take a few days, but after that, it should all be ready to go," Principal Sugo sighed, resting his hands.

"Aww don't worry, the work won't be too bad," Kaden hinted, aware he would have no required involvement in the process.

Marx glared at Kaden and his rude comment, clearly thinking that he was the one who slacked the most in the entire group in the room.

"Easy for you to say, Kaden Icelander," he scoffed.

"Come on, I am a manager at IT. It's a load of work," Kaden complained. "Hmm… safety and security for you guys. Not to mention keeping the satellite service for the IT-Phones."

"Very well, now that things have been settled, each of us can do our part to protect teh Mystical. The meeting is adjourned," Council Seat Jaedin announced before the new dispute could roll in motion.

"Well, I suppose I should make my way to the island as well very soon," Kaden declared.

"Why go now of all times, you've been here a short time. You could stay and continue contributing," Principal Sugo protested.

"It's simple. I've been here to investigate the District 1 incident, small stuff like that. Plus, I've been here a month. I think it's time to take a breather," Kaden said gleefully.

"Fine, do as you wish, but I hoped you could be involved a bit more with OSNYC and ATLAS schools as you do back at the island," Principal Sugo said, saddened at the denial of his offer. It wasn't really an offer but more of a "continual" service plea.

With the meeting ended, each gentleman went their separate ways back to their posts. Having important duties to attend to, no member was foolish enough to stay idle for more than a few minutes.

Marx especially held to this standard, however, he still wished for the chance to pound some sense into the young prodigy. Of course, Kaden darted out before anyone else even left the room.

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Many would've thought that such a young prodigy as Kaden Icelander lived in a competitive driven household growing up, but this was far from the truth. In fact, the truth was far more disturbing than percievable, but Kaden knew it well.

Tragic family suffering, self-sufficent at a young age, and his father too busy to be an exemplary figure; these were just the main events that shaped the young boy's attention and dedication. Kaden Icelander strove to create a new dawn of technology that would forgo the old customs. Not that possessions would change anyone's perspective, but it would enlighten them to a superior future.

Thinking back on the boy Avery Obtainia, Kaden leaned against his desk chair and gazed at the ceiling. It wasn't typical of him to daydream, but today was different. Having come back from the meeting, Kaden was intrigued about so many possible scenarios – dangers, the incident, the cult resistance.

He was bogged down with the weight of his mind when a sudden knock at his office dragged him back to reality.

"Oh yes, I forgot. Today's the day," he murmured as he shuffled papers and arranged them neatly. The person whom he expected was not going to be thrilled to see a mess, so a proper reorganizing would avoid such time wasting remarks.

Kaden Icelander was seated in his large office at the highest floor of IT Tower of New York City. This special honor was bestowed upon him by his father since his major role in the company required a decent working space. Being the COO to the CEO, it was Kaden's responsibility to manage the entire tower in his father's absence.

To say his father was absent was an understatement since he was on indefinite leave. Kaden had no idea where his father usually traveled to, but it was always confidential, even to him.

As the time was midday, the sun glared itself into the room, causing the rich marble floor and caramel wood desk to be illuminated harshly. Today, Kaden didn't bother tinting the windows.

"You may enter," Kaden called as he stood up to greet the guest. To Kaden, allowing someone to enter while being seated was a disgrace of the guest showing superiority.

A golden knob of the double doors leading into the office turned. Then the door itself was opened to reveal a tall girl.

“So, you’re back from the meeting! Hopefully it wasn’t more work for you,” she incited, striding towards the desk.

With pale blue eyes and weist length golden hair, the young girl was no older than Kaden himself. She wore a black business suit and held a tablet against her chest.

“Yes, I’m back,” Kaden responded briefly, sitting down again.

“Good. There’s a lot of documents for you to verify.”

Bobbing his head, Kaden sighed. Another typical rush of pointless paperwork.

“I won’t be here for very long. I’ll have to head out to do a few more secret missions,” he said.

“What? Already?” the girl pouted.

“I have to tend to some stuff, but you should be fine here managing a few remaining items during my short time away.”

“I suppose.”

“I’m glad you understand,” Kaden complimented.

“So what was the verdict?” the girl asked formally, jolting down data unrelated to the conversation. Already burdened with some other issues, she was irritated that yet another one would give her more hindrance.

“It’s nothing concerning. Honestly it was such a drag. I shouldn’t have gone,” said Kaden with an irritated tone. Marx Sumaho happened to pop into his mind as he thought about the meeting.

“Anyway,” he continued, “I’d say the shadow cult isn’t the threat.”

“Wait! What do you mean? You know that you’ve been searching for clues about their whereabouts for a long time!” the girl huffed.

“Come on, it’s not like my grudge lifted or anything. Something else is at work here,” Kaden said as he leaned against the desk intently.

“A hidden agenda? This isn’t part of the report.”

“It wasn’t mean’t to be.”

“What do you mean? So… you hid it from the other prominent figures in the meeting?”

“I wouldn’t call them… prominent, but I guess they were important enough. The info I could’ve given them might change the fate of the world itself if not handled properly.”

The girl was confused at the statement but she remained collected to display her lack of falter. “So you say. Care to elaborate?”

Fully aware that his personal office was hack proof and completely private, Kaden still felt uncomfortable sharing details.

“The boy, Avery Obtainia, is crucial to the shadow cult’s plan at the moment, however, I’ve realized his potential involvement in the near future is much more tied to the fate of the Mystical Beings,” Kaden explained in the simplest terms possible.

Picking up the hidden message, the girl nodded. “I see. So this is why he’s being sent to the island.”

“Partially true. Though sending him to the island may be for momentary protection, I believe his presence will continue to reveal secrets that were long lost. He’ll learn more and become stronger through his passionate drive.”

“Why all the effort? Generally you don’t care about low levels.”

“Ha! Oh Lucy, you never change,” Kaden commented to the girl, whose name was Lucy.

“What are you talking about? You’re the one who changed the most,” Lucy protested.

“But no. It’s not that I care more than usual, it’s because he may be the one who can aid in my plans to retake my land.”

“Looking at his profile, he doesn’t seem so special. I don’t know what you’re really up to but you’d better explain it now,” demanded Lucy intensely.

“Look closely,” Kaden gestured.

“Wait…! Those pink eyes!” she exclaimed. “Only one other person in history ever had them.”

“Exactly.”

“But, I don’t see anything else.”

“You’ll see in due time. Now isn’t the moment to ponder such problems. Changning subjects, I thought I’d ask how your expedition went.”

“You didn’t have to put it that way. Asking nicely would’ve done the trick,” Lucy huffed.

“So, how was your recent expedition?” Kaden asked again, obeying her remark.

“Nothing was out of the ordinary. I investigated potential shadow cult locations throughout the island and the mianlands but found nothing that gave eere vibes.”

“How about the other villains, Pyrus Bourn and such?”

“I looked into recent boat departures to and from the island. Here is the report. I found nothing strange.” Lucy handed her tablet displaying a detailed schedule to Kaden Icelander.

Skimming through, Kaden paused when he noticed a particular time that interested him.

“So, Avery’s encounter with him was not mere cuincedience…”

“What are you saying? You found something strange?” Lucy inquired.

“Though Mystical Beings are freely able to travel to the mainland, it isn’t strange for them to cover their identities so that the officials don’t suspect anything. Using simple deduction, I’ve figured out the alias for Pyrus Bourn,” Kaden explained.

“Why would someone like him need to cover his identity?”

“Who knows. Though it is a clever way to do sketchy business without needing to worry about one’s reputation being ruined. Pyrus Bourn searching for the orb around the same time as the incident does seem intriging.”

“So that’s what you mean,” Lucy said, enlightened by the facts.

“Yes, many of these strange events are connected, yet the main root of those problems have not been addressed.”

“Are you suspecting that some information got leaked out which might’ve caused the recent cult member and Pyrus Bourn to go on the move?”

“I’m glad you’re smart enough to follow along, that is why I specifically hired you,” Kaden commended.

“Just doing my job, you know,” Lucy replied, flattered by the kind words.

Kaden Icelander leaned back against his desk chair. “Hmm… We’ll just see what sort of intriguing events come next, won’t we.”

Chapter 8: Captain Levi's Tales

Another week passed in Avery's new life at OSNYC. Avery found himself understanding and adapting quite easily without other students suspecting false impressions, but he was far from mastering his magic powers. A few days would've done the trick, one would say, but this was not the case.

Leaning against his bedpost, Avery breathed heavily after another round of repetitive use of his light magic. He felt the magic coursing through his body better, yet the quantity that he could draw out only increased by a small margin since the incident.

It was evening, after another day of classes of mostly essentials, and both Avery and Ted were chilling in their dorm room. No events were scheduled that time so it was free time for students to do what they pleased. Avery was also relieved to not have to do club duties for the spy academy.

Ted focused on programming a new invention of his using his black circuit box. A pile of wires and motors scattered the floor, almost too close to Avery's side of the room. His computer was wired to the box and displayed a command prompt where he directly coded specific actions.

Almost stepping on a sharp gear, Avery bounced about being sure to avoid other obstacules. He approached Ted and demanded, "You should clean up after yourself."

Ted, who was deep in his mechanic paradise, only responded with a simple humph.

Before Avery could ask about advice for his magic training, a sudden knock startled the duo and swept silence into the room.

Avery carefully stepped back to his side of the room and glanced through the door peephole. Seeing a man in a suit made him shudder, but nonetheless, he opened the door.

"So who is it?" Ted called when the man stepped into the room.

Wearing a dark suit and posturing elegantly, the man held an faculty ID card before Avery and Ted. He indicated his presence to speak, but the duo only saw him as someone who carried threats.

"You two should pack up and come with me," the man's only statement pierced the ears of the duo. He then exited and stood at the far end of the hall expecting to quickly comply.

Was it for something we did wrong or was it something else important? Avery thought this as he went to his dresser to retrieve his belongings.

Ted didn't take it very well either. Seeing a glint of frustration, Avery suspected that he was divided as to whether to comply or rebel. Snatching most of his mechanical parts, Ted stuffed all his essentials into a backpack and followed Avery out of the room.

Avery, equipped with his light backpack, walked briskly towards the man at the end of the hall. "So what seems to be the problem? Did we do something wrong?"

"Just follow along. The principal wants to see you," was the man's only and final response.

If it was the principal, there were only two guesses how the encounter could go. The first being the strange optimistic attitude of the principal and the duo receiving praise. And the second being a new mysterious side of the principal yet to be discovered.

The duo followed the man into an elevator near the rear of the floor which gilded straight to the highest floor: the fortieth floor.

Stepping out upon arrival, the duo noticed they were no longer in what they could imagine as a principal's office. Instead, it was a large open space with windows surrounding the entire open floor. A single desk loomed before them as they followed the man towards it.

Gazing about, the lights of both the moon and the city illuminated the floor, giving a gentle, yet futuristic vibe.

Now a few meters from the one sitting in the desk, Avery mimicked the man's position and stood beside another person whose presence he just realized.

It was River Grant, who seemed to have arrived not moments before, beside him. She was in her same attire as a week ago. A small thick backpack laid on the ground beside her legs.

Avery gestured a slight wave, catching her attention. She nodded and exchanged a wave back.

"So what's the meaning of this?" Ted demanded, breaking the tense mood and making the situation more awkward.

It definitely felt like the encounter with the principal was going to be the latter: the mysterious side of the principal was just about to be revealed.

"Ha, you're not intimidated at all! I like people like you," the principal laughed as he sipped from a coffee mug. His bubbly dialogue was not present as he spoke, yet there was a sense of friendliness. He was now calm and collected, what one would expect of a principal of a prestigious institution.

Then with a slight gesture of his free hand, the principal sent the man who escorted the duo on his merry way.

"Now that it's just us, let's keep this chill. I'm Principal Sugo, as you probably know from the entrance exam and such," the principal greeted.

"It's nice to meet you," the three standing before him stated at once. They bowed with courtesy and expected him to erupt or something and complain about their behavior.

"You three are aware of the recent incident, but you most likely do not know what the long term effects are. Stll, I must make this brief."

Hearing the statement, Avery, River, and Ted's attention were piqued.

"Though the shadow cult attack was just a small hinderance, your involvement has made yourselves more vulnerable to potential future attacks, so, the officials and I have decided to send you three to the Mystical Island where you'll be better safeguarded and learn at an accelerated rate how to fend for yourselves."

"Going to the… island?" remarked Avery puzzled.

"Yes, it is for your better good that you be sent there. You'll each be enrolled in Regnum Academy for your continued learning. I hope that you do keep up with your studies, afterall, you are given free admission and nothing will be of expense on your behalf."

"Wait, what? What about my family?" Ted protested.

"Don't worry about that, they were already notified and they agreed it would be best for your well-being. You are the son of the notorious Techs, so you especially going to the island would serve your family's reputation some good."

"I can't believe they actually agreed to that… not that I care, of course," Ted grumbled.

He stood there solemnly, contemplating the destined facts. Much of his background wasn't disclosed to his friends but he knew of his parent's originality from the island and their newfound comfy life at present since he was born.

Folding his hands back and stretching, he stated, "Well, what can I do, am I right?" He suspected his parents had not much of a choice either.

The principal folded his hands and chose not to reply.

"T-This doesn't m-make ss-sense," River stammered suddenly.

"It doesn't have to," Principal Suog spoke brightly, gesturing his hands, "Just a simple decision from the higher ups. Smart students like you may figure it out in due time, I guess, hehe."

It was difficult to tell if the principal was joking on the last comment, but given his usual lack of demeaner, it was better not to question such judgement. His authority was powerful enough to induce the trio to obey.

"It's concerning me specifically, am I right?" Avery spoke up, suspecting that Principal Sugo was hiding some details.

Now, having been piqued, Principal Sugo leaned forward and spoke, "You're an interesting one. Now seeing you before me, I see why Kaden Icelander saw something interesting in you."

"Kaden Icelander? You've… met him?"

"Oh we just had a meeting a while back, that's all. You, Avery Obtainia and River Grant, were specifically involved in the incident, making you two the most important for protection. Teddric Tech was brought along to avoid further suspects," Principal Sugo dismissed.

"What do you mean by protection? OSNYC isn't protected?" Avery questioned. Somehow he guessed the issue was more than that especially regarding the shadow cult and Kaden Icelander's drastic maneuvers to contend with them.

The principal leaned back and grinned. "Being sure not to give the goodies away, I suppose I can tell you a little bit. The island is just much safer for you. On the mainland, any wrongdoing of Mystical Beings can linger for days before being caught and resolved."

His giveaway wasn't much of a sneak peak, but the trio thought it wise not to continue provoking him, afterall, a weird principal was still a principal.

"When do we leave, or how do we get there?" Ted questioned, changing the subject.

"Arrangements for your departure have been made. You three will ride along with a merchant on a private boat to the island. There, you should be met by some officials from Regnum Academy who will take care of you from there," Principal Sugo said delightedly.

The three said nothing as they nodded.

"With that, all should be done."

With a quick swipe on his smartphone, the principal called in a different man who was a security guard.

The security guard that entered the room immediately stepped next to Principal Sugo to exchange a quick whisper too quiet to be depicted.

With that, the meeting with the principal ended and the trio followed the security guard to the elevators where they were headed to the base floor of the school institute.

Riding the elevator down to the very bottom of the tower, it felt shorter than expected. Upon the door's parting, the trio witnessed a physical change in the school's quality.

Unlike the full rich decor of the school, the lower grond level was gray and gross. Several faculty cars lined the large empty parking lot where the concrete floor was cleanest as most of the other areas lacked maintenance. Exposed water pipes on the ceiling dripped water and other mysterious substances on scattered areas of the parking lot, thus furthering the grotesqueness of the scene.

As he guided the trio to his vehicle, the security guard, along with Ted, had to crouch a bit from the low ceiling. Avery, being more than a head shorter, felt pleased having not to be in an awkward state.

Having found the ride at last, they were escorted into a private school security car where they would be chauffeured to a nearby harbor.

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Upon arriving at the popular coastline of cruise ships and private merchant boats, the trio and the security guard exited their ride and headed closer to the ships. Unlike the

previous harbor that Avery and River set foot on, this location was much grander and far busier.

Several luxury ships lined the far end of the harbor and the large crowds made navigation and following the leader far more difficult.

A man stood a short distance away and waved his hand, indicating for the trio to come near. His deep brown eyes instantly narrowed to Avery.

The security guard handed a stack of papers and shook hands with the man. He then whispered a few words before turning his back and disappearing.

The silence of calm waves breaking against the port filled the air. The crowd's clamour only seemed to fade as they approached the man and the edge of the docks.

The man carefully glanced at the paper handed to him. His expression lit up upon reading a particular line.

Standing at a bridge leading up into the ship, Avery noticed the calm ocean below him. A small cargo ship loomed behind the man.

"So," he said at last, breaking the silence, "my name is Elmor Locks, and apparently, I am to guide you to the Mystical Island. You must be Avery and Ted. I've heard a little about your latest encounters."

He extended his hand as a welcome. Avery and Ted felt reluctant to shake a stranger's hands. River chose to not even consider it.

Stroking his short black beard, the man's gaze descended on his watch. He wore a simple waterproof jacket and pants, an attire standard among several fishermen about the region.

"As you know, I'm Elmor Locks, as previously stated. I am a government agent, or rather a diplomat through the academy, and I can guarantee your safety," Elmor continued in a light hearted tone as he looked at the trio hoping to win over their trust.

Avery felt as if the last sentence was a bit off the mark.

A loud noise screamed through the air, the ship behind Elmor Locks indicated the time for departure.

"Well, it looks like it's time to depart," Mr. Locks said as he indicated the trio to follow up the bridge.

The trio and the newly befriended Mr. Locks boarded the ship.

Moments later, the ship's soft engines roared to life. Gently gliding across the waters, it transversed at a tremendous speed away from the harbor.

As New York disappeared from view, Avery noticed that the vessel they boarded was far smaller than its majestic view on ground. Large crates littered the deck, all tied down by thick ropes, leaving only a fwe narrow passageways for manuvering.

A big burly man came swaggering over. The enormous sea coat and the top hat with medals and pins clearly showed this was the captain of the vessel. Swinging his hand out and jerking Avery's hand, he shook it ferociously, bellowing, "Ahoy there mate! Call me Captain Levi."

Pulling his hand back quickly and having his arm nearly torn off, Avery backed away saying, "H-hi, my name is Avery," in a small voice.

The capptain completely ignored him and moved on to the next passenger to shake their hand. Several other crew members filed onto the deck, capturing the captain's attention. Ted and River steered far away from the man, pleading not to have their arms torn off either.

After the greetings and pleasantries, Captain Levi swaggered off below deck, leaving the trio back in Elmor's hands.

Cleaning his throat, Elmor began, "That was Captain Levi… and he's very kind as long as you don't get on his bad side."

"Uh huh," Ted smirked.

"What's your relationship with him?" Avery questioned, puzzled by the fact a government agent would hold close ties to a lowly sea captain.

"He and I go way back when I was a student. I was a fisherman for some time. Now, I just thought I'd hop on a ride to pick you guys up, council's orders, of course," Mr. Locks explained, gazing into the air and reminiscing about his past.

"That makes sense. So, exactly how long will this trip be?"

Snapping back to reality, Mr. Locks answered with glee, "Approximatly ten hours or so. Best you guys get some sleep. You can find an area donw in the lower floors where some of the other crew members sleep, but I wouldn't expect a full night's worth."

Ted's mood lighted up as he glanced and gawked at the various machinery distributed around the ship. The engine room, the crate cranes, the intricate ship structure – he wanted to see it all.

"I can look around, right?" Ted pleaded earnestly.

Recalling some of his prier first experiences at sea, Mr. Locks answered, "Given that you are only guests, it is wise you stay only where someone can monitor you." He was about to regret babysitting some minors, but he kept his cool.

"That sucks," Ted replied, disappointed at the reply. He felt tempted to walk over to a nearby crew member tying some ropes to a crate, but restrained as he admitted its risk.

River walked over to the side of the ship and, clutching the railings, she gazed out into the ocean illuminated by the rising moon.

When the distant lights of the city faded from view, the swishing ocean wrapped around the solo ship as far as the eye could see.

Avery walked over to witness the same scenery. It was his first time out at sea, let alone on a boat.

Ted continued analysing the ship's machinery from a distance.

Mr. Locks came over to Avery and River and spoke, "I'm surprised you were able to keep calm given your circumstances."

Avery jolted at the comment. It was the first time he thought about his opinion of the matter. Though, deep down, he felt indifferent.

"There isn't much I can do. Complaining and rebelling won't really do any good. I guess… I'd gotten used to all these rapid changes," Avery said. Formerly being a beggar, he had no control of the day, weather, the type of food, clothes, or anything. He was essentially grounded by the principle of not being bothered by trivial matters, thus, the series of unfortunate events was no exception.

"Yes, I see. You were the boy who recently discovered your own magic at OSNYC. Quite an interesting turn of events, huh?"

Having not spoken a word once since school, River trembled as she thought of the matter. She kept her opinion to herself as disclosing it would only make the situation more tense.

Ted, overhearing, stated, "I dunno. I'm kinda annoyed being so far from my gaming computer, but since I am forced to come anyway, the upside is seeing all the new technology on the island."

"Yeah, you could make a new one," Avery suggested.

"A new one? Hmmm… you may be onto something, teehee."

Avery leaned against the railing almost up to his chest. “So, what is the Mystical Island like anyway? I’ve heard mentions of it and stuff.”

“Long ago, the only solo human named Zenith Luces brought the scattered Mystical Beings together and sailed them to an undiscovered island where they would thrive independently from the mainland,” Mr. Locks said.

“But more importantly,” he continued, “the island served as a new permanent residence for Mystical Beings where they would unleash their full magic potential. Several small nations are scattered around the island, but they all have a common goal of success. The best security and the top notch research facilities are located on the island also.

“You all will be taken to Regnum Academy, a school especially famous among all the Mystical Beings. Though there’s usually a competitive entrance exam, you’ll be excused from it.”

Avery felt dumb having not asked River or Ted prier of describing the island.

“Sounds intriguing,” he said at last, becoming even more curious as to what the island had in store for him and his friends.

“Oh, how hard is the exam?” Ted inquired, twiddling his thumbs.

“For the residents alone, the rate is less than five-percent. It’s one of the esteemed schools for the nobility and royalties alone and requires tremendous effort to excel well in. I wish you all the best,” Mr. Locks winked, implying his extensive knowledge.

Avery, Ted, and River stood frozen and dumbfounded.

After a moment of silence, Mr. Locks suggested, though his tone clearly indicated it as an order, “Best to head to bed, I suppose. You don’t want to stay out here too late or you’ll get frostbites.”

With their sudden rigid posture, it was very likely.

Seeing the options limited significantly, the trio followed Mr. Locks down to the sleeping quarters where most of the crew members were present.

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Heading down the flight of stairs at the back of the ship, the air suddenly became murkier. Navigating through the ship might’ve sounded easier if the architecture and

engineering was performed properly for the crew members, but this shape was specifically constructed out of a whim, at least that was how Avery thought as he and his friends followed behind Mr. Locks.

Mr. Locks ushered the trio through several windy halls before arriving in front of the entrance to the living space. Loud clamours rumbled through the walls.

"This seems sketchy," Ted murmured.

Without a response, Mr. Locks pushed the doors upen to unleash the full scope of sounds and smells trapped inside.

Following Mr. Locks, the trio laid their belongings in a quieter corner of the living quarters.

Mr. Locks' prior comment about not getting sleep was an understatmenent to the actual scene. At least fifty crew members occupied each bed spread throughout the room. Double bunk beds made of metal were planted evenly in rows and columns through the entire room.

The good news was most of the crew members occupied beds closer towards the door, but the negative news was their clamour only echoed off the walls towards the back, making the sounds seem louder.

Mr. Locks went over to a group of women who were unpacking and began small-talking with them.

At least the beds aren't disgusting, Avery thought as he hopped on his upper bunk which was layed with a light clean sheet over the mattress. River decided to occupy the bed below him.

Although showcasing the most energy throughout the day, Ted was the first to slump into his bed and fall asleep, regardless of the noises.

A theretical chill spread across the room when the captain of the vessel entered.

"Sir," most of the crew mates shouted as they stood up before him.

"You'll ask for me to tell a few tales of mine, no need to show your formalities," Captain Levi assured, taking off his captain's hat and tossing it to a crew member.

"Yes sir. What tale do you have for us tonight?" several unanimously asked.

Captain Levi sat down at the nearest bed, causing a loud screetch sound to come from its frames. Several crew mates backed away fearful to be in the resulting rubble.

“I’m not going to bite. Come closer!” Captain Levi barked, assuming the crew was afraid of his demeaning build.

“Are you sure–?” a few mumbled.

“Of course!” yelled the captain.

With no other choice, most of the crew eager for a story gathered at his feet like pigeons to a food feeder.

Avery rolled close to the edge. “Hey, River. Do you know why that person is?”

A rustle of the sheets indicated River was awake still. “Umm, never heard of him before.”

“Oh ok, it just seems odd that a bunch of crewmates are respecting him a bit too much.”

“A bit of an introduction for you new crew members. I’m Captain Levi, former navy admiral of District 7. I recently retired and started a humble cargo business to retrieve supplies for the island,” the captain announced.

A bunch of ooo’s and ahh’s went into the air after the introduction, probably proving the crewmembers were a bit too zealous.

“Perhaps I should tell a tale of my conquest against the lowly neighboring demihuman district.”

“Yeahh!” the crewmembers cried.

“Or perhaps the time when I single handedly beat a hundred enemy pirates.”

“Ahhh!”

“You know, the time I swam across the Atlantic isn’t a bad tale.”

“Whoaa!”

Cracking his knuckles and stretching his arms, the captain began his tale. “As you know, I’m one of the founding members of Regnum Academy, the same prestigious academy where most of the current great Mystical Island leaders also originated.”

Aveyr suddenly felt a chill as a strange thought went past his mind: what if he was not worthy enough for such a top-tier school?

“I wish I had gone there, I wouldn’t be in this crappy job,” a crew member complained.

"No you dummy, only the best gets to go. Also… are you calling this job dumb?" another crew member retorted.

"Now, now," Captain Levi smashed a fist on the ground, "no need to bicker about such a trivial matter. Starting a school didn't mean it would end up successful but I'm glad things turned out good… for the most part. Though these days, the current higher class have become quite snutty about certain ethnicity being a part of the school admission process and all. Whatever, my story isn't all about that anyway.

"Over thirty years ago, I was one of three founding members of Regnum Academy. The other members and I were close friends and we were all part of a group that sought to help Mystical Beings of all kinds. Back then, most of the Mystical Beings were still divided, so it was up to us and our crew to sail around various locations and gather the stragglers. It's also only been a decade or so when the districts were declared in order of their discovery as well.

"Luckily several sensor-type Mystical Beings were on the trip, so seeking out other Mystical Beings was quite easy. But humans and weather weren't the main challenges we faced, hehehe."

The sudden laugh at the end brought a shadow over the room.

"You'll aren't getting scared, are you?"

The crew members shook their heads.

"Ha! Thought so.

"Anyway, the biggest fear of the crew were the monsters of the sea. Not just any type, but magical ones. You see… the sensor Mystical Beings often felt large magic signatures in the middle of the sea and dragged us into all sorts of messes. We were after Mystical beings afterall, not Mystical Creatures. When we realized it, we were often too late.

"Since the **Demon Lord**'s stripping of all magic power, nearly all living species lost their spiritual mana link, but some managed to remain intact, specifically the deep sea creatures.

"Species that envelope in magic energy slowly, but surely, evolve as more of that energy spreads and overwrites the former structure of that creature's body. So the same occurred to one particular creature we encountered."

"Ohh! What was the creature?" several crew members interrupted at once.

Leaning forward, the captain spoke in a slow tone, "It was called… the Bestlynger. A dangerous monster whose only seen attribute was its large tentacles.

"On an early spring trip, we rode on a small ship to gather some potential Mystical Beings from a part of the Japanese islands, only to be confronted by the fearsome creature instead.

"Out at sea with little versatility, it was difficult to flee from the monster no less than fight it. The Bestlynger tore through our ship like thin wooden toothpicks and nearly drowned most of our crew. Of course, we'd never back away from a fight, even with the odds against us.

"I was known as the windshaker, the symbol of strength, the other two respectively were known as the stormbringer and seabreaker. Their names were Elaina Terner, the symbol of hope, and Oceanus Aquia, the symbol of peace. The others were pretty impressive, but afterall, you're here to hear about me, hehe.

"The three of us had the deadliest combo attack, one that surpassed the greatest Mystical magic at that time.

"During a situation where the boat was destroyed, Oceanus had to focus most of his water magic on saving the drowning crew members. Elaina created the path by distracting the creature with fast lightning magic attacks.

"But the bulk of the work was on me. I used my wind magic to steer the tentacles as far away from the crew as possible.

"Once the coast was clear, we used our combo attack called the '*Lightning Water Wind Magic: Hurricane of the Raining Thunder*!'"

"Amazing!"

"Cool!"

Captain Levi only nodded, soaking in all the applause.

"Alas," he said, calming the room, "We did not defeat the creature. It ran away after the blast of magic degenerated a few of its tentacles."

Some of the crew members hoped for something more hype but were content enough that the story ended well.

"That's just the tale of our defeat of the great Bestlynger, but I have another tale of our journey back to the island."

"Oooohhh!"

“As you should be aware, we didn’t have a boat anymore, so the feasible option was to abort the expedition. The journey was tougher than fighting the monster, not goin’ to lie. Some of us had to be pretty clever to use the techniques we had to survive.

“Oceanus focused on keeping us afloat and catching a few small fray that Elaina roasted with her lightning. I had the honor of holding the food midair so it remained dry. Since most of our resources were also destroyed, all we had to as a guide was the sun and moon. It took us nearly a week to find the closest dry land. And from there, we had to clevelry formulate all sorts of arrangements for travel back to the island.

“It was a sight to see, but too embarrassing for us when we arrived on the island in tatters. We thought our reputations were ruined, but everyone only joked how badly we were defeated by a mere monster. And so, to this day, I am always eager for its return so I can have a rematch.

“Now, looking back on it, it is amusing that such an event could be retold by yours truly.”

The captain laughed loudly at the thrill of his own tale. The crew went along with it. But staring back with a fierce intimidation, the laughter in the air instantly silenced. The captain found his own laughter astounding but the assumption of the crew laughing at him ticked him off.

“Sorry.”

“Sorry, sir.”

“Sorry, captain.”

Releasing a wide grin, the captain spoke, “You all are really a bunch of knuckleheads, aren’t you! Scared of your own captain?”

Who wouldn’t have. Such a stare would’ve shut anyone up.

“Those are just some of my adventures. There’s plenty more interesting ones… for another time.”

“Please? Another one! Please? Please?” several crew members chanted. They were like chilren at this point begging for more candy.

“It’s time for most of you to go to sleep. Early tomorrow. I’m sure another tale of mine will be told another day,” Captain Levi calmly rejected.

Aware of his grouchy attitudes sometimes, the crew members did not persist. Most of them began creating physical noises as they prepared for sleep. Once the captain exited

his private quarters, Mr. Locks stepped out of the corner and barked some orders into the laziest and loudest crew members.

Avery rolled in his bed, reflecting on the tales that the captain described. He imagined things couldn't get any weirder, instead it was proven that there was more knowledge yet to be gained.

The tales only inspired him to be more observant and stirred his anticipation even higher for the arrival on the island.

Subconsciously, he sensed his friends were both asleep now. He fell asleep not too soon after letting his thoughts rest.

Chapter 9: The Light of the City

When the boat arrived at the island, Avery Obtainia was still fast asleep. He was not present at early dawn when the crew all gathered to see the sight of the island as it appeared after passing through a thick gust of mist.

Waking up from the commotion of bells, Avery sat up and rubbed his eyes. Having no knowledge of the outside since the room contained no window, Avery quickly lept off the upper bed and examined the room. His excitement was overruling his droopy eyes and groggy head yet his body moved sluggishly with half-brain power.

River and Ted were both absent from their bed, leaving no trace of their belongings. The excitement of the morning also drove all the (usually) lazy crew members from their beds and onto the upper deck.

Feeling no rumbling beneath him, Avery suspected the ship should've arrived at its destination.

Avery fumbled through the halls and looked for any direction that indicated a path upwards onto the main deck. It was far more difficult to reverse replicate the path Mr. Locks guided him through during an early morning.

Climbing a flight of stairs onto the main deck, Avery witnessed the scene of crew members hard at work moving the cargo crates off the ship via the crane. Severa of them strapped thick metal wires onto the crrates for the crane to lift and place onto a nearby harbor. Again, despite their usually lazy nature, their desire to finish the job early came with going to the island as they pleased sooner.

Bright rays of sunshine almost blinded Avery's perception of the true spectacle yet to be visualized. It was a clear day with a deep blue sky that stretched like a dome. A few specks of white clouds circled ruthlessly around the sun.

Finding Ted and River, fully equipped with their luggage, both examining the new destination, Avery approached them. He glanced at what they had their eyes fixed upon.

The ship itself was one of a few dozen lined vessels of various sizes either entering or exiting the grand port. Unlike the features of humble wood of the harbor from whence the incident occured, this port was modern, populated, and illustrious. Several repair shops, rentals, and hotels lined the length of the harbor.

“So this is the island,” Avery exclaimed, looking from edge to edge of the land that stretched almost an eye’s view.

Though a city was up the hill from the harbor, the main spectacle was the large volcanic-like mountain at the center of the island. A beach skirted the perimenter of the island where no human constructivism was established.

Thick coats of trees covered the island, shading whatever civilization inhabited the various regions of the island.

Glancing behind him, instead of seeing what one might expect of an endless sea, Avery was shocked by the presence of a thick coat of gray mist that encircled a portion of the ocean and the entire island.

Though only part of the island and the mist were percivable at his current position, Avery knew that the mist enveloped the entire island.

Mr. Locks came from the shadows and placed his hand firmly on Avery and Ted’s shoulder.

“Now let’s get you to the academy.”

Indicating to follow, Mr. Locks strided down the gangway onto the rough silver concrete harbor.

“I haven’t even got the chance to let it soak in!” Ted complained as he dragged his feet unwillingly.

Avery felt the same but was too lazy to support the notion.

But Ted’s attention was instantly caught by the nearby shops that lined a major road perpendicular to the harbor dividing it in half.

What was intriguing about the shops were the futuristic glowing signs and architecture, almost like walking down the main street of Tokyo city.

“Whoa, check out those cool looking clothes. And… and look at that delicious spaghetti bowl! Look, there’s IT-Phones here too!” he exclaimed, almost too excited to keep up with Mr. Locks’ quick pace.

A large number of civilians gathered at the shops specifically near the harbor as they were the most prominent before departure or arrival, such as fast food, souvenirs, or necessities.

Not only civilians but Mystical Beasts as well, from a range of small rodents to large mounts.

From what Avery and Ted could tell, they were some sort of partner creatures to several of the citizens strolling about. They were not too surprised considering the extent of the Mystical they dwelled in.

Covering most of her head, River clutched onto her hood more tightly as to keep her presence hidden from the people surrounding her.

Though she had no problems interacting, she still seemed quite weary in the presence of lots of humans.

Though the buildings around him seemed eye-catching, Avery was still captivated by the mist surrounding the entire region.

"By the way, what is that mist… barrier?" Avery asked, pointing behind him.

He followed closely behind Mr. Locks, being careful not to run into him. Mr. Locks had been striding briskly and stopping would've caused an unfortunate negative impression to the general public around them.

Giving a slight glance but nevertheless unfazed by it, Mr. Locks replied, "That's the amazing mist barrier created by the Sutination Orb. The mist will make any non-Mystical Being travelers phase through the island and onto the other side of the mist. That ensures that the island remains hidden, even with the increasing expeditions of non-Mystical humans."

Given the sheer amount of information at once, Avery was just barely able to process the entire dialogue.

"I see," Avery remarked, "So, where exactly is this island then, you know, on the world map?"

"I suppose you weren't up when all the snow passed through, hehe. This island is approximately between Greenland and Iceland."

"In the Arctic?" Avery exclaimed.

"The Sustination Orb's properties allow the temperatures inside to be regulated. Thus, you can think of this as a massive greenhouse. As an additive, it draws on the sun's light to fully functionize the barrier."

"Yeah, you wouldn't imagine the amount of frost and snow that we passed before coming to the massive mist wall. Going through the mist, the entire vision distance decreased significantly, but that changed when we came out of the mist to experience the full powers of a bright summer sun!" Ted piped in.

“I guess things only get weirder from here on out, right?” Avery inquired.

“Nah, it’s all science.”

The crowds began decreasing as the trio and Mr. Locks continued towards the end of the main road. Shops on either side each seemed to attract a fair number of pedestrians as if proper allocation was a neutral born talent. There were, however, still a good number of families with kids that used the main road for pleasures and exciting races.

It all seemed firmly put together as an ideal society, but it was too soon for Avery to suspect only the good; afterall, he still hadn’t learned the judicial system.

The trio and Mr. Locks passed a marble fountain midway from the length of the road where several families gathered for photo shots and picnics.

Mr. Locks guided the trio to the end of the major road to a large parking lot that stretched almost the length of the harbor. Several normal-looking cars lined various lanes of the parking lot.

“Wow, uhhh, this is interesting,” Ted stated sarcastically.

“Yeah,” Avery agreed, gazing at the normal-looking parking lot with more similarities to ones in New York for the most prominent companies and institutes.

Taking a hint from the running gag, Mr. Locks stated, “You’ve yet to see what else is in store.”

The trio blinked their eyes in confusion.

“T-There’s m-more?” River spoke for the first time. She kept her head down the entire time.

“The school isn’t a direct route from here. We will have to pass through the most prominent city on this whole island. But first, a few important individuals will meet up and explain the main school transition process,” Mr. Locks said.

Making a diagonal cut through the parking lot, Mr. Locks ushered the trio to a particular car where the trio would meet the next faculty members of the school. It wasn’t anything extraordinary. Just a normal everyday car.

“Here they are,” Mr. Locks announced as they arrived at a black sedan.

The front doors on either side opened to reveal two figures exiting the mobile. One was an older gentleman with short white hair, a short-cut beard, and gentle yellow eyes. He wore glasses, a full gray suit, and a glistering silver watch. The other was a young

woman with black hair and purple eyes. She wore a simple black knee-length dress with a noticable silver belt strapped around her weist.

Both figures towered above Teddric Tech who naturally stood tall. Mr. Locks were only slightl shorter than the woman herself.

“Ah, they are here,” the man stated, pleased to encounter the trio at last. “My name is Professor Taskah. I am also the principal of Regnum Academy, but feel free to just address me as a professor.”

“Nice to meet you,” the trio said at once, each shaking his hand.

“I’m Charlotte Levy, a graduate from Regnum Academy and a leader of a cohort of the school’s welfare program,” the woman then introduced, rather coldly.

“Don’t mind her, she’s strict to maintain the stability of the school,” the principal addressed.

The trio then shook her hands. Something was amiss about her, but it was too difficult to describe in words.

Avery was quite relieved that the people encountered on the island were not much different from those at New York, for the most part.

“Please enter the vehicle and we will take you straight to the academy,” Professor Taskah formally said.

Then, turning to head back to the harbor, Mr. Locks waved a farwell. “See you guys, I’ll most likely see you later.”

Standing there alone with the two new strangers, the trio were unsure what else to do. They did as the principal instructed and entered the backseat of the vehicle.

Being in the driver seat, Charlotte Levy took charge of the vehicle and started the sedan.

Stirring out of the busy parking lot, the car sped across a double-lane road that curved up a steep hill towards a major city.

“Since it's your first time on the island, I suggest you take a good look at the civilization here on the island. The lifestyle and certain public policies are quite different from what you’ve experienced on the mainland,” Professor Taskah said.

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After a few minutes of passage through a thick forest, the car arrived at the border of the city. A large three-story tall white wall surrounded the perimeter of the city as far as the eye could see.

A bluish silver shimmering dome radiated above the wall and stretched as far as the eye could see across the inner city. Perhaps it was some sort of illusion magic, but Avery and the others didn't question it.

The car entered a short security line conducted by various expert guards. Hidden security cameras monitored the line for any suspicious activities.

Light blue holographic barriers at each entrance ensured no one passed without approval.

Handing an ID into the security booth, the guard briefly scanned the card and examined the contents on file via a computer.

Indicating an approval by handing back the ID, the car continued past the wall when the hologram barrier was lifted.

Inside the wall, the sight of the city far surpassed the expectations the trio had before they arrived. At first, the sight seemed normal as a typical city would appear, but then the dazzling neon lights of the towering buildings overshadowed the outer city district.

Several skyscrapers loomed near the heart of the city. A circular light blue holographic dome generated by the surrounding walls covered the entire ciy. Almost giving New York City vibes, this city was not as large, however, far more vibrant, even more so than the Times Square of New York City.

The black sedan softly became one of numerous vehicles converging onto a multi-lane main road that shot straight through the middle of the city.

"Welcome to the city," Professor Taskah stated.

Gasping at the sight of high-tech skyscrapers, the trio couldn't resist peering at the sights closely to the car windows.

After passing several buildings of various sizes, the car arrived at the edge of a large central field surrounded by prominent buildings. Scaling over several hundred meters in length and width, the field was the largest flat open area the trio had ever seen.

An IT Tower comparable to the one in New York City loomed at the end of the large thinly cut grassy field.

On a small hill guided by dozens of steps rested a large Greek-styled parthenon which was the city's town hall. This structure rested at the pinnacle of the field opposite to the IT Tower.

The entire area around the field became a popular tourist and pedestrian hot spot as several students, families, and individuals would roam about. Several small, but intriguing-looking, stores loomed in the shadows of the major buildings at each point of the field.

The surrounding skyscrapers enclosed the center as if the entire city was an unofficial stadium where the field acted as the playing ground where all cameras would be targetted.

"This city is much different in the evenings, thus, given the name, Lux Urbis – the Light of the City," Professor Taskah explained as they veered on a road surrounding the field.

"This is really something!" Ted exclaimed, both palms on the windows and gasping particularly at the grand IT Tower.

"So why is it called Lux Urbis?" Avery asked.

"It's mainly called that because it is the first city established on this island, Taskah described, "Also, this city became known as the brightest light in the darkness since the lights of the buildings never dim, even at midnight."

"Wow, I did not expect to see something like this!" Avery stated, thinking of his idea of the Mystical Beings' lifestyle which was far more primitive.

"It's definitely one of the major sights to see. Normally, other Mystical Beings from other regions only visit this city as short-term tourists or international affairs specialists, but you three get to stay at the coveted academy."

"I-it's famous? I-I've never heard of it before," Ted stated.

"I-It's fairly famous… I believe," River spoke shyly.

"It is a renowned city for sure. You may have heard of it referred to as District 7 since it is the seventh official Mystical Being inhabited location according to the current union of the Mystical Council on the island," Professor Taskah said.

"I see," Ted replied, now thinking back at the familiarity of the District 7 title.

"Where is this academy?" Avery asked, glancing at the buildings around the field.

"We're just about to approach it very soon," Prof. Taskah assured.

Driving until arriving at one side of the field, the car stopped in front of a large gate and wall that enclosed a private institute.

Parking temporarily in front of the enormous gates, they were indicated to step out by Charlotte Levy. As if on cue, the gates magically opened, revealing a lush, beautiful garden leading to a castle-sized red-brick building.

Promptly ensuring all luggage was removed, Charlotte Levy continued driving the car past the gates to a nearby parking garage. Avery, River, and Ted were now alone with Professor Taskah.

Turning to face the trio, Professor Taskah announced, “Welcome to Regnum Academy. Your new life begins here, if you can survive, that is.”

Though the statement wasn't ensuring, the trio weren’t fazed at all. They only felt anticipation of what was about to start.

Guiding them up to the entrance leading into the brick building, Prof. Taskah pushed the doors open and led the trio inside.

A grand circular booth awaited them in the center of the room. Numerous faculty were busy at work on their individual desks around the booth. A light gray polished floor reflected the light of the windows and the gold and silver lines of the dark wooden ceiling and walls. Several bright suits of armor of knights and Roman soldiers lined around the room.

Two subsequent halls leading to the wings of the building were located on either side of the center room. A few faculty members bounced briskly to and fro of the main center booth and the connecting offices lining the halls.

“Since school started several weeks ago, you won’t see that many actively roaming students till later today. Rest assured, everything will be properly set for you guys to properly begin your academy life,” Prof. Taskah elaborated.

Then, walking ahead towards the center booth, he began small-talking with a faculty member.

“The new transfer students are here,” Prof. Taskah said to the faculty member while handing his ID card.

“Hi there Principal Taskah. I see that you’ve returned. Everything’s been set as you said,” the desk faculty member informed.

The desk faculty member was a tall black haired woman who wore an eccentric attire. Her expressions from a distance gave the impression of a slightly too optimistic individual.

"Good, I take it you'll handle things from here." Then turning to the trio, he said, "I'll be off now. Some important duties must be done."

"Thank you very much, uh, Principal Taskah," Avery expressed.

"No need for the formalities, I will never get used to it. Call me professor, or whatever."

"If you're sure, then, alright. But again thank you!"

Turning and striding off, this was the last time the trio would see Professor Taskah for a while.

Catching the attention of the trio, the desk faculty member greeted, "Hello there! Welcome to Regnum Academy. I believe this is also your first time in the city, so welcome to Lux Urbis, the light of the city. You just happen to come on an excellent day. Tonight the school is celebrating the founding of the city with fireworks and a party, so be sure to attend. I'm sure you'll fit right in."

"Thank you, ma'am. That's… interesting," Ted said.

Avery and River nodded.

The faculty member then continued, "I forgot to introduce myself. I'm Sakura Yamaguchi. How about you guys?"

"I'm Teddric Tech," Ted introduced quickly, gesturing one of his specialty moves. Avery and River couldn't tell if he was hitting on her.

"I'm Avery Obtainia," Avery introduced next, giving a slight wave.

"I-I'm River Grant," River said at last, keeping her head half-bend down.

"Nice to meet you! I was informed of your predicament so it was great to finally see you all! Typically, this school does not get that many transfers, but strange events do happen sometimes, am I right? Anyway, I'm almost done calibrating your ID cards."

Somehow Sakura Yamaguchi maintained her bubbly atmosphere and eye contact with the trio as she kept up with her prior engagements. Glancing and moving her arms at tremendous speed, she was able to make her job seem effortless.

With a few clicks on a small desk printer, three ID cards were spit out and caught into her hands. Examining each card closely, she nodded when she found no errors present.

“Here are your ID cards,” Sakura said as she handed each of the trio their respective ID cards. “Now, be sure not to lose them. The school has an expensive charge on replacements.”

“How much?” Ted asked curiously. He was the only one out of the three who seemed overly interested in small details such as this.

“Hmm… about fifty or so bronze bits.” No idea how much that was, Ted and Avery thought it was expensive. They would learn about the money system later… and the hard truth of mainland paper money not being transferable.

Avery examined the contents on his card. On the front, there displayed a headshot photo of himself on the far left. A large lettering of his name was displayed on the top. Several more info were directly below the name.

Avery Obtainia

Age: 15 yrs

School: Regnum Academy, OSNYC (formerly)

Grade: 9th

Species: Angelor

Strength: Above Average

Magic Power: Below Average

Rank: *Commonus*

“This is pretty neat,” Ted noted, holding his card high in honor.

“The information on the card will regularly update depending on yourr actual stats, so be sure to check it regularly to ensure you’re keeping up with what you are assigned with,” Sakura explained.

“So that’s why my magic went up since the last time I knew about it,” Avery said, realizing his magic power had changed.

Ted examined his card and also saw additional changes. The trio each showed their card because… why not.

Teddric Tech

Age: 15 yrs

School: Regnum Academy, OSNYC (formerly)

Grade: 9th

Species: Metalor

Strength: Slightly-Above Average

Magic Power: Above Average

Rank: *Bonus*, **Level**: 3

River Grant

Age: 15 yrs

School: Regnum Academy, OSNYC (formerly)

Grade: 9th

Species: Naiad

Strength: Average

Magic Power: Above Average

Rank: *Altus*, **Level** 1

"Your magic power is pretty high, River. In fact, the highest of us all," Avery pointed out.

"Oh well, it's just how it is," River said shyly, not comfortable with the attention, especially being outstanding.

"Huh, mine went up a little bit since the last time I had mine checked," Ted exclaimed, waving his card in the air.

"By only a little bit," Avery corrected.

"Oh come on! I exercised and stuff. It's because I was a little bit lazier last week. That's all. If I had known you'd be fighting some cult or something I'd probably have joined," Ted said, clearly upping his morale.

Avery laughed while River gave a slight smirk.

"So, how does it go up and what is the purpose of it?" Avery asked, turning his attention to Sakura who looked pleased with herself.

"It's for school purposes usually, but it's also an assured way to track your personal growth," Sakura explained, snapping out of her glee. "The cards are each installed with the latest micro IT chips that have pulse and magic power sensors specifically designed to analyze and display the holder's muscle strength and magic flowing through their body. Note these are only numbers and do not represent skill or privilege whatsoever."

"I see," Avery remarked. *Just how much does IT as a whole influence the Mystical Being society*?

"Now, on the back of your cards are information about the room number and classes that each of you will be in," Sakura stated. "All freshmen have the same starting classes, so you all don't need to worry on your first day. Simply follow any students who look like they know their way. The class times and schedule will update occasionally depending on the situation, so also be sure to check that often."

Glancing on the backside, Avery noticed the list of classes were already filled and predetermined. Some crucial info about the dorm and room number were also displayed. Finding the information unimportant at the moment, he slipped the card into his pants pockets.

"Well, that's all the service I can do for you at the moment. Feel free to ask me any questions about logistics, but other than that, just go ahead and explore the campus. Everything that you are allowed to explore are within the campus walls, but areas restricted will otherwise be marked. Have fun!"

Sakura then instructed the trio to head down the right hall. "You'll see your specific dorm in that direction, if you want to drop off your belongings."

The trio nodded and then went on their way.

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Feeling a little nervous walking alone on the campus grounds, Avery almost suspected themselves as trespassers. The trio continued down the hall which then curved left for about half a head's turn before leading straight down to a pair of exit doors.

“This is the right way, right?” Avery asked for some sort of confirmation, desiring not to be the single one potentially in the wrong. He also felt a bit itchy being the single one leading the other two who were trailing purposely behind.

“I dunno. What’s the worst that could happen?” Ted hinted, casually shoving the choices onto Avery. For someone who was so dedicated and quirky, one position he would fail greatly in was leadership.

“Forget I asked, I guess. Let’s just see what’s on the other side of these exit doors. You guys can’t blame me if we got lost or anything.”

“I trust your judgment,” River responded to the situation.

Avery turned slightly red and lost focus for a mere second that the others were slow to catch. “Maybe not too much…”

Pushing a pair of the exit doors open, bright golden rays of the sun blinded the trio as they stepped out into the open again.

The sight they experienced was even prettier than the drive through the city. A large campus of various sized buildings surrounded an enormous lake about half a mile wide.

A small island could be located near the center of the island.

Distant walls of the same texture of the front entrance enclosed the campus space. Several smaller skyscrapers dotted the sky behind the walls completely surrounding the academy.

Numerous brick sidewalks and paths blended into the rich grassy pastures. Trees of varying sizes, from seven-feet to almost century-old sized, enveloped the atmosphere of the futuristic city and seemed to alter time back a few hundred years.

“The big field before was cool and all, but this… is so much prettier,” Ted exclaimed.

“Y-yes,” River agreed. She forgot to cover her face as she looked up into the sky and around the sight of the campus.

“For sure. This is just so beautiful,” Avery added, agreeing also.

Then pointing to a building complex that dripped with dorm vibes, Avery indicated for Ted and River to follow.

“Over there are the dorms, I believe. We can go from there and circle-counterclockwise around the lake which should introduce us to all the main facilities that we need to know.”

“What about the dining hall?” Ted asked.

"We'll check it out later. Now we should just drop our stuff off."

"Sounds good. I'd love to drop down this heavy backpack," Ted agreed, bending backwards to almost drop from the weight of the backpack.

"Same. It's fine with me," River said.

They then proceeded by following the brick path down towards the cluster of buildings on the far right of the lake. Not a single student was in sight, but that only made the encounter with them later even more nerve wrecking.

Avery rubbed his fingers along the soft surface of some birch trees along the path. Numerous more regular oak trees covered the bright sun with their overarching branches.

After walking for a few minutes, the trio exited the cluster of trees and stood before the entrance to the dorms. Unlike typical mainland universities or any institution with residential life, it was a known fact for dorms to be scattered throughout the entire campus, however, this particular dorm noted itself instantly as the single dorm on campus.

Towering a good four stories, the front of the dorm building seemed smaller when compared to its sides. Several older trees just barely surpassed the height of such a building.

Analyzing the sign on the left side of a flower bed beside the double glass sliding doors, Ted remarked, "It must be interesting to have a single dorm unit with numerous quads."

"I wonder what those are?" Avery stated.

"We should head in and drop our stuff off quickly," Ted suggested, now in a rush. "I want to go to the dining hall."

The doors slid open upon their close proximity. Upon stepping in, the trio were immersed in a… simple hotel-style lobby, nothing more nothing less. It was almost underwhelming, to say the least. Of course, the main academic and faculty facilities were obligated to get the most prominent attention.

Unlike a typical hotel setting, there was no head desk person to greet them in. Instead, the trio stood before a vacant deputy office booth.

Not wanting to stand around like idiots, Avery re-examined his card for his room number.

“Best to find our rooms, I guess, “ Avery stated, then began reading the backside of his card, “Dorm: Caesar, Quad: 44, Room: 1.”

“Mine says, ‘Dorm: Caesar, Quad: 44, Room: 3,’” Ted read next.

“Mine is, ‘Dorm: Caesar, Quad: 44, Room: 2,’” River read last.

“That’s convenient. We’re in the same quad or whatever. But the question is how to find it,” Avery explained.

Looking around the boring room, Ted was the first to spot a directory at the end of a hall. He seemed to have a knack for that sort of thing at this point now.

Rushing over and checking the diagram of the entire unit, the trio realized the Caesar dorm section was at the far back of the building.

“Uhh, how many halls are that?” Avery said, jaw dropped.

Ted began counting. “Let’s see… one, two, three…, seven…, nine. Oh wow, looks like fourteen.”

“T-they d-didn’t even make a linear route?” River questioned, squiggling her fingers along a path on the map.

“Based on the layout, it looks as if they continued expanding the original building when new dorms were created. You can tell by the continuous halls that pretty much wrap the entire building in a spiral,” Ted explained, dragging his fingers around the diagram and plotting the route to the Caesar dorm.

“That makes sense…” Avery meditated.

“It was super cost effective too. It seems as if they didn’t even have to close off the original dorm as they constructed each side one at a time,” Ted continued analysing.

“You’re quite skilled at this,” River remarked, seeing nothing that indicated those details.

Facing River to show off his cool pose, Ted announced, “Why of course! This is easy compared to circuit diagrams.”

“I don’t think those things are related,” Avery pointed out.

“Of course not, hehe.”

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Truly navigating the halls within the dorm building itself would've counted towards the best (or worst) escape room… that is if posters of maps were all removed.

The trio arrived in the Caesar dorm section of the building and quickly found their dorm on the third level. After some time of confusion, Ted later discovered their particular quad number was on another level.

"Oh I thought that the double numbers indicated the room number of the first floor, since, you know, there's no triple digit," was Ted's sad excuse.

Arriving at the 44th quad door, clearly on the third floor and not abiding by any familiar rules of room numbering on the mainland, Avery turned the door knob only to barely budge it. "It's not opening."

"You have to use the ID card, I'm guessing," Ted said, pointing at the barcode scanner above the doorknob.

"Oh duh," Avvery replied with embarrassment.

Scanning his ID card and then turning the knob, Avery successfully opened the door and gestured for Ted and River to enter.

Upon entry, the trio were greeted by a very hospitable circular common room with four conjoining doors semi-circling around it. A large couch and several smaller sofas circled a single TV on a small wooden shelf.

"It's so simple—," Ted began.

"—Yet so nice," Avery finished.

"Yeah," River added.

Ted rushed into his room, labeled room 3, and darted around to examine everything he could set his eyes upon.

"Check it out! We get our own bathrooms!" he exclaimed as he walked back to the others. "This is luxury!"

Not doubting Ted or anything, Avery and River made up their mind to check the site for themselves.

Upon entering his room, Avery was shocked to see a large luxury-class sized bed, a desk, a closet, and a dresser.

With the obscurity of finding the room amidst the surrounding dorms, Avery was surprised to see a large window at the farside of his room. It was slanted up sideways as if aligned for the night sky to droop in with the bed right underneath.

Being on the third and final floor and all, it only made sense they received the best view.

Any size room would have suited if he was to live alone… why, he was even content sharing with Ted or something similar.

The generosity of the school was top notch, regardless of the initial impressions.

He was excited to sleep in his own room for the first time in a while (not that sleeping with Ted was the worst thing ever, but was totally a plus to not have to).

The three met up again in the common room to recite their excitement. Ted lunged backwards into one of the small sofas and emitted an obnoxiously annoying gleam.

"I'm not disappointed anymore! The maze-like halls were totally worth it!" he announced. "The best part… it's free!"

Avery's eyes widened when he came to the realization that everything from arriving on the island up to this point was of no charge to him and his friends.

"You make an excellent point… which gets me to wonder just how long this'll last," Avery admitted, letting down the mood.

"Don't get so gloomy! That's future us's problems," Ted neglected without a doubt.

"Yeah, but still… I'm curious if they have a bill or something they are holding until we are well established before shoving it into our faces."

"Yeah, I'll just forget that I even came here by then. Maybe they'll let that all slide," Ted explained.

"I guess you're entitled," Avery confronted. Then, turning to River, he asked, "So, what do you think about this dorm?"

"It's ok, so long as I get my personal room," she replied.

Avery nodded in agreement. Though both possessed a similar satisfaction to the current living space, each of their reasoning behind it was different. For Avery, he was simply content with space and freedom. For Rver, however, she sought refuge from the citizens on the island, a strange action that would only be explained in due time.

After galloping around in excitement for a short time, the trio found themselves bored with nothing to do. It was clear their options were broad, but it also seemed unreasonable for them to make sudden choices as if they had a right in the academy.

Putting on a jacket and headset, Ted scooted a table over to his sofa and began tinkering with what few mechanical components he had on him.

Finding a book, River sat in a quiet corner and read intently.

Avery simply paced about the room as he thought meticulously about courses of action, tactics, and piecing together unrelated topics.

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A school bell rang a familiar sounding sequence of chimes throughout the campus, indicating the end of classes for the day. Not a moment too soon, the door to Quad 44 opened and a natured girl walked gracefully into the room.

Hearing the rustling of noise, the door slam, and the thump of the girl's shoes on the carpet, Avery, River, and Ted glanced from their activities at the girl.

Combining her long black hair with her hands, the girl streighted and waved with a fluttering gesture.

"Hi," she greeted with an outgoing tone, "You three must be the new students that were said to move into this dorm. My name is Jane Tee and I'm a freshman here. I've been here long enough that I'm confident enough to answer any questions you may have."

The girl, named Jane Tee, quickly approached the trio to examine them. "Just don't ask too hard questions, teheh," she said with a complacent giggle.

Ted stood up and pushed his headphones onto his neck. He approached Jane and gave an unnecessarily lengthy wave.

"Hey-yo, my name's Ted. Nice that we're roommates, right? I'll be sure to ask you lots of easy questions!"

Ignoring Ted's introduction, Jane skipped over to River who was only observing the scene from a distance at her same location.

"Ah, you must be a new girl here! You're so cute and adorable! Let's be friends!" Jane squealed, totally diminishing her friendly vibe and donning a girly personality.

River didn't know how to respond. She barely escaped the bear hug that Jane initiated. Clutching tightly on her hood with both hands, she also wasn't confident to display her demihuman features quite yet.

"Aww, come on. No hugs?"

Trembling with shyness, River responded quickly, "I-It's not that I-I don't won't one, b-but maybe n-not now." The awkward greeting got her really flustered.

"So, what's your name?" Jane inquired. Having been turned down, she quickly hoped a name would satisfy herself for the time being.

"M-my name is River Grant," River answered, now having more confidence. Each and every new person was steadily easing her usual timidity, ever so slightly though.

"Aww, that's so cute! I totally like that!"

Avery kept his distance and finished analysing Jane's behavior and personality to conclude she was quirky and amusing.

Jane, picking up on the eyes, turned and examined Avery up and down. "So, I'm guessing you're River's friend." Walking closer to Avery, she continued, "You're an interesting fella, I'm suspecting you're interesting."

"Is that so?" Avery blurted dumbly. He had no experience in awkward situations, but he remained constant, carefully not to stagger.

"You've got nice pink eyes, those are rare among Mystical Beings," Jane complimented.

Avery's face flushed just barely. "Uh, thank you. I'm Avery Obtainia."

"Obtainia, huh. Interesting indeed."

Jane was the second person who seemed perplexed by his last name. Avery began to suspect there was more history he was yet to learn.

Jane finally turned to Ted and gave the respect he deserved. But before Ted could reintroduce himself, Jane spoke, "Hi, I've heard your name. You're Ted."

Jane remained indifferent when glancing between Ted's mechanical work and himself. "So, you're a mechanic."

Though Ted was offended by the definition, he smirked and replied, "Yeah, I'm sort of a part-time mechanic. My main hobby is inventing new technology." A simp really does go far from rational behaviors, huh.

"Ah I see. That's cool!" Jane responded. She had never dipped her hands into the tech world so she was careful not to ask any leading questions.

"This is a fun little group, I'd say," Avery stated, eyeing each member around the room.

"I suppose it is. I didn't think you guys would be like this, heehee. I was thinking like… mean gruff looking guys or rich snobs, but I'm glad I wasn't disappointed," Jane Tee expressed competently.

"If that's what you first imagined, what is the school vibe?" Avery asked.

Tapping her fingers in thought, Jane responded, "The school doesn't have a vibe per se. It's very competitive, academic driven, and strength concentrated. So I suppose a few transfer students would be very unaverage since the admission rates for transferring into this academy is a lot lower."

"I'm glad you initially thought of me that way," Ted gloated.

"I don't think she addressed you specifically," Avery corrected.

"Aw, come on man, what'd you have to spoil the moment," Ted sighed.

Jane smirked. "You are kind of funny, Ted, you know."

"You think I'm funny? Noice! Maybe I can tell you a joke or something. Anything, just request it."

"I only said you were kind of funny," Jane repeated.

"That's too bad. I was really hoping to be assured by someone else that I'm funny. Oh well, back to the chopping block," Ted said solemnly.

Glancing at the wall next to the window, Ted lit up with a new sudden thought. "Say, what sort of activities are here at this school?"

Jane contemplated for a bit before responding, "You'll find out soon enough."

"You can't just leave us in suspense," Ted protested.

"I can do whatever," Jane stated, staccato poking the air with her pointer finger.

Ted folded his hands to indicate his disagreement, but he returned to his little gizmo project shortly after.

Avery thought the pair were intriguing enough. Perhaps something would blossom between the two unlikely as a duo.

"Anyway, River, you should speak a bit more. Don't let other people hog the conversations," Jane scolded lightly, shifting her attention.

"You sure?" River replied.

"Also, you should remove that hood of yours. I know perhaps you don't want to and I've been considerate, but really… you should show your face."

"Well, uh… I have my reasons."

"Oh well, whatever. I can't force you to do anything, but that's what friends are for, am I right? Maybe I'll see your full face and its supreme cutness later when we've gotten a lot closer, hehe," Jane teased.

"Anyway…" Jane added, "we should totally go to the Light Celebration tonight?"

"What's the Light Celebration?" Avery asked. Then, remembering what the faculty lady Sakura had briefly suggested, Avery had\ a possible answer. "Is it the founding of this city celebration?"

"Correct! When I was younger, it was always a grand event. Lots of free food, booths with fun activities, and a city wide firework show! This year, Regnum Academy will be hosting the school grounds celebration."

"Sounds cool! If there's free food, you know I'm there!" Ted exclaimed, pumped up.

"But in the meantime, I can show you guys around! I especially want you to know everything, River!" Jane said.

"Uh, sure," River nodded.

"Sounds good to me. I was thinking of continuing touring around, but I sort of forgot about it," Avery expressed.

"Yeah, I suppose we kind of got side tracked with the quality of the room when we did say we were just going to drop stuff off," Ted added.

"Well, no more delays. I'm taking some of my precious time to show you all around, so let's get going! Lot's to see!" Jane roused.

The trio followed Jane who efficiently exited the windy halled dorm building. The sun was just about to set, indicating the end of the day was drawing near.

Jane casually pointed at each building and explained some history as they all slowly circled the lake. The number of students bustling about drastically increased, however, most of them paid no attention to the trio.

Several of the prominent academic facilities were wedged between the buildings showing off grandeur. A large sports arena and recreation center was across the lake opposite of the academy welcome facility. Opposite from the dorms was the single cafeteria or food court of the institute.

After the tour and a while of patience, the real excitement was just about to begin.

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Pushing through the crowds of students, parents, and young children gathered in the stadium of the academy's arena, Avery just barely kept up with Jane, Ted, and River as they transverse to one of the few vacant seats in the entire arena.

The arena was large, but not super impressive. The center field was the size of a football field and a stadium structure was constructed around it. Trees obscured the arean as it was hard to catch at first glance when arriving.

"What is the deal with all these people?" Ted shouted over the roar of the crowd as he staggered through paying attention to his balance. He held onto his headphones to ensure it would not suddenly disappear. He hadn't come to the realization that most of them were here before the trio arrived at the school.

"Well, students aren't the only one's allowed to enter the academy sometimes! This is a prominent event, so essentially, the school gets lots of funds when they host public events," Jane explained, focused on her destination.

Arriving at their quieter location with much difficulty, the four seated themselves and watched as the crowds cheered when the center arena field lit up with neon lights and enveloped with thick fog.

Unlike a typical school-hosted event, Jane explained to the trio that this particular celebration was heavily budgeted so no majorily wild stuff would occur. It was more of a commemoration.

Not a moment later, the celebration remarks began.

An older graduate student guy stepped out of the mist and greeted the crowds.

"Welcome, welcome, nice to see you all tonight. I'm sure you've all adjusted finely to the academy. Tonight is a celebration of this city, Lux Urbis!"

Most of the crowd cheered, but it was obvious some were indifferent.

"Now, now," the speaker continued, "I'm sure most of you don't want to be here, afterall, you were required to attend this event, hehe. But don't worry! Free food right after! Anyway, the purpose of this event tonight is not only to commemorate this city, but to also hear from some important folks about the impacts they've had on the city over their career!"

Now at the edge of their seats, the crowds seemed more anticipated.

“Welcome our first guest, the royal prodigy Atlas Aquia! He is the cohort ceturnion of the Tempest Aquia of Regnum Academy! Let’s hear a few words from him!”

The main speaker stepped aside as another figure transcended out of the mist and onto the center stage. From a distance, he was regal and yet intimidating at the same time. Wearing a noble’s uniform and his long silver hair flowing behind him, he stared intently into the crowd.

“I am Atlas Aquia,” he spoke, calm and collected, “It is a pleasure to speak on behalf of the academy tonight on behalf of the legacy of this splendid city.

“I am the first son of Atalantia Aquia, Queen of the Atalantia Kingdom, District 5. I am honored to have served this city and this academy for quite some time now. I recently graduated from this very prestigious academy and have become a cohort centurion to further train my skills and instruct the best of the best.”

The crowd was automatically magnetized to Atlas’s introduction. Avery and Ted were especially intrigued by his advanced progress at such a young age – he was basically the age of a normal college student.

“This city is called the ‘Light of the Ctiy’ which represents the first leader who gathered the Mystical Beings to this island and ensured their safety to cultivate a new society away from the mainland. This city is the hope, the beacon, and the path to future developments and significant breakthroughs.

“This city contributed safety and ambition in my life, thus, I give my abilities back to secure new generations of splendid custodians and innovative experts. I strive for the protection of this city to the upper limit. This specific academy gruonds is the ideal of the first Mystical Beings on this island and their desire to create a society where magic is imminent.

“My lesson for you students here both new and returning: know your place in society. You all were admitted because of your brilliant mindsets and talented skills. Use that to pursuevere. The academy won’t make it easy for you, neither will the real world. Thus, in order to make this city yours, you must expect the worst outcome possible and be prepared.

“I expect only the best students will possibly join my cohort, the Tempest Aquia.”

A strange silver light emitted from Atlas’ back just as a shining white falcon soured into the sky. It lunged into an arc and spread silver sparkling water like a firework. Then it disappeared into a mist of silver light once again.

Then, with an alarming exit, Atlas disappeared into the fog, his bird partner being the exiting applause.

Naturally, the crowds cheered their hardest.

Only the most talented were able to move the hearts of the many, and Atlas Aquia was a unique individual who possessed such an ability.

Stepping back into view, the main speaker welcomed the next guest.

It was the woman whom the trio had met earlier, Charlotte Levy.

"It's a pleasure," she began, catching more attention and clapping than Altas. "I'm Charlotte Levy, the centurion of the highly prestigious Blue Legion cohort.

Charlotte pounced forward, bursting with sparks of purple flame, further exciting the crowds at a small taste of her innate powers.

"This city was built on power. And only thought that… will we surpass the past generations and become greater! This city was the pinale of inspiration. Though technology has risen and prosperity is flourishing, I believe that society has been slaking. Through my cohort, I only take in the aspiring and the ambitions.

"So, if you want to make real change instead of doddling on your phones and playing house, I suggest you at least try a bit harder."

A circular portal of dark purple mist appeared beside her as a black lion leapted out. The beast circuled its summoner, being Charlotte herself, and then disappeared into the same magical portal.

And with that short speech and presentation, she marched out of the arena, taking the breath of the crowds along with her.

"What was that?" Avery whispered, leaning toward the rest of the group.

"The Mystical Beasts the presenters summoned are their familiars. Everyone Tier 3, *Altus* get a familiar through a ritual later in their second years," Jane replied.

"Sounds interesting. I guess I'll learn about that when the time comes."

As soon as the two main speakers concluded, it was all boring from there.

The remaining guests had nothing prepared as miraculous as Atlas or Charlotte's grand speech.

Most of them spoke mostly empty words of praise and approval which only steered the crowds back to their usual habits, thus forgetting the memorable words of the first two speakers.

Of course, Avery lived his life in struggle, so those words of the first speakers only riled him up. Ted, Jane, and River seemed intrigued by the speeches, but nonetheless, they were mostly there to come and go.

The main speaker concluded the end of the guest speakers by suggesting the students to talk and interact with them afterwards. No one took it seriously as the other exciting events that night were far more important.

After the long talks, but before any student became too drowsy, fireworks around the arena launched into the sky and exploded with a surge of energy released into the atmosphere, shuffling the viewers' attention back to reality.

When the fireworks glittered the sky with brilliant colors, the main host speaker waved for the dismissal of the guests. The fog surrounding the arena lifted and numerous food booths lined the perimeter of the inner field.

The crowds forgot about the purpose of the celebration and went ahead to relish themselves in the food and the fun.

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Naturally, when the quad were free to roam about as they felt, Avery held onto numerous new questions that arose during the guest speakers. He was convinced to approach some of the speakers but felt reluctant due to the shoves of the crowds and the staggering line expanding increasingly.

As Jane, Ted, Avery, and River exited the arena after grabbing a few pastries and yakisoba buns, the moon shone brightly above the sky, indicating the day drawing to an end. The quad forgot the long wait time for each boot so they did not expect the setting to change so drastically.

Suddenly, in the midst of darkness after being absorbed in the lights of the arena, the quad felt a bit chilly walking back to their dorm.

"I wonder what we're supposed to do tomorrow," Avery remarked.

“Hmmm… Luckly tomorrow is a day off for students as it's an extension of the city celebration date. But… I suppose you three still need to get your supplies,” Jane stated.

“Supplies? Like what?” Ted asked.

“School supplies,” Jane answered quickly.

“School supplies?” Avery said, perplexed.

“Yeah, you’ll have to go and get them yourselves since you guys were never at school orientation,” Jane explained. “At least you’ll find your uniforms already in your room closet.”

“Uniforms?” Ted exclaimed. “Hmm, I guess I didn’t check inside my closet yet.”

“There was orientation?” River gasped.

“Well, of course schools do, what’d you think?” Jane scoffed.

Avery stood there in shock. He didn’t expect himself to be the one to do such a task.

And so, the real academy experience was just about to begin.

Chapter 10: Shopping for a Culprit

It was a day for shopping. Now that Avery was recently enrolled at Regnum Academy, he, unlike most of the others, needed to buy supplies such as spare clothes (specific academy issued ones) and new books. Hearing this sudden remark yesterday sparked an urgent quest to accomplish this task before school the next day.

Hearing about the true prestige of the academy, he fretted about the possibility of being expelled simply for lacking school materials. Unlike the situation where most students would've already bought and gathered their school boosk and supplies, Avery had to find all his supplies as quickly as possible before he fell even further behind.

Just one problem: Avery had not explored the city before, thus, he was as clueless as one could be in a situation as such.

It was a delightful sunny day on the Mystical Island and Avery had finally survived a night at the dorm room… which was quite nice. A bit too nice in which Avery was almost too lazy to get up.

Not wanting to go into the hassle of requesting aid, Avery decided to form his own expedition. Since the city enveloped the school, it was only a matter of picking the right edge of the school grounds to exit to the nearest convenient book or supply store. To Avery's dismay, no one really indicated which direction would've been the most effective.

Today, Avery set out to explore around Lux Urbis in hopes of finding some sort of store with school supplies. Equipped with his handy backpack and that's it, he decided to score for a random side of the city: the part nearest to the front entrance of the school, since he happened to be most familiar with that area from the short car trip.

Now that Avery was getting accustomed to a very futuristic city, the layout and lights of the city only confused his navigation prowess more. The city became overwhelming now that he was no longer relaxed.

Walking up and down the main street with local stores, Avery found nothing that resembled school supplies. Instead, he kept his eyes peeled for other students who were more aware of their surroundings or eccentric buildings that clearly screamed "school

supplies." Only numerous local resturants and grocery stores seemed to sprout into his view wherever he glanced.

Later searching around a city district with lower technology and wealth as the inner parts, Avery thought he would find cheaper alternatives when his prior exploits seemed futile. He only had a few hundred copper coins on loan from Jane that he thought would be better spent on multiple cheaper things than the expensive high-quality options, but it wasn't like he had much choice at this point.

Unlike the mainland money system, the Mystical Island functioned on the basis of real capital immersed in the economy such as pure silver coins and other authentic gems for higher rarities.

Avery held in his hands the lowest rarity of currency: bronze bits.

A hundred bits equaled a single silver coin, a denarius, the main unit of currency used by the wealthy.

A hundred silver coins can be converted into a higher currency called a tablet. There were three types of tablets: the emerald, ruby, and sapphire. Each of them held their own values and conditions when spent.

A hundred of a single tablet converted into the highest currency type: a diamond core. Only the royals usually had this prestige of a currency.

Nothing could be done to such currency such as theft or conversion since their molecular structure was concealed by a runic spell.

Typically, gold remained as scarce as they came so their abundance in even the Mystical was scarce.

Glancing about the rum of the mill shops and living spaces, a strange, yet almost enlightening, building suddenly caught Avery's attention.

Entering this building, an old bookstore, at a far corner near the city borders and sadly finding no textbooks or relevant supplies, Avery exited disappointedly.

He shortly stumbled upon River who was shyly walking down the street with a hood over her head. *Typical River*, he thought to himself as he rushed towards her. After enough interactions with her, Avery began to understand her shyness more and sympathize for her, though it wasn't as apparent in the dorm room.

Wearing cloaks didn't seem to be far astray from the typical fashion of the town, but it was suspicious, nonetheless. Though, it did bring benefits such as distance and

non-disturbance, something that most individuals distinguish, yet subconsciously, perform to evade such character profiles.

"Hey, where are you headed?" Avery inquired as he walked alongside her. It was pretty easy to catch up since she was walking in a drudging manner.

"Well… I had just come from somewhere. I've not decided where to go," River replied shyly, shivering, and not wanting to think about it.

"Oh? What do you mean?" Avery asked.

"It's… nothing."

"So… I take it you've got your supplies already?"

"Y-yeah… I have my methods."

Avery was intrigued, but he decided it was not wise to aske for a magician's secrets. He also framed himself from asking for help immediately.

River adjusted her hood, ensuring it would not blow off from a mild breeze passing by.

"Why do you hide your cute fox ears in public?" Avery asked, paying close attention to River's gesture.

River blushed when she heard Avery call them cute.

"Ah well… umm, it's because I'm a demihuman. You… probably don't know yet, but on this island, there is a hierarchy system, so of course the weakest and dumbest Mystical Being species are often on the bottom while the rich and nobility are at the top tier. The poor usually are treated poorly and don't get the same representation at local stores, especially in Lux Urbis," she replied quickly, stating the most amont of words in a while.

"Why? I thought that system was gone ages ago. I didn't see that sort of thing probably in New York." A murderous image of Billy Bones popped into Avery's mind. "Well, maybe the exception of a particular person, hehe. Is a demihuman really that bad, for some of the people here?"

"In the Mystical, magic is everything. Species have rankings and the hierarchy is put in place just to ensure the weak stays weak and the strong remains strong," River explained, not bothering to remark about Billy. "Demihumans usually have unrefined magic powers, thus, society here deems it unclean or untamable."

"Well, if that is what it is, screw the system. I'll just figure this out myself," Avery reassured, confident but unwire how dire the situation really was. River was just about to

believe that, seeing that Avery was someone who had defied the typical Mystical ways so far; but deep in her heart she knew that society wasn't going to change and neither her relationship with her family members.

"Don't call yourself dumb, I don't believe that at all," Avery assured.

Blushing, River covered her face with her hands and turned away. Being delighted at the comment, she still brushed it off as to not let Avery get any false ideas.

"So… so what are you doing?" River asked quietly, ready to change the subject once again.

"Uh well, I was trying to find some school supplies, but for the past couple of hours, I've come up with nothing," Avery shrugged. He had transferred from OSNYC, but their resources were much different from the list of items required for Regnum Academy.

"We could go to the mall…" River suggested and then became quiet.

"There's a mall?" Avery exclaimed, "Now that may have something there. I don't know this place very well. Maybe you could help me out?"

"Uh… sure," River replied shyly. "Though I don't think I would be that much of a help, but I'm better with my geography than most."

"You're not implying I'm part of the 'most' group, are you?"

River chose not to reply. Then she admitted, "I just happened to hear about it."

"Huh, is that right? I suppose it's worth a shot. You've already got your supplies, I don't want to hold you up or anything, so if you don't want to come, you don't have to."

"No, it's alright. You've done a lot for me already. I'm happy to help."

"Ah, thank you. Again, I appreciate it."

The mall River mentioned was near the center of town on easy street, so Avery doubted he would get anything useful there, but he thought that he needed a change of pace and scenery.

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Arriving at the spectacle, Avery's eyes burned at the futuristic displays at every angle, the transportation buzzing by, and the fashionable citizens bustling about. His eyes had gotten used to the dumpy side of town, so admiring this was almost unbearable.

Aside from the illustrious IT tower looming bigger than ever, the town hall on the largest hill of the city was unavoidable. Careful not to be crushed by the cars passing on the clearly pathed concrete roads, Avery and River headed in the direction of the mall entrance radiating its neon lights at the right corner of the IT tower property.

"So, it doesn't look that big…" Avery began, eyeing the mall entrance structure and seeking its ridiculously small size.

"Most of it is… underground," River replied as the duo reached the entrance.

Sliding doors weren't the future as this entrance was completely open. The only thing distinguishable to regular non-Mystical human methods were the surveillance cameras at the exterior and ceiling of the entrance in the shape of a long black bar. The citizens were just freely able to pass without an identification.

"Interesting, so the security camera is that long black bar above?" Avery exclaimed, thinking hard about how it would work.

He was starting to get a big brain by overthinking but was diverted by River's attractive attention.

"Yeah, but let's not ponder on that. Let's get through quickly…" River said as she grabbed Avery's hand and rushed across the lobby and down one of the escalators at the end of the mall lobby.

She had suddenly noticed someone familiar, and she did not want to cross paths with them, thus her lead puzzled Avery.

Unlike typical mall entrances which would lead into a large ugly exterior box, this mall was the size of the entrance and the lobby. The rest seemed to concave downwards, shoving the juicy parts below ground to conserve more space.

"So that's how you get down to the ma… – Wait what's going on?"

"No time to explain, just get away from them first," River replied, huffing as they both rushed down the escalator going downwards instead of casually standing still and enjoying the ride.

The room soon then dispersed to feature the entire scale of the mall: a majestic multi-level scenery featuring floors of shops and the pride of IT technological decorations on full display. On the curved roof was the digital display of a myriad of flying creatures flying through the simulated blue sky.

River and Avery had made it to the heart of the mall: a large circular scaling area with businesses and restaurants surrounding it. Four halls, on the sides of the area, extended

to further capitalize the size of the mall and the number of businesses thriving in such a place. The entire place was white with silver lining; each shop also had their own distinguished color themes and decorations. The prominent feature of the center area was the large flowing fountain at the center.

"Wow uh…" Before Avery could finish, River continued running, thus, Avery had no choice but to follow. She directed him towards one of the halls on the far left.

Moving away from the center area, Avery and River shoved through a crowd of people gathered at a popular ramen shop. With no specific thought in mind, River dragged Avery into one of the larger stores in the mall: a clothing store called Acitas.

"Did we lose them, whoever they are?" Avery questioned, confused. He had not even thoroughly examined this mall yet, to his dissatisfaction.

"Hopefully, for now," River replied, looking around on alert.

***

Atlas Aquia, the leader of the Tempest Aquia cohort, had brought along his personal platoon in search of a suspected target.

They mobilized towards the escalators to scan around the main lobby area for suspicious profiles.

Now at close view, Atlas was a regal individual who thought well of his presentation as well as his might. He had long silver hair which he kept flowing over his shoulders.

With a smooth spotless face and intense silver eyes, no one wouldn't recognize the royalty in his blood.

He also wore a simple blue eccentric uniform to further display his mystical ranking.

He bore a badge of the Tempest Aquia logo on his right chest as a token of respect and devotion for their cause.

Atlas's subordinates in his platoon were Antaro Eightawoe, a green haired guy who liked keeping reminders and checklists, and Flustra Litoriare, a light blue haired girl who supported the cohort with logs and technicalities.

"Why is it that we are tasked with such a low task?" Antaro spoke, pushing up his glasses.

Tapping and swiping on a digital tablet, Flustra added, "We should've gotten a B or A rank mission. But instead, we were assigned to a ridiculous C rank mission. That would have been a better investment for our time. I already calculated…"

"Enough you two. You know that catching a rogue faculty from Regnum Academy is more vital. Leaking sensitive data will impact the prestige of the school, so this threat must be dealt with as quickly as possible," Atlas corrected.

"Now, you can use any methods available to catch the culprit. He's here in the mall somewhere," he directed.

"No worries, he won't stray from us," Flustra grinned. "I've already calculated some countermeasures."

"What sort of countermeasures? I hope you're not talking about the stupid kind," Antaro demanded.

"Both of you, focus. Quit your silly games. This isn't cat and mouse. We're here to be swift and efficient. The culprit is probably several thousand feet away from us at this point. Remember, we can't let him leak info about the school," Atlas instructed firmly.

"Fine."

Water Magic: Water Body Detection.

Flustra called forth her magic and then tapped on the screen.

Suddenly, the mall layouts began drawing itself onto the tablet she held. It was a unique magical power she possessed which allowed her to send thin arrays of her magic around a mile radius to produce a model. The placement of water was determined by collisions with non-liquid objects. Being a second to none tech genius who didn't work for IT, she could imprint what she sensed onto the digital screen so her comrades could see.

Atlas studied the layout for a moment and then stepped to the edge of the escalator that led down. He eyed his surroundings, making sure that most of the mall was in his view. "Thank you Flustra, splendid work as always. Now it's my turn."

Atlas raised a single hand and aimed towards the same hall that Avery and River ran off to. With a sudden jolt, Atlas' mood was no longer a cold stern leader, but of an assassin with directed intent.

Water Magic plus Compression Magic: Crystal Water Needle.

Atlas' palm formed a small water sphere which rotated at an intense rate. It then began condensing until it lost its transparency. Then, taking the form of a small needle, Atlas aimed it carefully.

Compression Magic: Gravity Increase.

Atlas' palm then exerted an immense amount of pressure towards the water needle, causing it to shoot towards the desired direction. Atlas retained the position for a short time before re-posturing himself.

And just like that, the target was immobilized.

"Let's go," Atlas commanded.

Atlas was something else, an individual deemed one of the greatest at this current age.

"I can't believe you actually got him," Antaro remarked in astonishment.

Using compression magic to create an angled gravitational push, Atlas sped at an impossible speed towards the culprit while effortlessly evading the citizens. The other two pursued on foot but were already left in the dust.

***

As Avery turned a corner of the mall, he found River resting against an obscure wall. After scanning the area, but not really paying attention to details, Avery approached River.

"So, who or what were we running from?" he asked. He was confused at River's very sudden reaction and manuvering but he didn't question she had a reasonable explanation.

"It's Atlas and his cohort," River responded at last after catching her breath.

"Atlas? You mean the guy who did the speech yesterday? How come? I would've wanted to meet him, in my opinion."

"Well, uhh… it's complicated. I've known him back then, but we don't get along, that's all."

"Hmm, well okay. I won't pester you for any explanations. Anyway, since we're in the clear for now, I guess we should look for books."

Avery was still not convinced. Somehow River was hiding some crucial details such as her relationship with the Altas since she gave no clear indications of her prior life potentially on the island.

"You didn't happen to be on this island before?"

"No."

"Ok then." Avery chose not to pester her any longer.

Scanning around, Avery saw that he and River were in a corner of a clothing store near the changing rooms. Approaching a rack of suit coats, he checked the labels and saw the name "Acitas" written on most of them.

"Oh, so we're in an Acitas store. That brings back annoying memories," Avery stated.

River stood up and examined the place herself. "Yeah, of all places."

"If it is a sanctuary for whatever the situation was earlier, call it irony," Avery remarked. Then, turning to the front of the department store, his eyes gleamed in excitement.

"What is it?" River asked, curious to know Avery's sudden expression.

"There's a bookstore right next door! I'm surprised we overlooked the sign!"

"Let's go and, uhh, get it done," River said, hinting at her desire to leave this mall as quickly as possible.

River took charge and looked both ways of the large open path between different department stores. Trying best to blend into the crowds, the duo rushed towards the bookstore.

It was a fairly large bookstore with clear shelves stacked with old books, new books, smelly books, and peculiar books.

Finding the necessary books for the required classes, Avery managed to just barely scrape by with the small amount of money given by Jane Tee. He began reminiscing at her evil grin and her taunting for paying back with interest.

After shoving the books into his backpack, the duo decided to quickly shuffle out as soon as possible.

But with a rustling of books splattering around the ground and shelves crashing onto the ground, the duo were shocked at the new revelation. From the entrance of the shop was the start of the destruction path.

A moderate sized burly man wearing all black and a mask, almost like a local robber, sprinted into the store, trampling through the shelves and books in the process.

He was instantly distinguished from any other black-cloaked individual simply by his maniatic maneuverability. Though this time, it seemed he was not looking for trouble as, unfortunately, trouble was intent on seeking him, Andy everybody around him, instead.

Several civilians chose not to engage by running from the bookstore

Clearly targeting a pair of exit doors near the far side of the room, but seeing Avery and River in the way, the robber stormed his way through, heavily knocking the duo aside.

Avery had managed to grab River in time as they fell so only he would take the brunt of the damage.

Shoved against a shelf and knocking it sideways, Avery fell and endured the numerous pokes of the sharp corners of the books scattered around the ground.

"Aaauggugh," he grunted, feeling dazed. A few seconds went by before his awareness kicked back into reality.

"Are you okay, River?" he asked.

River, who was between his arms, slowly stood up and replied timidly, "Yeah, I'm fine. But… you're the one you should worry about."

Then suddenly, a silver wisp of light shot and curved into the bookstore, pursuing the robber. Just barely pushing through the pair of exit doors, the small light impaled itself into the robber's body, thus knocking him out cold.

"What was that?" Avery exclaimed, turning around quickly. Pain suddenly arched throughout his body when he realized he was in no condition to move about quite yet.

"It-it looked like magic," River said.

Then a pair of heavy footsteps were heard and not soon after, the man himself came onto the scene. Atlas Aquia smirked at the sight of the fallen robber.

River gasped and began backing away at the sight of his presence.

"Hmm, I see the culprit made some casualties," Atlas remarked, glancing about the room.

Not a moment later, Antaro and Flustra filed in behind Atlas. They were a bit winded from the chase, but seemd to still possess high amounts of energy.

“Whoa, check it out centurio, you’ve got him!” Antaro exclaimed. He then rushed to the body of the robber and shuffled through his clothes to obtain a small thumbdrive. “There, I got the stolen data.”

“So, now what, sir?” Flustra requested as she typed some finishing comments concerning the current culprit mission.

But seeing their leader’s gaze not upon the robber anymore, Antaro and Flustra were confused for a moment. They stood there silently and observed what their leader was doing next.

Turning his attention on Avery and River, Atlas stood there for a moment. He was perplexed.

“How are you here… little… sister?” he admitted in a disrespectful tone.

Avery still remained crumpled on the ground, but his attention was gazed upon Atlas. River stood where she was motionless, her hood had fallen off from the fall, revealing her fox ears.

“Uh, b-brother?” River spoke uncomfortably.

“I thought it was unanimously agreed upon that neither of us would see each other ever again. It was a disgrace to the Aquia name what you have done to the water kingdom,” Atlas stated.

“Y-yes, that was true since our father passed away, but I-I thought it would be different after a few years,” River explained. “T-the New York school sent me here.”

“Well, of all the places, and schools, you’d suddenly show up here,” Atlas protested.

“I-it wasn’t my choice,” River retorted.

“Hmm, your choice? You know why you retreated to the mainlands when you were young in the first place, so you ought to know better. You never had a choice after you made up your mind! But your sole purpose was to remain there and only that.”

Overhearing this, a sudden tinge of anger began to envelope Avery’s body. Despite the pain, he stood up and stood in front of River and before Atlas.

Now wasn’t the time for him to fret about his own reputation or future. All Avery knew was that River was being abused by one so-called family and he couldn’t stand it.

“What’s your problem? From what I understand, I don’t think you have the right to bad mouth your sister that way,” Avery objected in defense of River.

“So, you’re the new student,” Atlas stated, not a bit interested. “Stay out of our familial affairs. It does not concern strangers.”

Atlas gestured his hand slightly, sending a gust of force that sent Avery sprawling across the ground a few meters away.

Avery coughed as he tried to stand again. “I’ve lived alone most of my life, and you feel the need to be disrespectful to your own sibling? You think you are entitled to superior rights?” he muttered.

“What do you know about family then, boy?” Atlas demanded.

Avery gasped as another invisible fist of force punched him in the guts.

Atlas paid no mind and turned his focus back onto River who held her head down in shame.

“You are family, but I won’t acknowledge you as legitimate, afterall, your side of the family were all demihumans, the lowest of the low,” Atlas continued, intently spreading more salt on wounds.

“Regardless of how things are, you should let go of that discrimination and hate,” River confronted, this time in a stronger voice.

“If my position at the school allowed me to freely expel students, I would do that instalty to you. You lowly species don’t belong in a higher class city such as this. And to think you’d attempt to worm your way back through the grace of the principal was preposterous!”

“What are you saying, brother? You… don’t mean that? W-what happened to the noble side of you? You’ve always been resentfall, why have you not changed?” River pleaded. Looking up, she only saw what was left of her older brother when those changes had passed.

“I’ve always been like this. This city, Lux Urbis, has taught me what true excellence is. In the kingdom where our mother reigned, it was too small for the eventual ideals I’d form. I’ve already found my purpose. I’m not the one who has changed,” Altas explained.

River fell down her knees shouldering a myriad of emotions suddenly planted onto her back. Tears dripped from her eyes as her evisionment of the worst confrontation became realized.

"I think we're done here. Try to succeed at Regnum if you even can, you'll soon leave eventually." Then turning Atlas stormed out of the shop with his platoon following in pursuit.

Stepping within their vicinity, Avery shouted, "So you're just like the rest of the insufferable nobility jerks I've heard about! River and I, we will succeed in the academy. Though there is nothing I can do now, I will prove you wrong!"

Atlas and Antaro, who was shouldering the unconscious robber, turned and laughed at such a far-fetched statement. They then exited without saying another word, most likely to indicate their highest esteem to respond.

After their presence was no longer sensed, Avery relieved his frustrations as fast as possible before he accidentally barked at someone else. Then, turning to the wreckage of the bookstore, he clenched his fists.

River, who was unscathed, except for the fact she had cried a bit and she looked like a person with their soul internally pierced.

Standing there, breathing heavily, but still tolerating reality despite the aches in his muscles, Avery spoke, "Though it isn't my business to meddle in your familial affairs, I would like to get revenge on that jerk. So, River, will you let me do this?"

"W-what will y-you do?" she said dryly.

"I… no, we will prove that we are more than what he thinks of us!"

***

As Atlas, Antaro, and Flustra exited the mall, no one spoke until the tension had cooled off for a little bit. The trio beelined in the direction of the police department a few blocks from the mall entrance.

"So, what was the deal back there, centurio?" Antaro spoke, breaking the silence. He heaved the body of the robber up to readjust the weight straining on his shoulders.

"It's none of your concern," was Atlas' response.

"You called that girl your younger sister. I thought the princess, Alteria, was your only immediate sibling," Flustra indicated.

Atlas sighed. Clearly annoyed, he resented.

"It's complicated," he explained, "my mother remarried after her husband passed away, thus, that girl was born part of the Aquia family. The second marriage was unfortunately with a demihuman man who promised to swear alligances with the Water Kingdom, however, years later, he borke his vow. I won't go into the details, but that is the simple explanation of it."

"Sounds complicated," Antaro remarked.

"A demihuman of all people. How crude," Flustra added.

"Anyway, it's none of your guys' concern. It's not even a problem. I just wanted to put her into place, but… the hindrance now is that boy."

"Ohh, that boy. I wonder who he is?"

"Well, I looked into the academy student records but unfortunately, his record hasn't been updated yet. His name is Avery Obtainia though. He was among the three, along with that girl, who were transferred to the academy for some reason," Flustra noted.

"I see, the school higher ups probably know more than we do at the moment," Atlas stated, slightly intrigued. "But we have more pressing matters at hand. Today was just a small hindrance, that's all."

"I doubt that, sir, you seemed pretty worked up," Antaro pointed out.

"Best you shut up now," Atlas demanded coldly.

"Alright alright, sorry. No hard feelings."

"Now that we have the data, the school's privacy should be preserved," Flustra stated, changing the subject.

"Yes. Did you find any information on there that seemed very confidential?" Atlas asked.

"Oh right. The data seemed untampered with. None of it is too highly important or anything that could've ruined the reputation. Just some information about the infrastructure of the school such as school layouts and facility maintenance. Though, it does seem strange…"

"Strange? How?" Antaro piped in.

"Even for a student to run with school information, accessing the information and going against the policy contracts is rather hard. This man we caught is a faculty member who's worked for the school for a few years. It's not like he intently stole the information from the start," Flustra explained.

“Yes, you’re right about that. Some third-party has recently been involved,” Atlas stated.

“What’s the best course of action from here?” Flustra inquired.

“Antaro will drop the culprit at the police station. We’ll inform the school staff and then probably set up a board meeting with most of the professors and managers.”

“If the school’s been breached, it could relate to the recent incident in New York. I just pulled up some private school records that indicate so,” Flustra said.

“Incident at New York, huh. Tell me, does it relate to the arrival of the new transfers?” Atlas asked.

“The three transfers, Avery Obtainia, River Grant, and Teddric Tech, were directly sent from OSNYC after the incident. According to the record, the presence of a shadow cult member stirred the urgency of the event’s further investigation,” Flustra answered, reading from her tablet.

“I see. Looks like it's up to this generation to clean up the remnants of the past still lingering,” Atlas concluded.

***

At the end of the day, the incident at the bookstore remained enclosed. Most of the customers and store employees kept their distance from the commotion, so no word of mouth spread of Atlas' confrontation against River and Avery. Even people passing by afterwards were concerned about entering due to the mess at the entrance.

Avery and River left immediately as soon as their awareness and emotions were regulated; though it wasn’t very easy walking away from the scene of a crime and not reporting anything.

Avery staggered his way back to the academy grounds. River followed along but was uncomfortable to help, even though she was concerned. He didn’t feel assured that he’d even ask her since she faced the harshest challenge.

Arriving through the main entrance of the academy, Avery and River were approached by some faculty who noticed the distinguable injuries.

Quickly being escorted to a nurse’s office at one wing of the building, they examined Avery and River and demanded quite a lot of information about the cause. Of course,

both Avery and River were unsure if disclosing Atlas' presence and intimidation would've been a good idea, especially in the long run.

The nurses patched up Avery's bruises and cuts, mostly on the arms and back, and sent them both on their way with threats of varying degrees if they ever did such a thing again. The cover story Avery made was his unfortunate fall from slipping on a flight of stairs. He would never catch himself in that situation, but it was a good made-up event to explain the specific placement of his wounds.

Hearing the rapid demands of Jane Tee and Ted were the next things the duo had to tolerate when they entered Quad 44.

Avery and River set their belongings and store bought supplies down in their respective rooms and went back into the main room to chill on the couches.

Ted stood before Avery with a frown. "So, what sort of trouble did you and River get into now?"

Avery tilted his head with confusion. "Heh?"

"Don't play dumb with me. You can tell us. What is said here, stays here, I guarantee it."

"Huh, I don't know. That's quite a promise you made," Avery pointed out, thinking back on Ted's prior track record.

"Hey, before I met you. I was a good boy. I never poked my nose into others' business nor did I disclose secrets from my closest friends!"

"What are your closest friends? You seem quite content with this new life you have now," Jane Tee noted from behind a sofa turned behind them.

Avery resented and explained the situation that occurred during the mall visit without disclosing anything about Atlas' strange relationship with River nor the details of how weak he was when pitched against him.

He felt unsure whether it was wise to continue prying into her familial affairs. There were still questions in his mind such as her presence on the island before and her true identity. None of that changed who she was in his perspective, so he decided that she would be the one to explain anything further when she was ready.

"Hahaha, so you fell down a flight of stairs afterwards!" Ted laughed, rolling on the ground. Avery decided to keep the act a bit longer.

River, whose hood was casting a shadow over half her face, nodded in support of the entire getup.

"Ah, I didn't know you were a demihuman?" Jane Tee said, jumping from her chair upon hearing the abuse River got from Atlas.

River nodded shyly. She then removed her hood to showcase her caramel brown fox ears.

"Oh wow, they're something," Ted said abruptly.

"Oh man, you look even cuter!" Jane Tee exclaimed. "Can I give you a hug? Or maybe pet those ears?"

"I-I don't t-think I can handle that," River politely declined.

"Aww, oh well. Poor you, I'm upset such a thing happened to you. Alas, in this society here, demihumans don't usually live as ordinarily as the common folk, nobles, or royals," Jane explained with a disgusted expression.

"There's nothing I can do about that, I'll just have to avoid most people," River stated.

"Don't worry. We'll be here," Avery assured.

The others agreed with a nod.

"Tomorrow's the big first day for you guys, good luck," Jane Tee waved as she headed back into her room.

"First day, huh?" Avery spoke as he rubbed his chin.

***

The next day was a big day for the trio. According to the schedule, all first year students were taking the same rudimentary classes for the first semester before breaking up into their distinct subject focuses in the future.

It was also the first time that Avery, River, and Ted experienced wearing school uniforms for the first time. The male's outfit consisted of a long-sleeve maroon shirt and gray slicky pants that looked more like khakis. The female's outfit was the same for the shirt, but a knee length skirt instead of pants. Typically a badge was on the right chest, but it was only given to students who completed their first semester.

Upon arriving at the academic building near the dining hall, Avery, Ted, River, and Jane approached a group of students gathered around the front door. About thirty students were gathered and most of them were impatient.

The first class of the day was magic class, but apparently the professor was absent as the students waited for several more minutes.

Then a figure stepped up behind the students and spoke, shifting the students' attention to her, "Class will be held at the back of the building outside. Please kindly head over there now."

The trio were surprised to see the teacher for the first class was none other than Charlotte Levy.

The back of the academic building was nothing to gaze upon. A forest was immediately growing from the edge of the hard concrete parking lot at the behind the backdoor entrances to the building.

"Today, students, you will be using what you've been learning about basic magic and applying it via a small friendly two-vs-two combat," Charlotte announced, standing in the center of the parking lot as the students gathered around her in a semicircle.

"Whoa! Oh yeah!" several students chanted.

"With two hours of class time, it should be plenty of time to do eight matches," she continued.

This was Avery's first time in a distinct class that offered physical training. His time spent at OSNYC wasn't wasted either though.

Glancing over at Ted, he could notice an evil grin appearing on him indicating his excitement for his match.

"Since you have a separate physical combat class in the later afternoon, these matches should be a simple battle where you don't use any weapons but only your magic. The goal is to knock out your opponents from the circle or make them yield. I'll intervene if the match fight gets too serious, but other than that, feel free to go all out," Charlotte finished.

Charlotte drew a ring of purple fire around the concrete field just beside the building which caused a slight burn to be applied to the ground, thus creating the battle circle. She announced the names of the first members that would combat each other, indicating her pre-planned and memorized roster of the battles to come.

Several matches went by displaying the full powers and potentials of each first-year student. With varying magical attributes at show, the trio were astonished to see live action right before their eyes.

When it was suddenly Avery's turn, he happened to be paired up with Ted and the duo would be versing an opponent duo they had no familiarity with.

A little hesitant at first, Avery stepped into the battle ring and stood beside Ted. He was unsure whether he would be capable of defeating even a single weak student since he still lacked the same experience as the others.

"Are you ok about this, Ted?" he asked Ted quietly.

"Don't worry, if it comes to it, I'll defeat them both for you," Ted assured, in a loud volume loud enough for others to hear.

Several students winced but others smirked and chuckled. "Him? Neh, he looks like a hip-hop dude," several said amongst themselves.

Ted was convinced to go aggressive on the bystanders instead but maintained his cool. He really wanted to prove them wrong.

The duo stood several meters away from their opponents, waiting for the formal start of the match.

"Hello, you two must be the transfer students we heard about," one of the opponents spoke confidently. "My name is Ken Masumi."

The partner beside him greeted, "And my name is Kirk Masumi. We're both brothers. We're Huolors with the mastery of the fire element."

"Nice to meet you both, I'm Teddric Tech, but you can call me Ted, I'm a Metalor," Ted stated.

"I'm Avery Obtainia, I'm an Angelor," Avery greeted. Several students began murmuring upon his announcement of his species.

"Let's have a fair battle," Ted said.

"Yeah, sure thing," Ken agreed. "We'll be sure to go all out since you said you could beat the both of us."

"Oh of course. I don't want you to hold back," Ted said sarcastically.

"Don't mock us. The Masumi clan is famous for its extremely enhanced fire elemental magic. I doubt your metal magic can do anything against that," Kirk retorted.

"Begin!" Charlotte announced suddenly.

And with that, the two brothers were instantly on the move.

Avery and Ted stood there motionless as they eyed the duo brothers circling around them, tightening their route of escape.

Fire Magic: Fire Phoenix Talon.

Ken took a direct route toward Ted's side eagerly waiting for the right opportunity to strike his blind spot. With the right timing estimated, he pounced at his side and gave a great swipe with his hand immersed in flames that arched like a bird's claws.

"*Metal Magic: Metal Wall*." With a simple, but unnecessary flick of his hand, Ted created a metal wall several feet away from him to rise from the ground, blocking the attack from Ken.

The metal wall dispersed the flame talon and knocked Ken back from the sudden recoil.

The first wall faded and several more appeared wherever Ken attempted to strike Ted. "It's pointless, you see. My walls are just that much stronger," Ted stated.

Resting a short distance in front of Ted, Ken only smirked. "I was just seeing if you weren't just all words and no action, you see. Luckily I found a worthy opponent to use my fire against."

And with that, flames evnoloped around Ken's body, elevating the surrounding atmospheric temperature by about a hundred degrees. "*Fire Magic: Flame Aura*."

"Heh, you're not the only one who can use that type of magic. I can manipulate the temperature as I see fit," Ken said as he rushed towards Ted.

During that ordeal, Avery barely managed to hold his footing against Kirk's continuous fist attacks. "*Fire Magic: Fire Fists of Fury*." The first few blows, he managed to remain standing by blocking with magic imbued into his arms, but the continuous ones knocked him backwards.

"Is that all you can do? Huh, I guess I can tell what sort of progress mainland schools make," Kirk stated.

"You may not know this, but I've recently learned about magic itself," Avery said, standing back up. "I've faced real dangers, something that you probably couldn't compare to."

"Huh? What are you saying?"

Avery knew from the type of battles he's faced that power wasn't everything. If he wanted to outplay his opponents, he had to outmaneuver them first.

"Oh, I'm just saying, from the type of attack you just did there, it was not carefully thought out. I mean, I don't know, it could end anyone else, but it was kind of… predictable," Avery explained.

With two enraged ref flaming fists, Kirk lept forward with flame enhanced force. As soon as he was within reach, Avery sidestepped and easily evaded his attack. With a quick turn and another attempt, Avery easily dodged and sprinted a short distance away.

Avery could feel his already strong body imbued with magic that further strengthened his dexterity, agility, and stamina.

Now flowing with magic, he leaped into the air several meters off the ground. With a fist full of light magic, he aimed at his opponent, "*Light Magic: Light Fist*."

Kirk just barely evaded the blow as Avery planted his fist into the ground, causing a slight crack to appear in the concrete.

"That's pretty good, I'd say," Kirk complimented.

Both of them suddenly crumpled to the ground as the temperature rose well above a hundred degrees. Fehrenheit, of couse, since anything well above that in Celsius would've melted them.

"What's going on?" Avery questioned as he glanced in Ted's direction.

"Okay, brother, looks like you're using that ability already. Guess it's time to not hold back, right?" Kirk stated.

Fire then ignited around Kirk's body as he unleashed his magic all at once. "*Fire Magic: Fire Aura*."

The ground began to light up as if heat itself seemed to be flowing rigorously underneath. With the added temperature, the entire match arena became a scorching desert. The atmosphere became denser with heat and the scope of vision seemed to be dimmer as the air darkened.

"This is our best magic at full power. Our fire domain is unstoppable," Ken gleamed.

Kirk dashed straight towards Avery with a single fist imbued with intense fire magic. "I'll finish you in one punch!"

Holding both hands out in front, Avery willed for his magic to be diverted into his palms to be unleashed at once. Kirk was knocked back as his fist's magic powers repelled itself from a newly appeared light barrier before Avery, "*Light Magic: Light Barrier*."

"You continue to surprise me, hehe," Kirk exclaimed.

"Well, this is a first for me," Avery grunted. Dispersing the barrier, he took the initiative to lunge another light fist blow at the opponent.

Kirk blocked with his strong arms and rolled away to gather his magic for another counterattack. Too agile on his feet and his keen awareness at its peak, Avery managed to stay unscathed from most of his continuous attacks.

The flame aura in the circle, however, was slowly eating away rapidly at his stamina and strength. Kirk planted a low blow at Avery's stomach, knocking him a few feet away near the edge of the circle.

Kirk approached in triumph to do a final blow to send Avery out of the match, but his overconfidence became the better of him as Avery mustered the rest of his strength into a kick that sent him flying away.

Kirk managed to stand up unscathed, but nonetheless, he was open for another attack.

With his indomitable will steering his body even through the heat and damage, Avery charged and pushed him back. With a final shove, Kirk stumbled backwards and fell on his rear, completely out of the battle circle.

"Kirk Masumi has been eliminated," Charlotte announced.

Shifting back to the other battle, Ted was enduring the temperature moderately. Ken created a fiery shield and charged towards him.

Assuming the attack was another cheap attempt, Ted created a metal wall a few feet before him to block the attack, but Ken's sudden increase in speed and strength easily broke through and dented the metal structure.

The flames arched around and restrained Ted. Ken stepped up before his fallen opponent prepared to throw the final blow.

Then Ted's body turned a shade of silver as his skin became a layer of metal. He grabbed Ken's arms right before he could make another attack. He kicked the shin of the opponent, but it was rather weak due to the immense heat.

Ted let go of Ken and mustered his full strength into his fist. He planted the blow into the opponent's chest and sent him flying out of the circle a few meters away.

Clenching his fists, he raised them in victory.

Avery was happy to claim a victory this time with minimal damage. He high-fived Ted and both exited the circle.

The Masumi brothers were quick to recover from loss. They came over to the duo and congratulated them.

"Nice job out there. That sucker punch really was something," Ken complimented as he patted Ted's back roughly.

"Thank you, man. Though I admit I may not be able to defeat the both of you, hehehe," Ted winced.

"Heh, it wasn't supposed to, you were only half-right."

"You too, little boy. I didn't think you had potential in you," Kirk stated, shaking hands with Avery.

"I suppose that's why you guys transferred here. You were easily able to come due to your incredible abilities and potential," Ken exclaimed.

"Why thank you," Ted said, soaking in all the praise.

"I think you got the wrong idea about us," Avery admitted. But thinking back on the incident that led to their transfer, he didn't want that to be disclosed. "Uh yeah. Thanks. I suppose so."

Charlotte came up to the duo and the brothers. "Good job. Now, the next match!"

Ted and Avery joined the student body where River and Jane watched.

Some of the next matches were just as intense as the duo's match.

When River's match was initiated, she was with a stranger as a partner. They were up against two tough-looking opponents (not as tough as Billy's gang). The match instantly ended when River conjured a gigantic magic sphere of water at the center and flushed the opponents out of the circle before they even had the chance to prepare.

"Good job everyone… but I expect better performance tomorrow," Charlotte said in an authoritative tone, but with a hint of a threat. She said this to alarm the students, however, she truely wanted to bring out the best of each student. Avery suspected as so since afterwards, she began giving short remarks and tips for improvements shortly after the matches.

Each student took the advice to heart, which was quite unusual. Charlotte would point out large errors and mistakes each individual made and comment on how distasteful witnessing it all was. But she would always end with stating some good elements and saying to work hard. Apparently regular statements like “Good job” didn’t come easily for some teachers on the island.

The magic class set the expectations of the rest of the time at school. After the first class, Avery, River, and Ted went to their next few classes which were far more chill and more immediate to what they usually experiened at OSNYC. Math, language, and science were the three main courses for the mid-portion of the day.

The last class of the day was physical combat class, often known at the academy as PE class. Their expectations blew under the ground when they only engaged in continuous techniques, not actual combat. The concepts were very difficult to grasp, hence the prestige of the school, and no one else felt a bit of pity against them.

And so was the first day of classes at Regnum Academy. But little did the trio know of the greater challenges to come.

Chapter 11: Invasion by Fire

War, happiness, power – those were the objects of attention in his mind. It was all coming together now as to why he desired so much in the first place. Pyrus Bourn suffered so much to obtain a district of his own but he was still unsatisfied with the current status quo.

For his past few decades with the Mystical, he realized his ideals did not align with his former plans of claiming the Mystical Island for his own. No, it was different. Pyrus saw conflict from every turn he took. This time his focus was on something much greater than himself – peace.

Indulging in conflict was the least of his desires, however, it was necessary for the steps towards uniting the island of its contrasting views. Through the endless chaos he endured, he realized one crucial thing: corrupt leaders created continuous conflicts. He summed that if he wanted something done, it was in his best interest for him to do it himself.

Though it sounded like an ideal any same sane leader would think, Pyrus imagined his role much grander than that. He planned to be someone who could make a difference in the world – someone who could stir the hearts of others and convey the true meaning of existence.

Today, Pyrus Bourn was idling in the throne room of his large lair underneath the volcanic remnants of the largest mountain on the Mystical Island. The secret entrance to his lair was right in the forest between the two major districts of the island: District 7 and District 13.

Pyrus' throne room was quite dull with the only notable features of a red carpet, a heavy steel throne-like chair, a single silver chandelier hanging above, and strange paintings plastered on the deepslate walls. With a glistering black polished floor, Pyrus' subordinates ensured the cleanliness of the lair was top notch.

Wearing the same attire as before: a muddy brown sweater and baggy gray pants, Pyrus Bourn kept his sense of style private. His flaming crimson hair and tall stature immediately made him stand out among most of the Mystical Beings.

Pyrus glanced down at a pile of papers containing reports and breakdowns of costs for his company Fire Increaser Co.

Suddenly catching a glimpse of some irritating details, his flame orange eyes glared into the entire room.

"Blaugh, really? Another accident occurred?" he shouted in frustration, slamming his fist against the dense arm of his chair.

Right in the middle of his tantrum, a group of subordinates, three members, arrived into the room bearing news. But upon seeing their master's satisfaction, they feared for their lives and approached nervously.

"What is it?" Pyrus demanded, still annoyed and even more so now that he was needed for something.

"Sir, you know the plans you initiated a few weeks back…" one subordinate recollected.

"Yeah, so what?" Pyrus sneered.

"The faculty agent we sent into the school got caught," another subordinate finished.

"What? You're saying the intel gathering failed?"

"Not entirely," the third subordinate added.

Pyrus leaned back onto his throne after being enraged. "Well okay, explain."

"I'd like to say, based on the intel we've gathered, your trip to the forest in New York wasn't in vain. There's records of some ancient artifact that used to be owned by the Angeloress which holds the secret to the orb's whereabouts. Though that information isn't guaranteed to be accurate, there is data of a teacher in Regnum Academy who may have connections to finding the orb," the first subordinate explained.

"Though the faculty agent failed and was caught, rest assured that no background information was gathered. He managed to send a backup of the stolen data, so even the school doesn't know that we have successfully received it," the second subordinate added.

Pyrus leaned forward with a smirk. "Hmm, I see. Good work. The plans can continue as usual then."

"Yes sir. But you will probably need to plan how to either cross paths with the teacher or something if you want to get information," the third subordinate suggested.

“The faculty of the school may be preparing a meeting to discuss the logistics of the recent occurrence, so it may be that you will be discovered very soon,” the second subordinate warned.

“No worries about that,” Pyrus gleamed, “That’s just the perfect time to make a move, isn’t it?”

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A few days have passed since the first day of school. Avery could feel the strain and difficulty of each subsequent class catching up. Unfortunately, for him especially, the classes advanced quickly, not wanting to give any student the light of day.

After taking a quick shower and catching up with Ted and River at the academic building where magic class would be held again, the trio were quick to discover that the teacher, Charlotte Levy, seemed far less cheerful than usual (not that she was to begin with).

“Into the classroom,” she barked. And with that command, most of the other students seemed to know what this “classroom” she was referring to. The trio simply laid back and followed the crowd.

“This is pretty nice, don’t you say?” Ted said, as they filed up a flight of stairs.

Nothing was unusual from the building aside from the fact it looked like a normal high-school, so wherever Ted obtained his cheeriness, it was certainly not from the surroundings.

“So, what’s up anyway?” Avery asked.

Ted gleamed. “Well, yesterday when I was out doing a few errands, I bought a brand new game, heheheh. It’s the latest edition that I would’ve normally waited half a year to play!”

“I see, so that's that.”

“Oh, I just can’t wait to get back to my dorm tonight!”

“Shouldn’t you be upset… uh, waiting,” River asked.

“Neh, I’ve built up stamina for waiting. But since it is here, waiting for the end of the day only brings more anticipation!”

"Woo hoo… Sounds so exciting," Avery responded sarcastically. He got used to Ted's unusual behaviors, but seeing he lacked desires that a typical person would possess, he felt reluctant to remark on his other quirky sides.

"So, tell me a little more about these 'Magic Types' that the teacher will be discussing?" Avery asked. There was discussion on previous lectures that led to the very topic that he just now inquired about.

"Oh that? You'll find out. It's, I guess, semi-important so the teacher will most likely go in depth and set the expectations."

"You're not much help, Ted," Avery admitted.

"Hey come on! I'm barely keeping up here as you are," Ted said quickly. Something about that statement only indicated his lazy attitude.

"Hey guys, whatcha both talking about?" Ken Masumi appeared from behind Avery and Ted. He patted their backs as if they were good old friends for a long time.

"Wait up, bro!" Kirk Masumi called from behind, rushing towards them.

"So, what's up?" Avery asked the brothers, clearly confused with their overly friendly gestures towards him and Ted especially for losing.

"We haven't had the chance to talk or hangout since the last mock battle. I thought perhaps we should band together!" Ken exclaimed.

"Ah right, I suppose that's fine," Avery replied. He was actually exceedingly glad that such rivals at first could become friends.

"Don't think you can boss us, alright, cus we beat you fair and square," Ted said pompously.

After the flight of stairs, the four followed the group of students through several halls until they arrived at a large classroom. The four began chatting about the decently good food from the dining hall until Charlotte arrived behind the student body and demanded silence.

As soon as all the students filed into the classroom which was quite dull and empty except for the orderly aligned desks, the others sat down at their respective seats at their desks. Avery, River, and Ted had to seat themselves wherever empty remaining seats were.

Avery sat in the back near a window, River in the middle center, and Ted in the front against a wall. None of them were comfortable sitting between unfamiliar individuals, but there was nothing to do about it.

Not desiring the students to indulge into other interests before the session, Charlotte Levy ordered everyone's fixed attention and began immediately. Swiping on her computer touchpad, she initiated a slideshow that projected itself onto the white marking board behind her.

"Through the previous lectures, I've discussed the concept and application of magic. In this lecture, we'll actually talk more about specific applications and the roles each of you will take for the following semesters," Charlotte said with authority.

Several of the students began rocking in their chairs. Apparently the main course was just about to be served after numerous appetites.

Then Charlotte Levy continued her lecture, "Magic, in essence, is the byproduct of the energy released in numerous reactions and molecular interactions. Thus, the release of magic is called the 'Discharge' and the wavelength of that said discharge is what creates the different attributes.

"Most of you students here use your innate magic to release your elemental discharges, thus you are referred to as elementalists. There are, however, four other main classes of Magic Users that manipulate magic far differently than simply just innate magic.

"Alchemists are the next Magic Users that utilize their magic through the equivalent exchange law to produce or manipulate substances. They are able to produce effective potions, medicine, or chemical reactions that are otherworldly.

"Runecrafting is another Magic User that specifically utilizes enchantments or modifications of physical objects with magic. This can range from timed-magic reactions, automatic changes, or enhancing physical objects with magical buffs or debuffs.

"The Mage is a powerful Magic User who can, after casting their elemental magic, alter and shape it to perform specific tasks. Usually they're able to refine their magic affinities so that it is far more powerful on output, but very skilled mages can even change the wavelength of their magic to wield different affinities.

"Finally, the Sage is perhaps the most powerful Magic User. Unlike Alchemists, Sage's can manipulate the surroundings with their own innate magic. They're skilled at

releasing their elemental magic at any point within their confined sage zone. With certain conditions met, they're even able to change the molecular structure of their surroundings.

"And so, with the breakdown of the Magic Users, I'd like to continue by saying that not one of these users are more important than others. In subsequent school competitions or tasks, you will be required to refine your skills, select a user type, and stick with that choice.

"In case you're not aware, the school is depended on as a secondary task force aside from the police. Certain objectives are completed by a group of the student body involved in cohorts. These 'cohorts' are operated by a graduate 'centurion' and have several members handpicked by said centurions. I am the centurion of the highest ranking cohort the Blue Legion whereas Atlas Aquia is the centurion of the Tempest Aquia. So you all should be aware of.

"It is to your discretion whether you want to take part in such cohorts, however, not participating does count against your involvement in the school and thus, another career path should be idealized. The mention of this now is so that you may be more ambitious with your academics, afterall, only a portion of the student body can even join any cohort.

"You all will be doing some simple missions with a select number of cohorts as a practice run, so this is why I brought all this information up. Depending on your contribution and behavior, those cohorts may even invite you to join their ranks quite earlier."

Charlotte Levy took a pause and glanced about for any student who was lost.

Then a student in the back raised his hand. "Hey, teach, name's Jake Falloway. I have an affinity for lightning. There will be all sorts of fighting missions, each ranging in difficulty, right?"

"Yes, there is," Charlotte answered, "however, the missions range from combat to community service related tasks. Don't expect to only get crime related missions. Most of the filed requests are actually more civil. Expect to do things you'd have no knowledge in."

"Oh ok," Jane muttered disappointedly, clearing hoping for particular jobs over another.

“Now, having gone over all that, let’s prepare to determine what each of you are best suited for,” Charlotte said, moving to the next phase of the classtime.

And so, the rest of the classtime was spent determining each student’s magic user type while also answering any further questions.

Avery apted to stay as an elementalist for the time being since he had no skill or relevance to the other four user types. River apted the same. Ted, however, was stuck between elementalist and runecrafting since he was skilled in both fields. But in the end, he stayed confined in the elementalist user type as it suited his aspirations better.

Avery was curious when the first small mission assignment would be, but he was certain that at the current stage, he probably wouldn’t handle a combat-related mission very well. After some guidance from Ted, Avery was able to practice inserting magic into his physical strength to increase jump height and speed, however, the control aspect needed further refinement.

Every class with Charlotte Levy seemed tiresome and overwhelming, but the way she instructed was meaningful as clear milestones of skills were actually noticeable. Avery, among many of the other students, grew to like the teacher for who she waas, despite her usual cold attitudes.

After the first few classes of the day, Avery, Ted, and their new friends all decided to head to the dining hall together to grab a bite of lunch. Being slightly lazy, Avery flinched at the prospect of walking half the lake from the dining hall and back to the dorms later.

The magic class and several of the standard classes were hosted in the same cluster of academic buildings near the dining hall, so today, the usual walk between them was actually quite nice.

“What made you guys want to be friends with us?” Avery asked the Masumi brothers as they strolled under some umbrella trees.

“At first, I didn’t like the idea of ever becoming friends with other classmates since I was quite confident with my superior skills,” Kirk said. “But now that you guys beat us, it really shows how much we’d need to learn, in order to appease our clan. Though it is a bit self-centered, I think being friends with you guys will help us become stronger.”

“You can’t just go and talk like that as if I agreed to that, brother,” Ken protested. “But, for once, you do make a good point.”

"Well, I've always wanted some rivals to train with," Ted admitted, rubbing his head with a sense of pride. "You see, I wasn't going anywhere with this friend here. He's actually not that strong," he added, pointing at Avery.

"Thank you Ted, I really enjoy being bad-mouthed," Avery sarcastically thanked.Ted was right, yet mostly wrong.

Upon arriving at the dining hall entrance, the newly formed party each swiped their ID cards for passage and entered. With all the pestigue of the school on the line, the food court-style dining hall could single-handedly drive application numbers to skyrocket.

This was the first time Avery really took the time to appreciate the design, the crowds, and the intertwined smells.

Various food stalls circled the perimeter of the building in a large oval and tables and chairs were arranged in the center. Several free-style drink machines scattered the pinnacle points of the food court. Stairs and a ramp led up to the secondary and tertiary floors each with their respective food stalls and seating arranged arround a center oval balcony looking down on the first floor's center area.

Finding the view below surprisingly pleasing, the four members located an empty table on the second floor. They marked their seats with their school belongings and each respectively went their separate ways to explore the cafetera for food that pleased their sight and nose.

It wasn't long before each member arrived back with their top choice. Avery had secured some noodles from a Chinese food stall that was about to close. The Masumi brothers found chicken wings and mozzarella sticks. Ted, on the other hand, brought pepperoni pizza and a dark soda.

"Is that all you wanted?" Avery questioned Ted's judgement of food.

"Isn't this nice," Ted exclaimed as he seated himself and immediately took a huge bite.

After the four seated themselves and ate in silence for a short time, Avery removed his ID card and examined the class schedule on the backside.

"That's interesting… there are no classes listed for the end of the day," he said, breaking the silence.

The others checked their cards for clarifications and found the same result.

"That's strange. I thought they would've at least announced this during class earlier," Ted mumbled as he chewed on his pizza.

"That's pretty normal. It has happened once before even before you guys arrived at the school," Ken explained.

"Yeah, I heard that there was some sort of school faculty meeting regarding a rebellious student, the last I heard of it," Kirk added.

"From what I heard recently, there was some sort of faculty recently who tried to steal school information, but that was resolved before anything bad happened. Perhaps it's another meeting to discuss countermeasures for future problems as such," Ken said frankly.

"Not that it matters to us anyways, isn't no school for the rest of the day pretty good?" Ted announced in a rather lazy perspective.

"I'd agree. Let's make the most out of the rest of the day," Avery added. "But anyway, what sort of missions do you think the cohort's do?"

"Pretty standard, but important, stuff. Before taking the entrance exam for this school, our father actually took us to the headquarters of the cohorts and issued us a fairly easy mission. We were sent to clean some rich dude's backyard," Ken explained, recalling past experiences.

"It was horrible and so boring," Kirk added.

"Nah, it was that way because you were too lazy. Now that I remember, near the end you decided that it would be fun to shoot fire at a wild bird pirching on a tree branch. You almost burned down that guy's house," Ken recalled.

"Heheh," Kirk laughed slyly.

"Where were you guys from before transferring here?" Ken asked Avery and Ted.

"Well," Avery scratched his head, "It's a complicated story. But in short, we were in New York City before coming here."

"We were too good for that place," Ted overemphasized.

"New York, huh? That's a pretty mainlandish place. Must be rough having to hide your magic powers in public," Kirk pointed out, indicating he had never restrained himself before. Not like he could anyway.

"It was pretty easy," Avery admitted, thinking of his life before meeting the Mystical Beings. Then he added, "On the other hand, it was pretty hard for Ted."

"Hey, I was pretty concealed," Ted protested.

The four laughed. The Masumi brothers patted Ted's back.

“I could imagine,” Ken stated.

“Yeah, for sure,” Kirk added.

After a bit of silence, the mood shifted between the members.

Ken Masumi leaned in and spoke in a serious tone, “So, tell us, Avery, who are you and what is your involvement in the recent incident.”

“Wait… what are you talking about?” Avery inquired, clueless at reading the mood change.

“You haven’t announced it to anyone and no one has told you in person, but you’re an Angelor, aren’t you.”

Avery stammered, “Uh, yes. That’s true. I am an Angelor. I suspected you’d figure it out, but I don’t know what the big deal is about it.”

“So it’s true. You didn’t know yourself, otherwise you’d easily beaten us in the mock battle a few days ago.”

“I don’t get what you’re trying to say.”

Ken sighed and adjusted his seat.

Then he explained, “In the past, the Angelors were a great and almost divine species who brought balance between disputes within the Mystical societies. Then the Gostlyngers, a powerful dark magic species, came in and wiped the Angelors almost to extinction. To this day, there haven't been any sightings of Angelors except for one individual in the formation of this island’s inhabitants.”

“Who was this Angelor?” Avery asked.

“Her name was Caela Obtainia and she was one of the founders who helped Zenith Luces unite the Mystical Beings to this very island.”

“Caela… Obtainia? Wait, how do you know I’m an Angelor? Maybe I’m some other Mystical Being with light-based magic affinity,” Avery protested, denying the truth that he really was an Angelor.

The connections seemed to get more obvious yet also uncertain without further physical proof, so Avery imagined.

“Angelors are the only species who can utilize pure light affinity, so it’s hard to just assume you’re not one,” Ken stated.

“Well, my last name is Obtainia and I guess I am an Angelor, to what several have said before and this ID card,” Avery said as he showed his ID card which affirmed his species and magic affinity.

Eying the card for a moment, Ken muttered, “Interesting…”

“I can’t imagine how I’m connected to someone who’s from a hundred years ago,” Avery objected.

“I’d agree with that. I can also confirm that you don’t know yourself based on what you’ve relayed and how you’ve acted. Maybe you are a long distant descendent or something, or just completely unrelated…”

“Uh, thanks,” Avery said shyly.

Avery began recalling the vision he received from the raven and pondered its significance. Having the woman in the vision confirmed to have the same last name as his made the entire situation more complex.

“Are there potential problems of being an Angelor currently?” Avery asked.

“None, I guess. These days, regardless of how extinct one species is, Angelors, among others, are all considered demihumans. Honestly, I don’t really care if you are one or not, but usually the rest of the nobility regard demihuamns as lower than commoners. A typical career with light attribute magic though is a holy saint of the district’s legislature.” Ken replied.

“That is if he’s accepted… cus, you know, the other group that aren’t,” Kirk added.

“A holy saint? That sounds pretty cool!” Ted exclaimed, piqued at the sound of a nonstandard career path.

“What do they do?” Avery inquired.

“They actually ward off evil Mystical Beings and ensure peace among the different districts. Aside from each district’s Magni, the holy saints are the second highest authority on the island.”

“So what's the Magni?”

Hand in front of his face and shaking his head, Ted thought back on Avery’s neiveness of the Mystical.

“The Magni is essentially the ruler of each district,” Ken explained briefly. “This district has one called the Magni Mage, one of the most influential Magni of all. Though District 7 specifically hides the true identity of the Magni…”

Ted was astonished that Ken could keep a collected head and not scream from the constant pouring of questions. *I have been asking most of the questions, teheheh*, Ken thought.

"Anyway, enough of your prosecutions and all that, brother, we're here to hangout, right?" Kirk piped up.

"You're right, brother."

Once everyone finished their meal, the four took a vote and unanimously decided to head to the arena and check out a few school clubs.

***

Another school meeting in the same semester was a bit too much was what the principal of Regnum Academy was thinking when he entered a secret meeting room in the main faculty office of the school.

There were no windows in the room, so the yellow dim bulbs of the chandelier were the only source of light. A rectangular table was positioned at the center of the room with twelve chairs surrounding it.

Then the door opened and a butler gestured for several faculty individuals to enter and seat themselves. Principal Taskah sat at the head, right at the end of the table.

A tall burly man wearing a suitcoat and baggy black pants seated himself next to the principal.

"Welcome Sabastian Levi! It is a pleasure to meet one of the three symbols again!" Taskah greeted, putting a hand out for a shake.

"Peh, come on Taskah, you know that I'm a capntain now, so call me Captain Levi," the man instructed, shaking hands with the principal.

"Very well… Captain Levi."

Then a blond haired woman wearing an elegant dress sat beside Captain Levi.

"It's a pleasure to meet you in person, Elaina Terner," Principal Taskah greeted.

"Same to you," was her short response.

A tall silver haired man sat on Taskah's opposite side.

"Welcome, Oceanus Aquia," Taskah shaked the man's hand.

A few more members arrived into the room and seated themselves, thus, totaling half the total number of chairs.

"Now that everyone who was able to make it has arrived, let's begin the meeting," Taskah stated, hinting at his displeasure in several members bailing their attendance.

"I know that some of you were present for our other meeting a few weeks prior, however, this meeting has been issued because of some pressing matters."

"So, why ask a founding member of the school to come back when I've been retired," Captain Levi demanded.

Captain Levi thought that asking this question in front of everyone would escalate the priority for a reasonable answer.

"Where are the other current members?" Elaina added.

"Again, as I said before, we are in a dire situation and need the advice of the founding members to sort this sort of problem out," Taskah briefly explained. "I do know that a few of the other cohorts are involved in their higher-rated missions. A lot of them were sent to some new ones that appeared."

"Right, those mythical creature hunts… but still, they could at least tell what is more important," Captain Levi stated.

"You're saying you can't handle the situation with the current staff?" Elaina responded in a raised tone.

"Settle down you two, let Principal Taskah explain," Oceanus said.

Then folding his arms, he added, "What's done is done."

"One of our cohort centurions, Atlas Aquia, successfully captured a rogue faculty member who attempted to leak confidential information about the school. Though he isn't here to testify about the situation, I have suspicions that some information has already been noticed," Taskah explained.

"Hmm, this is quite serious," Elaina admitted. "Do explain what the consequences might be."

"Given that the culprit was a loyal staff member for several years, it is safe to assume that some third-party influenced his decision either by compensation or threat."

"So, we have reason to believe that someone seeks to obtain something. Perhaps it is tied to the recent incident in New York City?" Captain Levi stated.

“You have good perception. Looks like you haven’t lost any of your superior skills,” Oceanus complimented rue captain of the sea.

“Nah, my senses have only increased since my expeditions across the wide oceans,” Captain Levi admitted.

“It was an easy assumption really, after all, I was the one who picked up the three kids from New York and took them here.”

“I believe this information hasn’t been relayed to you all yet, but I have high certainty that the third-party may be trying to achieve the same goals as the shadow cult back at teh New York incident. I believe they’re after the orb of destruction,” Oceanus explained.

All the members in the room gasped.

“How can that be?” a fellow member raised up. “Oh, introductions. My name is Elmor Locks. I’m the cohort centurion of the Mystics.”

“The two recent incidents, the culprit and the New York incident, they occured almost simultaneously,” Oceanus clarified.

“Why take information from this school? If they were planning to attack the transfer students, they would’ve done that, so what sort of motive are they up to?” Elmor Locks demanded.

“This is what the meeting is for,” Taskah assured.

“I admit this is a serious matter that must be dealt with quickly,” Captain Levi said.

“Though I have other important matters to attend to, I do agree that this must be resolved,” Elaina Terner stated.

“If they were gathering school intel, it could be for another matter entirely, such as another attempt at reconnaissance,” Oceanus suggested.

“You may be onto something, Oceanus. What if they’ve done their reconnaissance already and they’re preparing for something much grander,” Principal Taskah said.

“What grander thing?” Elaina asked.

“Well, the intel that the culprit had on him was facility layouts and maintenance protocols. What if the enemy is preparing an attack,” Taskah stated.

“An attack? You can’t be serious?” Captain Levi denied.

Before further discussion could commence, a sudden knock on the door to the meeting room startled the members in the room.

“Hmm, what could be urgent that someone would be knocking in the middle of the meeting?” Taskah demanded.

He stood up and strolled slowly to the door. Opening it, he was met with a frantic faculty member who was sweating and panting for breath.

“Whoa, what happened to you?”

“Principal! The school is being attacked!” the faculty guy shouted frantically.

Upon hearing this, the other members stood up.

“How can they do this inbetewen our noses?” Elmor Locks said, clenching his fists.

“No time to waste,” Oceanus gestured.

The members hurried out of the room and headed into the open campus grounds to witness the sight of a sudden blaring attack.

***

So far the experience at Regnum Academy was mostly positive, however, things would take a major change with another encounter with nobility. Unlike Altas who prided in his self-esteem, others found their authority acceptable to abuse others.

Avery, Ted, and the Masumi brothers were heading towards an intriguing sports tournament hosted on a field near the arena when they stumbled upon a group of rich second-years who hogged the path. They had just come from a tour of a few local clubs inside the academic buildings so they were eager for a fresh whiff of air.

The four were casually walking on the right hand of the path passing through tall grass when the rich students halted them.

“Hey you,” one of the rich students, a tall blond haired guy wearing a silver buttoned suit, called out, “Get off the road. Can’t you see that we’re walking through here.”

“You’re welcome to walk on the left side, or your right, and single filely pass us. That’s what we’re doing,” Ken Masumi offered. “Besides, there’s no other place to stand.” He acted very gentlemen-like as he spoke.

“Are you questioning my command? Don’t you see who you’re in the presence of?” the same student retorted. By the authority he pumped out, he was the negotiator and speaker of the group.

Beside the blond haired students stood a black haired female student who looked like she'd say sassy things, but otherwise was extremely beautiful. She wore the school uniform consisting of a maroon long-sleeve sweater and a short skirt. But what made her stand out beside her natural beaty was the extensive amount of jewelry; several earrings, necklaces, and bracelets. Several other guys and girls flocked around her like pigeons to delicious crumbs of bread.

"You heard what my subordinate said," the girl student stated, sure enough in a sassy tone, "Get out of our way."

Avery choked at the sight of another rich entitled snob. "Sorry, but we don't have to obey what you say," he said. He stood beside Ted as to form a barrier.

"So, you've come to pick a fight?" the blond-haired student opposed. "You know that she's the daughter of a council member who governs this district, so you've been warned."

"Whoa, man, that's a hasty generlization," Ted pointed out. "Who cares whether her parents are famous or not, in this school everyone's treated equally."

"Oh I don't think you understand at all," the blond-haired student smirked, "Even in this academy, the main funds are backed up by rich individuals with weath, so swaying to those with the money is only natural. You can get reported for that retortive mouth you've got there."

Avery clenched his fists. "That is so messed up!"

"Oh you feel so entitled? I don't care if you hide behind a richie's coattails," Ted shouted.

"Still, we're not moving. It would be easy for us to back down, so doing it once would only make you guys feel entitled even more," Ken stated. "Come on. Let's go."

Avery, Ted, and Kirk followed Ken's lead. But right as they were shoulder to shoulder with the group as they were passing by, the blond-haired student unsheathed a sword around his weist and pointed it towards the squad.

"I challenge you to a match. Whoever wins get's to tell the loser what to do," he stated, then sheathed his sword.

Ken stopped in his tracks and immediately turned. "You've got a deal!" he gleamed.

"Wait, isn't that a bit hasty?" Avery questioned. "We should think about it before considering…"

“Don’t worry, I won’t miss a chance like this,” Ken replied, padding Avery’s back. Then turning towards the rich students, he suggested, “Why don’t we head to the arena and make full use of it.”

“Suit yourself,” the blond-haired student shrugged. “We’ll be waiting at the arena.”

The group of rich students turned and left the squad to their planning. Apparently the prospect of a battle excited those students as they completely forgot about the entire deal of claims to the road. Battles seemed the only way to settle disputes.

“Are you sure about this? We’d be pitted against seven opponents at once, making it seven versus four,” Avery pleaded, hoping to convince an alternative.

“My brother and I are all in. We won’t lose to a bunch of second year students,” Kirk assured, which sounded unassuring.

“They think they have the upper hand just because of their number and status as second years, but I’ll wipe their cocky grins from their face,” Ken grinned, cracking his knuckles fiercely.

“So, do you guys have a strategy in mind?” Ted asked, having been drawn into the Masumi brothers’ side.

“Yep, we’re going to wing it!” Kirk exclaimed.

The other brother nodded as if he already knew this was the answer.

After discussing a very redimentury plan, the squad continued heading down the road towards the arena at the end of the lake.

Upon arriving, they were greeted by the seven rich students standing at the center of the flat field at the center of the arena. They walked into the center arena and stood a short distance from the opponent to finalize logistics before the battle.

Avery and Ted were surprised to see Charlotte Levy, their magic teacher, standing among the rich students. She didn’t seem to be happy with whatever the blond-haired student told her.

“A teacher happened to be here,” the blond-haired student explained, “so she’ll administer the battle and make it fair. This way you wouldn’t blame us for winning unfairly.”

“That’s such a nice way of being rude,” Ted muttered.

“Now that you’ve arrived,” she announced loudly, “the battle can commence.”

“Isn’t the battle a bit unfair?” Avery observed, pointing to the superior number on the opponents’ side.

“It’s too late to do anything about that, they challenged you and you agreed, regardless of the situation, they are able to have all seven members in the match,” Charlotte Levy explained.

She then strided to the edge of the arena and watched the two groups from a distance.

“Now, the rules are simple: First, each team will stand twenty-five meters away from each other. Second, when I say so, the battle will start. Third, the goal is to either knock out or make all opponent team members yield. And finally, the winner may request anything from the loser.”

Both sides nodded and took their respective positions.

“I’m Lukas Gallery, the captain of the second year team and a member of the Centipedes cohort,” the blond-haired student introduced.

Ted couldn’t help but snicker at the name of his cohort. Avery and the others thought this was amusing too, but they obviously didn’t want show their mockery laughing.

The Masumi brothers were somewhat shocked at the revelation as someone so young was chosen by a cohort, even if it was mediocre.

“It’s not funny by the way,” Lukas stated in irritation. “The centurion of the cohort specifically chose me, of all the talented students.”

He had some sense of pride and wouldn’t even admit himself the funniness in the cohort name.

The girl, who was the life of the party of the rich group, then introduced next, “My name is Bei Renatus. I’m the daughter of District 7 Council Seat Jin Renatus.”

Then the remaining members of the rich student team introduced themselves but their names and personal information were quickly muddled in the mixture of each introduction.

The Masumi brothers were the next to introduce their flare and presence, but the opponents seemed the least bit interested in remembering. Finally Avery and Ted each showed themselves, finally ending the formal greetings and moving onto the start of the match.

The two sides glared at each other for the moment before Charlotte cried, “Go!”

And with that, the battle commenced.

Some of the supporting members on the second-year students team sprinted a wide arc aroumd the arena on either side to confine Avery, Ted, and the Masumi brothers within an enclosed space. The girl, Bei Renatus, and Lukas kept their distance and prepared a ranged attack.

"Man, they're good," Ken admitted, glancing quickly around him and seeing the enemy surrounding their every direction.

With the coordinated movements initiated, the surrounding opponents rushed towards the four all at once. Each rich student surrounded their fists with their representative elemental discharge in order to increase the impact of their blows.

Ted formed metal walls that surrounded the others as Ken lunged into the sky with his conjured flaming wings on his back. "*Fire Magic: Fire Pheonix Magestic Wings*."

Feeling the surge of magic flowing even faster in his body than before, Avery released his light magic and replicated the light barrier from his previous battle. The barrier was tough enough to ricochet two of the rich student's attacks.

The metal barrier dissipated and Kirk shot a spray of fire magic in a circle, making all the rich students retreat backwards, "*Fire Magic: Flamethrower*." He then leapt into the air, snatched his brother's hand, and lunged even higher into the air above everyone else.

"Let's do this!" Both Masumi brothers called as they quickly prepared their next magic attack. "*Fire Combination Magic: Pheonix and Bear Barrage*." The sky then lit with floating orbs of bright fire which benan raining down around the edge of the battlefield. Smoke and dust blew into the air and clouded most of the rich student's focus and view.

The brothers landed next to Avery and Ted after their area of effect attack.

The rich students scattered in the chaos and negotiated for another point of attack. Avery, Ted, and the brothers suspected their formation to be disrupted, however, the confusion seemed to only help in their endeavors.

Suddenly, out of the fog, a blazing lightning arrow pierced through and knocked the brothers back a few memters when they blocked.

The air crackled at the presence of another lightning bolt being prepared by Lukas when the fog cleared. Lukas arched backwards and gave this second arrow a thrust, thus launching it forward. Then enhanced by wind magic from Bei Renatus, the lightning arrow shot faster than before towards the squad.

Lightning plus Wind Magic: Enhanced Lightning Arrow.

Ted prepared a large metal wall that provided cover for the other three, however, the arrow tore through as if it was paper. Taking the blunt of the attack, Ted was flung backwards near the border of the center arena.

The remaining rich students formed a single brigade and rushed towards the remaining standing members.

Feeling the sheer pressure building against them, Avery and the Masumi brothers tensed at the face of the seven rich student second-years.

"Looks like it's time to finish this," Lukas shouted to his team. He formed a smaller bolt of lightning and waved it in the air as a sign to victory.

Forming a small ball of light in his hand, Avery prepared himself for any impending attack. He felt confident that at least his magic would not fail him in the drawing conclusion of the battle.

"Plrooogh!" He prepared to release all his magic attacks but the sudden explosion from the distance caught his and everyone else's attention. He turned and glanced in the direction of the main section of the school.

Smoke was rising from where the main school faculty building was located. Being a good sport he was, Lukas turned in the same direction to see what his opponent was so intently glancing at.

"Is that a good thing or what?' Kirk asked, loud enough for all the contestants to hear.

"Hmm, we'll have to put a rain check on this battle for another day," Lukas admitted and seized his magic.

Charlotte Levy intervened and spoke carefully, "This battle will take a hold. Let the faculty figure out this problem, so be sure to keep your distance."

Then, without another say, she disappeared in a burst of purble flames before a blink of an eye.

Ted, who had suddenly scrambled up from his short dze, scratched his head and fumbled for his bearings. He almost suspected the explosion and fumes from the distance to be some sort of accident made by one of the Masumi brothers.

"If I made such a mess, I'd be a top ranking Mystical Being or the highest rated fugitive," Kirk admitted.

Jokes aside, the two opponents came together and discussed their next objective. Lukas, being the representative of the second years, thought it would be noteworthy for

his resume for him to resolve the current incident. Even being a Centipedes cohort member provided him with certain restrictive rights.

And so, the combined members, totaling eleven, formed a truce and set out to locate the problem.

***

Numerous students fled from the scene of a burning recreation center located next to the main faculty building.

Unlike natural or magic flames, the fire spreading throughout the buildings were excessively overheated and were munching away at the durable aspects of the respective structures.

The flames blazed with a darker hue than typical fires.

Some warnings blared across the school ground but only added to the chaos that ensued. Charlotte Levy, who was at the center of action, used her unique purble flame magic to absorb as much of the other fire as quickly as possible.

“What happened here?” Lukas called to her, rushing into the action.

Annoyed at being distracted, Charlotte replied, “These fires suddenly burst into existence. Most of the faculty and students escaped, but there are a few injured as far as I know. If this keeps up, it could burn the entire school. If you want to help, find or report this aas quickly as possible!”

Taking heed to the call, Lukas sent some of his second-year friends to report on the incident.

Looking about, the group saw the flames continued to envelope the landscape and even the atmosphere in close proximity to the individuals tending to the fire.

Several other faculty and higher-year students with water-based magic attempted to wipe the fire out, but failed without avail.

Avery, Ted, and the Masumi brothers were about to step out of the way when they were suddenly standing before a trio of figures who did not belong at the school.

The head, a crimson-haired individual wearing a sweater and baggy pants, stepped forwards and gawked at the sight. He had a large cylindrical object behind her back and a sword sheathed against his weist.

Avery, who caught sight of his familiar appearance, called out, “It’s Pyrus Bourn!”

Charlotte glanced from the corner of her eye. Ted and the Masumi brothers stood there in awestruckness.

“He’s Pyrus Bourn?” they mumbled.

“Now that I think about it…” the man, named Pyrus Bourn, stepped forward.

Then, pointing at Avery, he gestured, “Haven’t I met you before? Hmm… ah yes… the forest in New York.”

Avery stammered without uttering a single word.

The two subordinates of Pyrus glanced at Avery in confusion as if they had never met him in their life.

“Never met him before,” the one on his left with black hair stated.

“Come on Tony, if the boss says so, that means we must have seen him before,” the other on his right said, slapping Tony’s back.

“Tony Smith, Tom Nado… quit it,” Pyrus barked.

Pyrus Bourn then turned and seeped in the sight of the flames blazing before him.

“Isn’t this splendid? My newest fire increaser product really has a kick to it. The best part is that it requires only a small amount of heat to ignite! Oxygen and mana from the air does the rest, mehaha!”

“What are you talking about?” Ken demanded, rushing in front of his brother, Ted, and Avery.

“Likewise, as I just said,” Pyrus Bourn stated.

He then removed the object from his back which resembled a fire extinguished except it was not.

Having his eyes piqued at the sight of someone interesting, Pyrus then called, “You, in the distance, you must be the famous Charlotte Levy of the Blue Legion cohort, yes? What do you think you are doing to my beloved flames?”

Being called suddenly, Charlotte turned and faced her opponents. “So, you’re Pyrus Bourn. What reason do you have to come here and make such a mess?”

This was the first time most of the students experienced her raised tone.

“I’m looking for something in particular, but if I must, someone,” Pyrus stated.

“What do you want? How did you even get into this school?” Charlotte demanded.

"Oh I planned accordingly," Pyrus confessed. "It so happened that a recent incident has caused this school to be on the defensive. I just seized the moment and came when the level of security was at its weakest. Getting in was the easy part, thanks to this fire increaser, hehe."

Realizing the identity of this foe, the nearby students and faculty went on the offense and prepared for any attack.

"You're higher ups are having their private meeting, are they not? It'll be too late when they find out and I should be wrapped up here when they arrive," Pyrus explained openly.

"How could you know their meeting time?" Charlotte questioned.

Pyrus smirked, "Heh, it was all really too easy. I happened to have information on file, of course."

"I thought Atlas had the culprit with leaked info caught."

"Well that's just the thing. It was carefully considered," Pyrus hinted. "I'm not here to enjoy myself. I'll be open about this. I'm here for the earth orb, and you, Charlotte Levy, know something about it, don't you."

Charlotte paused suddenly, indicating that she was aware of what he spoke of.

"I'm surprised someone like you can uncover information so maticulously like that," she complimented, "but you will have to get through me if you want information."

"That's too bad. I was hoping you'd be more sensible," Pyrus said disappointedly.

Leaping over the squad, Charlotte landed before Pyrus and took him head on. Enveloping her straight hands with purple flames, her flat fingers and palm, like blades, stabbed at Pyrus in quick succession.

With his keen sight being his only aid, Pyrus bent his body and dodged every single attack with ease. He stepped backwards after a moment of flexing and unsheathed his sword. It was an ordinary katana that lacked cleanliness.

Holding her hands together, Charlotte inverted most of her magic between her fingsers and released a small beam of purple flames towards Pyrus' feet. "*Dark Magic: Purple Fire Beam*."

Holding his sword before him and then aiming it downwards to ricoche the beam as it approached, Pyrus indicated his weapon wasn't just for show. Pressing the front of his shoes into the concrete ground, he lunged forwards with tremendous speed.

Using her flaming hands, Charlotte managed to grap the sword blade with both hands as it arched down at her. Her shoes dug into the concrete as cracks began forming, indicating the sheer force Pyrus applied on his weapon.

Several more exchanges of blows occurred but meither landed a direct hit on each other. To many of the students' surprise, Pyrus hadn't even shown any magic power, if he had any at all.

They were both comparable in skills and reflexes, but even though Charlotte possessed magic power, Pyrus Bourn showed his true power via his expertise in his swordsmanship.

Avery and the others were worried about the outcome of the battle yet they knew there was nothing they could do about it. Though it would've been feasible for intruders and the school to engage in battle with each other, more chaos would only result, so both parties kept their attention focused on the current battle between their leaders.

Getting agitated at the stalemate, Charlotte released more of her magic and formed dozens of small flame orbs that shot towards Pyrus.

Gleaming at the sight of a harder obstacle, Pyrus deflected all the projectiles with rapid swipes of his sword. HIs sword speed was only getting faster with each flame orb he cut through.

The battle seemed almost too inhuman as the two progressively pranced around the battlefield avoiding attacks and forming new ones. Their speed and agility were as quick as an active car on a highway.

Darting back and forth, Pyrus landed a few swipes that formed varying deep cuts on Charlotte's arms and legs. He then kicked her into the ground, creating a thud and more rubble to fly into the air.

Charlotte briskly stood up, some blood on her forehead. She parried invisible gusts of wind blades created when Pyrus swiped the air with superhuman strength. Clenching both her fists and compressing her magic, dashed behind Pyrus with brighter purble flames and impaled him in the back with force comparable to his own.

He was thrown into the air from the blow, but was able to catch himself against the wall of the flaming faculty building. Leaping off of it, he aimed his next attack under her feet, thus successfully tripping her. Refusing to be broken so easily, she performed a backflip and sustained her balance but lost her momentum.

After taking blows on both sides, the two stopped to catch their breath before a final assault. Pyrus stood tall and collected, waving his sword beside him and instantly shooting the blood and grime off the blade. Charlotte had her hands against her knees, panting with exhaustion.

Though the squad were all thinking the same thing, Avery and Ted were hesitant to engage, but the Masumi brothers made no effort rushing in and standing before their teacher.

Tom Nado walked up beside Pyrus and raised his hand. Then a large gust of wind pushed the brothers and Charlotte backwards and pinned them to the ground.

"I think that's quite enough, boss," he insisted. Then with a flick of his hand, transparent silver chains surrounded Charlotte's body. She was raised by a mini-tornado and was transported next to Pyrus.

Wind Magic: Mini-Tornado.

"Fair point," Pyrus nodded.

Turning to the students from a distance, he stated, "Know well that I am Pyrus Bourn!"

Tony Smith stomped the ground causing the concrete floor to erupt at such a speed that it shot the villains, and the captured Charlotte, several hundred memters above the school. "*Earth Magic: Rumble Thrust*."

Ken Masamnune lept into the air on his flaming wings and chased after the trio of villains. Kirk followed suit by enhancing his feet with flame magic and leaping into the air while boosted by the combustion of flames. "*Fire Magic: Fire Blaring Feet*."

Gaining more distance, the enemy only ensured their escape route.

Aiming his powers intently, Ted created small metal rods and shot them upwards towards the enemy.

Metal Magic: Metal Rods.

Feeling that he had almost reached a new discovery, Avery formed a light sphere in his hand and thrusted it upwards. "*Light Magic: Lux Sphere*." It successfully left his hand and held its form as it traveled faster than the other projectile and the Masumi brothers.

The light ball impaled Pyrus in the shoulder, thus causing him to wince, however he remained absolutely expressionless.

Tom Nodo formed a large tornado to catch his comrades and the prisoner.

Wind Magic: Super Tornado.

The winds circulating the tornado were strong enough to flip the trajectories of Ted's metal rods and both Masumi brothers as they approached.

Whirling the tornado about, even the surrounding clouds seemed to get sucked in and pushed aside as the tornado tore through the sky at almost mach one speed. In a moment's glance, the trio were only a small spec in the horizon.

In whatever disarray, even the grand holographic defense around the city stood little to no chance to the trio's speed, piercing through the holographic barrier.

Both Masumi brothers managed to land onto the ground with their limbs intact and uninjured. The enemy were long gone, so no actions could be performed.

"We couldn't even do anything!" Ted shouted in frustration.

The Masumi brothers kept their heads bent in agreement.

Scratching his hand lightly, Avery felt a certain numbness in his hand after throwing the light attack. He felt unsatisfied that such progress meant nothing still.

Several other students and faculty arrived to only witness the aftermth of the battle that ensued. Among them were the members engaged in the secret faculty meeting.

Lukas had arrived escorting the head of the school and the three founders of the school plus a few of the other cohort centurions. Several other students followed the important individuals to witness the scene for themselves and the faculty were too bothered by the issue to tell them to lay off.

It was a relief that no other places were lit aflame as Pyrus Bourn's sole purpose of his visit was a blessing to the curse. Not all the individuals arriving were as serious as the members who watched the fight.

"Qukckly gather as many water affinity Mystial Beings as you can!" Principal Taskah waved to the standing students and faculty who were gawking at the two burning buildings. Most of them immediately left at the command of their principal.

Walking and analysing about, Taskah rushed towards Avery, Ted, and the Masumi brothers, the specific individuals who engaged partially in the battle and were covered with evidence in the form of ash, dust, and grime.

"Though it is not as urgent right now, I will need you all to tell me what happened," Taskah informed the four as he padded Avery and Ted's shoulders.

"Pyrus Bourn came demanding for the earth orb and then took Teacher Charlotte Levy captive. Supposedly she knew something about it," Ken Masumi explained briefly.

"This is serious indeed," Elmor Locks stated, walking over while overhearing the conversation. He made his greeting before the four members and then stood a few meters from the faculty building. Raising a hand in the air, he began at work to quench the fire between his formed wind magic. "*Wind Magic: Emperor's Wrestling*."

"To think that this place could so easily be invaded!" Taskah shouted, clenching his fists. He examined the two academic buildings and became teary-eyed.

"Analysing it, it was our mistake to have defenses so weak at a time as this," Oceanus Aquia stated, walking up to the faculty building. He bent down and touched the ash remnants of the ruin.

"Hmm… seems like it was runecrafted fire magic of some sort," he examined.

"I can't believe we were all fooled by the schemes of some person whom we least expected," Elaina Terner said gravely.

"Yes, though it is to our benefit to conceal this matter and resolve it with a select few, it is to the public's best interest that we relate this to everyone. Countermeasures must be taken in place. This school's reputation should not be the result of our mistakes," Taskah announced.

The other faculty agreed.

Oceanus turned and then walked up the four members of the battle.

Making eye contact, Avery Obtainia and Oceanus Aquia made eye contact with each other for a moment in shock.

"It's you…" both said at once.

Avery thought he'd never see him again. It was the first time he'd encountered the same man, who apparently was Oceanus Aquia, after three long years.

Chapter 12: The Rune's Power

"You're the same man I met three years ago, right?" Avery asked, walking closer towards Oceanus Aquia. A few of the other faculty members and students turned their attention onto the two.

"Yes, to think I'd see you this soon and on the island of all places," Oceanus remarked, rubbing his chin. "So, you're Avery Obtainia, the same boy who was in the recent New York incident. And the Mystical Magic I sensed within you back then was actually Angelor magic instead of... hmm, nevermind."

"That's right. So, that's why you proposed I should attend OSNYC. You knew that I was a Mystical Being to begin with!" Avery exclaimed.

"Precisely. Back then, I was limited in my interactions with outside-island folks, so I'm sorry that I couldn't be up front," he confessed.

"Hey, no worries. It's not like it would've changed my life that much," Avery said. "Still...," Avery continued in a more serious tone, "why did you help someone like me back then?"

"Back then, I just sensed that you'd benefitted from the small gesture, after all, you possessed considerall raw talent that wuld only be developed in a setting like OSNYC and now here," he replied.

Then Oceanus turned and examined the wreckage.

"Knowking that you weren't targetted in this attack is assuring, but does complicate our carefully-examined understanding of the enemy's intentions. You will have to tell us what you witnessed a moment ago," he explained.

Shortly after the faculty and students remained idle, the reinforcements led by the students instructed by the principal arrived at the scene.

Avery, Ted, and the Masumi brothers gasped as they gazed upon the thirty or so students grouped together. They were not only the water affinity students, but also some of the second and third year students.

Avery suspected River would be a part of the group yet he was disappointed when she wasn't among them. He began to wonder what River and Jane were up to during the attack.

"Good, you've all arrived," Taskah greeted. Turning, he walked over to the group walking towards the main faculty building.

One of the students, a tall blue haired girl, stepped from the group and announced, "How may we pledge our services? It was our careless actions that made us unaware of the sudden invasion!"

"Thank you for coming as quickly as you can. You are Flustra, right?" Taskah said.

The girl, named Flustra, a close subordinate of Altas Aquia, nodded and turned to the other students. "Alright, our roles are simple: use medium water and extinguish the remaining fire and fumes you see from the two buildings here."

With a quick response of affirmation, the other students got to work.

Flustra, being the only one not going in, bowed her head before the principal. "Sorry again, principal, for our lack of diligence!"

"It's quite alright," the principal responded, shaking his hands. "Today happened to be an important meeting and I know most of the faculty were busy with other matters. Plus, you students were enjoying your time with other matters. It's our missjudgment that the enemy would attack the front and when the school was at its weakest."f

Gesturing for her to leave, the principal went back to the other faculty members and the founding members Captain Levi and Elaina Turner who were in a conversation with the unscathed facutly members working in the building before the attack.

Gaining their attention, the principal then ushered the members part of the prior meeting and Avery, Ted, and the Masumi brothers to a secondary building nearest to their location where they would discuss matters in private.

The four students took turns explaining the fight they witnessed and the demands of Pyrus Bourn.

After understanding the situation, the four were excused and allowed to proceed with their "normal" school day, which was quite difficult after such an irreversible event.

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"It's too bad we can't do anything," Ted admitted, sludging his feet against the sidewalk as the four proceeded in the direction of the dormitory.

"Given the situation, I don't know what we can do," Avery stated in a rather unfazed tone.

"I'm sure when the other cohort centurions come back, they'll make some sort of plan of either retrieving our teacher back or figure out the bottom of this problem," Ken Masumi stated.

Usually cheery and always in the midst of a juicy conversation, the four, with nothing else to say, parted ways upon arriving at the dorms.

Getting used to navigating the swirly halls, Avery and Ted found their way back to Quad 44. Seeing the common room empty and too peaceful, the duo decided to indulge in their own hobbies.

Ted continued on his mechanical project which was steadily growing in size but still messy and complicated as always. Avery was curious of what it would result in as all he noticed at this point were wires, a long metal board, and littered screws around the floor—the complete project steering away from any direction of completeness.

Avery trudged into his room and slumped onto his cozy bed. Not really sure what to do the rest of the afternoon, he decided a bit of thinking and sleeping would calm his nerves before dinner.

His head partially buried in his pillow, Avery noticed the round golden halo on his desk next to the bed.

Standing up, he picked up the rune and examined it. With a small release of magic, the rune began glowing brightly with the same golden aura as previously.

"I still don't get why this resonates with me only," he muttered. "Perhaps I should ask someone about it."

Avery then began contemplating in his usual manner for a few moments. Without realizing it, the rune gripped in his hand began humming with energy. With a sudden shock of its vibrating feel, Avery let go of natural instinct.

Instead of dropping to the ground as any normal object would, the rune twirled and remained afloat in midair like a vertical disk.

Unsecure of this new revelation, Avery backed up for the rune to follow and remain afloat. Doubting the realness of its weird behavior, he examined his room for the source of its power, but found nothing.

Instead, closing his eyes, he could feel his magic flowing throughout his body faster than ever. Like the same sensation of strange nocturnal surplus of energy, he could feel the sheer amount of magic within his body that was ready to be released.

Approaching the rune, Avery touched it again and felt vibrating energy within. *Could this be my energy flowing within it? I mean I was the only one who touched it*, he thought.

Suspecting it could be manipulated in some way, Avery intently concentrated on shifting its movement. With a thought of rising higher, the rune suddenly rose higher off the ground, to Avery's amazement.

"This is really something else!" he admitted with a bit too loud of a volume.

Eager to learn its true potential, he began testing the rune with numerous focused actions.

Unlike releasing magic from within his own body, every command to the rune did not deplete any noticeable amount of magic power yet he could feel his magic circulating from within the rune and around his body as both were anchored together.

With other subsequent tests, he was able to master basic movements within a certain radius around him, twirling and top-speed rotations, and various orientations (though he couldn't find any uses).

Gasping with another brilliant idea, Avery placed a foot on the rune. It did not budge nor rotate by the newly added weight. After placing one foot, he shifted his full weight on the rune by stepping on with the other foot. The rune was a bit smaller than a frisbee, so balancing on was a bit difficult.

Focusing on basic movements, he realized the rune was able to support his weight but it required more mental focus to remain concentrated. He also felt more muscle power was involved in applying sufficient speed into the rune.

After ten minutes or so, he was confident with basic gliding movements around his room.

He was astonished with the capabilities he discovered and thought that life would become more interesting with the rune. Not a genius in the long shot, he still thought of numerous tests he could conduct to test its potential, such as applying more speed, magic, or techniques.

Now that he applied sufficient magic enough to wake the rune, he didn't know how to release its magic. After numerous failures to release the rune, Avery gave up and acknowledged the rune as a permanent member of his arsenal.

Upon hearing the main quad door opening and slamming, Avery exited the room to greet the other roommates. The rune, as usual now, followed his every movement. Thinking it less conspicuous, he kept the rune floating behind his back.

River and Jane entered the common-room still wearing their school uniforms. Aside from their solemn expressions, they were impacted by the recent incident.

Ted, who was focused on his project the entire time, stood up after pressing a few buttons and releasing smoke into the room. Waving at the two arrivers in his usually swaggy manner, he greeted them as if he hadn't been fazed at all.

"So, I take it you guys heard about the recent attack on the school," Avery spoke, initiating the conversation.

Jane tossed her book bag onto a sofa and stretched her arms. "I heard about it alright. News spread fast. Luckily River and I were checking out the city and purchasing snacks when it all took place."

Ted's expression popped. He couldn't believe that his own friends went snack shopping without inviting him. "Guess you had fun," he said with jealousy.

"Oh we had so much fun without you," Jane replied sarcastically, taking note of Ted's obvious facial expression.

Then there was a moment of silence, something typical among the four at this point.

River, who was easily able to hide her presence, pointed behind Avery and asked, "What is the rune behind your back?"

Ted and Jane glanced and noticed the floating rune behind Avery.

"I'd figured you guys would ask about it," Avery stated, scratching his head. "Honestly, I don't even know myself. I guess the word for it is that when I accidentally put magic into it, it resonated and became controllable. There seems to be no deactivation or anything…"

Confident with his skills, Avery leaped into the air. The rune then instantly flew and rotated horizontally below his feet to catch him above the ground.

Avery then began gliding higher and faster around the perimeter of the common room; since the volume was larger than his dorm room, he could concentrate more on speed and elevation.

Twirling around a few times, he leapt off and landed on the ground. Then the rune flew above his out-stretched right palm.

“Perhaps you guys may explain what this rune is?” Avery inquired.

Having seen the rune before and not knowing an answer before, River shook her head and said nothing.

“The other thing I forgot to mention is that this rune seems to only take in my magic, not anyone else's, based on the behavior,” Avery added.

Jane stepped closer and glanced at the rune. She rubbed her finger along the rim and pressed on the strange inscription indentations around the halo.

“I’m no runecrafting expert, but I can say that what you’ve got here is certainly a unique object, possibly an artifact,” she stated.

“An artifact?”

“That’s right. Unlike regular runes created today, artifacts are usually runes crafted from rarer materials and old, usually forgotten, runecrafting techniques. The behavior of magic can change substantially given the methods of crafting the medium.”

“Sounds complicated.”

“Well, runecrafting is a whole other beast. The entry classes are usually second year level, given the sheer complexities. It goes over my head, so that’s why I only know the basic background around it,” Jane remarked.

“Well, they never taught or mentioned to us runecrafting at OSNYC,” Ted complained. “I’ve been taking a few lessons from one of my buddies about applying runecrafting onto this new invention of mine!”

Avery could almost imagine that that buddy was no other than Ken Masumi, who shared many similarities with Ted.

“Given the shape, I’d guess you could apply even more magic,” Jane stated, circling her hand around the rim.

“More magic? Are you sure about that?” Avery warned cautiously.

“It’s not like it's going to blow up or anything, just give it a try.”

Grasping the rune with his hand, Avery’s hand began glowing brightly in a pure white light as he channeled as much magic he could muster into the rune. Feeling a slight burn from the humming rune, Avery let go and watched as the rune unlocked a new behavior.

The rune rotated vertically, and floated above Avery’s head like the halo of an angel. Golden light began illuminating from it and spread throughout the entire room.

Not really sure what exactly happened, Avery scanned the room and realized his senses were sharper and more aware.

"That's interesting!" he exclaimed, shaking his head. Looking closely at the three others and himself, he could feel the surge of magic aura around them. Concentrating even harder, he could sense the varying of the pulses, indicating each individual's unique magic presence.

"So, what exactly happened?" Ted inquired.

"Well, it feels like my senses are sharper. Also, I feel that I could comprehend mine and others' magic signatures.

"Ted, your magic is dense and humming with power."

Ted gave a cheeky grin and gave a thumbs up. "Yep, my magic is strong as steel!"

"Jane's magic feels calm and concentrated."

Jane gave no remark, but remained calm as if aware the description matched perfectly.

"River, your magic flows with a strong surge."

"Really?" she responded rather surprised. "I mean, you did get it right."

"I guess in general, with this amount of info, I could identify the basic elements of magic or something, but it requires me to have prior knowledge of who they correspond with," Avery concluded.

"Sounds like a rare sensor-type rune," Jane explained. "Given the descriptions you gave, you were able to perceive the feeling of magic that others' experience. The affinity of one's magic defines the behavior of the magic and its radiating feeling when sensed by others."

"That's all news to me," Avery said. "So, what's the use anyway?"

"Oh there's all sorts of things!" Ted exclaimed. "Sensing magic is almost like thermal vision or a sixth sense compass!"

"Yeah, I suppose what he said," Jane nodded in agreement. "Given the type of rune, what you have far outclasses some of the best runes of today's era. Wherever you got it, it must have had a history."

Smiling shyly, Avery nodded, "I did find it in an old cabin anyway, so perhaps it really was something from a hundred years or something."

Thinking back on his journey so far, Avery suspected the discovery of the rune's abilities were largely due to his personal magic growth and mana capacity increase. After practicing creating light orbs, his mana was at least ten times greater than the previous fight against the shadow cult member.

"By the way," Ted piped in, "That hovering with the rune of yours won't beat what I've been working on."

"And what's that?" Avery asked, perplexed.

"Hehe, I'm not telling quite yet…" Ted responded.

Without another comment to add, the four decided to do their own things until the evening.

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Pyrus Bourn returned to his lair in triumph. With Charlotte Levy captured, he was one step closer to achieving his goals.

Though he only needed her momentarily for interrogation, he suspected that releasing her would cause too many complications, especially ones that would foil his plans already set in motion.

With numerous employees deployed at various sections of his lair and factory, he was able to set up guards with shift rotations. One of his newest subordinates, named Ellie Tracey, a red haired woman, had cruel interrogation methods yet clever tactics capable of making most hostages yield secrets.

Unlike political affairs of the mainland countries, the cities on the Mystical Island ran mostly independently and governed to their own discretion. Pyrus Bourn, being the owner of District 3, was able to maintain a small society in independence so long as his meddling with other cities were at a minimum. When describing minimum, no district could keep trades or competition under fair regulation. At best, a district would remain neutral when other districts waged secret battles with each other.

Being someone who worked in the shadows and remained neutral while supplying arms for other districts, Pyrus Bourn had set a reputable lifestyle for himself. Most of his strength remained dependent on his constant monitoring of the other districts and interfering if the right chance popped up. Sometimes, in the case of the hostage

capturing, risky precautions were necessary to continue the expansion of his district and influence.

Charlotte Levy, even at her unparalleled strength, stood no chance against the ruler of District 3 who didn't even utilize magic against her during their duel. She was kept inside a secure cell made of steel and guarded by two employees immediately on her arrival into the volcano district.

After a few hours since her capture, Pyrus Bourn and his three closest subordinates arrived and casually entered her cell for the first interrogation.

Tom Nado and Tony Smith, the two subordinates on the hostage heist, stood at the entrance and kept the interior guard. The pair lugged a large round barrel into the room.

Ellie Tracey approached the prisoner alongside Pyrus Bourn. The steel bars of the cell door slammed against the clasps of the wall, indicating no hope of escape.

The cell was nothing short of boring. Though it was clean and constructed in a unique medieval style, it lacked the vibrant colors of a majestic castle. Being a meticulous type, Pyrus left most of the construction plans for himself, even if it was a huge hassle.

"What's your deal?" Charlotte barked in her usual teacher tone. She sat on a fanciless prisoner's bed with her legs crossed. Having her arms still folded, she had been looking at the ceiling prior to the gang's arrival.

Without much delay, Tom and Tony dragged the barrel a few meters before her. Pyrus Bourn sat down on it and stared intently at her. To no surprise, the barrel was a Fire Increaser Co. labeled barrel containing the dangerous substance of the same name.

"Usually I tend to keep to myself, but drastic measures had to be taken," Pyrus spoke valianty. "It was difficult waiting for a long time, but now that I have, it was well worth it."

"Lux Urbis is heavily secure. How did you even manage to get through?" Charlotte inquired.

Gesturing his hands to express his same surprised expression, Pyrus replied, "It was quite easy. The news of the shadow cult's recent surfacing caused most of the districts to get in a tizzy. I could always travel to and from the island as I pleased, but this sudden opportunity created a path for me to sneak into the city quite easily. As for IT's safe dome around the city, it was quite easy to exit since magic is ejected outwards, the same direction as we planned on exiting. Entry was call for concern but we managed."

“I’m sure with your flashing exit that District 7 may start invading this place,” Ellie Tracey stated. Tossing her hair, she exemplified an ideal manager, yet her open opinions made her hard to handle but too valuable to discard. “The great Pyro who used to be quite comedic in the past but recently became a bit too serious. Oh well, at least small stunts like that still show that you’ll remain the same old person we’ve known for a long time.”

“Well, boss always wanted to be known, hehe,” Tony Smith added from behind.

Pyro clenched his teeth and tensed up as if ready to strike. “What’s that have to do with this situation now?” he protested.

Then, calming down, he stated, “I used to be a fool, that’s all. Given the situation I was in, it was better to leave as quickly as possible to avoid the potential arrival of the higher ups of the school. With the chaos I’ve caused, the school… no, the whole city is in a tight dilemma. Amassing forces and attacking another district is the last thing they’d do.”

“You had the chance to cause even more chaos, yet you came and only captured me. What sort of ploy are you getting to?” Charlotte demanded.

“I’m not the sort of insane person who only seeks pleasure in destruction.”

“You, Charlotte, are the only known living person currently who has studied shadow and forbidden magic. Knowing that you’d most likely not answer up front, we captured you in hopes of getting information,” Ellie Tracey confronted.

“Oh, is that all? My response depends on what you seek but getting knowledge of forbidden magic will not be permissible,” Charlotte responded.

“I’m looking for a rune… more specifically, a rune of the Angelor lost for over a century. Tell me what you know about it?” Pyrus inquired impatiently.

“Is that all? Humph. You sure went to all this trouble just for questions regarding that?” Charlotte responded in disbelief.

“Well, it’s strictly tied to events too confidential for the general public to be expressed widely, especially the finer details.”

“How could you possibly know that?” Charlotte demanded.

“Now, now, I’m doing the questions here. All I can answer is that I have my methods. So, tell me what you know?” Pyrus insisted.

“If you really need an answer, I can give it to you,” Charlotte responded openly. “It’s not like it would be of any use to you anyway. What you are referring to is the Rune of the Spellcaster, a mysterious runecrafted artifact passed down from the Angelor line. Supposedly it has the power to identify every Mystical Beings’ unique magic signatures. Though I can’t see what you’re looking for as the rune has been lost for eons.”

“It seems you don’t know quite about it after all,” Pyrus stated sharply. “So, those kids at the cabin rummagnged through things after all. Shoulda known.”

“I only know what I’ve researched. The rune is a mysterious relic of history that we may never get to learn more of.”

“What’s its appearance?”

“Nothing special, just a round golden halo with small inscriptions.”

“I see,” Prysu rubbed his chin. He greened at a sudden flashback of the cabin in the forest and the prospects of a sudden realization. “So, the whole time, I was looking for something without a clue of its appearance.”

“You remember something?” Ellie inquired, looking at the gleaming expression of her boss.

“Turns out I may know where the rune is after all,” Pyrus exclaimed.

“What? how?” Charlotte spoke startledly.

“For the past few years, I’ve been investigating the history of this island’s founding and the background of the past founding individuals. Ha, it turns out that remnants of the past prior to their known history still remain in the mainland, including, apparently, an event prior which might’ve altered the course of Mystical history to the current age,” Pyrus stated.

“What could you possibly use it for? Only an Angelor’s magic can even get it working,” Charlotte said.

“It’s not the rune necessarily,” Pyrus explained, “It’s the power it leads to.”

“Power it leads to? You don’t actually believe…?” Charlotte began.

“Of course I do,” Pyrus interrupted. “Otherwise it wouldn’t be fables. William Luces was always a brilliant and analytical man, getting into things he shouldn’t, especially as a mere non-Mystical. I happen to uncovner some of his notes that even the modern city would covet as a historical object.”

"Go ahead, chase after a fabled rune if you like," Charlotte spoke, foldinger her arms. She didn't want to look concerned to Pyrus Bourn's sudden reveal of well-known but lost ancient relics.

Then standing up, he stated, "I've got the answer that I was looking for. Turns out I already knew it all along. If there isn't anything else you'd disclose then I think we're done here."

As the subordinate duo opened the cell door to lead Pyrus and Ellie Tracey out, Charlotte stood and demanded, "What do you plan to do with me now?"

Turning around, he spoke shortly, "Nothing. You'll be here for a little bit but you will be treated hospitably. I'm sure someone will come looking for you, that is."

Exiting the cell and passing through a corridor, Pyrus eagerly sought his next objective. Tom Nado, Tony Smith, and Ellie Tracey trailed him with intrigued expressions.

"What's the plan now, boss? We very well can't barge into the city again," Tom Nado inquired.

"Knowing where it is now, I'm not in a rush. Buying time from the shadows should suffice for the meantime until an opportunity rises," responded Pyrus in a rather optimistic mood.

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It had only been a few hours since Pyrus Bourn's invasion into the school. By evening, word had already spread to every student about the recent incident and new procautions were established to keep the students on guard and likewise protected.

Stressing about the situation, however, only lasted temporarily as knowledge about a certain someone's arrival caught the attention of everyone. If IT was famous in the mainlands, then determining their influence on the Mystical World was almost laughable. The school's security system was quickly resolved shortly after the incident, proving the level of efficiency of prioritized task completions.

Cheers and gossip spread quickly throughout the school when word of Kaden Icelander's arrival was announced. Since the front entrance of the school was under repair and monitored by stationary guards, the rich prodigy entered the school on the westside where the academic institutes and dining hall were located.

Stepping out of his black limo and briskly brushing past security where, normally, students would be inspected upon entry, Kaden darted in the direction of an academic building where the higher ups were gathered. His cold, yet powerful, aura caused all students around him to keep a distance and respectfully gaze upon his presence – a perk that always eased access and personal space.

In the past week, Kaden was busy with various business tasks as part of his role at IT. When sudden news arrived to him regarding the recent school invasion, he, being close to the island, rushed there in the fastest means he possessed: a jet. And so, the arrival on the school grounds would ensure he'd get the direct info on the incident.

While following the central lake hurrying to his desired destination, Kaden suddenly stopped upon the sudden encounter with a few familiar faces. Perking up, he thought it might be far suitable to inquire with them about the recent news.

Avery and his quad members River, Jane, and Ted, along with the Masumi brothers, were slowly trudging their way to the dining hall for dinner. It was difficult keeping a lighthearted expression after leaving the dorms and seeing the disarray of the island's most prestigious school.

Upon seeing Kaden Icelander, the students stopped in their tracks.

"Kaden…?" Avery began, jaw dropped.

"Huh? The Kaden…?" Kirk Masumi remakes.

"Shhh! Dummy, be more respectful when in the presence of the supreme one," Ken hushed.

Overheating, Kaden smirked and responded calmly, "No need to talk formalities, you're talking to Kaden the civilian here."

Both brothers have a sigh of relief as if they had been holding in all their anxieties.

Perplexed to see the young prodigy in person, Ted simply stood there examining and determining the next hundred questions he'd ask. "So," he piped in, "How did you construct your towers all around the world?"

Kaden gave a sly smile and replied, "It's top secret."

Then, as a formality, he shook the five students' hands. The Masumi brothers each held in their squeals of delight meeting the famous one in person.

"What brings you here?" Avery asked, aware that Kaden wouldn't be anywhere just for the pleasantries.

“Small business trip, anyway, what exactly happened to this place?” Kaden responded, expressing great interest in the recent incident.

Avery, Ted, Ken, and Kirk explained the basic run-down version of the entire events which took place. Nodding expectantly, Kaden said as easily able to absorb and comprehend the large amount of info.

“I see. So that’s what occurred,” he said at last. “I can’t stay idle while my mentor remains in peril.”

“Your mentor? Charlotte Levy, that strict teacher?” Ted glossed.

“She did what I’d do in the same situation. But, what puzzles me is why Pyris Bourn would need her,” Kaden began observing.

“So, what should be done now that the city’s on high alert?” Ken inquired. “She was a great teacher with invaluable experiences yet the school won’t make any motion to save her.”

“Well, they can’t,” Kaden explained, “Barging into other territories openly may cause a war to stir.”

“Seriously?” Ted stated. “ Looks like it’s a big ‘bruh’ moment.”

“That’s a way of putting it,” Kaden remarked. “Regardless of that, I’m intent on saving her myself if I have to.”

“But you said there could be a war…!” Ken stated.

Kaden brushed the statement aside and confirmed, “I’m not going to announce myself. I’ll sneak in but some support would be good. However, to stay clear from danger, my orders must be followed to the letter.”

Avery, River, and Jane didn’t find the proposition too pleasing.

“It shouldn’t be too hard?” he gestured expectantly.

“Knowing that the great Kaden Icelander is leading it will ensure our safety,” Kirk announced, confirming his stance on the proposal.

“Infiltrating Pyrus’ lair might be the only best lead,” Kaden stated, “It may bring an end to the suspicious activities rumored to have spread quickly.”

“Sounds like this event will resolve to be more than a simple rescue mission,” Ted said.

Chapter 13: Choices

"So, are you guys in or not?" Kaden asked Avery, Ted, the Masumi brothers, River and Jane. His tone and the matter-of-a-fact voice indicated he wanted a final verdict there and then and as quickly as possible.

"What can we even do? The last time we were face to face with Pyrus Bourn, we stood no chance!" Avery retorted doubtfully.

"I'm intent on invading Pyrus Bourn's lair whether you guys join or not. Sure it may be risky, but the plan I've devised does not require confrontation with him," Kaden explained.

"Given his strength, this plan of yours sounds like suicide," Jane Tee protested in addition.

"We didn't even hear the plan, you guys. Can't we at least hear it out?" Ted suggested. The Masumi brothers nodded in agreement. There went three votes against the sound judgement.

Given the odds against them, Avery also nodded. Realizing even if he himself declined, a few of his friends were still intent on helping which ultimately would only make him feel guilt. "What will you do?" he asked River and Jane, who were also deep in thought.

"I don't know," River admitted.

"Well, the way you put it, I suppose it's the best action to take right now. I'll help out as much as I can, but I am doing this because there are no other alternatives available," Jane confessed adbruptly.

"I'll help too," River decided. Though it wasn't a part of her personality, she also didn't want to be left out.

"Good. I'm glad to find capable hands for this task. I'll go ahead and begin explaining the methods of infiltration," Kaden summoned up.

Finding the open air displeasing, he gestured the group to come into an empty classroom on the base floor of a neighboring academic building. The room they entered

was a chemistry lab with utility equipment, expensive microscopes, and chemicals scattered throughout shelves, walls, and other obscure places.

Though the classroom was glistering clean, it was still a bit stuffy from the recent atmospheric temperature increase. The seven teens gathered around a single lab table and began quickly exchanging info such as names, contacts, and magical powers.

Kaden, being the lead operator of the mission, cleared his throat and rallied everyone's attention. "Alright everyone, the plan for infiltrating Pyrus Bourn's volcanic lair is pretty simple: we'll wing it," he announced.

The others jumped at the unexpected decision.

"Well, to be specific, most of it would be acting on circumstances. Given this is technically a district invasion, I can't buy IT equipment or hire IT operatives to make this task any easier. From conducting some basic surveying through hacking, I do understand the basic lay of Pyrus' lair and the number of opponents we'd be up against," he explained.

"So, what are our chances of success?" Avery asked. The others nodded for a response on the same question.

"Ah yes, that's accounted for," Kaden assured confidently. "Most of the district is composed of regular factory workers, families, and low-staffed security guards. The ones to be most worried about are Pyrus Bourn himself, a fire increser maniac who is apparently very skilled with the sword, Tom Nado, his right hand man capable of manipulating intense winds, Tony Smith, his left hand man with rock affinity, and Ellie Tracey, a subordinate who is talented in electricity magic."

"Avoiding them would only require us to knock out the small fries, huh?" Ken Masumi confirmed. "But doesn't that lose most of the thrill?" he added, clearly disappointed he wouldn't participate in a far dangerous adventure.

"Finding the higher ups and challenging them will have no warranty if you lose," Jane pointed out.

"Yeah, you're right," Ken admitted.

"Don't worry bro, though I would agree with you, I believe saving our teacher is most important," Kirk encouraged.

"Why are you intent on saving Teacher Charlotte Levy?" Jane inquired Kaden.

"She was my mentor and I owe her for what I know today."

"Hmm, I see. Then let's get her back."

"Yes, I thank you for your… I mean all of your support," Kaden acknowledged. "Get the most important belongings which would aid you and meet me at the gate where I entered in thirty minutes."

Without another word or glance, Kaden strided out the room.

Everyone sighed having the pressure being lifted from their shoulders. Though it was easy to talk, no one could retain full focus being in the presence of the legendary young prodigy Kaden Icelander himself. Avery was less tense than the others, but he still remained uneasy due to his lack of confidence in his skills.

"I wish I could've met Kaden Icelander in a normal situation. I hope I don't disappoint him when going through with all this," Kirk stated in a mellow tone.

"We feel the same way," Ken patted his brother's back.

"He seems to be on edge about something, or maybe I'm wrong," Jane pointed out.

"If he's certain his plan can be fulfilled safely, let's just go ahead and get prepared. Not like we have anything productive to do anyway. In fact, I could try out some of my newest inventions," Ted remarked.

"That sounds… intriguing. But should we be leaving the school grounds?" Avery inquired of the others.

"There shouldn't be any problems so long as you have your ID; however, leaving the city may be a different problem but I'm sure Kaden's anticipated that," Jane replied.

And so, with no further details to discuss, the members of the newly formed infiltration party went their separate ways to prepare for the departure to District 3, Pyrus Bourn's volcanic lair.

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Thirty minutes later, the seven met back at the west entrance of the school where the prodigy himself had prepared a different ride to their destination. A sleek, black van with tinted windows awaited them, looking out of place against the backdrop of the school's semi-tall stone fence.

"Everyone ready?" Kaden asked, glancing at each of them. He analysed the members and ensured that everyone had been fully prepared, afterall, further complaints could hinder his plans. There were nods all around, though the tension was palpable.

Kaden himself wore a collared shirt with a light navy blue jacket. He also wore black sweatpants which paired well with his dark sunglasses over his ruffly white hair. Unlike his business casual attire, this time, he was ready for action.

Avery wore his same attire from ealier consisting of his usual jacket and pants, no change on his part except for much complentation during his thirty minutes. His rune shone and floated behind his head but he had no regard to how it acted on standby.

Ted, well, the man was of a different caliber. He donned a gray t-shirt, baggy pants, and a metallic wristband. A dark pair of headphones wrapped around his neck and he pounced around in a pair of thick stompy shoes.

Though it was unusual, River remained consistent in her outfit as she had kept her same hood over her head. She also wore the same skirt the day Avery encountered her in the mall.

Jane Tee wore a black shirt with a plant logo, jeans, and brown boots. She had nothing else on her as she tossed her hair to showcase the true elegance of being prepared, or whatever.

Ken Masumi wore his school uniform consisting of a maroon long-sleeved shirt and dark pants. Red tinted shades were over his forehead which he would pull down to use when needed. He also had equipped behind his back a large axe as a weapon. “Just in case,” he winked at the skeptical members.

Kirk Masumi took a different approach than his brother as he wore a black jacket over a red t-shirt with random squiggly lines and grey jeans. He equipped a pair of thick heavy duty gloves.

"Nice van. Looks neat," Ted remarked, trying to lighten the mood. "Is it rented or stolen?"

Kaden smirked. "Borrowed, with permission. Now, everyone get in. We don’t have much time."

They piled into the van, with Kaden taking the driver's seat. Avery ended up next to him, while the rest filled the back seats. As the van pulled away, the group fell into a nervous silence, the gravity of their mission settling in. Though everyone was prepared

to their capability, they seemed tense as no one wanted to shake the mood growing within the vehicle.

Kaden navigated the van through the city streets with practiced ease, weaving through traffic and taking shortcuts only a local would know. The cityscape gradually faded away as the van zoomed past security and through the exit gate without a quick surveillance stop.

"Alright," Kaden began, breaking the silence. "Here's a more detailed rundown of our plans when arriving. We'll be entering the district through a maintenance tunnel I discovered during my hacking sessions. It's usually used by factory workers, so security should be light. There isn't a formal city as the entire district is the mountain itself, so everywhere we'd be checking will be under."

"Should be?" Jane repeated, raising an eyebrow. "That sounds uncertain."

"Yes, should be," Kaden confirmed. "But we'll be ready for anything. Minor individuals shouldn't matter to those at Regnum Academy. The main objective is to locate and rescue Teacher Charlotte Levy. We avoid confrontation with Pyrus and his elite unless absolutely necessary."

"Once we're inside, what then?" River asked.

"Given that this is a party created out of a whim, I choose the arrangements out of randomness… and some analysis. We'll split into two teams," Kaden continued. "One team will create a diversion, drawing attention away from the main area, while the other team sneaks into the central facility where Charlotte is likely being held."

"Who's on which team?" Avery inquired. "And why should there be a diversion? I thought this was safe?"

"Our numbers are too big if we pace together, so splitting and causing some backend chaos should confuse them and buy time to finish this. In the case of team arrangements, Team A, the diversion team, will be led by me. It'll include Ted, Ken, and Kirk. Team B, the rescue team, will be led by Avery. Joining him will be River and Jane," Kaden assigned. "Any objections?"

"No," Avery said, though he felt a pang of anxiety. Leading a team was a heavy responsibility, especially against such formidable opponents. He, however, was a little disturbed to have to lead his two other members, both of whom were girls. Nonetheless, that didn't prsueade him otherwise. At least he was with River of all possible combinations.

He suspected Kaden chose him to lead since he was aware of his abilities and experiences in an almost do or die situation. He decided to take this position to heart and just do it since his friends probably wouldn't volunteer instead.

Then handing Avery a small device with a screen, Kaden explained, "This is a GPS device connected to the IT satellite. You should be able to pinpoint the rough location of where Pyrus keeps his captives."

"You have access to that?" Ted inquired with his usual interest in geeky topics.

"I did say I have limited access to physical resources regarding this mission, but I can access the digital services as I see fit," Kaden hailed proudly.

The others were surprised but nonetheless cared not at all with this.

"Good. We're almost there," Kaden announced as the van approached a small, fenced-off industrial area sticking out of a steep ledge. He drove past the main entrance, continuing around to a less conspicuous side gate. "This is where we get out. Everyone, stay close and keep quiet. Since it is evening, the security is very limited."

The team disembarked from the van and followed Kaden to a small, rusted gate partially obscured by overgrown bushes. Kaden produced a set of lockpicks out of his ice magic and quickly got to work on the lock. Within moments, the gate swung open with a creak. Another feat of the great prodigy was displayed before the others.

"Through here," Kaden whispered, leading the way. They passed through the gate and entered a narrow alley lined with old pipes and discarded machinery. Kaden stopped at a heavy metal door, partially hidden behind a stack of wooden crates. "This leads to the maintenance tunnel."

"Sure, but how many gates and doors does this side entrance even have?" Kirk protested.

Kaden just shrugged, not really caring for an answer himself.

Ted stepped forward and examined the door. "Looks sturdy. Let's hope it's not alarmed, cus you know, that would be bad."

"It's not," Kaden assured him with confidence. "I've already disabled the security on this entry point. It should last for a little bit before their security notices anything, so let's move."

He opened the door, revealing a dimly lit tunnel stretching into darkness. One by one, they filed in, the door closing behind them with a soft thud. The air inside was cool and

damp, the sound of dripping water echoing off the walls. But what was most unusual was the significant temperature increase as the tunnel went along.

"Keep your eyes open and stay alert," Kaden instructed as they advanced. "We're officially in enemy territory now."

The tunnel seemed to go on forever, winding through the bowels of the industrial district. Eventually, they reached a junction where the path split into two. Kaden turned to face the group.

"This is where we divide," he said. "Team A, we'll head left and create our diversion. Team B, take the right path and find a way into the central facility. We'll meet back here in an hour, with or without Charlotte. Understood?"

"Understood," Avery replied, his voice steady despite his nerves. "Though would it take that long?"

"Just for good measure. Now, good luck," Kaden said, giving Avery a firm nod. "And be careful, cus cleaning up messes isn't my specialty."

With that, the two teams separated, each heading down their respective paths. As Avery led his team into the unknown, he couldn't shake the feeling that they were about to face their toughest challenge yet. But for Teacher Charlotte, for their friends, and for the future, they had no choice but to press on.

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Avery, River, and Jane moved quickly but cautiously through the tunnel, the dim light casting eerie shadows on the walls. The tunnel eventually opened up into a large, dimly lit chamber filled with old machinery and stacks of crates. Apparently this sector of the lair housed the factory's raw material imports.

"We should use these crates for cover," Jane suggested, pointing to a stack near the far wall. "It'll help us stay hidden if anyone comes through here. You should check the GPS for the next route."

Avery nodded. It was a noteworthy plan to act upon.

They maneuvered behind the crates, taking a moment to catch their breath and assess their surroundings. Avery tapped a few diles on the screen and managed to shift the

focus on their exact location. A carefully laid out map popped onto the screen and indicated the heart of the district a few corridors away.

The chamber was quiet, but strange mechanical nosies loomed from the nearby rooms and corridors. Avery peered around the edge of the crates, spotting a staircase leading up to a heavy door.

"That's our way into the main lair," Avery whispered. "Let's head up."

They crept towards the staircase, each step carefully placed to avoid making noise. As they reached the bottom of the stairs, the door above them creaked open, and a figure stepped through. They froze, holding their breath. It was unexpected, yet now they had to deal with a witness.

The figure turned out to be a young factory worker, but he was oblivious to their presence. Creeping to the edge of the end of the stairs and into the shadow, Avery, Jane, and River held their breath. There were crevices in the walls that made redundant designs but escelleent hiding spots. Even not being noticed, anxiety of potentially being caught was much higher than any of them expected to feel.

The factory worker descended the stairs without regard to any trespassers in sight and headed towards a side door at the end, disappearing from sight. Avery exhaled slowly, motioning for the others to follow him through the passageway.

They reached the door, which was slightly ajar, and peered through the gap. Beyond was a brightly lit corridor, a stark contrast to the dim chamber they had just left. It was the main section of the lair where Pryus Bourn typically roamed about. Avery signaled for them to proceed, and they slipped through the door one by one.

The corridor was lined with doors, some marked with signs indicating various storage rooms and offices. They moved quickly and quietly, stopping occasionally to listen for any signs of movement.

"Which way now?" River asked in a hushed tone.

"Kaden said Charlotte would likely be held in the central facility," Avery replied. "We need to find a way to the main area. I noticed on the map that it should be in a path in one of the junctions just ahead."

They continued down the corridor, coming to a junction where it branched off in three directions. As they deliberated on which path to take, the sound of footsteps echoed down the left-hand corridor.

"Hide!" Avery hissed, ducking into a nearby doorway to a room labled, “Storage.” River and Jane followed suit, pressing themselves against the walls but opposite to the hall.

Two guards appeared, chatting casually as they walked past with slow heavy footsteps. It was past midnight now and most of the security was on low stasis. What few monitored the facility were the ones least eager about their roles.

“Man, nothing good ever happens here. Why bother monitering the halls this way… can’t the security do it?” one guard complained.

“You’re right about that, bro, but we’re being made pretty handsomely if you say for the least. Come on, even if you are a newer recruit, you can’t just start complaining about this soon. You’ll see that being patrol guards has its own perks,” the other explained emphatically.

“Uhh… like what again?”

“Six hour shifts, bro. Extended vacation times. Facility benefits. Money… to note a few of the good ones. Supposedly there’s a good batch of fruit newly prepared by the agriculture department, but I haven’t been ther lately to check it out.”

“Yeah, I guess. Still I get this dread whenever I start my shift so I guess I just don’t appreciate these few hours that much.”

“Boohoo, sad for you. I quite enjoy it. I get to look at the usual stuff and think about my plans in a few hours. Usually nothing out of the ordinary happens but it would be easy to spot cus when you’re a veteran like me, you basically memorize every one of these confusing halls.”

They paid no attention to the doorway where the trio was hiding, and soon their low voices faded into the distance.

"That was close," River sighed, her heart pounding. She was definitely not used to this yet she seemed more calm than Avery himself.

"Yeah, for sure. Let’s go right," Avery decided, peeking out to ensure the coast was clear. "We need to keep moving."

“They’re conversation was intriguing,” Jane commented. The others didn’t see the need to discuss it.

They slipped out of their hiding spot and took the right-hand corridor, hoping it would lead them closer to the central chambers. As they navigated the labyrinthine passages, the tension only grew as confucius sounds echoed louder ahead.

Expecting to see some supervisor at the scene of the noise, the trio only witnessed automatic machinery configuring nearly finished products of fire increaser canisters.

Looking about the other doors, Avery gestured the coast was clear for the time being.

River seemed less tense as she examined one of the products by picking it up.

"It's interesting to note just how dangerous these chemicals are," Jane commented, glancing over River's shoulder.

"Uh, yeah," was River's response.

Taking this moment to check their location a final time, Avery noticed a small message on the corner of the screen displaying Kaden's confirmation of his post.

"Looks like Kaden is all set up to attract any dangers. We should do our part quickly," Avery spoke with newfound authority and confidence.

Just stalling for time, the other two agreed.

Passing through a corridor much larger than the rest, the trio arrived at Pyrus Bourn's throne room.

"This is something else… like out of some anime," Avery remarks quietly.

Guiding the way, Avery led the other two down a hall on the right and into another room which housed the nicer quality jail cells.

"Well, we're here at last," Avery stated in a whisper, confirming on his device. "I don't see any other prisoners so finding Charlotte should be fairly easy."

"So far so good," Jane said unexpectedly with no hesitation.

Avery wondered who could tolerate her mouth. He just hoped the premonition would alter by having sheer confidence.

"Aye," was his response. Rhen, briskly rushing down the hall of cells, he found a cell door with small bars for windows. Inside was the resting body of their teacher Charlotte Levy.

"We planned for everything, but what about a key?" River inquired, analyzing the lock in particular right above the cell door handle.

"I should be able to override it with my plant magic," Jane whispered. This was the first time the other two would see her magic up close.

"Plant magic, eh," Avery said, "Sounds pretty handy."

"Yes, I think so myself too," Jane gloated over the compliment directed to her. Then, lifting her hand up, small roots began forming from her palm until it grew to the familiar shape of a small tree branch.

Kneeling down and at the center of attention, Jane got to work on the lock. Though Mystical technology has advanced the quality of doorlocks, Pyrus Bourn still ultilized old fashioned inventions.

Digging deeper into the lock and applying more magic to grow the branch all round the interior, the branch became firm and she was able to turn it. It was successful for the first few seconds before the branch tangled itself with the contractions inside.

"Whoosp, I might've messed up. Guess I'll have to remove it all and start again," Jane said with a sly smile.

As if the tension couldn't get worse, it only got worse. As she began her second attempt, the trio heard loud footsteps approaching their way.

"Could it be a guard?" River inquired quickly, already getting frightened of getting caught. She came closer to Avery and the two glanced back and forth frantically.

"Whoever it is, we should really get going quick," Avery said finally.

"Almost got it," Jane said in a voice a bit too loud.

"Shhh, uh, we don't have much time," Avery hushed with despiration.

Then a few seconds later, a loud click indicated Jane's sucess of unlocking the cell door. Without any delay, she opened the door and rushed to wake the captive teacher up. But as soon as she opened the cell, a figure approached the trio with a displeased expression about his face.

Standing before the trio was Tom Nado, the right hand man of Pyrus Bourn himself. He was not pleased with what he saw and was prepared to take action.

"Trespassers, huh?" he stated, "Boss doesn't like those kinds of people."

Without a single warning he arched his hand forward and shot a gust of strong wind that picked up the trio and sent them flying a few meters down the corridor. "*Wind Magic: Storm Breakthrough*."

Looking at the opened cell door, he slammed it shut and continued to advance on the trio.

"I thought Kaden was s-supposed to have lured them to his team!" River spoke with dread.

"Then we run!" Avery shouted as he grabbed River's hand and faced back the direction they arrived. Jane pursued them at her own pace but regularly glanced back to moniter the distance from the enemy.

Being able to alarm Tom Nado, the trio succeeded in securing a good hundred yards which bought them time to carefully rush through specific rooms rather than ramming into random ones.

"He probably didn't notice the cell had been unlocked fully. Let's just hope that teacher Charlotte Levy can wake up from all the commotion and get out herself," Avery pointed out, taking the lead on retreat.

Making a few wrong turns to locate the least busiest rooms, the trio were no longer on the same path towards the location where they'd meet up. Instead, more sounds, as if a battle had begun, echoed from the walls of the largest room in the lair. The trio took a breather at the end of a hall with two doors on either side.

"We managed to lose him for now, but we should probebly be careful and avoid being near where those noises are coming from," Avery suggested, pointing to a pair of doors where thumps and quick footsteps could be heard.

Jane glanced through the window of the door to the larger room and gasped. "No way, their plan of distraction was fighting?" she exclaimed. Looking on either side of her, Avery and River saw Kaden's team in combat against two subordinates of Pyrus Bourn. One opponent utilized earth magic while the other lightning.

The trio became startled when a gentle breeze brushed against their backs. Turning around, they noticed the figure of Tom Nado striding towards them.

"Don't think you can get away that easily. My strands of wind can pick up on the slightest movements even a mile away," he announced in a serious tone. "*Wind Magic: Wind Turbulance Tracking*."

With a slight indicated nod, Avery directed the other two to prepare to move. They had two options: continue the case of cat and mouse or turn the tide of the battle by aiding the others and conquering together.

With no other choice, the trio rushed into the room bringing another opponent and additional allies into the battlefield.

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Now, turning back to when the diversion team set out on their own, things didn't turn out how they expected.

Being the diversion team was Kaden's initial intention from the start. Seeing that the resuing team did not need backup, he decided it would be for the best to attract Pyrus Bourn and his close subordinates in his general area to stall for time.

Glancing at Ted and the Masumi brothers, he smiled knowing that they were eager to get in a few bouts to exercise their skills despite the risks attached to it.

Going through the other path and rushing into a corridor fully lit by modern lights, Kaden's team headed towards the perimeter of the lair where they would cause commotion to draw the enemy out.

"So, what's the point of causing a diversion if we're invading at the quietest moment?" Ken asked in a quiet tone.

"There's at least a few reasons, right?" Kirk added.

"There is," Kaden replied, "The main thing being info digging. I'll need you guys to guard me when I get into their local database."

"Really? That's why?" Ted exasperated. "That's cool and all, but isn't this a bad time to even consider that?"

"It's to mainly buy time for the other team to safely free Charlotte Levy. But really, a little battle doesn't hurt, does it?" Kaden responded.

The other three followed Kaden who knew the place for memory as they passed numerous confusing halls and corridors. As they traveled, the walls and features became slightly more modern indicating their arrival at the more maintained section of the volcanic lair. The temperature died off mostly but a foggy atmosphere still remained.

Without much realization of their whereabouts, the three finally halted when they noticed Kaden stopped before a sealed metal door. Beside the door was a small keypad with an iris biometric scanner.

"Uh, now what?" Kirk broke the silence.

"Don't worry, Kaden's got it," Ted exclaimed, analysing the young prodigy's gestures and attempt at hacking the door.

Turning around in the middle of his operation, Kaden announced in his normal volumed voice, "Guard me white I work this. Also, you three should scout the nearby area and make some noises."

“Noises? Are you serious?” Ted accidentally shouted.

Ken smirked and patted Ted’s back. “Don’t worry, good sir, hehe. We’ve got this handled, don’t we. It’s been a while since we’ve even fought, so let’s makethis chance out!”

“You said it, bro!” Kirk cheered.

The Masumi brothers were nice dudes once you got to know them. This was Ted’s thought as he followed them.

After walking a few meters, the brothers looked around the junction they arrived at.

Holding his hand over his eyes and narrowing his focus at the end of each hall, Ken asked, “What should we do? Should we wreck this place as compensation for the Pyro guy destroying such a nice school?”

“I never thought of that. Let’s do it,” Kirk responded.

Ted, who was a little skeptical about it, spoke doubtfully, “I don’t know, should we be wasting time doing that? We have a more important task at hand, you know.”

“It may attract the boss himself,” Ken stated, ignoring Ted’s comment.

Clenching his fists and bathing it in fire magic, Kirk already began work demolishing what he saw. He threw a few punches against the wall and only caused semi-serious dents to form.

“Aww, bro! Is that how much you can manage?” Ken laughed out loud while pointing at his brother’s handywork. “I’ll show you how it’s really done.”

Instead of powering up and performing a grand attack right that instant, Ken decided to punch a few dents and see what it felt like.

Ted stepped out of the way, not wanting to get in the way of the brothers’ bash and smash session. Being encouraged by the great prodigy himself, the brothers couldn’t resist doing something rather untypical.

Striding over to a wall adjacent to where his brother punched, Ken arched his arm back, prepared a fist of magic, and slammted it into the metal wll with intense force, shaking the surrounding structure.

Retracting his hand, Ken noticed burning oil covering his fingers and palm. He shook his hand quickly of the burning substance and glanced closer at the damage he caused. A large crack through the metal about twice as big as his brother’s dents. As a bonus, he even collided with a pipe transporting oil into the main factory site.

Not a moment later, alarms began to blare in the section of the lair where they stood. Red lights and hazard signs popped onto the walls of the corridor every few meters.

"Whoops," was Ken's only response as the trio headed back to where Kaden was.

"Now you've done it," Ted stated, clearly not wanting to get involved but unfortunately dragged into it.

"It was fun while it lasted," Kirk said.

Arriving back to where Kaden had been hacking, they noticed the door was open and on the other side were iles and iles of database computers. Kaden met up with them and was surprised to see them so soon.

"I take it you guys were the cause of the alarm," he said.

"Yeah," Ken admitted.

"Did you extract the data you wanted?" Ted asked Kaden.

"Yep, I sure did. Now the next step is to distract and wait."

"I don't know about that, the alarm might've caused the surveillance to act up," Ted explained. "Two particularly dummies decided it was fun punching the walls and stuff."

"Wasn't a destraction what Kaden wanted," Kirk protested.

"You guys did well. They're here, as I suspected," Kaden announced, brushing past the trio and out of the database.

Ted and the Masumi brothers prusued Kaden and stopped right at the entrance of the database where Kaden halted.

Standing before them were a dozen or so armored guards of District 3 all equipped with guns and swords. Each of them wore dark armor and a skull-like mask with holes for eyes.

"Get them!" the leader in front shouted. Then the others advanced, stomping the ground and causing a clamour much like a rampage. Some of the guards seemed groggy still but they moved with natural instinct as if the surrounding members gave them concentration and stamina.

Stepping forward and placing himself in their path, Kaden raised a hand and snapped his fingers to send a shockwave of miniature ice particles throughout the room, causing every guard to stumble and fall back. "*Ice Magic: Blasting Blitz*."

“Owww, my eyes,” some screamed as they dropped their equipment and scratched their eyes with their fingers. Others groaned having tripped on the particles

It was the first time Ted, Ken, and Kirk witnessed Kaden’s powers in action, so naturally, they just stood there and watched him handle the situation.

Though they were average soldiers capable of dealing with most tresspassers and dangerous situations, they stood no chance against an attack both difficult to see and tedious to combat.

Shooting some ice spikes, Kaden knocked the remaining guards unconscious. Then turning to the other three, he nodded as if expecting some praise or approval.

“If you want to be as strong as me, you’ll have to face tough life and death situations,” was his snarky advice.

Knowing the guards were altered from the alarm, it was only a matter of minutes before the real fight would begin. Kaden gestured for the others to follow as he rushed down another hall leading to a large factory maintenance facility.

Eventually arriving, the squad pushed past the double metal doors and entered a grand open spaced room constructed of dark steel and tiled with black concrete flooring that reflected the dimmly lit light sources along the walls. Some small scaffolding and construction vehicles lined the edge of the room where unfinished projects had been worked on during the typical workday.

“Given that we originally intended to avoid the higher ups, it seems to no longer be possible,” Kaden remarked, gazing at the architecture of the room. “I’m surprised even Pyrus got this advanced in technology over the years.”

“That’s cool and all,” Ted replied, “but what are we doing here exactly?”

“Wait for them to arrive.”

Not a moment after when Kaden said this, the doors on the opposite end of the room burst open and two figures strided into the light.

“I think we’ll get in trouble if we don’t deel with them, right?” one figure, a black haired guy wearing a simple t-shirt asked the other figure.

“Dealing with them isn’t the problem. The fact that they got in might already give us a punishment. So, if you want to please our boss, you’ll have to really make it up,” the other figure, a red-haired woman, replied sarcastically.

The guy was Tony Smith and the woman was the raging Ellie Tracey. Both were woken up by the alarm and were displeased to be disturbed at such an hour.

Then glancing at the four trespassers, Ellie seemed disgusted. “I can’t believe a bunch of children got in here!”

“No one dares call me that,” Kaden said coldly, creating a sword out of his ice.

“No way, that’s, uhhh…, Kaden Icelander, right?” Tony pointed with a shaking finger. “He, he may be young, but it’s… certainly him!”

“He might actually be a worthy challenge!” Ellie Tracey exclaimed, jumping into action.

She lunged forward and took a swipe at Kaden’s torso but only caught the whiff of thin air as the boy stepped back and countered.

Stancing his sword, Kaden bent down and sprinted around the women and took the chance to dab his sword at her.

Lightning Magic: Constant Flux.

She parried with the flat of her hand now engulfed in light blue electricity. On contact with the blade, the surge of electricity traveled halfway across the ice blade and deformed its upper sharp structure.

Bending backwards, Kaden flipped and shifted a few feet away to repair his blade.

“You’re pretty good,” he complimented as a courtesy of the unspoken rule of battling.

“Likewise the same. I’m getting to enjoy this, perhaps waking at this hour wasn’t all for nothing after all!” Ellie responded as she lept into the air with boots surging with lightning.

Kaden Icelander formed a pillar of ice below him elevating him a few meters off the ground as the woman landed onto the ground, causing a thump that sent a shockwave of invisible negatively charged energy to distort the neighboring objects’ behaviors.

Electricity Magic: Lightning Lynx Leap.

Without much time to recover back to the ground, Kaden instantly encountered Ellie Tracey suddenly behind him with claws of lightning inches from his neck.

“How in the…” Kaden began. With a quick instance, ice surrounded the boy and forced the woman to retreat backwards. Then the ice cocoon burst and the shards were sent flying around the room up to several meters away.

"I thought I almost got you," Ellie stated, disappointment filling her eyes.

"Aww, that's too bad. You don't want the fun to end too soon," Kaden chided.

Glancing to his friends, Kaden noticed that Tom Nado had not appeared on the scene yet.

Across the room, Ted, Ken, and Kirk were locked in a three-vs-one battle against the earth magic wielding subordinate named Tony Smith. Crushing his fists against the ground, spikes of rocks sprouted from random points of the floor around the trio.

The Masumi brothers effortlessly smashed through every directed spike, but their lowsyness caused the debris to scatter the ground and air. Ted formed a metal wall around himself and tried to anticipate the next attack.

When the time was right, Ted lept into the air and propelled himself with a thin metal rod that shot from his palms. "*Metal Magic: Beam Bullet*." Soaring through the sky, he formed guns around his arms and shot numerous small metal bullets at the opponent. "*Metal Magic: Pallets of Pestilence*."

A darker earth barrier erupted from Tony's hand and swiped the bullets offside with sheer force causing them to change trajectory.

Nearly blasting Kirk's toes off, Ted was not prepared to take drastic measures to stop their velocity, but Kirk was talented enough to sidestep in time. His scawl on his face showed his displeasure, otherwise he was perfectly fine.

"Sorry," Ted apologized frantically before leaping over some rubbled created by the flaming brothers.

Kirk dismissed the incident and continued to put pressure on the enemy. With his fists engulfed in more fire than ever before, "*Fire Magic: Double Fire Fists of Fury*," his rapid strikes against Tony Smith's constantly repairing barrier caused the enemy to falter a bit and lose focus.

Struck in various areas around his chest and his shirt tattered, Tony formed a thick layer of earth and retreated a few meters back. As soon as he made this move, Ken Masumi appeared behind him and scraped his back with flaming talons. Ted finished off by sending a pillar of steel against him, sending him flying into the nearby wall.

It was admirable teamwork to say the least, but no cheers could be celrated quite yet when a nearby wall shook and doors opposite from where they entered burst open to introduce a few more figures.

Rushing towards the trio was Avery, River, and Jane who were all three being pursued by the intimidating figure of Tom Nado gliding on a swirling tornado.

The gusts of wind knocked several nearby equipment onto the ground as Tom Nado descended onto the ground where Tony Smith lay.

"Argh, what happened?" he shouted, releasing a wave of wind that knocked everyone else from their feet.

Punching Tony hard in the guts, the earth affinity villain gasped awake and looked about.

"My head felt fuzzy," was his response as he got to his feet.

"You'll have to sleep later, otherwise the boss would be mad if we don't finish the job," Tom commanded.

"Oh all right."

Ken and Kirk stood up before everyone else and approached the villain duo.

"Time to end this," both said at once as fire enveloped their bodies.

"Let me handle this," Tony Smith stated, standing in front of Tom Nado.

"Kay, suit yourself, but don't fall over again" was Tom's advice before he swerved around and chose to engage another target.

Avery, River, and Jane were about to announce their failure in securing Charlotte Levy's rescue, yet they were approached by Tom Nado who wanted to wrap things up quickly.

Lifting his hand and swirling compressed air between his fingers, he released a concentrated beam of wind that shot at the trio.

Avery and River flew into the air and landed on the ground meters away. Utilizing water suddenly, River cushioned her fall.

Avery, on the other hand, tumbled against the hard ground and scraped his right arm and shoulder in the process. He felt a bit woozy and remained idle while the others continued in their respective fights.

Ted had arrived onto the scene before Jane and created a heavy shield that diverted most of the wind around them via aerodynamics. He happened to catch when the villain would unleash an attack.

Getting up and looking about, River dodged a nearly fatal lighttning attack from Ellie Tracey who was intent on targeting Kaden Icelander. The ice prodigy landed next to River and stomped his feet on the ground to form a thick ice wall.

"You have water magic, right?" Kaden asked River as he analysed his situation.

"Uh, yes," she replied, though a bit confused as to why he'd inquired about such a topic during a battle.

"Discharge it or whatever. Make a water ball or something," he said quickly as a portion of the ice melted from a beam of penetrating electricity.

Though Kaden was a vastly talented individual, he was pitted against a few of his weaknesses: heat and conductance.

River channeled magic through her body and into her hands to release in a single wave. Lifting her hand, she created a single larger water ball greater than the ones she made during the shadow cult member attack. With unusual flared force, she lunged the ball of water towards Ellie Tracey who only looked skeptical. The villain instantly became aware of its presence and began to sprint out of its path of collision.

Kaden closed his eyes and opened to have his natural blue eyes replaced with black pupils. With an abundance of magic at his disposal, he reached towards the water ball and turned it completely into ice. Then with total meditation on the object's size, he altered its course and steered it towards the retreating woman.

Initially overconfident, Ellie became fearful as the giant ball of ice smashed her against the ground. Surging more pressure, Kaden plunged the ball into the ground, splintering the ground and disassembling the ice ball in the process, all while the villain was buried underneath.

Brushing himself off Kaden was nearly confident he finished the job, but his face faltered when he sensed a tinge of lightning in the air.

Melting all the ice around her instantly, Ellie Tracey emerged from the ruin bruised and scratched but still prepared for more.

Kaden and River prepared for her every attack now that she was enraged.

While this occurred, at the center of the area, Ted and Jane faced off against the tornado born Tom Nado. Towering over them from within his brewed up wind, he smirked at the sight of the little pests below him.

Not in the mood to be bested, Jane summoned a large tree trunk which erupted from underneath the floor tiles and enveloped the tornado. "*Plant Magic: Concealing Tree*."

With needle-like branches, it launched attacks from all around Tom Nado, causing him to flee upwards.

Ted retracted his invention on his back. It was a long think board. After plunging through buttons, the invention roared to life and began to shapeshift through its eccentric mechanism. "*Metal Magic: Thought Acceleration and Metal Morphosis*." Placing a magic rune at its core, the invention was now the shape of a surfboard with thrusters at its rear.

Ted hopped onto the hoverboard and initiated its thrusters at max, causing him to shoot into the sky right above Tom Nado. He channeled magic into his fists and formed a large sledge hammer of steel which was unavoidable by both his own weight and gravity. "*Metal Magic: Steel Hammer*."

Because magic formulated the very essence of atomic structure, Ted could freely choose whether to disperse his permanent metal creations since he was aware of its structure.

With immense built up muscle, he lunged the hammer downwards at Tom. Jane pressured from around and ensured the branches would constantly grow back when destroyed by bursts of wind.

The hammer plunged into Tom's arms as he attempted to slow its fall and block its full impact. Using wind as thrusters around his feet, he propelled upwards and shifted the weight of the hammer so that it fell and tore through the tree creation instead.

"Bruh, he's so quick," Ted admitted, clenching his fists in frustration.

A bit worn from the endeavor, Tom emerged from the dust of the rubble unscathed. "A clever move to pin me down, but all three of us were trained to deal with especially Melior (the fifth rank from the ten) ranked Mystical Beings."

All three of the subordinates of Pyrus Bourn wielded such strength that rivaled even an elite at Regnum Academy. Even with tag teams pitted against them, they effortlessly held their ground.

Thus, the choices were made, and the fate of the island rested on the success of these individuals.

Chapter 14: Descent by Flames

There was no avoiding it. Potentially, the battle would move towards the favor of the enemy. The confrontation against the strongest of District 3 was only inevitable. Even though the villains were to be avoided at all costs, no one expected their presence as a danger to the operation and means of retreat.

Kaden Icelander and River Grant remained in a stasis battle against the gleeful Ellie Tracey, Teddric Tech and Jane Tee were locked in quick exchanges of magic against the tornado bringing Tom Nado, and lastly, Ken and Kirk Masumi held their bearings against a monstrous-level opponent Tony Smith.

Shaking himself off and now aware enough to consciously determine the next course of action, Avery hadn't fully decided who desperately needed assistance. In all three battles, both sides remained firm on their position, yet his intervention would give his side an upper hand in a single battle.

Before Avery had the chance to choose who he'd support, the sound of slow but heavy footsteps ringed in his ears. Turning around, he tensed at the sight of the boss himself who had respectfully chosen to join the chaos.

Pyrus Bourn this time had a dark silver lightweight armor equipped with a large belt at his weist holding various gadgets and his sheathed sword. The heavy metallic boots he wore caused the unusually loud stomping noise after every stride.

It would be an uneven battle if he joined into anyone else's fight, so Avery had no choice but to engage him directly and hope he could stall for time. Clenching his fists and willing light magic to pour into his fists, Avery approached Pyrus Bourn with slowly growing newfound confidence.

"So you're the Angelor, huh?" Pyrus inspected devilishly. "Bring it if you can!"

Avery's rune behind his back began glowing intensively. Subconsciously desiring it, he willed the halo rune to spin rapidly and shoot straight towards Pyrus Bourn.

Unsheathing his sword in the nick of time, Pyrus Bourn was able to block and deflect the full impact of the rune's high velocity. But staggering for better ground, he was suddenly ambushed by Avery's presence directly behind him.

“Heh, you clever little pest,” Pyrus hallowered as he briskly turned and pressed a foot against Avery’s shin to fumble his stature. With a strong kick from the same leg straight in his chest, Avery stumbled onto the firm ground a few meters from the villain.

When it came to skill, Pyrus Bourn was obviously scaling far past everyone else in close proximity. Willing the rune into his hand, Avery prepared for another round.

“So, you’re the one who happened to get the rune. This is certainly a turn of events. You do know what I’m capable of yet you’d dare oppose someone so far from your league,” Pyrus monologued in the midst of the fight.

“We came here to save our teacher, nothing personal with you. I don’t know what you’re blabbering about,” Avery spoke in a confrontive tone.

“Yes, that is true. I’ve nothing against you either, boy; however, the events are all destined for this moment to come. I sensed it in the air. Must be something that regularly happens to those exposed to magic for so long.”

Then, Pyrus pressed a small button on a device strapped to his belt. Sheathing his sword, he quickly lunged at Avery at point blink time before his prey even had the chance to react.

The next moment, Pyrus stood victorious, grasping his target’s neck between his right hand. “Sorry, but I don’t have much time to wait. I need the orb of destruction and only that rune has the means to lead to its destination.”

“What do you mean…?” Avery struggled to fully protest. He dropped his rune which began floating a few feet nearby.

The sound of blades swirling through the air roared through the walls. Then a large gate on the farside of the room where the battles raged opened and a helicopter blazed into the open area.

Pyrus attempted to grab the rune but failed as it automatically diverted every attempt.

“Sorry, boy, but you’re comin’ along,” he growled.

As the helicopter approached him and Avery as if to ram them, the villain effortlessly lept into the air and landed onto the opened compartment at the center of its body.

Avery was easily dragged along by Pyrus’ incredible unhumanlike strength. His rune resonated and returned to its position behind his back. The doors then began sliding to close the body from the open elements. He struggled to use his magic as all his attention was diverted to free himself as quickly as possible, but to no avail, his friends also had no open opportunity to aid him.

Adjusting quickly, the helicopter rotated and hovered a few meters off the ground preparing for its departure. Though the large open room appeared to be used for large constructio projects, its versatility was much more subtle. Not soon after, part of the slanted ceiling began to part to the side revealing the bright dark sky and the glistering moon. As soon as the gap was wide enough (though it was a risky endeavor), the helicopter soured through and out of the volcanic lair.

Being grasped tightly by the neck, Avery barely had breath to restrain Pyrus Bourn's brutal bear's clutch. The helicopter ascended even higher into the sky, steering further from the volcanic lair. Avery noticed his friends engaged in their respective battles on the ground become specks not soon after.

The other students, including Kaden, only realized too late what had occurred and Avery's disappearance.

Not wanting to waste anymore time, Kaden and River decisively unified their magic release together to produce a nearly infinite beam of ice that sprayed and spread whereever it landed.

Water plus Ice Magic: Concentrated Beam of Ice.

His eyes still fully darkened, Kaden's ice became denser than ever before, almost turning a shade of whitish-blue instead of semi-transparent.

Ellie Tracey swong about the room dodging the attacks, but little did she realize the duo's formulated strategy of trapping her within missfired shots. The unusual behavior of the denser ice was its property to spread after landing on its target.

The woman shot bursts of lightning which the duo avoided fairly easily through mainly the guidance of Kaden. Expecting shots to come from any point, a single bolt impaled River in the knee and caused her to writhe in pain.

Injured, but otherwise alive, she maintained her focus and stated, "This… is nothing."

Still claiming to hold onto mental strength, she shot a spray of water towards the villain.

Water Magic: Water Shot.

Cockily, Ellie pointed out, "You know that electricity conducts well with water. An attempt like that will only get you killed." She then lunged towards the water and released lightning from all around her body and into the body of water.

River was about to be encountered by a wet, lightning engulfed villain, when the young prodigy himself teleported behind her with a fist surrounded with ice.

Ice Magic: Ice Travel.

"How did you…?" the villain began, astonished that he traveled such a distance in instantaneous time.

With a finishing blow, Kaden's ice punch landed against her chest and surrounded her with the white dense ice. She layed motionless on the ground still conscious but unable to do anything.

"Unlike the previous ice I used, this one won't conduct or melt from your electricity," Kaden explained to the defeated villain. "With Ice Travel, I can bend the laws of order and phase through dimensions to get to my destination quickly."

Across the open room, the two Masumi brothers faced off against Tony Smith who was the strongest of the three but the most weary minded.

Facing two opponents with demons for eyes and fiery magic for bodies, Tony began to shudder and back up.

Both brothers engulfed themselves with magical flames, allowing them to harness more magic, move briskly, and release their inner selves.

Flame Magic: Demon Reincarnate.

Kirk rushed before the villain and performed an uppercut which successfully landed but only penetrated an earth layer at Tony's chin.

Pressing his hand against the ground, the floor suddenly erupted as a monstrous earth statue emerged and faced the duo. It was fully armored and wielded a sword and shield.

"*Earth Magic: Earth Puppeteer*.

The earth construct was over thirty feet tall and seemed intimidating at first, but its incriminating advance was haltered by its slowness.

"Oh great, one of those things," Ken grunted as he pushed on.

Both brothers dodged its first landing blow by evading on either side.

With flaming wings, Ken launched into the air and pummled the earth statue from above. Kirk, on the other hand, raced to one of its feet and began punching very hard.

As the temperature grew from both brothers' presence, the statue began to melt under the damage and heat.

After the statue was demolished, the brothers glared at Tony Smith, causing him to retreat.

"That should do," Kirk stated.

"Yep, we sure did a fine job," Ken said, scanning the mess before them.

Across from the brothers' finished battle, Ted and Jane remained in fight with the final surviving member of the subordinates.

With metal wrapped around his fists like armored gloves, Ted maintained his footing by punching the incoming gusts of wind with simply sheer strength.

Metal Magic: Metal Creation.

Keeping a constant superior height over his opponent, Ted flew about on his overboard to look for an opening. Once one was opened, he lept from his ride and plunged himself straight ontop of the enemy.

"I've got you now!" he shouted as he wrapped metal around Tom Nado.

Hitting the ground, he jumped away as Jane wrapped wood branches in knots around the enemy.

With a sudden beep from a comm hidden under his ear, Tom Nado burst from the wooden trap and, igoring his opponents, launched off the ground with concentrated wind and disappeared past the opened roof.

"Well, he's gone now," Ted shrugged.

"Shoud we chase after him?" Jane asked.

"Nah, let's just finish up here."

After the chaos cleared, the six remaining gathered together to discuss next operations. The open room no longer consisted of its familiar features as destruction and rubble scattered the ground and dents and cracks lined the walls.

"Brother and I can go and check on Charlotte Levy," Ken stated at once.

"Oh really?" Kirk said.

"We may encounter some more small fries, won't that be fun?" Ken explained.

"I guess," Kirk admitted.

"What about Avery?" River questioned, bringing the most important topic up.

"Looks like the device I handed him dropped part ways, but it seems that Pyrus Bourn is heading to Lux Urbis," Kaden announced, analysing a map on his phone.

"What should we do?" Ted asked.

"Us four remaining will go after him and ensure the city is fine," Kaden concluded.

Desiring to end any potential fights, Kaden placed an extra layer of ice around Tony Smith and Ellie Tracey.

And with those plans decided, Kaden, River, Ted, and Jane returned to where they entered to ride back to the city while the Masumi brothers seareched for the captured teacher.

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The helicopter continued on its path away from Pyrus Bourn's volcanic lair district. Though it was strange for the villain to retreat (if it could be defined that way), some sort of scheme was still yet to be realized.

"What do you want with me?" Avery coughed, gripping Pyrus' arms and putting as much pressure as he could muster. It was barely able to make the villain even wince.

"I didn't expect you'd come so soon, or even at all. Turns out District 7 is in a bigger fuzzle than rumered," Pyrus taunted.

"Where… are you… taking… me?" Avery huffed, desiring the answer more than anything to prepare for whatever came next.

"Back to Lux Urbis, where I'll finally end it all," he grimaced. Then, with unbelievable maneverablility, he grasped the rune floating behind Avery and tugged it before his face.

"So, the orb was right here all along, heh?" he gloated. Feeling no surge of power or response from the rune, he tossed it aside and pinned Avery against the helicopter wall. "I see now, the orb was never to be found by the one led by the rune. Instead, the orb is in the rune itself!"

Avery's eyes went wide by the sudden proclamation. Being grasped tighter, Avery felt his consciousness become doozy and unfocused.

"Go ahead boy, call for the orb the same way as you bend the rune to your will!" Pyrus demanded. "Though I can't threaten you to such a high degree, I can still make sure you suffer and concious enough to endure it until you submit."

He then pressed a foot on top of Avery's to send a surge of pain up through his spine. What would've been a scream from his mouth was only a sudden exhale and continuous dramatic coughing.

Just thinking about the orb and its origin from within the rune sent an odd surge of magic energy throughout Avery's body. It was as if his magic was the activation and the mere thought of it was the key to its reveal.

Pyrus Bourn let go and backed up as Avery's body crumpled to the ground. The halo rune floated horizontally above his head and began to illuminate in a flaring orange light. Crackling with a newfound surge of magical power, swirling fire began forming in the center of the rune and became larger by the second until it formed into an orb of fiery magic plasma encased by an invisible solid layer.

The villain grinned as he marvelled at the sight of his dream coming true. "Ah yes," he exclaimed, "It is time for me to bring my ideals to the light."

"What… light?" Avery called out with a low voice. Through all he endured, his body was at an unusual state where pain became partially irrelevant. "Your invisionment of the world had to come by what price?"

Avery stood and held a firm posture balanced to the shaking helicopter. He stood before the orb forming between the rune. Then reaching out, he snatched the orb and grasped it tightly in his hand.

"For the good of the world and the future of others, a few merely had to suffer. Isn't that much better than the current system?" Pyrus gestured. "That boundless power in your hand is the key to my ideal!"

Pyrus Bourn charged and attempted to restrain Avery once more but failed as the boy sidestepped in anticipation of the same move.

Feeling the orb's unusually powerful aura, Avery's hand began to burn and strain from the orb's heat and slowly accumulating mass.

Though he was irritated at the current predicament, Pyrus knew that there was no escape as long as the two remained several hundred meters above the ground. The interior resembles a medium sized transport plane which could hold at least ten seats in a row in width.

"The orb that tormented others in the wrong hands. The orb that freed societies from the oppression of the powerful. The same orb that will fullfill the ideals of a true peaceful world under my guidance! That is the power that is bestowed onto those who seek it.

What is the use of such power if it is merely there as a decoration or stored away because of the fear in the eyes of those it opposes?" he monologues.

"Hurting people with this power is the only way?" Avery questioned, disgusted at the sound of its mere consideration. Avery was surprised he could even refute a man of a much higher caliber, yet he also felt that his unusually long luck may run out shortly.

As soon as he thought this, he quickly evaded an incoming blow from Pyrus Bourn who had suddenly become impatient. The villain's fist landed on the helicopter wall instead and formed a permanent dent. Just seeing the resulting impact sent shivers into Avery's body.

I'd be gone if I hadn't dodged just in time, Avery thought, yet all his skills were drained from focusing on Pyrus' hands. He suspected that Pyrus would instantly alter his fighting style to suit the situation; afterall, if the villain wasn't sane, he would be unusually brilliant instead.

Even though he was up against such an opponent, he still was not ready to give in. There was plenty of room to maneuver and the sharp jolts of the helicopter from Pyrus' first attack proved useful for evasion geared towards agility which was Avery's specialty.

Pyrus continued his consecutive blows which all ended up planting into various parts of the helicopter. His large strucutre and fast movements caused the helicopter to shake. Avery utilized the rocking of the vehicle to slide and dodge as he pleased.

"Everything alright, boss?" a radio voice called from speakers on the ceiling. "Some warnings popped up of various processors being destroyed. If this keeps up, we may crash land."

"Yeah yeah, that's not the concern right now," Pyrus shouted. Then focusing on Avery, who was a few yards away, he witnessed the boy grasping the orb in front of him and imbuing magic into it.

"What do you think you're planning?" he sneered.

"A countermeasure, or rather, perhaps, a way to finally stop you," Avery proclaimed.

Feeling the overwhelming heat from the orb sering his hands and even his mana ciculation, Avery tossed it into the air and blasted it with a sphere of collected light magic.

"Nooo!" Pyrus Bourn shouted as he backed up. "You'd do this and risk your life too?"

The orb dropped to the ground and began glowly uncontrollabily with shades of red energy. The air within the helicopter steadily rose as the temperature of the orb likewise. Avery's magic was then completely consumed within the orb.

Suspecting an explosion or fission of unstable energy, Avery backed up to the helicopter's sliding door and attempted to pry it open. Glancing outside the window, Avery analyzed they were within a few kilometers from Lux Urbis.

"What did you do?" Pyrus called from a distance, attempting his own methods for securing his life.

"Since the orb is a ball of compressed magic, I just thought that added magic may make it unstable," Avery stated, thinking the news would make the villain more startled.

Unexpected by the both, the orb's color became red and shot a surge of light red electromagnetic energy into the air, thus, causing the entirety of the helicopter's system to be disrupted. The energy knocked Pyrus and Avery from their feet and knocked their senses from stability.

"Gah," Pyrus wailed.

"Err," Avery grunted.

Stumbling about, Avery remained stable enough to hold onto the sliding door's handle to avoid being dragged into the jolts of the vehicle.

Warnings blared as the helicopter's propellers rattled to a stop. Then the vehicle remained afloat for a mere moment before accelerating due to gravity.

Admist the chaos, Pyrus reached for the orb which began rolling to the back compartment of the helicopter. But before it could be secured, the rattling of the vehicle caused the orb to release a physical surge of bright orange magic energy, causing the latter half of the helicopter compartment walls to shatter. As the orbs aura continued to skyrocket, the surrounding metal at the rear began to glow and melt.

Keeping his distance, Pyrus Bourn focused on determining an escape route. Finding and snatching a parachute pouch mounted on the wall, he strapped it to his back and prepared for the worst. He tapped on his comm hidden under his ear and shouted, "Tom Nado, come to my location quickly!"

With the rune floating on standby to secure his safety from the fall, Avery charged towards Pyrus and shoved him towards the orb as it initiated a third surge of energy.

Realizing his intention a bit late, Pyrus stumbled backwards towards the latter half of the compartment where small holes formed from where the metal was shattered and ripped.

The warnings blaring halted as soon as the vehicle entered its near final stage of destruction. The pilot had jumped out before the worst would initiate.

The duo continued to wrestle to prevent the other from escaping; however, their fight was disrupted by the orb's third surge which sent a shockwave that completely split the vehicle in the midsection.

Fully exposed to the outside air, Avery retracted and leaped onto his rune which floated under his feet. Seeing the city of Lux Urbis several hundred meters below him, he stedied his balance and slowly descended through uneasiness swept him since he could fall at any moment.

Pyrus Bourn, with his superhuman strength, lept off the latter half of the falling helicopter and popped open his parachute. With nothing he could do to control the situation, he allowed the wind to carry him to the ground.

The helicopter ascended quickly into the city and into the upper part of the central field at the center of the city. From the height he was at, Avery witnessed the explosion formed from the collision of the vehicle and the town hall directly below. It was deep in the middle of the night, thus, the sound was not immediately tramsmissioned by the surrounding inhabitants.

Eventually landing, Avery and Pyrus respectively sprinted to the town hall to witness fumes and flames circling and envoloping the entire demolished building.

"Looks like the orb is within that mess that you won't be able to access," Avery stated, keeping his distance from the villain but still monitoring his every move.

"It seems there's no point in fighting at the moment since both of us are in a stalemate, but alas, I've got backup and I'm prepared to see this through," Pyrus explained.

Then from the night sky, a sudden gust of wind split the ground between Pyrus and Avery, causing the two to step back. Subsequent wind strikes launched Avery a few meters into the air and backwards. He stumbled and rolled unstably down the steep hill of the town hall.

"Clear the fire for me!" Pyrus demanded of his subordinate.

"Alright boss," Tom Nado saluted.

Halfway down the hill, Avery managed to stop his fall and slowly heal serious injuries with his healing magic. With no apparent plan, he eventually crept up and examined the villains of their sudden moves.

Tom Nado came a few meters from the town hall and released a typhoon scale wind which could've cleared any normal forest fire; however, the orb being the catalyst of the unnatural fire was only slightly diminished.

"You gotta put more power into it, you dummy," Pyro hollered.

"Yeah… but I did, boss," Tom replied, scratching his head.

Pyrus sighed and walked up to the destruction himself. Then sighing, he stated, "The city will be awake before we know it. Too late to hide now. I'll have to initiate my plan even if there will be violence."

Tom Nado continued with his outburst of wind magic as Pyrus watched from the sidelines.

Glancing about the city, Avery noticed flares going off near the border but no immediate response from the main city.

Not a moment too soon, the police and fire trucks from the main city arrived on the scene. Unlike the mainland operations, the police officers utilized magic as their primary arms and the fire truck was heavily equipped with accessible tools for various scenarios. A fire hydrant became the source of water for the water affinity Mystical Beings.

Pyrus angrily marched towards them due to their distraction and placed a hand onto the ground. He detonated the ground with fire increaser chemicals shot from the palm of his glove. The fire increaser liquid streamlined to the vehicles and exploded them from below.

Raising his hand, he burst live flames from a contraction on the same glove, cousin the firefighters and policemen to back up.

Some spray of water passed through the flames and drenched Pyrus Bourn, but he only retaliated and intensified his own and pressured them to retreat.

"Irritating little pests," he muttered.

It was only a matter of time before the higher ranked Mystical Beings would arrive onto the scene such as emergency missions contracted to the cohorts at Regnum Academy.

Then, the roaring motor of a speeding car caught the ear of the villains and Avery. Turning around, they noticed a van zooming up the hill and through Pyrus' own flames. It parked in between the city citizens and the villains.

"I have no idea what happened yet, but this is where you ended up, Pyrus Bourn?" Kaden Icelander spoke as he came out of his car. River, Ted, and Jane filed out and rushed to the police and firefighters' aid.

Pyrus smirked, "Oh? Just the person I wanted to see. I don't suppose you can quench all my flames, huh?"

Through this statement, he was obviously hinting at something that would proceed his plans, yet Kaden was unaware of it.

Avery, realizing it was clear to move, rushed onto the scene and was about to shout for Kaden to restrain himself. But it was too late.

Ice burst from Kaden's feet and spread quickly around the entire town hall building, engulfing every flame in its path. If it hadn't been destroyed, the ice enclosed town hall might've become famous for its spectacle.

Forming a sword of ice, Kaden rushed forward and locked blades against the fire villain who had reached for his own.

"Though my flames have been quenched, you have done me a favor for once," the villain gloated.

"Favor? Oh, I'll do you a favor of ending your schemes. Your plans will be stopped before you ever get your hands on the earth orb," Kaden eyes burned with malice.

Pyrus grinned an evil smile and laughed.

"The orb's in the town hall!" Avery shouted before the villain could continue to fool the prodigy. At least he could notify Kaden instead of engaging in the fight with him. His contribution against the villain would've only held the prodigy back from unleashing his true skills.

Stunned for a moment, Kaden nodded and increased his strike speed to lock the villain in a restrained fight.

"It's too late for you guys," Pyrus huffed as he continued to avoid Kaden's strikes and sword blocking any lethal blows. The man moved and skipped in evasion all the way to the town hall's doorsteps, his movements a twisted dance.

Though the duo were almost evenly matched when it came to the swordsmanship skill, Pyrus' enormous strength ensured his strikes landed harder.

With such force, he snapped Kaden's blade numerously amidst the fight yet the prodigy's flexible agility buyed him time to craft a new one.

Pyrus Bourn quickly became aware of the ice's ability to spread on contact so he decided to block with only his blade at any point. Standing still, his blade arm flew at a new rate causing Kaden to step back and be on the defense.

Pyrus was clearly holding back, hoping to preserve some of his energy for tougher fights later in the city. With a free hand, he thrusted through the town hall's doors and skipped inside the wreckage.

Both Avery and Kaden pursued inside, their every intention to prevent the villain's progress.

Taking a fire increaser canister from his back, he lit the ground around him with chemically created flames only for Kaden to extinguish it with ice. In this split moment of a diversion, he leaped into the air and landed on the ground under the ice-covered town hall roof with a great hole formed by the fallen vehicle now laying in splatters.

Kaden landed nearby a moment later to witness the villain digging through the rubble with his gloved hands.

Past midnight now, the moon shone through the roof and lit between the two locked in a duel.

"Oh no you don't," he sstated, rushing forward and aiming for Pyrus' neck.

Pyrus snatched the blade midair and chuckled with conquest. With his other bear fist, he lunged into the boy's gut and sent him flying into the wall.

"Killing young lives isn't part of my plan, but insisting on bothering me will give you what you deserve."

With a fire increaser blast shot from his palm again, he shoved large debris chunks towards Avery who could do nothing but hold his arms to protect his vitals. The weight shoved him down, causing him to muster healing magic.

Bright orange light shone around the room as the final rubble was shoved aside to reveal the orb's presence.

Slowly standing to his feet, Kaden, clearly drained of stamina and most of his magic power, continued to protest against the villain.

Lifting the orb high, Pyrus, somehow conscious of the inner power stored within, unleashed an explosion that seperated the building into pieces. Everyone, including Tom Nado who stood on standby, became victims of the disaster and were buried by the destruction.

The rubble and the remnants scattered several meters all around the hill and brand new flames encircled the entire surface.

With the rob clutched within his hands, Pyrus Bourn was the sole remaining individual who stood unscathed from the destruction.



Chapter 15: Awakening

Rubble flew in every direction, dust and dirt buried the once great hall. It was no longer in its regal state; now it was a devastated burnt ruin from whence Pyrus had appeared. The flames contrasted drastically with the cold dark night.

Buried under the rocks, Ted's attempt of breaking free was of no avail. The large roof of the hall crumbled and scattered the field, burying the motionless bodies of River and Jane.

Amidst the silence and destruction, Pyrus Bourn stood triumphant, unfazed of his actions. His sinister smile shone above the defeated as he held high above his head the glowing dark red orb.

"After all these years, I've finally got it," he exclaimed. "You low Mystical Beings didn't stand a chance."

His expression changed from one of triumph to extreme pain as the orb's overflowing magical power started surging through his body. He dropped the orb and fell to the ground, writhing in pain.

As Avery lay beaten and battered a few feet nearby, his eyes slowly secumming to defeat, he watched as the orb of destruction fell and slowly rolled towards him.

Avery felt the strange sensation he felt so long ago, his instincts telling him to reach for it.

It was a mysterious force urging him—touch it and let the magic resonate with his own.

Reluctantly, with nothing else to do but take the risk, he extended a hand and gently touched the smooth surface of the blazing orb.

Immediately, he felt his mind open. Power seemed to flow into him. Despite the awakening feeling, it was not all one sided.

He felt an uncontrollable force knotting in his stomach, and he doubled over feeling nauseated. His head started to spin, and a loud noise started to drown his ears.

Memories flashed in his head as he watched the first time he was bullied, the first time he was ever happy, and a potential future of the last time he ever got to say, "I love you."

Touching the source of almost infinite magic caused one to reconsider what they even knew or held onto—recalling a vestage of their destiny and fate.

His existence would've either tore apart or succumbed to insanity with the amount of visions passing through his head.

Avery closed his eyes wanting for everything to go away, wishing he never had been found, and hoping for it all to end. Unlike Pyrus writhing in pain, he only felt his mind being teared from within from the sheer amount of overwhelming magic.

Giving up wasn't an option, so he let his mind go, ending the visions and sending him into a pitch dark void.

Opening his eyes, he found himself standing over a clear glass pool of water reflecting a spotless white sky.

His soul at some point in time had ventured past the door that shone brightness and now he stood in a rather peaceful paradise.

It was not the same sesnation as living or dying—rather, a fragment of reality and dream blurred in a statis of virtual conciousness.

The waters reflected the invisible rays casted from the pure whiteness of the endless dome that encampased the area seeable by the naked eye.

Avery was not alone either as another figure remained in place a short distance off.

Facing him was a young woman flowing with beauty and peace. She had reflective brown hair and the same pink sapphire eyes as his. Her white dress shone with the water as if she were part of the sky itself.

She smiled at Avery and glided over to him gently pressing her hand on his cheek. Her eyes filled with tears as she touched him.

The boy couldn't react nor oabject to the strage friendly gestures of the woman.

"Avery, you have grown strong. You have faced challenges beyond any capable man. But you must endure and survive. I tried everything in my power to protect you, but now you must learn to fight and defend yourself. I'm glad that I am able to watch you grow."

Avery looked at her in a dreamy state of mind. The first words he spoke was not of confusion.

"Who are you?"

The woman smiled as she stood back, "You will know in due time. But right now, we don't have a lot of time. You are in a subconscious dimension separated from life and death. How this may have occurred, I cannot say. I have come to warn you that the orb you placed your hand on granted you enormous power and strength; however, all power comes with a great cost. You must not abuse the power the orb gave you."

Avery's head was still spinning, and his eyes were already slowly closing again. He mumbled out, "What cost? And what power?"

"Power than rival even the most powerful of the deities in legend. Remember that the orbs were never supposed to be used as they are the compressed magic of the ancient times. Take heed on this warning."

"Warning? I–I don't understand."

"Your case was unique and no one else may venture down the same path as you. This warning calls not only your action of obtaining power, but the risks of this power in the future."

Avery looked around and gave no response. This all was too sudden and had connections to his strange unknown origins before life in New York.

"Your magical potential has arisen. You have now attained Tier 2: *Bonus*, Level 3."

Avery was shocked by such a substantial jump in magical power. The women even smiled as if to reflect his progress.

"Why me?" he asked the woman.

"Because I have chosen you. You, along with the others, will be the ones to change the world in due time."

Before Avery could ask more, the subconscious dimension began to fade. As his eyes closed once again, the woman smiled only mouthing, "I love you."

It was a strange sensation. He didn't recognize the woman as his mother yet her gentle tone and familiarity with him felt comfortable and desirable.

Now whisked back in reality again, Avery felt a searing pain throughout his entire body ready to explode out.

As if the mental urges subsided, he no longer felt the orb's magic as an attractive force for his own.

Gaining hope again, he slowly began to rise, his body shouting in pain and begging to yield. He kicked the orb further away from him afraid of its power and determined not to allow Pyrus closer to it.

Avery's body was glowing in an unnatural bright yellow light, almost as if armor of light surrounded him. His senses sharpened as if magic itself was fueling his mental stability and concentration. All of his intentions morphed into the powers he needed at most.

He conjured a light sword and approached the groveling body of Pyrus still in the midst of internal pain.

Light Magic: Gladius Lucis.

"Looks like this is it for… you," he stated, standing up straight, breathing heavily.

"You think so, eh?" Pyrus mocked as he himself began to stand up. Suddenly, he was no longer in the same state he was before. His armor was crumpled and tattered, however, his demeaner surpassed his anguish and pain.

Magic poured out of him in waves that even intimidated Avery. HIs opponent was no longer unranked due to lack of magic. Now, Avery could just estimate that he was Tier 3: *Altus*, Level 1.

Apparently it was an awakening for the both of them respectively.

He unbuckled the weight strapped onto his back and removed parts of his equipment scattered about his armor in preparation to unleash his newfound abilities.

"Looks like… the orb was way too powerful for a non-Mystical Being like… m-myself." he stated in an agonizing voice.

Then with another holler of pain, Pyrus Bourn's body began to glow with a bright fiery light as some sort of energy began to flow throughout his body.

"But… huhhhh… it seems to b-be… a different story for those with exposure to magic for some time."

He sethed in and out to subside the attention of his wailing body.

Avery stumbled backwards from the increasing heat increasing around the vicinity of the villain.

"Ugh, what is this?" He shielded the glaring sunlight like heat emitting from Pyrus.

The radiating fire magic was something else compared with the Masumi brothers'. Though the emitting flames were still orange, it was no longer classified as anything normal.

"Not what I expected to occur… but this brings a whole new age of products," Pyrus smirked, letting his fire go wild and release from his body.

With no hesitation, he compacted the fire into a sphere and launched it in the direction of Avery.

"Now stay down."

"Stay back!" Avery shouted as he dropped his light sword and created a wall of light. "I won't back down!"

Being in a situation where he couldn't focus on his magic power, in his current state, all he could manage was the release of all his magic from his palms at once.

Light Magic: Light Barrier.

The fireball and light barrier clashed, combining the energy of both magics and sending sparks of both magics counteracted.

"AAAHHH!" Avery shouted as he endeared the full weight of Pyrus' incoming attack.

"Huh, what? What is this light magic?" Pyrus exclaimed in a rising voice. "No matter. I'll… just… stop it!"

Avery noticed his light barrier was far more compressed and brighter than it ever was. Even dealing with the fireball attack was easier than before.

"Looks like I understand the full extent of this power," he murmbered out loud.



After the fire ball vaporized, Avery dispersed his light shield and approached Pyrus more confidently than before.

The halo rune behind his back floated higher behind him while radiating with more magic as well.

“Are you prepared to be utterly defeated?” Pyrus taunted, creating a ring of fireballs circling behind him.

Avery created a light sword again; this time, he applied more light into the sword to create the same weapon with more compressed light, thus making it brighter than before.

Compression Magic: Condensed Light.

Turning to a charging stance, Avery sprinted towards Pyrus, planning to end the fight once and for all.

Launching the fireballs, Pyrus greened at the thought of the fight coming to an end. Rushing towards Pyrus at full speed, Avery deflected and sliced the fireballs drawing near him.

"What? You weren't this strong before!" Pyrus protested, launching more fireballs. "So you must have touched the orb too! Such a phenomena would only occur if you possessed little magic before—"

Deflecting them as before, Avery came within inches before Pyro and took a swipe of his sword, causing him to stop mid sentence.

Unsheathing his own sword, Pyrus blocked the attack at an angle thought impossible by even a great swordsman.

"—Sorry, but I'm the world's greatest swordsman. So, this is my specialty," he gleamed. "Magic or physical, all attacks are the same for a swordsman like me."

Now suddenly bending the laws of gravity around him, Avery formed a ring of condensed light orbs around his rune which began to spin moderately. A light circular halo radiated around his back with the rune at its nucleus.

Light Magic plus Compression Magic: Spiraling Light Seeking Orbs.

He lunged his hand forward and sent the swirling orbs towards the enemy all at once.

"Humph, and what is that supposed to do?" Pyrus demanded, stomping the ground and causing a geyser of fire to spew from the ground.

The flaming geyser engulfed the light orbs, yet the light magic did not cease to press forward.

Now in a defensive stance, Pyrus sliced each light orb one by one before they reached their targets to impale them.

Engulfing his blade with flames, he launched numerous archs of fire from his blade to which Avery deflected with agility.

Feeling his magic draining rather quickly, but nonetheless, purer than ever before, Avery felt his imagination open up at the magical possibilities and the potential he could gain through practice.

As the halo rune descended onto his head, he channeled the light energy throughout his body, thus, making him faster than ever before.

His body radiating with light, he launched several fist attacks capable enough to even put the villain on the defensive.

Still hesitant on his newfound powers but quickly adapting to it, Pyrus launched forward with fire propelled thrusters from his feet to reach an incredible speed.

Fire Magic: Flame Prepulsion.

He swiped past the boy before he could react.

Avery fell back as a deep wound appeared on his chest. With magic continuing to flow through his body, his quick leap to retreat from the villain was greater than ever before.

Pressing magic imbued hands against his wound, the damage was quickly sealed and began to regenerate quickly.

“Pesky little magic you’ve got there,” Pyrus pointed out, analysing Avery’s actions from afar.

With this new power up, Avery might’ve stood a chance against the normal Pyrus Bourn, yet the villain's inferno powers elevated his already strong capabilities even further.

Not aware of the boy’s magic limitations quite yet, Pyrus kept his distance to devise a strategy for ending the battle. He didn’t want to burn through magic just to continuously fail.

The duo remained several meters apart on top of the destruction anticipating the strike of whoever acted first.

Avery poured more magic into his shins and blitzed forward at the same speed of the villain before. Swiping his condensed light sword at the villain’s torso, the blade phased past.

Pyrus glanced down at his armor and saw the pierced marks of where the cut phased through. Surprisingly, his body was still intact and where skin would’ve been shone, fire sprouted out instead.

Avery, a short distance away where he landed, turned and gasped at the sight of the villain standing tall with flames bursting from his torso without a hit of a groan of pain.

“How?” he exclaimed.

He stood up to face the villain only to realize his magic was mostly drained.

Pyrus looked down on the boy and stated, “I’ve not just consumed fire, I’ve become fire itself!”

Fire Magic: Flame Reincarnation.

With a burst of laughter, flames erupted from his hands and crumbled the nearby structure remnants.

Hoping his friends were not stil within the mess and chaos, Avery channeled light magic into a sphere in his free hand and charged.

His light ball clashed with the villain’s fiery blade, causing the both to be knocked back.

Reaching on his head, Avery snatched his halo rune and threw it towards the villain while mentally commanding for it to rotate.

After traveling halfway, the rune turned viertically so that Avery could fire a blast of light magic through the center.

In a life and death situation, his intellect was imagining various strategies to counter the villain’s very intentions.

Light Magic: Light Wave.

The circulatory motion of the rune caused the phased light magic to twirl rapidly to become a tornado light current with increased hitting power.

Pyrus blocked with the flat of his blade and was continuously pushed back by the immense pressure of the magic.

“Gah!”

He reached with his free hand and pushed against the magic with his own fiery inferno vortex of the same magnitude.

Inferno Magic: Vortex of Doom.

Pitting magic against magic, only the stronger one remained dominant. Not long after, the tide turned to the villains favor as his flames engulfed the light and pressed towards the caster.

With the rune in front of him, Avery reversed its direction to counter the flame vortex swirling towards him. The fire interacting with the rune immediately dissipated.

“Cheeky little brat. You think you can reach my level and counter me? Looks like I’ll have to use a little more just to end this,” the villain clenched his fists.

Then propelling upwards and flying meteors into the sky, Pyrus Bourn looked down on the ruined terrain and stated, “I’ll just destroy you and everyone else!”

His hands now glowing bright yellow with enormous magical power, he launched the flame in a beam towards the remnants of the town hall.

Inferno Magic: Nova Beam.

Seeing the scale of the magic attack would disintigrate everything within a few kilometers, Avery lunged forward and poured the remainder of his magic into a massive scale light barrier to reflect the fire beam.

The beam shot straight into Avery’s barrier and cracked it with its immense weight. The boy crumpled down while still remaining fixed on not letting go.

As both his heart beated rapidly and his blood pressure elevated, he continued to pour poor magic outwards to sustain his activated barrier.

Channeling magic straight up his upper body at a rate never performed before, Avery grunted with pain as he endured the continuous blast of inferno fire.

Willing to shoot through the sky, Avery’s back began to burn as more magic coursed through then ever before.

Then, grand white wings burst from his back as the magic turned into a physical characteristic of his Angelor heritage for the first time.

Aware of what he had to do, even if he lacked the experience or proper training, Avery flapped his wings and leaped into the air.

Though he was awkward adjusting to his new ability, he nonetheless, effectively supplied enough force to break free from gravity and sour into the sky.

Pushing against the magic blast with slowly but increasing speed, Avery directed the blast towards the villain by minimizing the distance between them.

As he soured up, the parting flames of the attack began to burn his skin even under the layer of magic protecting him.

Without a way to extinguish the attack, the inferno blast exploded in the sky, causing the duo to fall back to the ground.

Using his remaining light magic to shield himself, Avery fell a good distance and injured a leg upon contact to the ground.

He remained vulnerable as soon as the remainder of his magic became used up. His new wings became bruised by the fall but otherwise undamaged.

Pyrus, on the other hand, remained mostly unscatehd from his own attack. He landed after the immense drain on his magical energy.

But it was apparent, Pyrus then began to caugh as the immense toll of the attack backfired on him.

“Uh… tsh, I’ll end you for the… annoyance you’ve been.”

Seeing the orb nested under a few rocks, Avery crawled towards it hoping to guard it from the villain’s clutches again.

As Avery lay in defeat and Pyrus' looming figure shadowed over him with a demonic sneer ready to rain destruction and imminent death on him.

Avery looked back at the words that Kaden grinningly once told him, “Remember, if you’re ever in need, I’ve always got your back.”

As he locked eyes with Pyrus Bourn ready to take his last breath—if anything to stop the merceless villain.

Then, emerging from the rubbles, a familiar figure entered the scene.

Kaden Icelander appeared, his clean business suit tainted with battle, holding a sword. He emerged from the ruin and had a whole new demeaner about him.

“Remember what I’ve said,” Kaden said, swinging his sword forward releasing a powerful icy blast of air, “I’ve always got your back.”

Quite ironic for him to appear at that moment, but what mattered was that he was here to take a shot.

The blade he held this time was not of ice, but of cool hard metal with intricate textures of ancient inscriptions. Snake-shaped lines coiled around the hilt with their blue eyes peering on either ends of the guard.

“Well, finish what we’ve already started,” Avery replied weakly.

He watched as Kaden examined the villain who was emitting a more powerful aura than before that radiated across the room.

Pyrus was quickly adjusting to his new powers, even recovering after a short conquest.

“Kaden can’t do this by himself.” Avery cried hard to maintain consciousness but the strain on his body was too great, so he slowly blacked out.

Pyrus Bourn examined his hands which burned in a delightful hue comparable to his frustrations. As his flames raged by burning the atmosphere, he sensed his recovery was abnormally quickened externally without effort.

With a gleeful smile of his new power, he narrowed his eyes upon his next opponent.

Kaden, now alone without any support or aid, marched slowly forwards towards Pyrus Bourn. His eyes glowed with pride and power compared to his foe.

"What made you think that you could simply come into our school and take what you wanted? Everything has a price and I'm going to set it for you," Kaden called out as Pyrus began preparing for a counter.

"That's old news. Why bring that up now? You then went and invaded my district! So revenge is all you play at when left to choose?" Pyrus sneered.

"I just wanted to feel good about myself," was the prodigy's reply.

"Heh, that's such a messed up way of thinking."

"Says the one who has such a self-centered idealistic goal only reachable by doing terrible things."

Pyrus grinned, his fiery aura intensifying as he prepared to unleash another devastating attack.

"Idealistic goals or not, I will achieve what I set out to do, no matter the cost! This is the only way to bring peace to this disunified Mystical Island."

Kaden, standing firm and resolute, raised his sword, which now glowed with a cold, blue light as ice from his hand surrounded it.

"Then prepare to face the consequences, because ideals or not, the methods you've chosen will only make enemies, starting with me."

"What if I care? My ideals undoubtedly will form division—all for a greater purpose!"

Pyrus launched forward, his body engulfed in brighter flames. He shot a concentrated stream of fire toward Kaden, intending to incinerate him where he stood.

Kaden responded swiftly, raising his sword, now in ice, and channeling his innate ice magic to go to work.

Ice Magic: Glacial Shield.

A massive wall of ice erupted from the ground, intercepting the inferno blast, as soon as Kaden plunged the sword into the ground.

The intense heat clashed with the icy barrier, creating a burst of steam and mist that enveloped the battlefield.

As the steam cleared, Kaden was already on the move. He dashed forward, his sword trailing icy particles in its wake.

Ice Magic: Frozen Strike.

He slashed at Pyrus, who barely managed to block with his own fiery blade.

The clash of ice and fire sent shockwaves through the air, the ground beneath them cracking from the sheer force of their blows.

Unlike before, Kaden Icelander was surging with unfamiliar magical energy which caused his movements to increase yet his hasty blows indicated he was on a limited power amp duration.

Pyrus, determined to end the fight quickly, channeled more of his infernal power.

Inferno Magic: Flame Whip.

He created a whip of fire, snapping it toward Kaden's leg with lethal precision.

Kaden, not missing a beat, countered with a another move of his own.

Ice Magic: Ice Chains.

He thrust his hand forward, and icy chains erupted from the ground, intercepting the flame whip and wrapping around it. The ice rapidly spread, extinguishing the flames as it moved closer to Pyrus.

The attack insnared Pyrus and immobilized him just for a moment for Kaden to pounce in front for a quick slash.

The blade, even in ice, phased through as the flaming menace became seperatable flames for a brief duration.

Kaden leaped back just as Pyrus snarled in frustration, breaking free from the chains with a burst of fiery energy.

"You're more of a nuisance than I anticipated, but this ends now!" He raised both hands above his head, conjuring a massive sphere of fire which became slightly bluer than the prior flames before.

Inferno Magic: Hellflame Meteor.

Kaden's eyes widened as the massive ball of fire descended upon him.

He knew he had to act quickly. But there was just one thing, he was not actually wielding the true powers of the sword at the moment.

Instead, it was a blunt blade coated in ice to seem fiercer. No resolute power was capable of defending against the next inferno attack.

So, he had a single choice.

He sheathed his sword and concentrated, drawing upon the depths of his ice blade's innate power. It wasn't something easily done—risky at that also.

Ice Magic: Absolute Zero.

With a slight push of a finger for the blade to retract from the sheath, he gripped the blade with a free hand and swung it in an arc before him.

A wave of freezing air radiated from Kaden's blade, dropping the temperature around him to extreme lows, even far surpassing the distance of the villain's own explosive ability.

He then thrust his hands upward, and a colossal spike of ice shot forth, meeting the inferno meteor head-on.

Now with the temperature set right, his defense was more stable to counteract the incoming inferno.

The fire magic became enveloped by ice and became a giant crystalized sphere of frosty icicles. Then, the collision created a spectacular explosion of fire and ice, the opposing forces battling for dominance but canciling each other out equally.

The air chilled and crisped at the same time. The pavement also cracked and bent under the harsh environmental alterations.

In the midst of the chaos, Kaden pushed himself further. He called upon every ounce of his strength and magic, despite the wavering sideffects of the blade's ability kicking in.

Ice Magic: Frostbite Frenzy.

He launched a flurry of ice shards and frost-covered attacks at Pyrus, each strike faster and more powerful than the last.

The shards grazed the villain in numerous areas due to fire affinity's natural weakness.

Pyrus struggled to defend against the relentless onslaught. The temperature around him plummeted, his flames dimming as the cold sapped his strength.

"No... this can't be…" he muttered, feeling his power wavor.

Through each attack, Kaden felt his magic draining rapidly and his own attack became progressively more rusty, but the villain did not catch on quite yet.

Not wanting to be beaten so easily by a talented individual at a distance, Pyrus lunged forward and pitted swords with the opponent.

Kaden, with no choice, blocked with his own blade.

As soon as his flame blade clashed against the strange blade wielded by Kaden, it started to crack and shudder from an intense blue wave of magic.

"What is this?" he muttered, prancing backwards and glancing at the weakened state of his blade now cracked and tattered.

"This blade is called the Goblin Sword and was wielded by an ancestry of Icelorians You could even call it the Icelorian Sword," Kaden indicated, raising his shiny blade to compare with the villain's.

"Gah, so that's the fate of that treacherous weapon. How come you chose not to wield it earlier? Things might've turned out differently?" Pyrus grimaced.

"Even at this moment, this blade cannot be wielded by one with short convictions. I'm utilizing it now since it is a desperate situation but there'll be a great cost to it," Kaden responded.

He gripped the hilt tightly and prepared for another assault.

"Humph, despirate or not, you'll lose," the flaming villain threatened.

"You're right, it's time to end this," Kaden remarked, dashing forward with his blade held up to stab the villain.

Pyrus knew that another strike would cause his flames to retract completely, so he needed a method of refualing his mana quickly.

More sirens flared throughout the city as the commotion on the hill woke the nearby inhabitants. The duo had progressed too far to be concerned of any third-party encounters.

Kaden Icelander dashed forward, his Icelorian Sword raised to deliver a decisive blow. His eyes were fierce with ressolve, but the toll on his body from wielding such a powerful weapon was becoming too apparent.

Every step felt heavier, each movement more labored. He hadn't anticipated the battle drawing this long or the enemy to be more capable.

Pyrus Bourn, though his accumulation in the air could not replenish his power fast enough, deemed his remaining reservoir was necessary to finish the deal.

His fiery aura intensified, a blazing inferno against the encroaching cold of Kaden's ice magic.

As their weapons clashed once more, the sound echoed through the ruined hall, a cacophony of fire and ice. Pyrus' own blade became more crumpled from the sheer impact.

"Your strength is commendable, Kaden," Pyrus sneered through gritted teeth, "but you are outmatched. If it was another time in another place, I'd take you on as a disciple."

Kaden's breath was ragged, but his resolve remained unbroken. "I won't let you destroy everything we've fought for. Not while I can still breathe!"

With a final, desperate effort, Kaden swung his sword in a wide arc. The blade, infused with his ice magic, collided with Pyrus' flaming sword one last of time.

The force of the impact shattered the ground beneath them, sending shockwaves through the battlefield. Rubble flew into the air and the clouds in the night sky became distant.

Despite Kaden's unwavering resolve, Pyrus was relentless as a wild beast. Drawing upon the stored reservoir of strength, he pushed back with a surge of red fiery power.

The flames roared, consuming Kaden's ice magic and driving the young boy to his knees.

"N-No!" Kaden cried out, feeling the intense heat sear his skin.

His grip on the Icelorian Blade faltered, and Pyrus seized the opportunity.

With a triumphant roar, Pyrus unleashed a torrent of bright yellow fire, engulfing Kaden in a blazing inferno.

The heat was unbearable, and Kaden's defenses crumbled under the overwhelming power. He was thrown back, his body battered and burned, landing in a heap among the rubble.

Avery, in a similar condition, unable to move his body, could only watch from the distance.

Pyrus stood tall, his victory seemingly assured. "This is the end for you, Kaden Icelander. It was nice fighting with a prodigy, and winning of course."

Just as Pyrus prepared to deliver the final blow, a new wave of sirens pierced the air nearby. Police officers, drawn by the chaos, arrived on the scene in their vehicles. They aimed their Mystical-enhanced guns and other weapons at Pyrus, their faces resolute despite the evident fear.

“Freeze! Stand down and surrender!” one of the officers commanded.

Pyrus laughed, a deep, menacing sound. “You think you can stop me? You're nothing but insects to me now.”

With a casual flick of his wrist, Pyrus sent a wall of fire towards the officers. They scattered, trying to avoid the searing heat, but many were caught in the flames, their screams filling the night.

About to laugh again with triumph, Pyrus glanced through the smoke and noticed certain figures looming in the distance. Then water engulfed the flames and extinguished the fire on the wouunded officers.

Surprised, but otherwise irritated, Pyrus marched forward and lit his hands with red flames. “More pests have decided to interfere?”

But emerging from the ash and smoke was a tall man with long silver hair. His eyes were fiercer than ever as he effortlessly sprayed water on the small flames on the ground around him.

“And who might you be?” Pyrus demanded.

“Name’s Atlas Aquia. No one gets away messing up the city we’ve so tediously built up,” the regal figure declared.

“Ah I see. You’re just one of those cohort captains at Regnum. What chance do you stand against me?”

“Don’t get cocky, you villain. You’ve yet to realize the full capabilities of that magic of yours or the restrictions,” Atlas stated.

Then another figure emerged from the smoke. It was a familiar woman with black hair and a serious demeaner.

“You?” Pyrus gasped, “How did you escape?”

Charlotte Levy, the other figure, approached the villain and stood beside Atlas. “Thanks to certain students of ours, we were notified shortly after my awakening of your schemes,” she responded.

“Though you’ve caused quite a casualty, at least the students buyed time for us to arrive before the city became in danger,” Atlas added.

“So be it,” Pyrus snared. “Bring it on!”

Seizing every second to fan his flames to intensify and absorb more magic, Pyrus began to become a little uneasy about his continued battle.

Regardless, he was not backing down. Even if he was to not become human again, he decided to use *his* power to his fullest.

Giving a small gesture to indicate the battle sequence, Atlas remained fixated on the villain. He compressed water magic within his palms in preparation for an opportunity to attack.

Charlotte nodded to the Aquia Captain’s commands, her purple flames flickering with intensity. “Let's end this.”

In response, flames burst around Pyrus’ feet as he conjured a large orange ball of inferno fire.

“You think stopping me is the solution to this societies problems? I won’t give up on my end until the desirable outcome is mine at last!” he roared.

“I wouldn’t distract yourself with that mouth of yours,” Atlas stated.

He extended his arms, and torrents of water surged from his palms, dousing the flames around the villain. The water collided with Pyrus' fire, creating a hissing steam that clouded the battlefield in steam.

Charlotte, her purple flames crackling with energy, launched herself at Pyrus from the misty steam.

“You won't get away with this!”

Pyrus, taken aback by the ferocity of her attack, barely managed to conjure a shield of flames to block her assault.

“You were beaten last time. It shouldn’t matter whether you’re in my way or not.”

Charlotte's eyes burned with determination. “We'll see about that. Last time, I was holding back to see what sort of business you had.”

“Oh really?” Pyrus smirked, not buying the response.

With newly revealed speed, Charlotte darted around the villain like a beast to its prey and lunged with fangs of purple flames.

Fire Magic: Talon of the Abyss.

Unlike their first bout, her flames were far more intense and regulated with the intention to brutally harm the villain.

—Or it was rather the unique advantage the duo had on the villain.

As one would expect magic to dissipate once utilized, Charlotte's flames from her attacks lingered in the air after each strike, thus, limiting the villain's maneuvering every strike.

With her shoe immersed with purple flames, Charlotte kicked Pyrus in the chest, causing him to fly into the ground a few feet.

"Gah!" he coughed as his body crunched against the pathment.

As more of his magic became used up, his physical body began to resurface. He then scrambled up and faded behind the veil of steam.

"You've drastically underestimated the power of Lux Urbis," Atlas stated, indicating his turn on the offense, but cautious on every step.

"Nooo! My ideals won't go up in flames. Can't you see the corrupt world that needs mending?" Pyrus shouted through the fog, his voice echoing all around.

He formed this divisive tactic at the last moment, resorting to persuasion to plant some doubt on his contenders.

"You've only been causing destruction. What could you possibly do that could make this city alone better?" Charlotte remarked, glancing about for the direction of the real voice.

Pyrus Bourn looked around at the ruined town hall and had no answer to refute the argument. He was too far to turn back now.

To fullfil his goals, no retreat was possible. It was time for his last stand if needed be.

Converting all his mana into raw magic, the temperature around him drastically increased as the flames around his body turned a bright shade of yellow.

With a specific concentration of heat, he was prepared to blow up his surroundings to take his opponents out—even at the risk of his humanity.

Stepping forward to reveal himself as the ticking time bomb, he was intrigued of what action the duo would take.

Swirling excess water around him, Atlas sent a stream of water around the enemy and formed a cell around him.

Water plus Compression Magic: Water Cell Walls.

Without realizing it, Pyrus Bourn became the victim despite thinking of being the trap. Confined in the water jail, there was no reversing his alreading detonating attack now.

The durability of the condensed water cells slightly budged by the intense flames as it blew within the confined space, incinerating all matter within the water cell.

Pyrus Bourn remained conscious as the flames only tingled his own flamafied body.

Buying plenty of time for Charlotte to strike, the idle opponent became an easy target for finishing.

With a flat palm pointed forward, Charlotte engulfed her hand in an avatar of purple flame magic that spiraled towards the trapped Pyrus Bourn.

Fire Magic: Flame Dragon's Ascent.

The magically created dragon phased through the cage and collided with the villain and stripped him of the existing flames surfacing from his body.

The flames leaped from the villain and circulated, as if dancing, within the jail. The flames somehow did not harm Pyrus, despite his human body appearing back into farm again.

"Ahhhh!" the villain wailed in agony… only for a short moment. Other pains within his body intensified from the overuse of magic circulation.

He then fused flame magic within himself and exploded his way free after absorbing the circulating flames from within the cell.

Inferno Magic: Hellblast Charge.

"I won't stop… never… won't stop… will I finish," Pyrus mumbled as

Launching forward with flared yellow eyes, he pressured Atlas into a defensive stance.

Water plus Compression Magic: Water Barrier.

Using his repulsive force to increase his speed, Pyrus launched rapid fist attacks on Atlas who defended with a hardened water barrier.

Bursting upwards with flames, Pyrus crashed into the ground nearest to the town hall rubble, overhauling the destruction and sending chunks of rocks towards Atlas and Charlotte.

The pair doged and rushed to where the villain had landed.

With a shift in his mood, Atlas irritatedly poured water around the villain and encased him within a dense cocoon.

Water plus Compression Magic: Dense Water Prison.

Not desiring to repeat the same mistake, this time, the prison was five times stronger than the last.

Charlotte quickly approached the cocoon and placed her hand within it and touched Pyrus Bourn.

When she ignited her palm with purple flames, Pyrus Bourn's own magic began to dissipate until all flames extinguished from his body.

Fire Magic: Magic Absorbtion.

"This can't be…" he murmured from inside the water prison, his magic depleting him to nothing and his strength betraying him.

"Villains like you are dealt with swiftly," Atlas stated, intently eyeing the enemy and expressing his sheer dominance.

Feeling nauseated, the villain lost consciousness due to the magic drain. He then returned to his normal appearance of red hair and a scawly expression despite becoming unconscious.

Atlas released him from the cocoon and bound him with water handcuffs that prevented his magic flow from his hands and feet.

Then a white falcon familiar leaped from a silver magical portal behind Atlas. The bird landed and perched on his master who directed some simple instructions.

The bird then flew up and squealed loudly to call in the remaining forces to tend to the destruction site.

The villain steamed a bit from his ragged armor, but otherwise was quenched of his immense power.

Avery witnessed the battle play to the end and was astonished by the sheer power gap between him and the cohort captains.

Even the villain stood no chance against their combined strength and coordination. He soon lost consciousness as his body finally gave in.

More firefighters and police officers arrived on the scene to tend to the others buried under the rubble and knocked out.

Kaden was one of the first to be tended after his severe mana depletion and direct attack from the villain.

Other police offiers took hostage Pyrus Bourn and one of his subordinates, Tom Nado, and drove them off to the Lux Urbis prison.

"To think… all this was orchestrated by those behind our backs," Atlas contemplated. He analysed the scene of what was left of the town hall and the recent excavation team that arrived to clear the area.

"Well, gotta thank those students of mine for following an unusual leader like Kaden Icelander. Though I would be against it, I never thought they were capable of pulling off a feat as invading another district," Charlotte remarked.

"It was clearly thought out, for the most part. Kaden probably knew that an open front district invasion would've stirred the entire island. I'll be sure to notify the school who should reach out to the council about this ordeal. We'd most likely have to send some envoys to regulate District 3 and pretend none of this happened," Atlas explained.

"Due to the situation at hand, they won't get any praise, but that probably works out for the best. Despite all that, they may well grow to even surpass us someday," Charlotte observed.

"Surpass us? Like that'll happen. I've just begun my journey to eventually become Magni Mage of this district," Atlas rebutted. "Anyway, let's finish up here."

"What about the earth orb? It's a surprise to me that such a legendary object really did exist," Charlotte inquired.

"I'll see it secured. In the meantime, the council must be notified of this, afterall, this changes everything of what occurred such as the school attack," Atlas responded.

Several Mystical Beings specialized in affairs directly under the Mystical Council arrived shortly with the means to pick up and secure the orb.

They picked up the orb with specialized magic repellant gloves and locked the orb into a metal blastproof canister.

And so, the orb that laid at the center of the destruction was carefully examined and concealed in a secure container and was quickly brought into a truck heading towards the Lux Urbis private vaults.

With the enemy bound, the battle was won.

Despite the young party led by Kaden being defeated, their ambitions would grow through the effortless show displayed by the cohort captains.

Chapter 16: Resolution

Avery woke up in the school's hospital facility. Looking down, he saw his arm and legs were patched with bandages and his body ached all over. His wings were still out and he had no way of reversing whatever caused it to appear in the first place.

He felt better after some time of sleep and his passive magic's rapid recovery on his body, yet he felt a tinge of guilt knowing there may be a stern talk from the higher ups. Something along the lines of, *Why, a mere student would do such a reckless thing? Such a vile act could endanger the school's reputation as a whole!*

Glancing out the nearby window, Avery saw the sun was on the horizon indicating it was far past midday. On another bed beside him, he noticed Ted already awake and concentrated on repairing his hoverboard that laid scattered on his bed sheet.

"Ted? You… good?" Avery called quietly, then halted.

"Man, I forgot how much my head throbbed from the impact of those rocks," he mumbled. Then turning and analyzing Avery, he spoke with an excited tone, "Hey, I'm doing all right. You should be more worried about yourself. I only got some minor stuff anyway, but you fought that flaming dude."

"Uh, yeah," Avery admitted weakly, scratching his back.

"So, you're an Angelor all right. Those wings indicate so. They're pretty big and… uh, cool. That means you're… a demihuman."

"Thanks, I guess? Regardless of that, these new powers from my magic helped me stand a little against Pyrus Bourn," Avery said. "Though, I still don't understand the vision I had…"

"Vision?" Ted asked, perplexed. "Hyperventilation?"

"No, it's not that. Just something a little confusing," Avery said. Then he explained in great detail what he experienced.

"Whoa, that's something else! Never heard of anything like that occurring," Ted exclaimed, not much help to explaining Avery's problems. Still, he seemed to believe every word.

“I suppose we’re cooped in here until they say we are healed,” Avery stated, looking around at the medical room the two slept in. Surgical equipment looked tempered with but otherwise prepared for use. Whoever responsible for the medicine left pharmacy drugs on a silver platter atop a wooden cart.

Avery then sighed. Thinking back on all their efforts of stopping the villain, it was all in vain until the cohort captains arrived on the scene to wrap up the mess they theoretically created.

He gritted his teeth and slammed his fist against the bed. A tinge of fury surfaced on his face.

“What’s wrong?” Ted inquired, shocked by the reaction.

“I just—I don’t know. What do you think of it? Fighting the villains? I feel like we failed on our part of securing safety for the city.”

“Listen,” Ted said, “we did what we had to do to save our teacher. It’s typical that we stood no chance against a villainous boss like Pyrus Bourn. We succeeded, that’s all that matters. The Masumi brothers were able to find Charlotte and warn the city.”

“Even with this mysterious power,” Avery spoke, holding his golden rune, “I felt weak compared to the villain.”

“Sure we messed up big time, but what were we supposed to do about him just happened to discover the earth orb?”

Avery wasn’t too convinced, after all, he was responsible for releasing the orb’s power and allowing it to be snatched up by the villain. He understood now just how the Angeloress, the spellcaster of the sealing of the orb, hid the artifact for so long. Now it was his fault for not reading the lines and openly giving the villain the orb from a pocket dimension of the rune.

Breathing heavily to calm down, he and Ted remained fixed in silence to formulate their feelings.

Then Ted stood up, walked over and patted Avery’s back—a bit too hard though.

“Rest assured man. Our journey on the island is only beginning. You could think of these incidents as the appetizers to the adventures we’ll face eventually as cohort members, upperclassmen students, and then eventually as adults.”

Avery’s head perked up. “Adventures?”

“Heh, thinking back on it, it was pretty fun rummaging through District 3 even if it was risky. But hey, we gained experience that I bet most of these students have never faced before! Doubt we’d be unprepared next time.”

“Yeah, you may be right… or overly cocky, Ted. I am working on dreaming for my future also,” Avery replied, thinking back on his thievery days in New York and how much he’d come from unexpected turns of events.

“We started this together, so we’ll continue on!” assured Ted.

“What do you mean? The first incident that started streamline progress to the island involved River and I specifically. You were useless,” Avery joked.

“Aww man. You were right. Heh, I’ll just prove it to you next time.” Then Ted slumped back into his bed, believing the both of them were not released yet.

“Mmm… some sleep doesn’t sound too bad,” he muttered, face planted into the pillow. His mechanical parts were still scattered on top of him but he displayed no signs of flinching from uncomfort.

Then moments later, just as the duo thought they’d get much needed sleep, some officials arrived into the room when notified the duo were conscious.

The three figures that entered the room were Elmor Locks, Principal Taskah, and… Atlas Aquia—to Avery’s discontentment.

Now that the both were in a dire situation, Avery did not harbor any ill feelings toward the latter, neither than Atlas himself who recognized the boy as the same one he flung around in the mall.

Ted rolled in his bed and leaned up. “Just when I was about to get some z’s.”

“Hello,” Avery waved shyly, intimidated by not one, not two, but three superior figures, all of whom were dead serious.

“So, what happened to the villains and how come help arrived so late?” Ted asked quickly before they could even introduce their visit.

“Though we, as a district, couldn’t interfere, we’re glad to have put Pyrus Bourn and his close compatriots into custody. Some officials are working on concealing the entire situation so this information must be kept under wraps. Only the few involved will know of this information,” Elmor Locks explained to the duo.

“As soon as the villain entered the city, we were able to act when the alarms blared,” Principal Taskah added.

"Just like that, you can perform criminal justice directives?" Ted asked.

"The school's cohort system is essentially the secondary police for higher threats. Everything else also falls under that jurisdiction," the principal explained.

Just how much power did the school hold alone? Aver thought.

"Anyway, we were here to just assure you that no one was severely injured in the town hall explosion," the principal said.

"That's good. So, the others, I mean our friends, are okay?" Avery asked.

"Yes, they're fine. The only one with mild injuries was Kaden Icelander, who engaged directly with the enemy," Elmor Locks replied.

"To think the enemy would act so quickly after the school invasion. That would've been concerning had you not followed Kaden and secretly invaded District 3. Though your actions are susceptible to charges, I do have to admit what's done is done. You've learned the hard way what's dangerous, so no punishments will be issued at this time," the principal continued.

Although Avery and Ted admitted their wrongdoing, they still felt they had made the right choice in the end. And now, they were rewarded, to their good fortune.

"Regardless of that, we couldn't leave someone captive," Avery said finally, confident with his final decisions.

"Knowing that someone was in trouble and not acting is a sure way of being a coward," Ted added. "You'd do the same given your own comrades, right?"

"Yes, you two had commendable courage, yet you are students who lack experience," Elmor stated. "There are cases where breaking the rules for a greater good is appropriate, but in this case, it was just recklessness."

"Yeah, we know," the duo said together.

"But who would even rise if we did not?" Ted inquired back.

"Hmm… right," Atlas admitted. "That was essentially then a choice between what was better for the city, despite the odds against your favor."

"The resulting chaos might've brought the district to shambles, but had not Pyrus received the orb, the resulting damage might've been minimal," the principal recollected.

"Again, this was an unprecedented turn of events," Elmor Locks recalled. "Who would've imagined that such an ancient artifact came to exist?"

Avery immediately relayed his part of the story where he unveiled the orb during his capture on Pyrus Bourn's helicopter.

Then there was a moment of silence before Atlas Aquia spoke for the first time since arriving. "A demihuman with the Rune of the Spellcaster, quite a revelation indeed," he indicated, examining the boy.

Avery looked surprised that Atlas maintained his cool whilst stating the obvious.

Gesturing the rune to float above his hand, Avery explained his discovery, "I found this in a cabin in the forest of New York City. It seems to only react with my magic."

"Yes, it seems so. It is one of the ancient artifact runes of the Angelors. Since you've inherited all its powers, you should hold onto it. Perhaps it would be something to look into in the future," the principal inclined.

"Uh, thanks."

Commanding the rune to float behind his back, Avery noticed his wings fading as the rune began to glow in a gentle golden light.

"Whoa…?"

"By using the rune as a conduit of magic, it seems you can hide even certain characteristics," the principal remarked. "Such a rune might be considered national level if it did not have a user restriction."

"Huh. There's more than even I don't know. I suppose my journey with this rune since the start has helped me better understand the Mystical even further," Avery said.

"Yes, your journey alongside your friends was an interesting one starting your academy year. Surprisingly, most of the dots of the recent incidents prior to yesterday's ordeal add up now and make more sense. Though we don't know how involved the shadow cult were at the beginning of the chaos, we can guarantee that the orb will not be put in the wrong hands," Principal Taskah stated.

"What is the orb anyway?" Avery asked, now realizing not much was explained of its origin or purposes.

Ted raised his hand a bit to answer the question but restrained himself since the officials likely knew a more comprehensive definition.

"By the defeat of the **Demon Lord** so long ago, the magic that he tried to consume for himself was separated into three orbs instead. What you just discovered was the orb of destruction, the Terracustodis. It is one of the orbs that hold a third of the earth's

original magic in ancient times, thus making it almost limitless in magical potential since it has become a magical source, or catalyst, itself. It's very dangerous to wield as its chaos in nature," the principal explained.

"I touched the orb, yet I didn't experience the full pain or transformation that Pyrus Bourn endured…" Avery asked.

"The orb's a mass of uncontrollable magical power. You're lucky that you did not end in the same fate as the villain," Atlas pointed out.

"I didn't feel like I'd die, yet… I experienced a weird vision and gained better control of my magic," Avery explained. He then also described his vision to the faculty members.

"Hmm… this may have to do with your immature magic state, your body not fully adjusted to magic itself," Principal Taskah said.



"So the power you used against the villain was condensed light magic! That's a similar Regnum Spei as Atlas over here," Elmor Locks exclaimed.

Atlas was skeptical but nonetheless kept his feelings to himself. Catching note of this, Avery raised his hand and summoned a sword of light via his normal light magic. Condensing the weapon in his hand, it began to glow even brighter and feel heavier in his grasp.

"Intriguing! You have one of the Eight Forces of nature," Principal Taskah announced.

"Eight Forces?" Avery inquired.

"Atlas has the power of compression alongside his magical power. You have the same primal force as him, allowing you to condense your light magic for higher defense. This unique magical affinity or attribute is called a Regnum Spei, the power of hope, as it is unique among a very rare few and can change the course of any situation," the principal explained.

"More specifically, the eight forces are special Regnum Spei that allows the user to govern a prime force of the universe like gravity and magnetism. This is accomplished through a unique genetic fusion of a prime element and one of the yin-yang magic drivers."

"Uh, I'm confused, what do those terms mean?" Avery asked.

"The prime element is one of the four elements of nature and the yin-yang magic are dark and light," Elmor Locks explained.

"That's cool and all," Ted piped in with a little bit of jealousy, "but I wish I had something like that."

"There are other paths that may just be as powerful, if not more," the principal assured. "One may be adept to a certain magic type but the potential to gain additional Regnum Spei relies heavily on one's indomitable will."

"What exactly happened to the villain then when he touched the orb?" Ted mused.

"Not much is clear, but from his long exposure to magic itself and then an aver-abundant exposure to the orb's magic, he gained an affinity in inferno fire magic, something rivaling the innate powers of an arch-elemental. Restraining him and draining his magic slowly is the only way to prevent him from exploding his way from our grasps. That is why you saw him undergo a magic synthesis that made him a living flame," Elmor Locks said.

"Now, we were just here to check up on you guys and explain a few things. We'll be making our leave now. Rest up and continue your growth at this school as it is the only way for you to combat against someone of Pyrus' caliber in the future," the principal said before leaving with the cohort captains.

The discussion that sounded like it would lead to mention of punishment was finally over and both students felt burdens lifting from their shoulders.

Ted stretched and yawned before going back on his tedious work on his bed.

Avery felt relieved that the ordeals since arriving to the island had been resolved. He slumped back into his bed and fell asleep quickly.

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Avery and Ted were excused from the medical wing of the school the next day. They exited and headed to their quad room to adjust their belongings, take a shower, and prepare to meet up with their friends, whom they missed already since the pair had built up topics to discuss.

It wasn't as if they could easily change their perspective or habits after the huge ordeal in the middle of District 7. Both could only contemplate on the events and reflect on its worst case consequences had they not done what they did (by following Kaden). Now that they were back at school, it wasn't as if they were expected to not feel as the incident came and went.

And so, with a sigh of relief, the duo prepared to walk as normal students to their next destination.

School happened to be canceled for the entire week as new regulations went out and training regimens were initiated. Since District 7's two consecutive attacks, all students were expected to use the full week to train their magic and prepare for even tougher courses rumored to replace old ones for the remainder of the semester.

Since the details of the event were kept secret, none of the other students were aware of the few who fought the neighboring district's villains nor the discovery of the orb of destruction. Had it been known, other districts may have stirred and caused more trouble to Lux Urbis, now at the lowest of its prime. The incident was covered up by a fake story of a political movement by a neighboring district in seizure for control, which

was technically the innate motive of Pyrus Bourn, though ulterior to his main goal of seizing the orb of destruction.

Thus, as Avery and Ted marched out of the dorms and into the path where several other students bustled about, they were not mobbed as they thought they'd be. Observant people could've put dots together, but it seemed to not be the case.

It was finally a chance for the duo to have a normal student life, so they decided to make the most of their week off of school: have fun, move on, and still be aware of the risks in their *future* actions.

Walking peacefully around the lake, the duo encountered the Masumi brothers walking up all in one piece and with barely a scratch.

"What's up, my boys?" Ted called from a distance, rushing towards them and leaving Avery in the dust.

The brothers waved back and gestured for them to come quickly. They recovered well from the recent incident also, having been the major players in bringing backup.

The four met together and continued on their walk to the cafeteria for some highly coveted food they hadn't had for a while. Even though this wasn't the case, deprivation of energy and running on overdrive would stir one's hunger.

"I can't believe we actually did it," Ted announced, feeling prouder with himself now that he had some friends to brag to.

"And what did you do, Ted? You let the wind dude get away!" Ken stated.

Ted clenched his fists. "Uh, it's not my fault! It's not like I could fly—wait nevermind, I wasn't able to react in time, that's all."

Then the three laughed out loud.

"We're just lousy students compared to those guys," Avery said seriously, not understanding why they were in such a chipper mood. He himself felt content but not overly ecstatic like the others.

"Hey, we still held our own. But against the main villain, he was in a totally different league," Kirk reprised.

"I'm glad those cohort captains showed up when they did though. Two of them combined could effortlessly defeat Pyrus Bourn which shows just how much more we have to train to even reach that point," Ken stated.

"At least we can do this together, I suppose," Kirk suggested.

"Yeah, it does feel good to be with friends," Avery said, feeling overjoyed for the moment. This really was the first moment in his life where he valued someone else rather than his own existence.

"So, there's something interesting happening soon and we couldn't let you guys out of it," Kirk declared.

The others ooh'd at the sudden announcement.

"Tell us now!" Ted requested.

"Nah, I'll wait till we meet up with the girls and maybe Kaden before saying so," he finished, disappointing the others.

"How come you didn't tell me about this, bro?" Ken demanded.

"Heh, it's a secret," he said in staccato.

Upon arriving at the familiar cafeteria, the squad noticed a mob of students surrounding a particular someone. He then paved his way through the crowd and strided towards them.

"Hello guys, Kaden here," the boy greeted the four in his school uniform that matched Regnum's.

"What's going on?" Ted asked, surprised at the sudden outfit.

"Thought I'd chill at this school for a while, you know," Kaden responded to the other's blank expressions.

"That's great," Avery said. "So, did you see River or Jane?"

"Ah, they were grabbing some food. I'm waiting for you guys though."

"That's kind of you, great Kaden, but you didn't have to," Kirk said. "So, must be rough tending to the other students…"

"Yeah, I'm kind of a big deal on the Mystical Island too," Kaden admitted. "Don't worry, they respect me so much they wouldn't dare touch me without permission. And if I command it, even they would part the way for us to walk through."

"Oh wow, way to use that power," Kirk scoffed jokingly.

Kaden just shrugged. "Works fine with me if they choose to comply."

"So, feeling better?" Avery asked, changing the topic.

“I’m doing alright. Though my magic is still drained from overusing this sword,” he said, indicating the source of the weapon by pointing at his silver ring on a finger of his right hand.

“You have one of those concealing runes?” Kirk said.

Kaden nodded. Then indicating for the group to follow, they entered the cafeteria.

It was a breeze through the check-in line and also getting the food as students moved aside to provide the young prodigy and his friends passage just as it was stated.

“What exactly are you to all these students? I mean you have a lot of female admirers too!” Ted pointed out as they paced around with their food for a suitable seat.

“Some, an idol; others, a prodigy; a few, unrivaled; the admirers, the ideal one; and those who dislike me, nerd,” was Kaden’s response.

“Oh whoa, shocking,” Ken teased.

The guys found Jane and River waving for their attention a few tables away. Arriving quickly, the seven seated themselves around a circular table with their various chosen food and beverages.

Avery sat beside Ted and River. Jane sat on the other side of River and beside Ken Masumi. Lastly, Kaden sat between Kirk Masumi and Ted. Now was the second time the seven had gathered together.

The certain group sort of stuck, so no one made the decision to depart from the newly formed secret society under the lead of Kaden Icelander (unanimously chosen by the six others).

“Now,” Kirk slapped his palm on the table for the gorup’s attention. “I’ve got some news for you guys. Though this would be a good chance before others.”

The others were eager to know this long-hidden announcement.

Kirk then chuckled and began biting into his turkey leg, causing the others to get annoyed.

“Come on, out with it already,” Ted demanded.

“Yeah, spill it,” Jane persisted in addition.

“Alright alright… chill,” he mumbled with meat in his mouth. “As you know, the cohorts regularly look for members to join their ranks, effectively guaranteeing your graduation and also a potential job in the future.”

"Yeah, we know this," Ted said. "I've heard mentions of it."

"Simply put, essentially you have to do a good deed or prove your strength to a cohort captain and you may get a chance to get in. Well, I eavesdropped on a group of second years and found out that there is a private event where most of the cohort captains will be watching a free-for-all fight, or… something like that."

"You definitely shouldn't have been able to get that information," Kaden smirked, folding his arms. "But yes, that does sound valid."

"So, uh, what about it?" River asked. She still kept her hood over her head concealing her ears to everyone's no surprise. Her purpose of hiding it still was to prevent her bullying from other students walking nearby.

"Well, I just thought that perhaps we should go, hehe," Kirk suggested. "You know, so we can stick together and all."

"That's a bad idea, even from someone who's as dumb as you, bro," Ken stated. "But I'm all in if everyone else is."

"Isn't this a bit early?" Avery inquired.

"Nah, nothing is too early, even teach said it herself," Kirk stated.

"I won't be participating directly," Kaden assured.

"How come?" Jane asked. "It does sound like a chance for us to prove our strength, especially after our bouts against the District 3 enemies."

"Heh, you see. I'm already in a cohort," Kaden said.

"What? No way! You're at least the age of us and I didnt even see you at the commencemnt ceremony and orientation," Jane refuted.

"As you know, Charlotte Levy and I go way back. I was practically garenteed a spot given my sheer skills," the prodigy gloated.

"Ohhh" the group gasped.

"I take it you're in Blue Legion, the same one she leads," Avery confirmed.

"Uh huh."

"Wait, does that mean you've been to Regnum as a student?" Ted inquired.

"Sort of… I am technically a year older than you guys for the reason of finishing all of college in one year. Here at Regnum in fact," the young prodigy spoke. "Being invited as a member was just expected. I suppose I can consider myself a second year now."

"Way to show your talent. Though that could explain the sheer tough entry qualifications," Avery observed.

"What other cohorts are there again? Cus, you know, some of them are way harder to get in than others such as said Blue Legions," Ted asked.

"Well, there's the Tempest Aquia, let by yours truly Atlas Aquia, and a few others I forgot," Kirk stated, counting the numbers in his head.

"The others are Mystic, Centipedes, Dai-Battalion, Black Rampart, Red Shred, and Nuntios, though some of them are essentially impossible to get in as they're private," Jane explained.

"Private? What do you mean?" Avery inquired.

"There are certain rankings among missions from S+ to D rank. Of course, the more reputable cohorts take on the higher ranked ones. The Nuntios is the only cohort which takes on only S+ ranked missions and comprises four individuals," Jane replied.

"Yeah, and the typical cohort has an average of fifteen members at max at a given time, so wasting time waiting won't get us those spots," Ken added.

"Consider yourself lucky if you can get into my cohort," Kaden stated. "That is… if Charlotte Levy will let you anyway."

The others weren't too sure if she would after their selfless act of saving her but risking their lives in the process, something she would certainly be against.

"That's just one less cohort," Kirk winced.

"We should worry about severe punishments in her class instead," Ted said quickly.

"Yeah, I suppose she's a scary woman," Jane's loose thought popped out.

"Scary does not even come close," Kirk corrected.

"Nah, let's worry about that later, if we see her," Ken said. "Uh, hopefully we don't see her for a while."

"Hopefully all this washes over," Kirk said.

"Well, since there's nothing else better to do, let's go for this secret event," Avery announced, standing up.

"Yeah," River agreed, standing in support of Avery.

The others had no further objections, so they all rose. "To our newly formed friendship," they all cheered together.

The group were ready to set out on another expedition (a safe one, at least) now that the recent incidents had come to a close.

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Pyrus Bourn sulked in his cell of Lux Urbis feeling utterly defeated. With his pride gone, his freedom, and his chance of ultimate rule, he felt ashamed to be demoted to such a sorry state.

Tom Nado, Tony Smith, and Ellie Tracy, his compatriots in crime, were in neighboring cells experiencing other mixed feelings.

It had been a few days now and the recent incidents had dialed down quite a bit. Suddenly, the main cell chamber door was opened and guards escorted two gentlemen into the room. The rich nobles were displeased to be striding into a dusty muffled cell facility but were intent on investigating the villains.

"Pyrus Bourn of District 3, you've finally made your move, huh?" one gentleman, a rich noble with a bushy beard stated.

Pyrus raised his bent head and eyed the noble with his orange swollen eyes. "What do you want with me, council member?"

"Just thought I'd pop by to see the state of the villain we've caught," the council member replied.

"Have you come only to mock me? Heh, you're no better than what I imagined of you. You all are such hypocrites," Pyrus jeered.

"Hypocrites, you say? Says the one who broke the treaty pact between districts," the other noble, a tall brown haired man with blue eyes. "I'm Council Seat Jaedin and I'm here to see that you are aware of your sentence."

"Oh? Is that so? Do your worst," Pyrus taunted mockingly.

"You'll be sentenced to jail indefinitely for abusing the orb of destruction's power, invading a school, kidnapping, and again destroying a district's property. Your district is also under seizure of this district and your comrades will suffer less 'strict' sentences as they followed under you," the other bushy bearded council member declared.

"I'll figure out a way of breaking out of this place eventually," the villain stated.

"Try if you can. The cell is modified with the recent magic regulating technology from IT Industries," Council Seat Jaedin remarked.

The council members left the jail, leaving Pyrus Boun to his continuous demise of his defeated schemes.

Looking down at his hands, Pyrus knew that he was no longer the type of human he used to be; now he was a monster.

He did not anticipate the orb to completely change his genetic and spiritual makeup on the spot, yet he felt his heart beated stronger than before. A wave of new freshness circulated his body as he realized the presence of accumulating magical energy.

If this is what was meant as the feeling of satisfaction, then the disunified island really didn't value the existence of magic nor of life, he thought.

Believing these ideals but not having the current means to see them through caused the villain to groan.

"Gah, this is so infuriating!" he hollered.

Then bending down, he sighed. "I won't let some shadow overtake my desire for true utopia for the Mystical. They don't understand the corrupt government that is leading them astray."

This wasn't the end for him, he was sure of it.

***

Some time after the final battle against the flaming villain, Avery and River had quietly snuck away from the rest of their friends and were sitting on a pier over the central lake of the school.

It was now almost the end of fall, the three transfers were successfully able to survive the harsh landscape of dwelling at Regnum. Each member of the newly formed group of seven, except for a certain prodigy, had surpassed expectations for their respective classes due to their innate growth from the incidents. No extra events were hosted by the school for the remainder of the semester as the lingering uncertainty of District 7's safety still remained a major topic of discussion to this very day. The school heavily remained focused on academia and individual growth to more efficiently combat events that would rise in the future.

With nothing immediate in the horizon for the duo to worry about, they simply wanted to relax in the cool weather and contemplate on their struggles and gains.

Avery's golden hair blew under the light breeze, his pink sapphire eyes wide in awe as he gazed at the sunset in the distance. With the mist barrier shrouding the winter-like weather outside, the sun shone a bright golden yellow with streaks of red arching around various hues of orange.

River's caramel hair blew under her hood and she gripped tightly between her fingers. She couldn't resist losing all thought as she watched the sun slowly inching down.

"What did you call me out for?" Avery asked, breaking the silence.

"This is one of my favorite spots in the school in the short months we've been here so far," River replied. "I just wanted to show you because you're my closest friend."

"Yeah," Avery agreed, blushing lightly. "We faced some problems together and I really got to know you a bit. My journey of the Mystical started off awkwardly but thanks to you and Ted, I was able to stay courageous whilst pondering on discovering who I was, I mean, who I am now."

River took Avery's reply to heart. She felt the same way as she felt alone most of her life before accidentally bumping into his life also.

"Do you think you would be better off not knowing all this?" she asked.

"With the friends I know now and the life I have gained, never."

"I see. I'm glad. I just want to assure you that you're the only one I can fully trust right now."

"Whoa, that's, uh, great and all, but aren't you being a bit hasty. I don't even know my own past and I can't guarantee to be the exceptional person you may think I am," Avery said quickly, taken aback by River's sudden openness.

"No, but eventually I'll feel more at ease sharing my past and I want you to be the one to hear it," River said.

"If it has to do with your relationship with your family also, I'll be here for you and make sure that that Atlas jerk won't hurt you," Avery assured.

"That means a lot."

"You and I went through a lot and grew through these… journeys, but I have a sense that more obstacles will only be in our ways if we continue to pave a path forward in these unjust societies."

“It’s the injustice of the ruling power, especially towards demihumans and those bearing low magical power.”

“The latter doesn’t include us, but I can feel for those with low mana given that I’ve experienced a beggar life in the streets and a world without magic. It’s not just the authorities that are corrupt, it’s the mindset of people in general.”

“What can be done about that? All we can do is just—”

“No,” Avery rebutted, “Those that think that way give the authorities their power. Although it’s hard, we have to be an exception… an example. Somehow we need to prove to them that demihumans like us are capable; through our results.”

“Y-Your right. W-What was I saying,” River replied. “Our goal… is to prove them wrong. Become stories told from ages to come. Bend the hearts of others to the truth and demonstrate through our actions, not control.”

“Yeah… like, **Mystical Legends**. You have a good way of putting it.”

River sighed. “Perhaps we could be the ones to fulfill that title.”

“Uh, title? I dunno. You make it sound like something we gain after we’re long dead,” Avery indicated.

“Oh maybe, you suggested it.”

“Yeah, you’re right. If it's been only a century since the birth of Mystical Beings coming together, I can’t imagine what type of impact we could make in such a short time frame.”

***

In a strange dark room far away from the Mystical Island, two figures exchanged information about the events that occurred in District 7 several days prior. One figure removed a device from his pockets and showed a video of a particular event. The other became intrigued and watched closely.

And what was displayed on the video clip was Avery's defense against Pyrus Bourn's early attacks before he exploded in inferno. Quickly after touching the orb, he dropped it and began wailing in anguish.

Fire scattered the road of the scene. Avery was a short distance from the orb and was instinctively persuaded to reach for it. His head throbbed a bit and he closed his eyes. When his eyes opened again, he did not display the same fearful depression as before.

A brilliant blast of flaming light blasted from Pyrus Bourn who was still trying to regulate his body within his new fiery form. It directed itself towards Avery's direction.

The blast illuminated for a few minutes before dying down. What would've been ashes and crimson, was instead a barrier of the strongest magic possible. A strange figure hovered above in the center of the barrier.

Yet what was different was his attire of pure white, his golden hair flowing and glowing intensively. White ancient markings lined his left eye. His sapphire pink irises shine brilliantly as if a sea of mana engulfed his pupils.

He held his hand before him, effortlessly deflecting the remains of the explosion that would've been fatal if unavoided.

When all came to pass, the barrier faded, and the glow of the figure disappeared. The boy's eyes closed and opened again with a surprised expression before continuing to face off against the villain. The clip ended, showing the remnants of the explosion and the survival of those who were in it.

"Intriguing, so, we're not the only ones," one cloaked figure spoke, rewinding the video to the illuminating figure to inspect in greater detail.

"With all these events coming to pass, does it point towards that one destiny?" the other figure said.

"With all that I'm seeing, I believe that even the spirits foresee what is to come."

"I see. The age of magic will take another turn sooner than later…"

Extra Chapter: Journey of the Mystical Beings

Zenith Luces - Part 1

It was a cool but fairly warm summer morning, and the sky was clear.

A boy leaned against the post of a fence watching sweaty soccer players of his hometown running across the field with a ball while the opposing team tried to steal it.

He lived in a tiny town which mostly had forests and wildlife including a big playing field that is usually used for soccer and golf. The people who lived in this area cared for nature; they placed houses and shops along the sea rather than the plains.

The boy's name was Zenith Luces, which meant, "The Most Successful Light."

He was a bright sixteen-year-old boy who enjoyed whatever life threw at him. His father was a rich geographer who drew maps of the lands during his younger years; it was said that he knew of many secret places unknown to other humans.

Zenith Luces would hear stories of such tales, but he never considered them as part of his life.

Zenith leaned on the railings and watched the soccer game until he felt a gurgle down in his stomach which reminded him to eat a hearty lunch.

This was the time period near the early nineteen hundreds, so vendors and fast food did not exist, but there was decently cooked food available that was both cheap and nutritious.

Zenith walked away from the old worn bleachers and headed to a restaurant called Danny's Diner which sold food that made his mouth water.

He bought a burger and lemonade and sat down at a small table off to the side near a blurred window which had probably not been washed since the restaurant opened.

While Zenith ate, he noticed a strange guy walking a little bit funny similar to a goat's trot, and his hair shined like polished gold.

At first, Zenith didn't bother to find out who the person was because it might intrude into his business, but also, he felt that the person needed help which sounded silly to him when he first thought of it.

He made up his mind and stood up and followed the guy into the bathroom.

And so, Zenith walked straight up to the strange person and asked courageously, "Who are you and can I help you?"

The guy literally jumped out of his shoes and turned around amazed, and he said something that Zenith did not predict, "We can't talk here… Meet me in the back alleyway."

Confused, Zenith followed the guy out of the diner and to a nearby alleyway which was abandoned and ravaged with litter that almost made him puke at first sight.

The guy introduced himself by saying this, "My name is Rowan Ager (pronounced Aw-gare) and I see that you have an interest in my kind."

"Interest in my kind?" Zenith thought, "What does that mean?"

Then Zenith spoke, "My name is Zenith Luces, and I don't understand what you mean."

"Oh," Rowan said, "Well you might think I am crazy, but I am a Satyr."

"Like the ones in Roman Mythology, or was it Greek?"

"No! Satyrs are not mythology unless they don't exist, but they do exist. My point here is this: the Mystical Beings are alive just like you humans," explained Rowan.

After explaining this, Rowan kicked off his shoes, like flying rocks from a slingshot, revealing what looked like hooves.

"How I didn't notice that before," thought Zenith as he gazed at the satyr whose face even looked mystical.

Then Zenith noticed Rowan change his expression from a joyfulness of meeting a new person to deep sympathy.

"What's wrong?" Zenith asked.

"Now you know about a secret that I should not have spoken of; we Mystical Beings are in hiding because of the repopulation of humans. Life is hard for us because of our differences, plus our different abilities. I came out of hiding in search of someone or

something that could help us escape the human lands, perhaps a boat to travel to some land that is unknown to all humans," explained Rowan.

"My father is a geographer, and he knows of many secret lands. He is also extremely kind," Zenith added.

"Well, I also know of a person who can find hidden places. Her name is Caela Obtainia and she is an Angeloress, which is the female gender of the Angelor Mystical Beings, a powerful group of beings who can bring the Mystical Beings together," Rowan said.

"I'll go and get a vessel and you can go and ask the Angeloress to gather the Mystical Beings together," offered Zenith, who sought adventure.

Afterward, both set out to fulfill their roles in setting the Mystical Beings free.

***

Also at this time, there was an evil man who sat on his evil throne in his evil factory.

His name was Pyrus Bourn, and he was a cunning man who wanted power. He did not commit blatant crimes, but his motives defined him as evil.

He lived on a small island on a lake near the city Zenith inhabited.

His lair, known as the Midas Quarters, was the main producing location of matches and firelighters. People bought them because they were dependent on fire at that time.

The factory was made of black wood both dirty and worn which showed that it needed a good paint job from the fumes burning all day.

The particular room that Pyrus was in was decorated with a high ruler's throne and red flags hanging up the upper walls.

Pyrus was reading some bills, and he was complaining about them as usual when his advisers, Tony Smith and Tom Nado, came into the chamber.

They were average humans who loved doing secret things, especially ones that the other workers didn't get a chance to do.

Pyrus glanced up and asked, "What is it now? Did you find any information about an island that I can inhabit and control instead of this puny lake?"

"Umm, well boss, we did find out that a great geographer lives nearby, and it is said from people that he knows about secret islands," Tom Nado answered.

"Maybe you're right that this geographer could have information about an island that I could have as my own," Pyrus said with a grin that revealed that he had devised a plan already.

"Do you want a boat prepared so that when you get hold of a secret map we could sail immediately?" Tony Smith asked.

"Yes, and I shall pay a friendly visit to the geographer's home," Pyrus replied as he exited his chamber.

***

After the time of Pyrus' meeting, Zenith was walking outside of the downtown trading shops near the docks, looking for a ship.

While he searched, he saw the small cartographer shop which was owned by his father, William Luces.

The shop was decorated with maps of every continent and William himself says that he traveled the world when he was younger to draw such maps.

Zenith entered the empty shop and leaned against the trading counter waiting for his father, who arrived not long afterward.

"Father," Zenith spoke, "Do you have a spare map of your secret islands? I need it."

"What for, son?" William asked.

William was a tall middle-aged wise man. He always wore an explorer's hat and suit which was made of fabric from many continents.

He was also a rich man who used his money wisely and he did not allow fools to even have a penny of his honest earnings.

"Because…oh, you wouldn't even believe me. I met a satyr who wants to sail the Mystical Beings across the ocean to an island uninhabited by humans," replied Zenith who feared his wise father would think he was talking nonsense.

But his father shockingly replied, “Honestly, Zenith, I would not have allowed you to have one of my maps, but since you showed courage and there’s a real reason for it, I shall let you have a map.”

“Oh, thank you, father!” Zenith then said.

“You might need a fast, efficient, and strong vessel for the journey, so I’ll give you some money too.”

Zenith was overjoyed to hear this from his father, but he also had some new questions.

“Father,” he asked again, “Why weren’t you surprised about the Mystical Beings, and will you come with us?”

“I once met a mystical elf on my expedition of the world, but I don’t have time to tell the story. I might as well go on this last journey for pleasure because it has been a long time since I was out at sea.”

Both father and son examined the available ships in the market which sold every kind of vessel that could be used on the journey.

The market was busy like always and it lined the wooden platforms along the beach bed.

Since many passengers would be going on the ship, they bought a fairly large ship, which was called “The Mystery.”

This ship had four different floors each containing rooms for the Mystical Beings and also a captain’s quarters. The ship itself was constructed of polished light oak and it had large sailing masts with strong sails.

***

When both the father and son headed back to the cartographer shop, they were met by the insidious Pyrus Bourn.

“Hello, are you the so-called great William Luces?” he asked with the hope of snatching some secret information.

“Yes, my name is William Luces. Yours?” replied Zenith’s father.

“Pyrus Bourn, but did I catch you buying a ship?”

"Is there a problem with that?" Zenith asked.

"Yes, I did buy a ship," William confirmed.

"Hmm, then where are you heading?" Pyrus asked.

"Does it matter?" William asked, "If you're wondering, no guests are invited."

"I was just checking. Plus, I wanted to go out to sea," Pyrus replied.

Zenith and William Luces entered the cartographer shop while Pyrus walked away.

"So, they are up to something; I must follow them," Pyrus murmured.

***

While these events took place, Rowan was also having difficulty.

"Why, I think it was this way. Or maybe that way?" he thought as he walked through a forest called Weeping Willows.

He was lost in the woods and that was the moment that he realized he could not find the Angeloress because the Mystical Beings had the power to manipulate their magical essence.

Rowan continued through the forest which seemed to cast shadows of somebody trailing behind him.

There were traces of bones and dried intestines lying about from several rodents and defenseless herbivores.

Rowan could smell perfectly, and he knew right away that those animals were killed by wild wolves and red foxes.

Rowan immediately quickened his pace until he arrived at a cabin which was old and homey. The windows were covered and there was no sound heard inside; he almost thought it was abandoned.

He knocked at the door and waited while doing his best not to be afraid.

The door was opened by a woman of great beauty and when she saw Rowan, she quickly let him in.

"What are you doing out there alone?" she asked when he was settled.

He was surprised at this question and then said, “Well I am searching for this person who could help me save lives. My name is Rowan Ager.”

The woman did not state her name but continued to argue that he should not have come alone.

Rowan got restless and asked, “Who are you and why did you immediately let me in?”

She ignored the question. “You are a satyr, are you not?”

Rowan replied, “Yes…but why do you care…? Wait, are you Caela Obtainia?”

“Yes, and whenever someone comes here, they are searching for help,” she replied. She stood up and gave Rowan some apple slices.

“I need help finding all of the other Mystical Beings so that my friend and I could take them to an island uninhabited by people.”

He explained all the other details that do not need to be repeated.

“How should I believe that this isn’t a trap to kill all the Mystical Beings at sea? Especially when you are trusting a human boy! But…I will help you because it’s the right thing to do and because we Mystical Beings do not need to endure humans any longer.”

“Good! Zenith is getting a ship now,” Rowan replied with enthusiasm.

He got up from the chair and grabbed his supplies.

“It is a pity to leave this forest which I sustained,” she remarked.

A few minutes later, Rowan and Caela left the old cabin … forever.

Caela used her power to search for other Mystical Beings. This power gave her a vision that identified every person and what species they fall in.

***

Rowan and Caela met Zenith and William a few hours later at the docks.

There were no humans nearby except the Luceses and it was almost dawn. All of the Mystical Beings were gathered at the entrance of the ship waiting for a captain to lead them.

Zenith approached Rowan and asked, “Hey, Rowan. Did you get everyone?”

"Yes," he replied.

"Okay, well, we probably need to leave as soon as possible because of the Mystical Beings. We cannot leave them here at the docks tonight so it's best to actually leave now," Zenith explained.

Rowan stood before all of the Mystical Beings and announced, "We need to leave now, but first we must elect a captain to lead us and give us orders so that we won't be confused when danger comes."

The crowd cheered and then talked among themselves.

"Who do you propose?"

Caela spoke out, "Since it was this human Zenith who started this journey, I think it is wise to let him lead. He does have a plan, does he not?"

She stared at Zenith.

"Of course," he announced. "I have a plan that should work perfectly as soon as we get out to sea."

Then a new person spoke, "Wait, you said that it *should* work. Does that mean that this plan can fail?" The person came out of the crowd of the Mystical Beings; Rowan addressed him as the "Greatest Survivor."

His name was Ion Mustard, and he was an ice being, but his features did not show that.

He had dark skin and curly black hair, and he always wore iron armor. He even had a sword that was passed down from many deadly generations.

Zenith argued back, "No plan can be fully known to work or not."

"Ooof," Rowan whispered.

"I'll elect him. He's pretty smart," Ion said. Everyone else agreed.

"Okay, then let's get going," Zenith said as his first captain's order.

Zenith then led them into the ship which was prepared and armed for mysterious sea battles.

He stationed some Mystical Beings to guard the cabins and others to man the ship while he, Rowan, and Caela studied the map by William Luces.

Caela also created a defensive mist around the ship that would protect it from dangerous storms and high waves.

William loved to look out at sea whenever he sailed so he stayed in a spare bedroom, in the captain's quarters, which had a balcony.

He was writing another map for this particular journey. One of his greatest skills was to look at maps as written documents instead of a paper with drawings.

The boat started to sail right at dusk because that was the best chance of not getting noticed by merchants and fishermen.

***

Pyrus watched the Mystery sail away from the harbor before he entered his boat called, "The Red Shred."

The boat contained what it was named; it had a very sharp point, and it was painted dark red.

He had a fairly light crew onboard journeying with him. The first two were Tom Nado and Tony Smith, his best men.

"Get my boat out to sea now so that I can take over that boat," Pyrus commanded as he entered the captain's room which had red colors everywhere just like the evil man himself.

Tom Nado, Tony Smith, and the other crew obeyed. The boat jolted out to sea very quickly - probably faster than the fastest boat at that time.

While that was in motion, Pyrus had his plan revolving in his head. He opened a metal safe and took out a torch lighter and a custom item that he created called a Fire-Increaser which made a fire explode with heat and chemical reactions.

"Perhaps this shall do to complete my plan in taking over," he mumbled to himself as he clipped the items onto his equipment belt.

Pyrus exited the room and went outside to the main deck.

"How far are we from those pests?" he called to his men.

"Right behind their tail, sir," Tom replied.

By that time, it was completely dark, and the Mystery's lights were seen from far off. Pyrus then decided to make the next move.

He steered the ship towards the Mystery and sailed as fast as his ship could go, which was as fast as an underwater sub deep in the depths of the sea.

However, Zenith and the Mystical Beings did not notice the boat, so Pyrus easily sailed next to the boat.

"Me and my men, Tom Nado and Tony Smith, will go first. Watch for my signal," explained Pyrus, who placed a plank on the edge of his boat towards the railings of the Mystery.

The boats were within five feet of each other.

He silently, without a single expression of fear and worry, leaped between the two boats onto the deck of the Mystery.

Everyone was in bed asleep by now, and Tom Nado and Tony Smith got across safely while making very clamorous noises.

But little did they know of the bored sentries watching over the main entrance to the captain's quarters which contained the control to the ship.

Ion Mustard watched three shadows pass by and he suspected that someone had gotten on board. He called for some more men and searched for them.

Zenith walked out of the captain's quarters ready for action.

He saw Ion standing in front of the weaponry, confused as if there was a mystery, so he walked up to him and said, "What's wrong? Did something happen?"

"Ahh, Captain," Ion emphasized. "You should be sleeping. We are the guards taking care of this."

"That means somethings wrong!"

"Yes, and you won't be part of it!"

"What!"

Ion drew a glistering metal sword and pointed it at Zenith's throat.

"I never trust humans, especially one that is controlling our kinds. I want control, and this is the perfect time to do so. Seems as there was scheming behind my back!"

Zenith was stunned at this and asked, "Why are you doing this?"

“Because I can’t have a human in the mainland who knows these secrets. Plus, you’re not worthy. Few humans, in the history of the world, have ever led all the Mystical Beings,” he replied.

While Ion talked, Zenith inched towards a wall with swords and bows hanging.

There was even a rifle hanging upside down not far, but he could not reach that otherwise it would cause Ion to have suspicion.

“This was not according to my plan,” Zenith said.

He took the chance and grasped a sword by the hilt and quickly repositioned it so that he could block.

“Good move, but you can’t kill me. I’m too powerful,” Ion laughed.

He stepped closer and his sword glowed with an aura of blue mist that felt intensely freezing.

Zenith was held back and now near the railings that led toward the sea which could be called death itself.

He calculated his options that would save his life.

He could fight, which would be a bloody mess for him, or he could attempt to run as fast as the waves away from the Not-So-Friendly-Guy.

He chose option two.

Ion laughed and slowly walked towards Zenith; he was swinging his sword back and forth against the air which created an icefield that made him hard to approach.

Zenith ran onto one side of Ion, the side of him that wasn’t holding a sword.

He succeeded but that did not stop Ion from being a master runner especially because he could run on the ice faster than on the ground.

Ion’s aura of cold literally froze the floor which was now bluish brown oak wood.

As Pyrus ran past the armory, he accidentally knocked into the backside of Ion.

They both slipped and fell onto the ice but quickly got up like a lightning bolt.

Ion turned to see who this person was and then he asked, “Who are you and how did you get on board?”

“Burr…You are so cold! What are you? No humans are that cold, “Pyrus exclaimed bitterly.

Pyrus adjusted himself, uncapped one of his fire-increasers, and pointed it at Ion.

Tom Nado and Tony Smith arrived panting, with other Mystical Beings behind them who were holding swords. Zenith turned and held his sword firmly watching this discussion.

"I am not like you, weak humans. I am an Icelorian," Ion answered. "But you, trespassers, are on my boat!"

Ion's sword morphed into the most powerful substance that exists, black ice.

Then everyone stepped backward away from him except Pyrus and his minions.

"What is that supposed to do, dissolve me?" Pyrus questioned.

"I think, boss, we should be afraid," Tony whispered.

Rowan then stepped out from the guards behind Tom and Tony.

"What is all this trouble, Ion, and why are you holding a black ice sword," he asked. "That same sword killed thousands."

"That…is not your business," Ion replied, smirking. "I will use this sword unless you give me control and this ship. And these humans," he pointed to Zenith, Pyrus, and Pyrus' minions, "are dangerous spies who should DIE!"

Then the land seeker yelled from the watchtower, "LAND AHEAD! LAND AHEAD!"

"Too late," Ion stated.

Ion lunged like a wild predator at Zenith while Zenith bravely withstood the attack with his sword.

Pyrus threw his fire-increaser and yelled, "Take this, brain freeze!"

The fire-increaser bounced off of Ion's back and spilled all over the ground and then started to bubble.

There was smoke sizzling up into the air, and then the ground erupted into a great bright light with Ion inside.

Everyone stared in awe until they saw Ion walk out of the flames.

"Nothing can stop me, not even fire," he said, swatting some smoke off his shoulders.

The flame continued to burn the ship. There was already a hole forming on the deck as the ship sailed calmly across the sea towards the island.

Caela sprayed dissolving fire magic but apparently, Pyrus made it pretty much invulnerable to everything.

"Sorry, I was trying to kill him, not burn the ship," he confessed.

"Put it out," Rowan yelled, but he realized that Ion disappeared.

Pyrus ran quickly towards his ship mumbling, "I am getting off of this wretched and cursed ship."

But when he arrived at the rail where his crew was waiting, he saw the ship out at sea sailing away with Ion on it. Ion then turned the Red Shred around towards the Mystery with the sharp point aiming for the hull.

"NOOO!"

Then Tom, who was behind Pyrus, asked, "Why is our ship going to ram us so that we will die?"

"It's that uhh … whatever he calls himself, Icelorian, is commanding MY ship," Pyrus explained. "And yes, we're going to die."

The Mystical Beings all woke up from the commotion and clamor and came outside to see their fate. The sun was also rising from the east, shining onto the bright red spear-like ship speeding towards the Mystery.

"Sail the boat away," Rowan whimpered.

"Sorry, we can't move the ship that fast, but crashing into the island might be our only hope of survival," a guard replied.

"I shall do so then," Zenith agreed.

He ran to the captain's quarters, which was half burning, and ran up to the ship's wheel. He aimed the rudder straight so that the ship would sail towards the island and hopefully not kill anybody.

While that was in motion, Zenith then went out in search of his father who loved examining ship mechanisms.

Zenith, surprisingly, found him in the lounge-room.

"Father," he called, "we must be on deck because there's a fire and also there's another ship splitting our ship in half."

"Why, what happened?"

“No time to explain,” Zenith said, pulling his father’s arm along, which forced William to stand up and walk with his son.

The ship was now close to shallow water which could tear the ship’s hull. Additionally, the Red Shred was now gaining speed and was very close.

Zenith ran to the ship’s wheel again while William watched in horror of what might happen.

Zenith turned the wheel to avoid a pillar of rock that peeked out nearby. He navigated the ship around the rocks and crashed into the beach, which stopped the ship instantly.

“Everyone out,” he yelled.

While the Mystical Beings were running out of the ship in fear, the Red Shred sped right into the hull of the Mystery which then created such a large impact that the fire burning on the Mystery erupted once again blowing both ships apart.

Then Rowan asked, “Did the explosion kill Ion?”

“I don’t think so," Zenith replied, “He is one of the toughest Mystical Beings that has ever lived.”

Everyone was out by then, but they lost all their belongings from the ship. Plus, they were in a strange new land.

The island itself was full of life; it contained rich fruit trees and many pastures for buildings in the near future. It also had a great mountain that soared higher than the clouds.

“This place feels so mystical and powerful,” Caela exclaimed. “Our presence will form a foggy mystic barrier that will be our garrison. The barrier of mist will transport humans to pass through and take them to the other side of the island; they will pass it without even knowing if there was an island in existence. I shall gather the spells and work on that.”

The other Mystical Beings agreed.

And so that day the Mystical Beings used their gifted powers to quickly create homes to dwell in. The mist appeared that night with power and Caela’s protection.

Zenith and his father helped the Mystical Beings settle in and found their domain depending on their types.

After several days, Zenith and Rowan were walking together on the beach line where the Mystery had crashed.

"Thanks for helping me save the Mystical Beings from the mainland. They appreciate living free now," Rowan acknowledged.

"It's no problem. Plus, I was hoping to search for an adventure," Zenith said. "Whatever happened to Ion?

"I don't know, but at least if he comes, he'll be too late for control. The Mystical Beings are prepared for anything," Rowan explained.

"Yeah, you're right. Plus, Ion could not have survived that explosion anyway," Zenith said calmly.

"Additionally, even Mystical Beings have limits. It's not like he'll pop up and say I'm here," Rowan laughed.

"Hopefully this island will stand for generations and generations," Zenith said.

"It will. There will always be a hero among the Mystical Beings who will lead them out of the hard times," Rowan stated. "By the way, you show lots of courage and kindness to help the Mystical Beings even if there is trouble and the risk of death."

Both of them continued to talk about things they love and how they'll live on this island.

***

But one particular person who still wanted to rule an island was not happy and he was Pyrus.

Pyrus had easily made himself an underground lair after he ran away from the Mystical Beings that day of the explosion that blew up the Mystery and his ship.

He had made himself a chair and desk out of wood that was not comfortable.

The only ones who seemed to be content were Tony Smith and Tom Nado. They walked into Pyrus's chamber each munching on an apple.

"You know boss, this island is quite comfortable and good. It has all kinds of fruits, even this delicious apple," Tom Nado explained as he chewed the last bits of the apple core.

“Yeah, and the good guys always win, and I lose! Why is that?” Pyrus complained.

“First of all, boss, we’re not the bad guys because the real one was that evil Icelorian,” Tony Smith corrected.

“What benefits did I get out of this?” Pyrus questioned.

“Well, this island of deliciousness,” Tony replied.

“And this cool mountain,” Tom added.

“Argh, you’re not helpful,” Pyrus complained.

“Thanks, boss, happy to help,” Tom Nado and Tony Smith said as they left the room.

While Pyrus was spinning his swords, a strange shadow appeared.

“Would you like to conquer the island with the orbs of power?” a voice offered.

Then Pyrus looked around confused.

“Who are you?” he asked.

“I am the great…Ion,” the shadow replied, still hidden.

“Why have you come to me to seek help and aren’t you supposed to be dead?”

“Dead! I never die easily and you, I see, have potential.”

“Uh-huh.”

“We can rule the island together.”

“Hmm … I guess,” Pyrus said. “Actually, I think we can work together well. Perhaps I haven’t given you my full reason that I came here, but how did you survive that explosion?”

“Because I am invincible from any form of fire—I can resist them all. Ha, ha, ha, ha,” he laughed excitedly. “Your domain awaits!”

Once he said that the shadow disappeared.

And so, ends that journey and the beginning of many others.

The Mystical Beings lived happily for many years because of one boy named Zenith Luces who showed love and compassion for all people and not just his kind.

To be continued…



Zenith Luces and the Journey of the Mystical Beings was a CC (Classical Conversations) assignment for the short story English strand back in 2018.

Glossary

Magic Rank

- Tier 15+ **Celestius Deus**
    - Average Ages: —
- Tier 14 **Maximus Deus**
    - Average Ages: —
- Tier 13 **Magna Dea**
    - Average Ages: —
- Tier 12 **Altier Deus**
    - Average Ages: —
- Tier 11 **Bonus Deus**
    - Average Ages: —
- Tier 10 **Ultimus Dominus**
    - Prerequisite Rank for Magni
    - Average Ages: 100+**, Level 1, 2, 3.**
- Tier 9 **Maximus Dominus**
    - Average Ages: 90+**, Level 1, 2, 3.**
- Tier 8 **Magna Domina**
    - Prerequisite Rank for District Council Seat
    - Average Ages: 75-89**, Level 1, 2, 3.**
- Tier 7 **Altier Dominus**
    - Prerequisite Rank for Magni Candidate
    - Prerequisite Rank for Regnum Academy Teacher Role
    - Average Ages: 45-60**, Level 1, 2, 3.**
- Tier 6 **Bonus Dominus**
    - Prerequisite Rank for Cohort Captain Role
    - Average Ages: 30-37**, Level 1, 2, 3.**
- Tier 5 **Maximus**
    - Average Ages: 21-25**, Level 1, 2, 3.**
- Tier 4 **Magnus**

    - Average Ages: 17-19**, Level 1, 2, 3.**
- Tier 3 **Altus**
    - Average Ages: 16-17, **Level 1, 2, 3.**
- Tier 2 **Bonus**
    - Average ages: 13-16, **Level 1 (Lower Stage), 2 (Mid Stage), 3 (High Stage).**
- Tier 1 **Commonus**
    - Any Mystical Being below other ranks possessing any amount of magic.
- Tier 0 Nothing
    - Possessing no magic at all.

Prime Affinities

- **Shadow (Dark)** – Influencing Origin Magic, Yin
- **Light** – Influencing Origin Magic, Yang
- **Fire** – Origin Magic, Prime Element
- **Wind** – Origin Magic, Prime Element
- **Earth** – Origin Magic, Prime Element
- **Water** – Origin Magic, Prime Element

Derived Affinities

- **Ice** – Derived Magic (Wind + Water)
- **Snow** - Derived Magic (Wind + Water)
- **Steam** - Derived Magic (Water + Fire)
- **Mist** - Secondary Derived Magic (Snow + Fire)
- **Metal** – Derived Magic (Earth + Earth, rare chance)
- **Electricity** - Secondary Derived Magic (Mist + Mist, rare chance)
- **Plant** - Derived Magic (Earth + Water)
- **Mud** - Derived Magic (Earth, recessive)
- **Strength** - Derived Magic (no apparent affinity combination)
- **Speed** - Tertiary Derived Magic (Electricity + Strength)

Supreme Forces

- **Compression** (Gravity) - (Light + Water)
- **Decompression** (Antigravity) - (Dark + Water)
- **Purification** (Decomposition) - (Light + Wind)
- **Contamination** (Composition) - (Dark + Wind)
- **Fusion** (Nuclear Combustion) - (Light + Fire)
- **Antifusion** (Energy Conservation) - (Dark + Fire)
- **Magnetism** (Attraction) - (Light + Earth)
- **Antimagnetism** (Repulsion) - (Dark + Earth)

Magic User Types (Roles)

- **Elemental** – Releasing and converting magic as matter through one's innate magical catalyst.
- **Sage** – Changing matter around oneself in a given radius.
- **Mage** – Changes matter within oneself or delicately manipulating advanced magic spells.
- **Alchemy** – Produce potions with unique effects when magic is applied.
- **Runecrafting** – Applying magic to inanimate objects and making them function.
- **Cultivation** - Training magic and absorbing magic catalysts to strengthen one's own magical potential and mana capacity.

Magic Attributes

- **Zekron** - Classified as those inheriting power based magic, such as destruction, lightning, etc...
- **Lynnhera** (**Lin Li**) - Classified as those inheriting spirit based magic, such as healing, purification, etc...
- **Napoleon** - classified as those inheriting liquid based magic, such as water, chemical mixtures, potions, etc...
- **Hadestias** - Classified as those inheriting soul based magic, such as shadow extraction, shadow realm, and undead manipulation.
- **Lorares** - Classified as those inheriting body modification based magic, such as strength, agility, perception, etc...
- **Son Adoli** - Classified as those inheriting energy based magic, such as temperature, fire, energy manipulation, etc...
- **Catathena** - Classified as those inheriting mind based magic, such as deception, control, and brain productivity, etc...
- **Ceresara** - Classified as those inheriting nature based magic, such as plants, beast, etc...
- **Venersa** - Classified as those inheriting charm based magic, such as sensory manipulation, attribute enhancements, etc...
- **Vulcus** - Classified as those inheriting creation based magic, such as matter manipulation, runecrafting, potions, etc...
- **Artiana** - Classified as those inheriting sensory based magic, such as sense enhancements, awareness modification, etc...
- **Mercemes** - Classified as those inheriting space based magic, such as teleportation, swiftness magic, etc...

Cohorts of Regnum

- **Blue Legion** - Most renowned cohort, led by Charlotte Levy
- **Tempest Aquia** - Most prestigious cohort, led by Atlas Aquia
- **Black Rampart** - A good cohort dedicated for clearing all missions, led by Carla Storm
- **Red Shred** - Most rampageous cohort that performs daring missions, led by Billy Bones Acitas
- **Mystic** - Most studious cohort with the best minds, led by Elmor Locks
- **Dai-Battalion** - Most sporty cohort and always at the top of the game, led by Len Hiyama
- **Centipedes** - A meme cohort that have no apparent rules, led by Cedric Paine
- **Nuntios** - The best of the best; known for only four members that take on S+ ranked missions, led by Josh Picard

Mystical Districts

- District 1 - Paradise: Dwelling place of the Icelorians and dwarves. Famous for its rare minerals and ores. Located nearby Japanese islands.
- District 2 - Aliorvia: Sacred home of the elven nation, queen (Magni), and council. Located in Italy.
- District 3 - Volcanic Lair of Pyrus Bourn: Stronghold of the infamous Pyrus Bourn and his Fire Increaser Co. factory.. At the snow caps is the location of an armory. Located on the Mystical Island.
- District 4 - Silwastra: Dwelling place of satyrs and nymphs. Located on the Mystical Island.
- District 5 - Atalantia: The kingdom where the Water Spirits, Naiads, and Nereids reside. Located in the sea along the Mystical Island.
- District 6: Home of the strong Magniverigentis clans. Located on the Mystical Island.
- District 7 - Lux Urbis: The central haven of the Mystical Beings, the famed Magni Mage, and the Mystical Council. Also the first known established district and most technologically advanced. Located on the Mystical Island in the Arctic region.
- District 8: Home of the mythical dragons of the long past. Currently inhabited by elemental species such as Metalors, Huolors, Terralors, Herbovirs, and Wentors. Located in China.
- District 9: A sheltered home for the beast-looking demihumans, including species such as Avelerions and merfolk. Located in Australia.
- District 10 - Animusteria: A natural plains abundant in magic and inhabited by beast-like predator species. Mostly undeveloped, except a steampunk underground world, and often a highly-used place for magical research. Located in Africa.
- District 11: Home of the Runigists. Located in Canada.
- District 12 - Luminia: Dwelling nation and kingdom ruled by the Magni Luminis and the highly devoted followers of bird-like demihumans. Located in Italy.
- District 13 - District of Doom: A populous place, second-best technologically advanced, containing entertainment, sights to see, and dark secrets. Located on the Mystical Island.

Mystical Species

Most Mystical Beings are humans with unique attributes, hence giving them their unique titles. Some are named after their magic affinities while others are named after their physical characteristics. All of these species are easily distinguished through their genetic makeup. Unlike the regular behavior of genetic data passing, the offspring does not become a mix of two species, rather, they gain the traits of the dominant species in return. Some instances may allow them to gain additional affinities or derived affinities though. Keep in mind, more of these species will be explored in due time.

- **Celestial** - The highest order of Mystical Being species. These beings are the ones who have surpassed the very limits of magical boundaries such as mna limitations, output maximum, and regenerative powers. Though they are considered "higher order," they do have limits such as how much they can interact directly with the physical world without.
    - **Deity** (Body) - A Mystical Being who has absorbed immense amounts of mana to the point where their physical body has dissipated, leaving only their soul and spirit fused as a single entity. These beings exist within the physical realm as observers of history's unfolding. Because they lack a corporeal form, they are immune to death. Their interventions are limited to directing magic, granting enhanced abilities to select individuals throughout time, thereby shaping history as known today. There are only twelve such deities known to exist.
    - **Demon** (Soul) – A Mystical Being with the capabilities to manipulate the souls of the shadow realm due to the nature of their existence. These beings were once humans who tempered with dark magic that disrupted the very nature of life. By attaining immortality, these beings directly absorb the soul energy from the shadow realm. Their interactions on the physical realm are limited to how shadow energy resonates in the physical realm. There are twelve known high demons, also known as demon kings, and numerous other lower-class demons that follow orders. The individual that tempers with forbidden magic and souls for immortality are known as the **Demon Lord**, as they are like a demon residing in the physical realm.
    - **Spirit Beast** (Spirit) - When the released mana of those who died return to the spirit realm, the mana eventually condenses into sentient divine species in the form of animals due to the various nature and prospects of human beings. These spirits can be contracted to be soulbound to currently living humans in a mutual relationship of both sharing mana and assisting in various tasks in the physical realm. There is said to be one unique spirit beast for each Mystical Being that attempts to make a contract ritual. There are twelve species known as the twelve Zodiac animals.
- **Arch-Elemental** - A higher-order Mystical Being elemental with immense natural magical potential and mana capacity. They possess strong magical affinities that make others fail in comparison. Each of the sub-species possess unique affinities known as Regnum Spei, special grade magical powers that function vastly different from the average Mystical Being.
    - **Icelorian** – A Mystical Being elemental species with immense dark ice powers, proven to be capable of piercing steel and the like materials. Noted to be descendents of pure dark

magic species. Often distinguished with their light skin and light-colored hair. Icelorians are regarded as the strongest species of the "big three" due to their superior nature and adaptation to circumstances.

    - **Gostlynger** - A Mystical Being elemental species with affinities oriented towards darkness and the night. They are nocturnal beings with often pale skin due to the lack of sunlight. Gostlyngers were usually classified as dangerous for their natural interests in risky experiments and forbidden arts. They are also regarded as one of the "big three" due to their intellect and ability to use most magic user types.
    - **Water Spirit** - A Mystical Being species with water affinity and the strong inherited ability to manipulate all forms of water. They also possess a strong connection to spiritual beings and pure magical essence. Unlike regular water species, they can control water to a higher degree including the ability to harness the prime force of compression. They can transform freely to and from water. They are considered the third member of the "big three."
    - **Dracolor** - An actual mythical species of Mystical Beings with powers of the almighty dragons of legends. They wield attributes that make their body and magic stronger than most other elementals, even rivaling all the other arch-elementals, to some extent. They possess regular physical characteristics as humans but they can morph freely into actual dragons entirely or partially if needed. As dragons are deemed the highest authorities, they are worshiped and respected above all other species.
    - **Larvan** - A Mystical Being species artificially created through one's intense exposure to strong fire magic particles and natural magic in the atmosphere collectively through decades. They have enhanced fire affinity magic stronger than typical elementals, making them arch-elementals. Pyrus Bourn, being the only known member, can also utilize extreme fire called inferno magic.

- **Elemental** - A normal Mystical Being classified by this main category due to their lack of majorly unique physical appearances. They possess a main affinity that makes them distinct from other subspecies. Each of these species are the most common among Mystical Beings and are often labeled as the "twelve" Mystical species.
    - **Naiad** - A Mystical Being elemental species with water affinity specifically geared towards freshwater sources. Being the largest obstacle, the presence of salt in any water source makes Naiads weaker and their powers significantly harder to control. They can breathe in freshwater springs or lakes. Possessing no distinct features but their ability to transform to and from water.
    - **Nereid** - A Mystical Being elemental species with water affinity specifically geared towards saltwater sources. They possess small distinctions such as their fish-like gill ears and small fins. They can breathe in saltwater streams, lakes, and the ocean. They cannot transform into water but their speed within water is as fast as the current itself.
    - **Nymph** - A Mystical Being species with wood affinity, typically tree or plant manipulation and creation. Their distinct features are their fair skin, dark hair, and slightly pointed ears. Most are usually spotted with the brightest emerald-green eyes.

    - **Elf** - A Mystical Being species notable for their pointy ears and elegant stature. They have varied derived magic affinities oriented in nature such as weather, climate, seasons, and terrestrial alterations. Having a high physical aptitude, they are known as the fastest Mystical species to exist.
    - **Dwarf** - A shorter statured Mystical Being notable for their facial hair but also their incredible craftsmanship. They possess no inherent affinities so they utilize their magic as affinity-less mana that is then used as energy for runes and potions.
    - **Magnivirigentis** - A Mystical Being species with strength and endurance related magic affinities. They are notable for their accelerated growth through protein synthesis and accumulation, thus, giving them their strongest build of all Mystical Beings.
    - **Metalor** - A Mystical Being species with an affinity to metal and other very durable earth related attributes. Because of their immense magical prowess and craftsmanship, they are regarded as the best runecrafters and elementalists of earth. Their characteristics consist of a more strengthened body build, agility, and calculative mind. They appear the most normal in appearance when compared to a regular non-Mystical human.
    - **Wentor** - A Mystical Being species with an affinity to the wind attribute. They possess no distinct characteristics except for their sharp nose and agile limbs. They appear with yellow or green hair, yellow eyes, and light skin.
    - **Terralor** - A Mystical Being species with an affinity to earth magic and the related. They typically have a stronger build than the average species and they can withstand most weaker attacks with their rock-tough skin. They often appear with black to brown hair, brown eyes, and darker skin.
    - **Herbovir** - A Mystical Being species with an affinity to plants. They can control plants and become a part of one. With their mild toned skin, they can even syntehsize energy straight from the sun, making them more powerful in the daytime.
    - **Huolor** - A Mystical Being species with an affinity to fire and similar elements. They are usually distinguished from others by their red eyes, durable skin, red eyes, and sometimes flaming hair.
    - **Runigist** - A Mystical Being species with no apparent affinities. They are usually shorter than elves but have similar pointed ears. Possessing mana, their typical use of magic is through controlling and creating runes.
- **Demihuman** - A Mystical Being species with physical animal attributes such as talons, animal ears, a tail, etc… They typically have superior sight, hearing, smell, and agility due to their partial animalistic nature. They possess magic typically related to their animal characteristics but can range by their inherent affinities. Their magic is also often more derived from natural affinities such as the origin magic themselves. Beastmen are also species that are often classified with demihumans.
    - **Angelor** – A Mystical Being with attributes of angelic light powers, regarded as both immense and truly powerful above most other magic. Famous for their splendid white wings, also making them true demihuman species. Had not for such demihuman aspects,

Angelors would be considered as powerful as an arch-elemental level Mystical species. They possess light affinity magic but can also attain secondary affinities from one of the prime four elements.

- **Vulpivor** - A Mystical Being demihuman species notability known for their fox ears and tail. They possess beast and body modification based magic affinities plus their respective elemental affinities and are common among demihuman species.
- **Canilor** - A Mystical Being demihuman species notability known for their wolf ears and tail. They also possess beast and body modification based magic affinities plus their respective elemental affinities and are common among demihuman species.
- **Felior**: A Mystical Being demihuman species known for their cat-like features such as cat ears, a tail, bright colored-eyes (mainly yellow and green), and cat-like postures/gestures. They are agile on their feet, maneuverability, and elasticity. They possess speed and enhancing-based magical affinities plus their respective elemental affinities.
- **Avilerion** - A Mystical Being demihuman species known for their bird-like features such as various colored wings on their backs, yellow eyes, and sharp perceptions. They possess sensory, agility, and speed based affinities plus their respective elemental affinities.
- **Merman** - A Mystical Being demihuman species known for their fish-like features such as gills, fins, and tails. They typically have yellow predator eyes, water breathing capabilities, and keen heightened senses. They mainly possess water-based elemental affinities.
- **Satyr** - A Mystical Being beastman species with goat horns and shaggy goat legs. They are also known as beastmen and have wood related affinities.
- **Luporian** - A wolf-like Mystical sentient beastman that can telepathically communicate and act relationally. They can range from various sizes and have immense speed and strength. Their affinities range from sharpened senses, strength, and wind magic.

Other Books

Mystical Legends

(in Chronological Order)

Most of the books in the series are planned to be released and are not available right now.

- **Nuntios** – Search for Survival
- **Rune of the Spellcaster** (Mystical Legends #1)
- **The I.T.E.R. Chronicles - Initialization** (Mystical Legends #2)
- **The I.T.E.R. Chronicles - Rectification** (Mystical Legends #3)
- **The Aqua Revolution** (Mystical Legends #4)
- **The Festival Saga** (Mystical Legends #5)
- **Red Showdown** (Mystical Legends #6)
- **The Rogue God** (Mystical Legends #7)
- **Will Eternal** (Mystical Legends #8)
- **Shadow Dwelling** (Mystical Legends #9)
- **Uniting the Districts** (Mystical Legends #10)
- **Mystic War** (Mystical Legends #11)
- **Global Revelation** (Mystical Legends #12)
- **Awakening Legacy** (Mystical Legends #13)
- **Angelic Retribution** (Mystical Legends #14)
- **The Reign of Magni** (Mystical Legends #15)
- **Inheritance** (Mystical Legends #16)
- **Regnum Legends** (Mystical Legends #17)
- **Gates from Shadows** (Mystical Legends #18)
- **Fractured Reality** (Mystical Legends #19)
- **Celestials' Ascent** (Mystical Legends #20)
- **From the Day** (Mystical Legends #21)
- **Immortal Hunts** (Mystical Legends #22)
- **Age of Hunters** (Mystical Legends #23)
- **Subzero** (Mystical Legends #24)

Author(s)

Kenny Calhoun, as of 2024, is a part time creator and author of the Mystical Legends series along other related and dissimilar works. Some of his hobbies include sketching, animating, music composition, piano playing, working out, watching most anime, reading light novels and manga, game development, and playing video games… mostly stuff that could benefit his series. He lives in Virginia with his parents and six other siblings. He is a sophomore majoring in computer science and physics at William and Mary, hoping to obtain enough experience and knowledge to someday work at NASA or the related. Although starting Mystical Legends as a side hobby, he aims to push it towards the scale of a real brand with more than just books—so is the reason he does a lot of part-time hobbies.

As a fellow brother, **Kaleb Calhoun** doesn't have much going for him except earning lots of money after college. As of 2024, he is finishing his last year of high school. You could say most of his interests, such as computer programming and cybersecurity, are for the benefit of a high paying job. His interests include violin playing, music composition, drawing anime characters, socializing with friends, playing lots of video games, watching his favorite anime, and feeling good about himself. He is a part time storyboarder and assists his brother whenever he feels like it… when he feels like it, that is. He does aspire to help out whenever he can, especially on the non-fantasy fictional works (a particular one right now is a science light novel series).